Your memory engraved in my soul
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Your memory engraved in my soul

by Lilliae

Summary

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> …
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> “Mydeimos,” the thin one said again.
>
> Mydeimos. That high, firm voice.
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> Mydei. That low, soft voice.
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> These five knew something. Knew him or those voices.
>
> So he gave them those two words burrowed somewhere deeper than his mind or body. Aedes Elysiae.

When Mydei finally emerges from the Sea of Souls after nine harsh winters, the most precious thing in the world to him isn’t his name, his body or his life. But two words he can’t remember the origin of: Aedes Elysiae.

As the years pass in exile, he finds himself plagued by knowledge that comes from the same maybe-past or maybe-future that wasn’t quite Mydei’s and yet was.

It took four years for him to stumble across Aedes Elysiae, a boy that calls the place home, and why those words were engraved upon his soul.

Chapter 1

Chapter Summary

> Mydei being an absolutely feral child in the Sea of Souls and Amphoreus.

Chapter Notes

> Hoyo please explain the inconsistent Mydei lore please please please please please

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The world was dark and murky. It had been for as long as he'd known it. It clung to him in a stagnant weight that never shifted on its own but always dragged him back whenever he moved and buffeted him with the movements of something coming towards him.

They came for him often. Blurry figures that moved through the world with an ease he didn't have. They lashed out faster than he could dodge, caught any weak hits he threw at them, and retaliated with tears everywhere they could reach and cracks deep in his body.

When they lost interest and discarded him to sink, those cracks and tears were the closest things he had to warmth.

Warmth. A bright light. A gentle voice that held him and didn't want to hurt him.

The whole world was nothing but darkness and pain but, somehow, he knew of these things from beyond it.

Sometimes, when his body was still putting itself back together, it almost felt like he was somewhere else. Like there was something at his back. Hard or soft, it didn't matter, just that he wasn't sinking anymore. Like there was someone beside him.

Often times, the voice was higher but firm when it spoke to him in words he couldn’t understand but knew the meaning of. Fight with all his strength, endure any hardship, never waver. Other times, the voice was deeper but softer when it told him with certainty that he could survive anything.

So when he felt his body sway, he tensed. His fingers and toes curled, returned from the burning pain to the cold world and his own control. He opened his eyes and they stung with their newness but he could see again and dodged the lunging dark shadow.

Another one swung in his peripheral vision but he couldn’t stop his own momentum in time to dodge that too. He could only throw his hands and grapple it the same way it grabbed at him.

Soft. Slippery. But he clawed in and felt it puncture. The tentacle thrashed and more snapped around his arm. Yanking. His fingers creaked with their hold in the wound, on the brink of breaking with the force of fighting the creature’s pull. If he let go and it wrenched his arms apart then he would lost them again.

Colour spread beneath his fingers. A dark blot that blocked his view. But he didn’t stop. A tentacle dove for his neck and the snap he had once felt still echoed in his ears. He jerked his head down, opened his mouth and snapped his jaw closed.

The creature spasmed around him, under his fingers, between his teeth. It clenched and unclenched in raw panic as a foul taste filled his mouth and he bit harder anyway.

It shot off. He didn’t know where they were going but it thrashed in eagerness to get rid of him. He dug his nails and his fangs in and didn’t waver. Never. He would do better than survive. He would kill this thing.

But then something changed. Pressure and coldness. It was different. Lessened and warmer.

He wrenched his head back and any resistance was torn away. Something cracked in his chest this time when it shuddered in pain and crushed him.

His hand slipped and it felt the loss of his two footholds because it flung him away.

He flew backwards and—

And hit something.

Under his feet, his back. It moved when he pushed against it. Unhelpful but better than the nothingness he was used to. It was like the gold around his neck and in his mind alongside a deep voice. But dulled. It fell apart into chunks, then smaller, when he dug his fingers in.

Everything was brighter around him. Easier to see. His eyes didn't feel as if they would burst in his head even as they stung.

The creature was more than a dark blur. Its tentacles flowed against the water, pushing smoothly and quickly as a pair of big eyes darker than the world he knew stared at him. Circling him but not attacking. The stump of the tentacle he had ripped free flailed. It was nervous.

The light dimmed. There was something above them. Another dark shape, rounded on either side until it met at a sharp point at the top and bottom.

It didn't seem to notice the two of them. If it did, the creature's bleeding wound should make it the primary target while he escaped or lurked to finish off the injured victor.

The creature looked at him and he dug his toes into the thing beneath him in preparation. It was coming again.

Then it darted straight up.

It was injured and it would rather take that unknown creature above them than him? He was smaller and weak than anything else in this murky world.

The tentacled creature smacked the newcomer and it… it rolled over immediately. Two more shapes appeared. Extra limbs?

But he watched the back and forth of their bodies, bobbing, and he knew the shape of them. It was the same every time he looked down at himself.

They were like him.

He kicked off and sped through the water. The tentacles grabbed hold of them and they struggled uselessly. They didn't even try to dig their fingers in, stamp their feet or use their teeth. They just flailed around. Weaker. Both of them weaker than him.

A tentacle flicked at him but he dodged. Easier than before. There was less dragging him down up here.

He whipped his head round, seized it, and bit hard. The tentacles writhed but he grit harder, gripped harder, and *tore.*

Not a blink later and he threw it away, launching himself at the two trapped prey. One of them had stopped moving. The creature tried to flee but it was too late and he sank his finger, toes, teeth in to free the one still moving.

He pried them free. They stared with wide, glassy eyes. He didn't have time to get them to safety. Were they so weak they would just accept death and not even try to flee?

He darted for the next prey and the creature swung them out of the way but he closed the distance easily. While he was quicker, the creature was slower up here and he snatched it before it could curl away from him.

He tore it as mercilessly as the rest and flung the unconscious one at the motionless one. That seemed to finally spur them into action as they caught their ally and dragged them up, up, up with them.

He didn't bother watching where they went as he lunged for the creature again and ripped it to shreds with the same viciousness done to him.

Only when it was reduce to a mess of floating limbs, twitching like they could still escape, did he wade out of the mess.

That strangely round and pointed shadow was gone. So were the two creature that looked like him. No sign of where they had gone. So they could flee just fine after all. But for beings as weak as them to survive all this time… how? Where had they gone?

He dropped the creature's head and let it sink back into the depths. He tipped his head back. It was warmer up here. A bright light came from above and he thought of blue, white and gold and reached for it.

His hand broke through first. The weight he thought lessened suddenly vanished completely.

His head passed through next and—

Hot. Cold. Pressing down on his skin and blowing against it. Noises in his ears. His chest ached and spasmed, rough sounds and something else trickling out of his mouth and merging into everything around him.

There were more things in the distance. Everything new and unknown and dangerous but if those two weak being could survive up here then he would be fine.

He paddled towards where the thing surrounding him ended and merged into something gold like what he'd found underfoot earlier.

Small things darted below him and shadows passed overhead. But nothing ever attacked. They only ran away. Everything up here was weak.

Eventually his feet touched something solid again. It still broke apart and moved every time he tried to push off but it was enough for him to stumble the rest of the way. When that weight finally let go of his ankles, he collapsed onto his back and didn't move.

His body ached. Not in the way of limbs ripped free and growing back. This was different but still so familiar.

It was blue with a bright light above him. Closer now than when he was weighed down. He reached for it again and the warmth gathered in his

hand.

The hardness at his back. The burn in his nose even without blood or injury. The… sky and the sun. Like he had seen them before. Like he had laid here to see them before.

His hand was too heavy to hold and it dropped beside him. His eyes followed, slipping closed and even then the world was less dark than it had been his entire life.

There was one thing left on his mind. Two words. The only things that never left him no matter how many times he sank into darkness and reemerged.

They were all he had even when he opened his eyes not on something hard —but soft. The light and warmth were different now. They didn't come from the dark thing that had replaced the sky and joined with the four solid things all around him. It was somewhere beside him, in a colour that reminded him of the marks on his body and not the sun.

But he didn't entrust those words to the being he found when he emerged from a lighter, easier darkness than what usually consumed him when he closed his eyes. The being was one of the two he had saved from the creature and it made all sorts of noises he couldn't understand. It bared its teeth but didn't bite. A warning?

Now that the former prey was safe again, there was no reason to assume it wouldn't attack him too. They were both alone but weak things usually attacked in numbers, using trickery and force to overwhelm him. So when it wasn't looking he snuck away and ran before its allies could arrive.

Unlike in that cold and darkness, his movements were free of that clinging drag and there were lots of places to hide. The beings who looked like him came to search when they realised he escaped. But they were easy to evade in the tall golden stalks.

When the sky began to darken, the rustling and shouting stopped. It was quiet again except his own breathing. He could occasionally hear things

moving but they were just as hidden as him and nothing ever approached him as he crawled further away from those things that looked like him.

The sky lightened and darkened as he roamed. The gold stalks thinned and disappeared quickly but he found more shelter, more hiding places, with ease. If he heard the loud noise of something bigger, stronger than him, he ducked out into the open where they didn't prowl. If he saw a thing that looked like him out on the open paths then he wove his way into the green.

He was right when he assumed that everything was weak up here. The most anything did was scratch and bite him. No missing fingers or hands, toes or feet, or eyes. No crunch or snap when they grabbed him. And they crumpled easily in his hands before he ripped into them with his teeth.

And still those two words followed him. He mouthed them to himself with every step, every bite, every gaze up at the sun as it rose, held and sank again three times.

It was when the sunlight accompanied him that fourth time, some of those beings that looked like him finally chose him as their prey. There were five of them, hunting him in a group. They were smarter and stronger than the ones he first encountered.

He tried to lose them by winding in and out of every obstacle or hiding spot he could find. He was smaller and quicker and quieter. Every new corner he turned, it was like he'd seen it all before. He knew where to drop, where to jump, where to slow down and speed up. They were persistent but so was he.

It took another two rises of the sun before they cornered him.

It was his mistake. He'd fallen into a ditch trying to make a tricky jump from one ridge to another, hoping it would be enough to lose them for good.

His leg snapped and burned in a way he hadn't felt since before he had slain that tentacle creature. He ignored it and clawed his way up. It would take them time to get to him safely. He would need to be somewhere else before they found a way down.

When he finally emerged from that pit, the five of them were already waiting.

He bared his teeth at them and bent low to the ground. That thin one looked like the easiest to kill but he had seen how well it moved. Either way, he had to take that one first.

“Mydeimos.”

Mydeimos. He knew that word. Except for those two voices that held him together in the depths, it was the first time anything had ever made a sound he could understand.

The thin one’s lips curved upwards, not baring teeth, and lowered himself. Not low and ready to pound, but to one knee. And then he tilted his head and exposed his neck.

The other four followed.

“Mydeimos,” the thin one said again.

Mydeimos. That high, firm voice.

Mydei. That low, soft voice.

These five knew something. Knew him or those voices.

So he gave them those two words burrowed somewhere deeper than his mind or body. *Aedes Elysiae.*

Chapter End Notes

> My first multi-chapter fic that managed to double in chapters between conception and the final full stop. The whole fic is written I’m just editing chapter by chapter for my own sanity.
>
> Anyway, Mydei I’m so so sorry for everything I put you through this chapter. Blame Hoyo and/or Eurypon. It gets better I promise.

Me ranting about some writing stuff and chapter details:

▶ Details

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> Mydei finally hears rumours of Aedes Elysiae and follows them to a wheat farming village.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In the fourth year of Mydei's exile, he was assailed by the image of poisoned arrows. It came to him in dreams, conversation, thoughts. Unbidden but always lurking to strike when he least expected the assault. When Perdikkas asked him one night where the Kremnoan detachment would be marching to next, Mydei blinked at the fletching in his stomach and back only he could see. He only had one answer: not Ladon.

None of his warriors questioned the command. They cheered, hoisted their honey brew high and returned to their songs from a home everyone shared and longed for except him.

They wandered the wilds without much direction. Disregarding, the military discipline, the detachment was a group of mere exiles, so their days were spent following the rust scented winds and their nights wiled away on food, drink and music.

The town they ended up in had a name but not one any would care to map. It was too far from any major city-states that none had even claimed the territory their own and, something Mydei concluded with a brief glimpse over the market stalls, produced nothing of real value. It was a mundane place. Perfect for a brief respite and resupply.

He shadowed Krateros as the man negotiated with the town's blacksmith. The detachment's weapons were beginning to wear down. They needed repairs or replacements but enlisting the services of some unknown blacksmith in an unknown town wasn't enough.

Kremnos had its own forging techniques that had been taken into exile with the detachment. The quality of the materials and the forge wouldn't be up to par but it was better than nothing.

"They're willing to allow us to rent their forges but only at night," Krateros summarised for him while the blacksmith got back to work.

Mydei grunted. They had spoken in common tongue but he couldn't understand the blacksmith's accent and gotten lost too quickly. No matter Mydei's thoughts or emotions, his face rested in a look of quiet anger. It did well to hide his confusion even if it drew the ire of strangers who didn't appreciate being looked down upon by a child.

But Krateros, despite being a relatively recent member of the detachment, choosing self-imposed exile to seek them out across Amphoreus and finally join them half a year back, was responsible for the bulk of Mydei's education. He had observed Mydei's father for many years, and his mother many more, so he had honed a talent for reading the opaque.

"Tell the others when we get back."

There were still supplies they needed to pick up. Primarily grain and honey brew. The detachment could weather any storm without complaint so long as they had those two things and one more: steel.

They hadn't moved far from the blacksmith when Mydei caught sight of another stall. A fletcher.

The arrows loosed overhead. Mydei sucked in a harsh breath.

Krateros paused at the sound but only considered the bundles of well-crafted arrows. "Arrows… Ptolemy mentioned they would be in need sooner rather than later."

Mydei watched his teacher approach the stall and forced himself to follow. The fletcher had the same accent, so there was nothing to distract Mydei from the… thoughts, memories, foresights. A future that had already happened in the past.

They walked away from the stall with a bundle of arrows wrapped inside waxed leather. Mydei eyed the feathered ends and saw them coloured red.

“Teacher?”

“What is it, Your Highness?”

It wasn’t as though Mydei knew everything. Only feelings of familiarity like he had seen or done these things before. Vague recollections of conversations, hazy images of scenery. But he didn’t recall this town.

“Do you think Fate can be defied?”

It was a silly question, he knew it was before it had even left his mind, but Krateros had lived long enough to mask the disbelief.

“Your Highness, of course not.”

Mydei let his face rest in its anger and not disappointment.

And Krateros didn’t notice as he gazed at the sky, seeking out the silhouette of a mobile fortress. “But fear not, your father was bewitched by traitors and led astray. It was false prophecy fed to him. Not the will of the Titans. When you reclaim the throne, you will bring the thousand year Kremnoan dynasty to new heights of glory with that blessed body of steel.”

Mydei hummed and tugged at his chlamys hung over his head. He knew that prophecy. Krateros explained every word to him not long after he joined, as he regaled to Mydei the relationship between his parents and how things had ended so twisted. But that wasn’t the foretold future Mydei was interested in.

What if a prophecy came from something that wasn’t a malignant mortal nor a Titan? Something… beyond even Fate? Then surely, if he put his faith in that knowledge…

Across the street, Hephaestion smiled at a travelling merchant who possessed some of the only interesting wares in town.

“Krateros, return to the encampment.”

With a brief glance between Mydei and Hephaestion, Krateros knew Mydei would be in safe hands and took his leave. Mydei lurked in the shadows between buildings as Hephaestion revealed an intricate bronze mirror they had pillaged from a small army. It had flown a flag Mydei hadn’t cared for beyond the spoils, knowing it originated from neither Ladon nor Kremnos. The men were so poorly trained, the army crumbled at the first strike of their Kremnoan formation.

The travelling merchant’s eyes widened, practically sparkling in the reflection, and his mouth opened, looked once over Hephaestion, closed again. He handed over the coins at the price Hephaestion had set, along with the herbs Perdikkas had been searching for, picked and preserved from somewhere near Tretos.

Mydei’s lip curled and he tugged his hood as far down as he could before pushing off the wall. Hephaestion had chosen well. The merchant knew enough to recognise that Hephaestion was likely a member of the nameless warrior exiles that used Kremnoan techniques without bearing its flag.

Then remembered that bartering was considered offensive amongst Kremnoans—only the owner could decided the worth of their own possessions or labour. It was only up to others whether they accepted the product or sought better prices elsewhere. But never to barter—and so he accepted the given rate.

When Hephaestion saw Mydei approach, he smiled and met him halfway, dropping the pouch of coins into Mydei’s palm.

He weighed it and arched a brow, choosing the harsh sounds of Kremnoan over the smoother common tongue. “It was just pretty bronze.”

Hephaestion laughed. “My dear friend, it’s less the item itself people like that man take interest in. Its value is the life that object has led. He can have it appraised but the story he’ll tell all his guests is that it came straight from the spoils of that nameless army making itself known across the land.”

He tossed the pouch up, coins rattling, and caught it again. So he paid for pretty words instead. “If he had won it himself, only then would there be a story worth passing from the host onto a guest.”

Hephaestion raised a hand and Mydei tossed the coins back to him. “It will make a good conversation piece for that Okheman merchant on the savageness of the Kremnoan people.”

Long fair hair neatly tied back. A golden hoop in each ear. A slender face and body. Clothes as clean as could be reasonably expected while constantly on the move. Hephaestion was far from a *savage.*

Now, Mydei on the other hand. There was a reason he kept his hood up and refrained from speaking with the merchants. His body was still short and thin after nine years of malnourishment. At thirteen he still bore the stature of a child but a merchant from another minor town, only important as a distant territory of a larger city-state, had startled so badly at the sight of his tattoos it alerted the city guards.

His grasp of the common tongue had been poor at the time, not long enough after he emerged from the Sea of Souls for him to answer in more complex language even if he somewhat understood it. There had been numerous questions about his past crimes to warrant an identifier on his face at such a young age.

But he was such a pitiable sight the city guards turned to other ideas: kidnapping, slavery, the unsavoury unknown warriors so clearly Kremnoan. When they tried to “rescue him”, he bit one of them, clawed at the other’s face, and slipped away. He’s certain that encounter was made into another story of Kremnoan barbarism.

“I believe I saw some pomegranates in the arms of a woman who passed us by earlier,” Hephaestion said. “Shall we, Mydeimos? And on the way we can discuss our troubles.”

He frowned but Hephaestion had already turned his back. “What troubles could I possibly have to share?”

“Mydeimos, if someone of your status wishes to lie then they must take care to do it well.”

His frown deepened, accompanied by a twitch of his brow. He could accept Krateros referring to him as *Your Highness* or *Crown Prince,* but never liked how Hephaestion would mention his supposed status. The Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos? He was birthed more from the Sea of Souls than any human city. They were all companions in their shared exile: what difference did status make?

Everything. He knew that. The only reason his five friends had expended the effort to pluck him from a feral life in the wilderness was because of that status. One they caught wind of in a rumour about a child emerging from the sea and slaying with bare hands the sea monster that had so troubled the fishermen. That child’s most distinctive features were the mane and eyes of a solitary lion, and jewellery of blue and gold.

While lacking a formal education, the one provided by the Kremnoan detachment and then Krateros was as close as numerous exiles could come to preparing him for kingship. The king that would lead them home and restore glory to Castrum Kremnos.

“I’m not lying,” he lied.

Hephaestion glanced back, an amused crinkle at his eyes. “Of course not, Mydeimos. Then, as one loyal soldier under your command, I beseech you to explain your sudden aversion to Ladon.”

They both knew Hephaestion was a lot more than that. A subordinate who marched on Mydei’s orders, a comrade who shared food and drink and toasts with Mydei, a teacher in whatever Mydei could learn from him. A friend, his dearest one, and a confidant.

But when Hephaestion asked why he was so attached to the words *Aedes Elysiae* and where he first heard them, even he was not privy to an answer.

In part because Mydei didn’t know himself. Didn’t know how to explain the feeling that he had already seen and done this. Not everything down to the

finely woven threads, but the tapestry each one came together to create felt like it had been draped over his shoulders once before.

Hephaestion shortened his steps on legs far longer than Mydei's, slowing to his side so they could speak more lowly between themselves. "The Kremnoan detachment harbours no doubts. Your judgement has never led us astray—it's the mark of a born warrior, and a worthy king."

Mydei kissed his teeth. "They coat their weapons with poison. We shouldn't throw lives at those who fight so dishonourably."

Hephaestion's brows rose. "Poison? I've never heard of Ladon using such underhanded tactics. Where did you hear such a thing?"

Mydei tugged his hood over his eyes.

"Forget I asked," Hephaestion relented, knowing Mydei could stay silent for days, weeks, on end if he wanted. It was more difficult for him to speak than refrain after nine years of silence. "Is that what concerns you so that you've been tossing and turning every night in your cot like a newborn?"

That was an exaggeration. Sometimes Mydei had restless nights, as all warriors who had spilled life and guts into the soil did. His rest just happened to be plagued by thoughts of a lightless abyss where monsters and the dead grappled at him knowing he didn't belong. If not that, then a dream about unimaginable pain through his back from the blade stained gold as it pierced through his chest.

Even as he told himself there was nothing to be embarrassed about, he turned away his burning face.

Hephaestion chuckled. "Feel reassured, so long as we have Perdikkas by our side, no warrior of yours will succumb to poison or ailments."

Mydei peeked out the corner of his eye to find Hephaestion already watching; a hand over his heart in a show of sincerity that Mydei found in his smile and creased eyes. A gesture to his weak heart and health. But he

still stood tall and able thanks, in part, to Perdikkas' concoctions as well as his one tenacity.

But sincerity wasn't the same as truth.

The truth was that Mydei knew the colour Perdikkas' skin would turn when all the blood rushed out the wounds in his stomach. Then how that pale skin would green and yellow when the poison spread through him. The shaking, the cold sweats, the convulsions.

At some point, his pained cries would dwindle away into nothing more than harsh pants and crazed mumbles. On his very death bed, as Mydei clutched a hand that lacked the strength to do more than twitch, Perdikkas found the strength to bestow his parting words.

Mydeimos, do not mourn. I have achieved honour by bestowing a noble death upon the enemy.

Except Mydei had mourned, would mourn, was mourning for one of his dearest friends that was still alive. Perdikkas greeted him every morning, sang Kremnoan folk songs in harmony with him, checked him for injuries knowing they would heal perfectly every time. And he would do everything to keep it that way.

Just as he would never allow Leonnius to have his legs cut off and body disappear in a bottomless swamp. Ptolemy to be crushed by rebels in the snow covered city. Peucesta to martyr himself for their retreat. Hephaestion to fall ill after ten years in exile and finally succumb. The visions that tormented him every night was knowledge for him to use and emerge victorious. Not for honour nor glory but for the sake of a future where the six of them together might live without being dogged by Strife eager to end them.

Footsteps thundered across the ground and Mydei twisted his body to dodge out the path of whatever idiot was sprinting through the market place at full speed.

"Mydeimos! Hephaestion!"

He groaned. It was one of his idiots.

Leonnius sprinted past, then did a double take when he noticed Hephaestion's distinct hair. The speed of the detachment's fastest runner meant he was already a good ten steps away but he spun on his toes with hardly any momentum lost.

The two of them shuffled over to the side of the road, Hephaestion showing an apologetic smile to all the bystanders who had nothing better to do than stare, and Leonnius skidded to a halt.

There was no telling how far and how fast Leonnius had run. Many of the detachment had scattered to sell or trade their spoils for supplies. If he recalled correctly, Leonnius had gone with Peucesta to exchange an ivory carved flute for some gold, yet Peucesta was nowhere to be seen.

"Is there an emergency?" Mydei asked. There was no other reason for Leonnius to leave Peucesta behind and appear so suddenly.

Leonnius took one deep inhale to catch his breath and then spoke in a level voice untouched by exhaustion, "We found it."

Found it. They *found it.* And he knew with absolutely certainty what *it* was.

Hephaestion grasped Leonnius' shoulders with urgency for a nonexistent emergency instead of celebration. "Found what?"

Leonnius opened his mouth but Mydei got their first as he breathed:

"Aedes Elysiae."

Just the word brought a warmth up the back of his throat, dripping from the tip of his tongue, like he had swallowed pure sunlight.

Hephaestion shook Leonnius by the shoulders. "Explain yourself. And where is Peucesta?"

They had traded the ivory flute and been purchasing grain. Peucesta was a man of few words but his skill with their craft and rhythm were undeniable.

If Mydei wanted information then Hephaestion and Peucesta were his first choices.

And the detachment had made it their secondary mission to discover the meaning of the words *Aedes Elysiae.* They assumed the words were passed onto Mydei from the Sea of Souls, so they must have been of the utmost importance.

A person? A skilled warrior or tactician or physician? Only Kremnoans were permitted to join the detachment but there was unspoken agreement that an exception could be made for another gift from the Sea of Souls, second only to Mydei's immortal body.

Not even Mydei knew what the words meant. He only knew that the very thought of them brought images of something brighter than the sun. Of white, blue and gold. That his heart ached and his body very nearly trembled with the urge to move, to search, to reach and unmask this unknown.

"It's a small village not far from here. Two days march westward," Leonnius recounted. "Touches the coast but the only thing it's known for is wheat."

It wasn't a person but a place. Mydei felt something in his chest twist but…

Wheat. Yes, that was right. It settled into his mind comfortably, as though it had always been there, washing mud from metal in a river until the water ran clear and revealed the truth beneath the grime. Golden in colour; warm under the sunlight.

When they returned to the encampment, Mydei had one order: march westward, for Aedes Elysiae. The detachment cheered and split into two parties. Those who would follow Mydei and those who would stay behind to utilise the forges before marching to Aedes Elysiae under Krateros.

That night around the campfire, a new air of anticipation came with every cheer and song. Mydei turned the meat, a boar hunted from the wilds by Ptolemy, on the spit while the others engaged in drunken revelry. If he

didn’t watch it then it would undoubtedly burn, or the seasoning would fail to bring out the meat’s full flavour.

Above the cheer and song of the others, Peucesta strummed his lyre and sang an old epic about ancient heroes while the rest of them listened. The metre changed as the tale of heroism cooled into one of lovers.

Despite the playful mockery of the pink tinge Mydei preferred to his drinks, Hephaestion passed him a half-full chalice alongside a pot of goat’s milk. “Nervous?”

He mixed the two together, swirling them as the red began to lighten. “Why would I be?”

Hephaestion hummed and the firelight added colour to his face that only made Mydei think of his feverish skin on a sickbed. “It could be anything, or it could be nothing.”

None of them wished for Mydei to be disappointed. He was their crown prince, their would-be-king, the one who gave them commands and charged into battle at the lead with his infallible body and would one day take them home.

But he was also a child. As much as he loathed his malnourished body yet to recover from those long nine winters and wished it would grow sooner rather than later. A child they had raised and were still raising with their own rough hands. What father, brother, uncle wanted to see their child crushed?

He watched the boar brown over the fire, fat dripping onto the loaves he had set underneath. “Whatever comes, I will not falter.”

Hephaestion didn’t say anything more. He simply raised his chalice. The other four noticed and paused their merry making to lift theirs. Mydei did the same, the metal clinking together, and they threw their drinks back as one. It was a promise to stay by one another’s side through all hardships.

A voice he hadn’t heard in many years came to him in his sleep. One that had once told him how he could doubtlessly survive any challenge the world threw at him. Now it whispered to him in a voice like the sea breeze through the wheat fields.

Two full days march was conservative. Halfway through the second day, the green forests flattened to fields and from the plains golden wheat sprung abundant. It was almost endless.

Leonnius returned from scouting ahead and announced that the village was only an hour or so ahead. The sight of a fully equipped army, especially with the rumours flying faster than their feet could carry them through Amphoreus’ wilds, would… frighten those poor villagers, so Mydei ordered everyone to set up camp again despite the early hour.

It was better than being met with the best siege defence the place could muster. Strife begets Strife and Mydei would prefer peace where it could be found

While the others set up the tents and dug fire pits, Mydei climbed up a nearby tree and settled on its branches to keep watch. Ahead, the flats dipped into a valley and supposedly that was where Aedes Elysiae rested.

He didn’t know what awaited him there. A small, sleepy town? One that grew wheat instead of warriors. Why had the name of such a place been imprinted onto him by the Sea of Souls or something beyond it?

So deeply engraved into his soul that even the knowledge of it ahead of him, like the sun beginning to break over the horizon, filled him with an indescribable feeling. Every breath was heavy and light, his body tense and relaxed, his mind full and empty at once.

A sharp whistle pulled his gaze to the ground. Ptolemy grinned at him, a strung bow and quiver over his shoulder, a coil of rope in his hands. “Are you coming down, Mydeimos? We’re holding a contest over the game hunt.”

Mydei nodded and swung himself down, holding his weight as he dangled for a heartbeat before falling the rest of the way. He shook the splinters off his gauntlets.

Other people hunted with bows or spears—although Ptolemy excelled in traps. Ones he only needed to read about before he could recreate each knot and length of rope flawlessly—but Mydei preferred to hunt with his hands, gauntleted or bare. His body was his best weapon.

Ptolemy cocked his head. His grin grew and he leaned down, cupping his mouth conspiratorially. “Or you could take the opportunity to go off on your own.”

Mydei languidly blinked at him and recounted, “All members of the detachment are to travel in pairs.”

If someone were ambushed or injured, their chances of survival drastically increased if at least one other person was at their side. Whether it was game hunting in the wilderness filled with lurking predators, restocking supplies in nearby towns that may become hostile on a coin toss, or even going down to the nearest water source to bathe. The exception was Leonnius’ fast feet serving as their most reliable messenger.

Ptolemy rolled his eyes, amused. “I doubt this little place is harbouring anything that could bring serious harm to you, Mydeimos. Either you disappear now so I know how long you’ve been gone and where. Or you can disappear later when no one will know.”

He wanted to defend his honour. *He wasn’t going to…* but he faltered. Maybe he was. Maybe he wouldn’t have been able to shake off the allure of Aedes Elysiae and whatever he may find there, calling to him like a siren lured a father to throw his child to the sea. Maybe he would have left everything behind and disappeared without a word to anyone.

Thrown away the weight of their expectations and his responsibilities and ran for the thing that had captured his interests. Captivated him so completely with sweetness warmed gold by the sun.

Then Ptolemy smiled and laughed through his nose. “Besides, some things are best experienced on your own.”

And Mydei gazed off towards that horizon again. There was a word for this feeling; he was certain. But all he could recall was Peucesta’s songs about a warrior who sailed across the West Wind to retrieve their lover.

“I’ll be back,” he promised.

Ptolemy handed him a dagger as a precaution. “Before evening begins to welcome the night.”

Mydei strapped the weapon to his thigh, hiding it beneath his tunic. “If I fail to return…”

“I’ll ensure we try peaceful means before Hephaestion burns the village down searching for you.”

Mydei nodded but didn’t turn to leave immediately. He stared at Ptolemy, watching him back expectantly, and shifted his weight between his feet. “Thank you.”

His smile softened and he raised an imaginary cup. “May triumph be yours, Mydeimos. Whatever form that triumph takes in your next battle.”

Then he was off. The wheat stalks scratched at his bare legs as he ran, pushing them aside and weaving through the gaps. It didn’t bring any pain. If anything, it was sheer relief that pulsed through him, a companion to the anticipation racing in his ears. The heat of the sun overhead, the harshness of the grain, the wind in his ears that smelled of the fields and the salty sea —they were all reminders that this was real.

Aedes Elysiae. Not just a perfect, peaceful place his mind conjured for him amidst the darkness of the Sea of Souls. Finally, *finally,* he would be able to see it with his own eyes and settle the endless yearning for something he had never known but still *knew* that had made a home in his chest these past thirteen years.

There was a break in the wheat ahead of him. He could see where it had been disturbed. Parted and kept as such by something.

When he looked down, a pair of blue eyes gazed at him from beneath white lashes. A young boy but older than himself. Taller, well-fed, broad shoulders and muscles suited to a real sword and not the wooden one resting on the ground as languidly as its wielder.

Mydei met the stunned, wide eyes of that boy and something in his chest caved. It shattered like glass and rained down like stars and new words emerged from the cracks.

The love of my life and the one to end.

Chapter End Notes

> Mydei the moment he sees Phainon for the first time and has some weird flashbacks and realisations: …
>
> Phainon while he waits for this random child to start speaking: ???
>
> Same as before, writing rants and extras go below

▶ Details

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> Mydei and Phainon introduce themselves to each other properly and almost immediately start a duel.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Neither moved. Mydei's heart raced, breath quick, like he never stopped running and he searched the boy's face for even a hint that he was feeling the same things tearing through Mydei. It was the same way he tore through obstacles, whether monsters or human: bloody, brutal, teeth and fangs bared.

Nothing. No anticipation and relief and exhilaration shaking hands and flushing skin and dilating pupils. Just a confused scrunch of the boy's nose.

Mydei deepened his breaths and wrangled his heart back under control with the efficiency of any good warrior. It wasn't disappointment. It wasn't. He never had any expectations for what Aedes Elysiae might hold. Mydei was good at adapting and it was time for him to adapt.

The boy pushed himself to his feet. Mydei wasn't wrong. He was a lot taller than Mydei's malnourished stature, yet it didn't feel like the boy loomed over him, leered down at him, when he smiled.

"Hello, I've never seen you around here before. Are you lost?"

He had a nice voice. Still youthful, high and a bit whiny, but it balanced out with a certain softness like the wheat swaying in the wind. Carefree, relaxed and flexible. Mydei didn't recognise the boy's voice as one of two.

Mydei's hands curled into fists at his side and he knew his face rested in that stony anger, despite his true feelings, but he couldn't bring himself to

change it. “No.”

“It’s okay to admit you are,” the boy encouraged brightly, seemingly oblivious to the metal claws on Mydei’s fingertips even as it creaked. He hadn’t cleaned them properly. “Where are your parents?”

“I don’t have any.”

“Oh… so who do you live with? Do you know where you live?”

“I roam around.”

It was clear none of those were the answers the boy wanted. His face had become increasingly sullen the more short, sharp replies Mydei gave him.

“Your legs must be tired then.” The boy sat back down and patted the dirt next to him. “Come rest for a bit. What’s your name?”

There was no one else hiding in the wheat fields. Mydei would have noticed them already. It was just him and this boy he apparently had loved and would love and already loves with the way his heart made itself known against his chest. This boy staring up at him so earnestly, practically pleading with him to accept his invitation.

Apparently his heavy plates of jewellery and red tattoos didn’t scare him. No fear; although, a glimpse of Mydei on the battlefield might change that.

He crossed the last couple steps and sat down. “Mydeimos.”

“I’m Phainon.”

That name, too, slid into place. Something always known yet not remembered. But it wasn’t quite *right* when Mydei watched Phainon stick out a hand. Mydei clacked his claws at him but he didn’t even blink, just kept his hand out until Mydei shook it.

“Nice to meet you, Mydei.”

Only one person, if a voice in his head could even be called that, had ever used that name.

His eyes widened and he turned away, snatching his hand back. “That’s not my name.”

“Sure,” he chirped back, undeterred by Mydei’s rough edges. “But your name’s long. Besides, Mydei is a lot cuter than Mydeimos so it suits you more!”

Mydei replayed the words in his mind, wondered if he had misheard among Phainon’s accent and quick speech, two traits he usually disliked. When it was clear he hadn’t, whipped his head to Phainon. *“Cute?”*

He nodded with a giant grin. “You remind me of my friend’s cat. Livia. That’s my friend, not her cat. She has eyes like yours—“

“I’m a boy,” Mydei clarified, just in case. He shouldn’t need to but Phainon seemed like an idiot.

“I know! But her eyes and fur are the same colour as yours. Plus, she’s always hissing at Big Snowy,” Phainon rambled away, one hand raised and curled like a cat’s claws and Mydei glanced down at his own gauntlets. “That’s my dog. I think you’d like him. He’s very big and fluffy. Would you like to meet him? He’s very good at finding me so if I call him I bet he’ll come running right away.”

“Do you always speak this much?” Mydei asked because he couldn’t imagine saying so many words in such quick succession.

He stopped mid-breath, closed his lips, and smiled sheepishly. “Sorry, that must have been annoying.”

Mydei shrugged. “Not really.”

After all, Phainon had a nice voice. Despite speaking in common with an obvious accent, Mydei found he could understand with ease. Every syllable of his easy cadence sank right in. Kremnoans were usually ones for shorter

words, or better yet actions, over extraneous chatter or persuasions. But Mydei wasn't averse to Phainon's ramblings. He actually enjoyed listening to him.

Is that why he falls in love with him? Because he has a nice voice? That thought didn't fit, displaced where the right ones interlocked their joints into a steady framework. Unless the maybe-past, maybe-future version of Mydei was surprisingly shallow for a pretty boy and pretty voice, there had to be more.

He pointed at the wooden sword between them. "Do you know how to use that?"

He couldn't imagine entrusting himself to someone who couldn't defend themselves. It didn't have to be a sword, if not his gauntlets then Mydei was partial to a spear, even a bow and arrow would suffice. But if the sword was Phainon's then Mydei could only assume he knew how to use it. Or else he was just a kid playing pretend and what could they ever have in common?

Phainon picked it up and swung it at some invisible foe in front of him. "Of course. I'm going to train to become a hero and protect everyone."

Mydei rolled his eyes. "Heroes aren't real."

Phainon's smile never wavered. "Maybe you just haven't met one yet."

Everyone assumed he would meet one in Aedes Elysiae. Some part of Mydei did, too. The same one whose voice murmured in his ear in the darkness and despair, blazing like the sun, to keep going. That someone would have all the answers about Mydei's strange mind, would understand him and guide him to subvert that Fate.

The simple tunic, the wooden sword, the carefree smile. Mydei knew Phainon wasn't that hero even if he was *something.* And that made Mydei just as curious. He may as well try to understand what exactly he was meant to uncover in Aedes Elysiae and why. What Phainon was to him—a lover, a murderer—and why.

He knew the Kremnoan detachment, all its exiles, and Castrum Kremnos itself was his responsibility and nobody else's. It had been a foolish hope. A dream, a wish, more than a reality he thought he could grasp.

"You have to be strong," Mydei said quietly, "if you want to protect everyone."

Phainon nodded, surprisingly somber even if his smile didn't change. "That's why I'm planning to go to Castrum Kremnos to train."

Wooden sword. Carefree smile. A proclivity for words.

"They'll laugh you away at the gates."

Phainon chuckled. "Then I must have told a pretty funny joke."

He didn't dignify that with a proper response and Phainon scratched his cheek at the judgemental silence and unimpressed stare.

Mydei showed some mercy when he asked, "How old are you?"

"Fifteen."

Kremnoans began formal military training younger than that, closer to Mydei's age than Phainon's. But the informal training began the moment they could hold anything in their little hands.

Their hands grew clutched around a child's sword, a dagger, a spear and their legs grew to hold the weight. As soon as they learned to walk, they learned to run with a weapon dulled just enough not to hurt. If they couldn't survive a night in the wilderness by the time they were seven, then that death was only an inevitability brought quicker to spare the family's honour and resources.

If Phainon went to Castrum Kremnos, not only would the guards laugh him away, they may even bring a child to throw him out.

"How old are you?" Phainon asked.

“Thirteen.”

Phainon squinted. “You know, there’s nothing wrong with being younger.”

“I’m not *lying.*”

“But you’re so…” Something crossed his features and he shook his head. “Never mind.”

“*What?*” Mydei asked. Sharp, lips pulled back like a feral dog gave warning.

“What?” Phainon asked. Just confused and not condescending.

Mydei pressed anyway, “You were going to say I’m something. What was it?”

“It was nothing. I was wrong.”

“It can’t be both. So tell me.”

Phainon swallowed, hands pulling at the grass, and braced himself. “… small.”

So the apparent love of his life was not only an idiot, but thought Mydei was small. Weak. A child and nothing more.

The love of my life and the one to end. The knowledge that Phainon would kill him one day didn’t faze Mydei. There were many reasons someone Mydei loved might come to cross blades with him. Life and battlefields shared many things; first and foremost was their unpredictability. It could be as simple as a conflict of interest. It could be as likely as Mydei finally going mad like his father and needing to be put down.

But if Phainon was someone worthy of having Mydei’s back and bestowed the honour of taking Mydei’s life one day, then that would be because they were *equals.*

“Stand up.”

Phainon tilted his head but was already halfway to this feet. “Why? Where are we going?”

“Nowhere. Pick up your sword.”

That finally brought some hesitance, glancing between Mydei and the wooden sword he had left on the ground. “Well…”

Mydei scoffed. “You insulted me, so now I have to defend my honour.”

Phainon just stared as Mydei rolled his wrists and ankles to loosen the joints. “I’m not fighting you. I don’t even have a spare sword for you to use.”

Mydei clacked his claws at him.

Phainon considered them for a moment but it wasn’t with approval. “Those look sharp. Who gave them to you?”

Mydei stretched his biceps and shoulders, then slid his weight to feel the stretch in his calves too. “Don’t worry, I won’t aim to kill.”

Phainon kept staring. “You’re serious.”

To prove how serious he was, Mydei lunged. Phainon yelped and dodged the first swipe. Not bad. He was fairly fast, graceful when he used the momentum to bend low and swipe his sword up without stumbling. Instead he straightened and twisted at once so the two of them were face-to-face.

Good reflexes. Quick recovery. His stance balanced his weight, mindful of the uneven ground, and would let him respond to Mydei’s next attack. He could admit it was better than he expected but his eye twitched when he realised Phainon was staying on the passive defensive.

Fine. Mydei would make him realise that wasn’t enough.

Mydei bent low and pounced. Phainon’s weapon gave him a range advantage but Mydei had always been fast, slippery, body honed to move in

water weighted with dread and Death. Air and solid ground was nothing. They were a boon.

It was the one advantage of his small body. He easily dodged Phainon's sword—decent swing. If it connected it would *hurt* on a lesser man—and closed the distance in a blink. Phainon's eyes widened at the claws surging from below for his throat.

He threw his head back and twisted his body. His shoulder took the brunt of the hit. No blood. Mydei wasn't interested in that. Just some torn fabric.

Then he jabbed his elbow at Mydei's chest and he barely caught it with his free hand. He threw Phainon back, already searching for his next angle of attack, while Phainon was already opening the distance again. Retreating.

Except it wasn't a retreat.

His sword arced. Mydei dropped low and felt it skim past the top of his head. He straightened just in time to jerk out the way of a slash. Phainon had abandoned the defensive just when Mydei was preparing to exploit it.

Phainon pressed the advantage and Mydei deflected his blows. He kept speeding up without sacrificing strength. As though every swing brought momentum he carried forward into the next step, the next attack.

Mydei tried to close the distance again, slip into range, but Phainon was watching his routes in with an eerie focus in his eyes. He was so steady as he closed in for another hit. Face set and hands sturdy and base even. An immovable object against Mydei's unstoppable force.

He showed his hand too early. He was too eager and paid the price. Usually his opponents were stupid and dead or smart and retreating.

If he were going for the kill—

Mydei changed tactics and aimed to grab Phainon's sword on the next attack. But Phainon twisted the blade, pulled it free and angled for Mydei's

hands. Already gone because Mydei needed to be faster, stronger, better to match Phainon.

If Mydei were going for the kill… that would mean Phainon was too. This was just play fighting, no different from dogs pulling each other's tails. It wasn't that they got lost in the violence as their attacks came harder, quicker, closer to something deadly or at least seriously injurious.

Every attack, dodge, parry was proof of their skill and a taunt. Better. Be better if you want to win. So they did *better.*

But Mydei felt a sudden rush for battle. A real hunger for it. One he had never felt before. It couldn't be just any battle. It had to be *theirs.* Both of them at the height of their power, clashing with a thirst for victory and intent to kill that couldn't be sated by any other.

He needed to know what it would feel like when it was a real sword in Phainon's hands. To bleed on it and draw his blood in turn.

Yes, of course this would be the man worthy of his back. Not only one of Mydei's many thousands of lives but the *one life.*

But not yet. For now, Mydei still needed to win.

He took the next hit to his stomach. Phainon's eyes widened and his grip faltered. Mydei should have been able to dodge that. He should have.

He didn't because it let him grab Phainon's blade and yank it from his hold. Disarmed and still stunned, Mydei easily tackled him to the ground.

The impact winded Phainon and he choked on a breath but still scrabbled at Mydei with surprising strength left in his fingers. It was pointless. Mydei excelled at hand-to-hand combat and had him pinned by the wrists in seconds.

He sneered down at him. "Yield."

Phainon's fingers clenched, muscles flexing in Mydei's hands, as he tested the give. There wasn't any.

He tried again anyway and his face was flushed, chest rising and falling in harsh pants, but he grinned with the same flash of teeth as Mydei's own. "You don't fight like a thirteen year old. Maybe you lied about your age after all and you're actually a very short adult."

"You still have energy for pathetic jokes?"

Mydei didn't dare move even one of his hands from Phainon's wrists, pinned above his head. He was too strong and would break free in an instant. Instead, he dug a knee into Phainon's chest and watched him wheeze.

He still managed a strained laugh. "Do you always get riled up at pathetic things?"

"No." He leaned more weight onto Phainon's wrists, his chest. He could handle it and let Mydei come closer. "I usually kill them."

His smile only grew. "So I'm the exception. I'm flattered."

"At least you know what you are."

"Flattered?"

"Pathetic."

"Oh, Mydei, if I was so pathetic, would I be able to do this?"

Mydei realised his mistake the moment Phainon's weight shifted beneath him but it was too late. Phainon snapped his hips and twisted his torso and Mydei's one knee on solid ground wasn't enough to stop Phainon from throwing them both.

If they had been on stable ground then Mydei would have been able to recover. Unfortunately, they were on the side of a hill.

He was weightless for a moment and he used it to latch his hands behind his head and tuck his body. Then he hit the ground and kept hitting it all the

way down. He only clenched his teeth and curled up tighter as the compact soil beat aches and bruises into his body.

By the time he slammed into flat ground, his whole body protested in a way even the toughest battles couldn't manage. He was usually ready for those hits.

He didn't bother moving. He sprawled on his back and the only reason he knew he was still alive was his heart thundering in his head to the same rhythm he had tumbled.

Phainon laughed, *laughed*, beside him. "Haven't done that in a while. Mydei?" Rustling as Phainon moved. "Mydei? Are you all right?"

He sounded genuinely nervous even after Mydei had proved himself by wrestling him to the ground. Maybe this was just how Phainon was. Concerned over the smallest things.

He kept his eyes closed. "I'm fine."

"Can you… did it hurt?"

That level of pain was nothing. He could already feel his body healing it away. "Forget it."

More rustling, closer this time, before the warmth of the sun vanished over his torso. Mydei opened his eyes to Phainon hovering over him, lips thin and eyes downturned.

"Sorry," Phainon said so sincerely Mydei half-expected his bottom lip to tremble under the weight of his guilt. "I didn't mean to hurt you. At all."

That was obvious from the way they were fighting but Mydei nodded anyway. "I know."

"Where does it hurt?"

"I'm fine now."

Phainon’s hands hovered uselessly, not sure when to poke and prod but needing to do something. “You don’t have to keep lying to me.”

“I never lied to you.”

Phainon’s expression only became more grave. “You tucked up, didn’t you? When we fell. I thought you’d roll flat. I—“

“I don’t want to hear apologies,” Mydei snapped. He sat up, pushing Phainon away with a hand against his chest. “I challenged you to the duel so save your pity for something more pitiful.”

Phainon searched his face for something, probably pain, but if a tumble down a hillside were enough for Mydei to curl up and cry then he would’ve died a thousand more deaths by now. Pain was a friend even older than Death.

When he found nothing, he relaxed with a harsh exhale. “You’re right.” His breath caught in his nose and Mydei only realised it was amusement when Phainon raised a fist to his mouth and laughed. “But really? Taking that hit to your stomach? Are you out of your mind?”

If Phainon thought that was crazy it was only because he hadn’t seen Mydei do it on a real battlefield. No matter how battle hardened the enemy, a child being impaled on their weapon only to grab it and yank the weapon closer —when most adults would be a choking, cooling corpse—was enough to disarm anyone.

A blunt hit to the stomach was nothing. Never mind that the force of Phainon’s swing could do more than wind a man who tried to bear the same hit. They would spit blood.

“It worked,” Mydei grumbled and his body didn’t protest anymore when flopped onto his back again. “But what kind of underhanded tactic involves rolling down a hill.”

He didn’t really mean that. If it were pure chance then maybe. But Phainon had kept a keen sense of his surroundings and known what he was doing

when he goaded Mydei off balance and threw them. Mydei just wanted to poke and prod a little. It was childish but Phainon didn't seem to mind.

"It worked," Phainon threw the words back at him, laying down on his side. "So who won?"

"Do you really need to ask that?"

"It's better to be on the same page."

Mydei muttered some Kremnoan curses under his breath before he spat, "*You.* "

Phainon preened. "That's right. Which means I get to claim my prize."

"The spoils have to be agreed upon before the duel."

"Wha—you're saying I don't get anything?"

Mydei glanced out his eye at Phainon's frown. He sighed and rolled onto his side too. "I'm saying it depends on what you ask for."

Phainon's smile returned like clouds blown away to once again reveal the sun. "Then come home with me."

"*What?*"

"Come home with me," Phainon repeated, just as casual and shameless as the first time. As though Mydei hadn't heard him when the issue was that he definitely had. "My parents won't mind. My dad went fishing this morning so my mum should be cooking fish for dinner. I'll ask them to let you stay."

He was almost afraid to ask. "The night?"

Phainon stared at him, dumbfounded, like Mydei was the fool. "As long as you need."

How was he supposed to reconcile the warrior he had traded blows against with the fool staring at him with such wide, hopeful eyes at the idea of what? Providing Mydei a warm meal and place to sleep.

“I don’t need that.”

Mydei didn’t need Phainon’s home. Even if Mydei didn’t have parents or a house to return to, he had a home of his own. People who cared about him. People he swore he would give everything to protect. People who would worry if he went missing.

He jolted upright. What colour was the sky? “I have to go.”

“Wha—Mydei, come back!”

Phainon scrambled to his feet but Mydei climbed the hill on all fours and was already halfway up.

“Mydei, there are wolves out there at night.”

He could snap a wolf’s neck with his bare hands. Wild animals generally knew better than to approach the numerous campfires and rambunctious people but, on the rare occasion some were too bold, hungry or feral, they had night guards on duty in case.

“So don’t follow me,” Mydei called back, hauling himself up the crest of the hill.

He was about to sprint off when he noticed something wooden on the ground and snatched it up.

Phainon was, of course, following him, and rather quickly. But he was forced to stop and catch the wooden sword Mydei threw right at his head.

“I would never withhold your rightfully won spoils,” Mydei announced while Phainon stared up at him, the wind stirring his sweaty bangs and fresh exertion colouring his cheeks. “So I’ll come back tomorrow.”

Then he turned and ran and didn’t stop running until he reached the Kremnoan encampment. He had wheat in his hair, mud and grass stains on his clothes, new scuffs on his gauntlets.

But Hephaestion, pacing by the main fire while Ptolemy knelt looking thoroughly scolded, took one look at him and the anxiety was replaced by three words.

You look happy.

Chapter End Notes

Brat Mydei and Brat Phainon. They’re just different types of bratty and both insanely fun to write when they’re both so silly.

▶ Don’t have much to rant about this chapter but

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Phainon gives Mydei a personal tour of Aedes Elysiae.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The next day, the entire detachment was practically fighting to be one of the few allowed to venture into Aedes Elysiae. Not because they needed a resupply—they were just nosy. When everyone pestered Mydei over honey brew and a campfire about the place and he refused to say a word, their curiosity had surged into something insatiable.

No one asked if he found what he was looking for. Hephaestion's word had become law the moment it was uttered: Mydei returned from Aedes Elysiae *happy*.

The grin on Perdikkas' face that morning foretold trouble and Mydei tried to ditch the others on the way. But Leonnius' feet were as quick as his tongue would be when it came to spreading the gossip. No matter how he ducked, wove and circled through the wheat fields, he failed to lose Leonnius before he arrived at the hill.

While Phainon had been relaxed dozing in the field the day prior, that morning he had taken to pacing back and forth while nibbling at his thumbnail. As soon as he heard the wheat rustle, his head jerked up to Mydei.

He beamed and strode over. "Mydei! You really came back. Not that I doubted your word, of course, but…"

From the wheat moving behind him and the warm body just treading the edge of a polite distance, Mydei knew Leonnius had caught up.

Phainon glanced between the two and his smile didn’t change but it was somehow more fixed than before. “Is this your brother?”

“No.”

“Uncle?”

Mydei arched a brow that, compared to Leonnius’ was rather thin. Leonnius also possessed a larger nose worn well upon his longer face. Unlike Mydei’s untamed mane, his soft hair was cut short and perfectly coiffed, untouched by the wind he ran upon. The two of them looked nothing alike.

“No.”

Leonnius laughed and showed some mercy, “I’m a friend. A brother in arms.”

Phainon looked from Leonnius to Mydei with that stiff smile. Mydei didn’t realise he could express emotions that weren’t carefree joy, a warrior’s focus, and needless anxiety. Certainly not something so complex.

“Mydei, come over here. I wanted to show you something but you ran off yesterday.”

The only thing Phainon wanted to show Mydei the day prior was his *home* . And now that he had used that nickname—one Mydei has heard and kept close to his heart next to Aedes Elysiae—it would undoubtedly spread through the encampment.

Mydei’s brows furrowed, nocking an argument to loose.

But then Phainon added a soft, “Please.”

Mydei sighed and went to his side. The sun glinted off him and that was what it took for Mydei to realise the sword strapped to Phainon’s waist wasn’t a wooden plaything wielded with deadly precision—it was real.

Phainon unsheathed it and levelled it at Leonnius in one smooth motion. “What could an older man want with a young boy.”

Leonnius didn’t even blink. His demeanour switched as effortlessly as Mydei’s, assessing the new threat, but he still whistled playfully. “Speak for yourself.”

Age lost a lot of its meaning in the detachment, just as it did in Castrum Kremnos. What did age matter compared to an individual’s skill and the camaraderie fed blood and Strife on the battlefield. If Mydei wanted, he could sweep Leonnius off his swift feet and have his hands around his throat with hardly any blows taken.

“Why does he have so many tattoos?” Phainon pressed, any warmth used to temper the edge of his voice and then extinguished to leave it cold and cutting. “He’s underfed. Why does he need weapons for hands?”

Perhaps Mydei’s penchant for short answers and little explanation had finally done more harm than good.

Leonnius glanced at Mydei but he shrugged and then, after a moment, gave a subtle thumbs up hidden from Phainon’s view. The sword sheathed at Leonnius’ hip was to remain that way. Mydei didn’t need rescue; he didn’t need slaughter in his name.

“Heard wind of that flagless army roaming Amphoreus?” Leonnius crooned.

“The one that uses Kremnoan tactics.”

His smile widened like he was a heartbeat from a glorious kill on the battlefield. “That’s us.”

Phainon’s blade didn’t waver. He only firmed his stance. “Do you make a habit of taking in young boys with no home and no parents.”

Mydei motioned for Leonnius to make himself less offensive but his grin grew to show the subtle dip in each of his cheeks. Mydei would get him back for this and all the rumours he was doubtless concocting in his mind already.

“Not at all. Mydeimos is just special.”

Mydei glared and Leonnius pretended not to notice.

Phainon’s grip whitened, trembling for the shortest moment before he regained enough composure to quell it. But his lips pulled in real anger. Somehow it didn’t appear out of place. “You’re *sick*.”

“That’s enough!” Mydei barked and he smacked the back of Phainon’s head. He didn’t stumble but he did falter enough to look at Mydei. “I’m here to honour your victory. Don’t waste my time by dragging me into pointless squabbles.”

“What’s so pointless about your wellbeing?”

Leonnius practically purred, “How cute. He cares about your body, Mydeimos.”

Mydei spat every Kremnoan curse he knew but Leonnius only cackled. When Mydei raised a clenched fist it was a reminder of the punishment to come. He was too far away at the moment and if Mydei lunged at him, he feared Phainon would join him to cut Leonnius down when Mydei only meant to give him a thorough beating. Leonnius still needed function in his legs to fulfil his role as a messenger.

Mydei didn’t bother to soften his anger when he rounded on Phainon. “Get out of your own head. Do I look in need of rescue?”

“But Mydei…”

He crossed his arms, squared his shoulders and tipped his chin back as he drew his voice from below his chest. “Leonnius is one of my dearest companions. Someone who has been by my side for years. Now, if you don’t want to claim your spoils then I’ll leave and I won’t be coming back to waste any more of my time.”

His grip tightened around his sword, as though he were prepared to launch himself at Leonnius on his own. It would’ve been quite the show at least,

and a chance for Phainon to win his respect.

But he relented with a sigh and sheathed his sword. “I trust you, Mydei.”

Mydei forced himself not to smile. “Then get moving. You too,” he ordered Leonnius with a jerk of his head.

Leonnius raised both hands in surrender, a false one despite the speed he disappeared. He was just itching to get back to the others and wag his tongue.

Head bowed, Phainon peered at Mydei through his lashes. He somehow perfectly balanced a look that was at once throughly chastised and yet gave no indication he wouldn’t do the same thing again. Like a dog who had stolen someone’s dinner and only licked its lips when caught.

Mydei huffed. “He was messing with you. Empty your head of his words.”

“Yeah,” Phainon agreed, sullen.

Mydei wasn’t good at comforting others beyond food, drink and battle. He shuffled between his feet and clacked his claws at his side.

But then Phainon shook his head and slapped his cheeks, red and stinging when he grinned. “Come on, let me show you around.”

“I thought you were taking me to your home.”

He laughed and swept a broad hand to the wheat fields, the sky, and the village down below. “Aedes Elysiae is my home.”

It was apparent how at home Phainon felt as he guided Mydei down the worn and winding village paths. He waved at everyone he saw and, no matter what they were doing, their faces lit up as they returned the greeting. Despite Mydei being nothing more than a stranger in their close community, the amicability they showed Phainon extended to Mydei at his side.

Although, they weren't openly hostile to outsiders. While Phainon took him around the small marketplace—asking if he was hungry, when the last time he ate was, what his favourite foods were—Mydei noticed Hephaestion and Perdikkas purchase some food and local herbs.

Mydei knew Leonnius' slander had already reached them because Perdikkas elbowed Hephaestion and they both grinned knowingly at him. Perdikkas mouthed something uncouth in Kremnoan and Mydei gave a gesture right back even as Hephaestion rolled his eyes at them for it.

"It's harvest season," Phainon explained as he passed a fig, given for free but Phainon insisted he check the young woman's roof in exchange, "so everyone is busy. This is the school but lessons are cancelled until the harvest is over."

The building was hardly any different from the homes they had passed. White walls and wooden frames dulled by time but not rotted by it. The only distinguishing feature was the small outdoor platform. There was no training ground.

"Can you read, Mydei?" Phainon asked, honestly curious instead of insulting.

He scoffed anyway. "Of course I can read."

"Really? What about writing?"

"I'm not a fool."

"Well, since you're…" he glanced around and then dipped his head to speak lowly between them. "You can speak Kremnoan, too, right? Not just in common."

If he were a prince who couldn't speak, read and write his native tongue then he wouldn't be a prince at all. He answered with an unimpressed look.

Phainon chuckled. "I get the message."

He prepared to take them up a slope but Mydei tapped his arm and pointed behind them.

“What’s that statue?”

A hooded figure with clasped hands. Slender and grey with things left at the base as it stood watch over the village.

“That’s a statue of Oronyx, the Titan of Time. They protect the village.”

Mydei gazed up at the faceless statue but he knew he could lay down offerings, sat on his knees and clasped his hands, and none of his prayers would be answered. He had tried that already when the detachment first told him about the Titans.

He wanted to know what the meaning behind these thoughts and feelings and memories that weren’t his own yet were. He wanted to know who or what gave them to him. He wanted to know why him and seemingly no one else.

Nothing ever answered.

But the statue of Oronyx gazing across every small corner of the village made some sense. Everything about Aedes Elysiae was so old and simple. Untouched by the rest of the world as the golden wheat and the vibrant leaves swayed to their own rhythm. In a way, Aedes Elysiae felt timeless.

Up the hill was the Sacramental Courtyard dedicated to Oronyx. Phainon tried to take Mydei inside but he refused at the sight of high walls and only one, maybe two if there was another he couldn’t see, exit.

Phainon pursed his lips thoughtfully and his searching gaze settled on the small pier built above the pond. “Get on.”

Mydei assumed he didn’t mean just the pier but the small wooden plank strung from a tree listing over the pond. “Why?”

“It’s fun.” Phainon insisted, a hand at his back to guide him over and down. “I use it all the time with Cyrene.”

Mydei gripped the ropes. “Who’s Cyrene?”

“My best friend,” Phainon said and pushed.

The swing swayed just a little. Phainon’s hands hardly left Mydei’s back before the warmth of them returned again for another push. Mydei went a little faster, a little higher, that time.

“You should meet her later. She’s in the courtyard with the elders right now. They’re preparing to send her to Janusopolis to become a real priest of Oronyx. That’s when I’ll leave, too, for Castrum Kremnos.”

He snorted, leaning back on the downswing to pick up more speed. “Good luck finding it. It’s a sky fortress. It always moves.”

Phainon caught him and pushed him again. “Wow, so that’s true. But I heard it always docks for the Kremnos Festival so the best warriors from all over Amphoreus can board. Have you ever seen a Kremnos Festival, Mydei? What’s it like?”

Mydei kicked his legs on the upswing. He was starting to gain some real height. “No.”

“Oh.”

Mydei stared up at the sky, growing near and then further and then even nearer again. If he let go, it felt as though he could soar.

“Higher,” he demanded.

Phainon chuckled and pushed him harder. The wind blew past his face, ruffling his hair, and his stomach dropped as he rose. He unclenched one hand and reached out for the sun.

A loud bark just to Mydei’s left and his body instinctively prepared for a fight. Unfortunately, that meant his hands flew to defend his torso just as he

reached the peak of his swing.

“No, Mydei! Don’t let—“

Too late. Mydei was thrown from the swing and flew into the air where he hung weightless for one moment. He could see the sun glistening off the wheat fields, the sea in the distance, the pond right at his feet.

Then he crashed into the water.

It was shallow and did little to soften the fall even as he went boneless and hit the pond bed with the meat of his thigh and shoulder, hands around his head.

A splash and the water lapped at him as it moved. Phainon dropped to his knees and placed a hand on his shoulder, his back. “Mydei, are you hurt?”

His shoulder scraped a little on impact but it hadn’t popped. He catalogued his body for scrapes, bruises or aches.

“No.”

Another bark and then a splash. Mydei watched a fluffy white dog bound through the water towards them at full speed and it didn’t slow even as the distance rapidly shrank to nothing. The closer it came, the bigger it got.

“Snowy!” Phainon demanded attention but the dog didn’t hesitate before it threw itself at Mydei.

Mydei fell backwards into the water as the dog’s paws slammed against his chest and its tongue came for his face. It was moving too much, squirming and barking and slobbering all over him. He didn’t want to hurt it by grabbing with his claws so he held his breath, closed his eyes and kept perfectly still.

None of the strays Hephaestion chose to nurture were ever so boisterous and friendly. They usually showed their affection in smaller ways, curling up beside Mydei while he slept or following him around the camp.

“Yes, Snowy, you’ve said hello. Now get off him. You’re heavy.”

The weight lifted off his chest and Mydei dragged a handful of water down his face before opening his eyes. One of Phainon’s arms was wrapped around the dog’s middle, pinning it to his body and leaving its legs to dangle, while the other hand scratched behind its ear. The two of them looked remarkably similar.

Phainon smiled sheepishly. “He got a bit too excited.”

“I noticed.”

“He still thinks he’s a small dog.”

A quiet sound caught his ear. High and muffled. Mydei looked towards the courtyard.

On the upper levels, a head of pink hair leaned out the window. A girl stared at them drenched in the pond and cupped her mouth but the gesture did little to hide her laughter.

“Cyrene!” Phainon called when he noticed where Mydei was looking, raising both arms over his head and waving.

She waved back. “Phainon! Introduce me to your new friend later! I’ll do him an oracle reading.” Her head suddenly whipped around and any amusement fell from her face. “Got to go!”

She ducked back into the building, likely caught shirking her duties.

They clambered out the pond and Snowy danced at Mydei’s feet as they wrung their clothes out.

“Good thing the sun’s out,” Phainon said, bent at the waist and squeezing the fabric around his thighs. “Should help us dry quicker.”

Only Phainon’s lower half was soaked from where he waded ankle deep in the pond and then dropped to his knees. Mydei wasn’t so lucky and had

shouldered his way out of his tunic to wring it to the side. Snowy innocently lapped at the water as it fell.

“You really don’t have any injuries.”

Mydei twisted harder, mindful of his claws. “Why would I?”

“No reason,” he said with a shake of his head but he sounded relieved. “Although, you have a lot of tattoos. Are those some kind of Kremnoan tradition?”

“No.”

“So they’re just for you? Where does a kid even get those kind of ideas?”

“Stop calling me a kid. I’m only two years younger than you.”

“A lot shorter though.”

Mydei glared. “I won’t look shorter when I knock you to the ground.”

Phainon practically perked up at the offer to spar. “I’ll hold you to that. But I’m still claiming my prize. Speaking of, I thought of a better idea than standing around waiting to dry off. Come on, we’ll hit two birds with one stone.”

They closed the loop around the small village by walking down the hill, passing a scarecrow wearing familiar colours but when Mydei pointed at it Phainon only laughed and blamed Cyrene. The wind blew from the coast, tasting of sea salt, and followed them back into the village streets. It rang the wind chime above the entrance to a house no different from the rest.

“This is my home,” Phainon announced with a little chuckle and a scratch at the back of his head. “Come inside and I’ll find you a change of clothes.“

It was small. As he peered around the main room, Mydei guessed at two additional rooms. Phainon hadn’t mentioned any siblings; only a mother, father and dog, so they likely shared a bedchamber and one or two

mattresses. With the scent wafting through the air, the other room must be an indoor kitchen.

It was more spacious than the tents that could be shared between seven members of the detachment at a time. More sturdy against the elements.

A woman emerged from the room to the left, hair a mix between an aging grey and a recognisable white. “Phainon? What are you doing ba—you’re wet!” Two hands turned Phainon around and shoved him back towards the door, which meant right into Mydei. “Out! You’ll track water through the house.”

“B-but mum,” Phainon protested as he tried to dodge Mydei and stumbled over his own feet. Mydei side-stepped. “Mydei needs a change of clothes.”

She paused. “Mydei? That Mydei?”

“Yeah!”

The woman finally looked past Phainon and noticed Mydei’s short stature hidden behind him. Her face softened. “Hello.”

“Hello, ma’am.”

Phainon’s head whipped around with wide eyes and Mydei squinted back at him. Of course he knew how to be polite if he wanted. This was Phainon’s *mother*.

“Oh you’re soaked through, you poor dear.” She hurried towards him and he held himself perfectly still against instincts trained to flinch away, letting her lay a hand on his shoulder. “What has Phainon done to you.”

“I got wet too, you know.”

“I know. I can see you dripping on the floor.” A hand on each of their backs guided them out the door. “Go wait outside in the sun while I get a change of clothes. I’ll look through Phainon’s old ones for you.”

“Thank you, ma’am.”

She chuckled. “No need for that. Just call me Audata. Any friend of Phainon’s is a welcome guest.”

Beside the house was an area for storing sacks of grain and a bench to rest between the heavy labour. Snowy curled up at their feet as they sat and waited for Audata to come get them.

Mydei kicked his sandals across the dirt. “Your mum is nice.”

She offered him clothes and friendly touches despite dripping a mess across her floor, his unkempt appearance and the mark on his cheek that usually earned at least a suspicious second glance.

Phainon grinned and nodded his head vigorously. “My mum’s the best.”

“My mum…” He gripped the bench tight, claws chipping at wood but he couldn’t bring himself to let go. “My mum was too.”

When was the last time Mydei had ever spoken about his mother? The detachment had told him a few things here or there—a fierce warrior, the first to stand against his father’s tyranny, a valorous death—but Krateros was the only who could claim to know her. Even so, Mydei never asked about the woman he would never get to meet himself.

Phainon didn’t look at him, only leaning back on his palms and gazing into the distance. But Mydei knew was listening when Phainon’s foot bumped against his calf.

“My dad didn’t want me.”

Because wasn’t that the truth? Beneath all the grand prophecy, the right to rule, the legacy of Castrum Kremnos and the Titan of Strife, his father simply… hadn’t wanted Mydei enough to keep him.

He swallowed and kept his voice even, “She died trying to protect me.”

Phainon didn’t say anything but he slid closer, until their thighs were almost touching. But it was up to Mydei to decide whether they were or they

weren’t. Mydei pressed their sides together and they both watched the birds soar past the clouds and the sun across the horizon.

Much closer than the sky, a pink figure bobbed down the hill. One Mydei had only seen once from a distance but recognised enough as Cyrene hurried down the hill of the Sacramental Courtyard.

“There you are,” she panted when she finally arrived, dabbing her sleeve at the sweat on her brow. Her other arm pinned something to her side. “I finished my lessons. I’m Cyrene. It’s a pleasure to meet you officially.”

“Mydeimos.”

She slid onto the bench between Mydei and the edge. Snowy greeted her with a butt of his nose against her leg and she giggled, petting his head. “So what has Phainon told you about me?”

Phainon laughed but it pulled over a certain nervousness. “I haven’t gotten around to any of those stories yet.”

“Good. If your new friend is going to hear stories about me, they should come from me.”

“And if those stories of yours happen to involve me too? Probably doing something embarrassing?”

“Time preserves all. Even your most embarrassing moments.”

“Right… and would *time* happen to go by any other names?”

Cyrene smiled, innocent and mischievous and Mydei understood why the two of them got along so well. But she was really sitting too close to him. He might have moved away already but he was trapped between Phainon and Cyrene. Phainon also called her his best friend so Mydei didn’t want to stir trouble by offending her.

However, Phainon pulled away from Mydei’s side, shuffling down the bench. Mydei kept his breathing even instead of sighing with relief as he shifted into the newly opened gap.

Cyrene plucked the thing from under her arm and held it out to him. “Have you ever done an oracle reading, Mydei?” He shook his head and she opened the pages, pulling out a card from each page. “That’s all right. It’s actually quite simple. Just close your eyes, open your heart and pick a card. It’ll tell you your future.”

She held the cards out to him face down that supposedly held his future. He closed his eyes. It was just a silly game between children. There was no reason to put weight on what picture he happened to choose.

But he still thought of the future he wanted over the future he knew, somewhere in his mind, his soul, would come to pass. Had passed before. A future where his five dearest friends lived to see him become king and lead their people to a brighter future. A future where Phainon was with him until the end brought about by steel stained gold and Mydei wouldn’t begrudge him for it.

“The Ruler.”

His eyes opened. He hadn’t realised he’d chosen a card, let alone that Cyrene had taken it from him.

Phainon rested on Mydei’s shoulder as he leaned in for a glimpse. “What does that one mean?”

“It stands for discipline, authority and glory, but frequently also points to isolation and warfare,” Cyrene explained with a small frown, looking between Mydei and the card.

He huffed a laugh. “Seems pretty accurate.”

“No it doesn’t!” Phainon protested right in Mydei’s ear. He flinched but Phainon kept going, “Isolation? So Mydei’s going to be alone.”

“A ruler directs their will down onto the people,” Mydei recited from his lessons with Krateros. He kicked the ground. “Of course, the ruler has to be alone at the top.”

“That’s not true at all. I-I mean—“ he sputtered for some kind of argument, “—kings have queens, right? They have someone who rules beside them. So they’re not completely alone. And Mydei has me now.”

“*Haikas*,” Mydei hissed, face burning while Phainon only looked at him so painfully earnest and hurt at the idea of Mydei being alone. As though he hadn’t spent nine years completely alone. “Do you ever think before you speak.”

“At least you know it comes from the heart.”

“It certainly doesn’t come from your brain.”

His lips thinned, more sulky than angry. “Cyrene, show him my card.”

“If you wish.” She searched through her deck and pulled one card between her index and middle finger, flipping it to face them. “The Deliverer.”

Deliverer. That word sank in and, more than the name Phainon, Mydei knew it was *right.*

“According to the tripartite prophecy, this card means absolute harmony and perfection.” Phainon preened and Mydei rolled his eyes but didn’t interrupt Cyrene’s explanation. “In fact, it’s the only oracle without a dark side. It’s the card of someone destined to bear the wishes of many, and answer the world’s call.”

“See.” Phainon gathered Mydei’s hands in his. Warm, calloused along his palms and fingertips from a sickle and a sword. If Mydei just stretched out his curled fingers it would look like a prayer. “So tell me your wish, Mydei.”

“My wish.”

It was on the tip of his tongue. The feeling that something, everything, had happened before. This knowledge he couldn’t explain. The insane fact that Mydei had known him—known Phainon. Known the Deliverer—before he had even known the sun.

That his friends were fated to perish. That he was destined to die. That this feeling in his chest when he stared into Phainon's bright, desperate eyes and felt his hands, sharp metal edges and all, cradled inside Phainon's was in some way some Mydei's *love.*

Love like the kind that would kill his friends. Had killed his mother. Had and would kill Mydei too.

He turned away like that would free him from Phainon's sincerity ingrained in his mind. "It's not something anyone else can grant. I have to do it on my own."

"Then I'll do everything in my power to help."

"You don't even know me."

"Of course I do. You're my friend. If I can't grant the wishes of the people I care most about then what's the point."

It was that face again. Still tormentingly earnest but also set with determination. The expression of a warrior prepared for battle.

"Boys?"

They both looked to the entrance of the house. Audata stared back, darting between both of them and their joined hands before sliding away. "Oh, and Cyrene joined you."

"Hi, Audata. I was just leaving," she said, book flipping closed so she could jump to her feet. "I promised dad I'd help out with the cleaning today."

"Tell your parents I said hello."

"Will do."

When Audata invited them back inside, she had a change of clothes prepared for the both of them in the main room. Mydei was accustomed to a lack of privacy in the detachment so he had no qualms stripping out of his tunic and tugging Phainon's over his head.

It fit well. The clothes were still in good condition even if they smelled as though they had been in storage for a while. It had been well worn and well repaired, based on the added patches and stitches.

Light blue and white weren't the colours Mydei usually wore. Black and red was more practical: they needed less thorough scrubbing when dirt and blood was less visible.

Mydei turned to find Phainon already watching and he raised his arms. "How do I look?"

Phainon blinked and then stepped closer. "Here, let me help you."

With what? Mydei didn't have time to ask because Phainon's hands were already on his shoulders. He plucked at the fabric, shifting it around, brushing it down for invisible dust.

Mydei glanced across the room at Audata. She was stitching up the shoulder on clothes he recognised as Phainon's. The exact ones he tore yesterday during their duel. He felt a little guilty and accepted it was well deserved when his pleading eyes were only met with her amused smile.

He took a step back, looked Mydei up and down, and nodded to himself. "You look good. Come on, there's still one last place I want to show you. Bye, mum."

"Bye, Audata."

"Oh, Mydei, will you be joining us for dinner?" When Mydei shook his head, she sighed and lamented, "That's too bad. Feel free to come back another day."

Mydei didn't know how many *another day*'s he had in Aedes Elysiae. Until Krateros and the rest of the detachment had finished repairing weapons and rejoined the rest of them at least. The detachment were wanders by choice and by nature. Even if they were exiles, they were still Kremnoan. They sought out battle, spoils, honour like others sought out peace in a sleepy village only known for its wheat.

“I-“

“He will. I’ll be back for dinner, mum,” Phainon practically sang and looped his arm around Mydei’s to drag him out the door.

They ended up back at the shore. The fishermen invited Phainon onto the pier but he waved them off in favour of a private spot: a grassy bank sequestered away from view by the trees and shrubs.

Phainon kicked off his shoes and dipped his feet into the water. “How long have you been with the army?”

“Four years.”

Mydei knew he was silently doing the calculations—that Mydei was only nine years old when he joined—but his strange protectiveness flash like steel again.

He plucked some grass and let the wind take it away across the sea. He leaned forward like he could follow. “You must have seen a lot of Amphoreus.”

“I’ve wandered around.”

Phainon propped his elbow on his knee and rested his head against his knuckles, the sunlight reaching across the water to illuminate his hair, his eyes, and his smile aimed solely at Mydei. “There’s a whole world outside of Aedes Elysiae. Can you tell me about it.”

Mydei didn’t tell him about the lightless abyss, the monsters, the dead and a prophecy. But he did tell him about the Kremnoan detachment and every member that had passed through its ranks. By name, by lineage, by the battles they had fought together.

Phainon listened, enraptured, and Mydei told him more and more about the history that blew on the ends of their empty flag. He wanted him to know. To understand. The same way Phainon had shown him around a small town

encircled in golden fields, Mydei took Phainon’s hand and led him right through his home and into his heart where he could choose to stay or leave.

Chapter End Notes

> Endless dog metaphors with Phainon. He’s a big white puppy and I will never see him as anything else.

▶ Details

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

> Whether it’s discontent in the detachment or the black tide itself, Mydei solves his problems the best way he knows how: with his fists.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Two weeks passed in Aedes Elysiae. He had kicked off his sandals and competed with Phainon to wrangle fish from the river, eaten at Phainon’s home with his mother and father, had fallen asleep languishing in the wheat fields and woken up with flowers in his hair and Phainon half-curled around him.

That morning, he knew Phainon had something planned about… fairies. Whatever that meant. Phainon declared that Mydei just had to meet them because then it would be a secret shared just between him, Phainon and Cyrene.

But Mydei returned from Aedes Elysiae the night before to a figure stood guard outside his tent. He doubted a hostile party could breach the night watch but he still clacked his claws at his side.

Only when he came closer did he recognise the well-groomed facial hair and familiar armour.

“Krateros.”

He bowed his head. “Your Highness. This is a late return.”

At first, Mydei had consistently returned to the encampment before the evening darkened into night. But as the days passed and nothing hostile reared its head to disrupt the peace of Aedes Elysiae, it felt safe enough to return later.

“I can take care of myself,” he reminded him as he pushed into his tent.

Since they had stayed in the area so long, extra tents had been set up so everyone could have more space. Mydei’s was private.

He had joined Phainon’s parents for dinner again. Mydei thought he had a big appetite but Phainon’s parents had been concerned and insisted he feel no shame in eating everything he needed. One glance at Phainon inhaling his food explained their… skewed perception of a child’s appetite.

“Of course,” Krateros agreed and followed Mydei in, which meant he wasn’t just waiting to make sure Mydei returned safely. He had more to say. “But there are other things Your Highness is responsible for taking care of.”

Mydei stripped out of his clothes for a cleaner set. Still suited for combat; gauntlets still on. “Speak plainly, Krateros. Anything else doesn’t suit you.”

Krateros’ face was grave. “The detachment is restless.”

Mydei’s hands paused pulling his tunic into place. There were a lot of questions he could ask but that would just be… feigning ignorance.

Of course Mydei had noticed something was off. It started when Krateros’ men rejoined them after six days in Aedes Elysiae and they asked the question Mydei’s men had not yet asked: what now?

Every warrior appreciated a reprieve every now and again to recuperate their muscles, care for their spoils, and repair their weapons ready for the next battle. Anytime they set up camp somewhere peaceful for a little longer than usual, it was an excuse to make merry through the night and wake with the realisation of what a terrible decision that was, only to do it again that same night.

But that was just the problem. It had been two weeks and the Kremnoan detachment hadn’t gained new direction.

Aedes Elysiae had been found but for what was unclear. The prince's happiness? As fond as they all were of Mydei, that meant little if his happiness was tied to a small wheat farming village in some forgotten corner of Amphoreus.

The seeds of unease had quickly taken root in fertile soil. Kremnoans may not have been as savage as the rumours liked to portray them, but they were still undeniably warriors. They needed battle for more than honour, glory or the thrill of victory—they needed it like a blade needed a whetstone. It kept them sharp, capable and competent for the next inevitable battle. It was the difference between lying defeated in the dirt or trampling the dead underfoot.

Prolonged peace made them anxious, especially when the future was so murky. Mydei meant it when he regaled Phainon with tales of the detachment and called it his home. But, much like Castrum Kremnos where they all came from, if Mydei tried to settle on the earth in one place for too long then his home would move on without him.

"I'll deal with it," Mydei's promised.

He had known but hadn't addressed it—he simply hadn't found a good time to tell Phainon he would be leaving and maybe, just maybe, asking him to leave everything behind. To join the detachment instead of seeking out Castrum Kremnos—but the choice was taken from him when he was awoken that morning by a scuffle in the camp.

Fights weren't uncommon in the detachment. They were all grown men who slept with their hands on their weapons, shared extremely close quarters, and had hardly any company except for each other. The tiresome life in exile sometimes wore their patience thin and mere words were taken as slights that had to be refuted with fists.

But all they had in the wilds of Amphoreus was each other. If they didn't have that, then spoils, honour, glory was meaningless—they had nothing.

At least half the encampment could found in the brawling throng. It was all movement: the flash of weapons, blur of bare skin, the spray of blood. He

could hardly see beyond the outmost layers of the mob. His five companions were nowhere to be seen.

If he dove in he would just be another drop of water in a storming ocean. The longer he let them beat each other the higher the risk of real injury, even death.

He inhaled until his lungs couldn't expand any further. Then he unleashed it all to scream the war cry that led them all into battle on his heels.

The fighting stopped and everyone turned to him. Ingrained discipline winning over the adrenaline.

"Fall in line! And explain yourselves!"

The crowd parted and confirmed his suspicions. At the centre was Hephaestion, bloody nose and hair unkempt, and the rest of his friends in similar states nearby. He didn't spare them a second glance as everyone separated into lines loosely mimicking their battle formation.

A spar had gotten out of hand. Not unusual in itself but neither participant had backed down when first blood was spilled. And the rest of the detachment hadn't stepped in to prevent any serious injuries, but had goaded them on.

When Hephaestion intervened, Mydei's name was dragged in and the fight sparked anew. No longer an outlet for tensions but a two sided conflict. The Crown Prince grown soft over a boy.

He couldn't put it off any longer. Aedes Elysiae welcomed him with open arms and he had fallen into peaceful slumber hoping it could keep him away from the rest of Amphoreus in blissful ignorance. This was the price. His home splintered and he had driven the wedge in with his own hand.

He raised a fist high in the air. "We'll be marching on tomorrow. Wherever the rust scented winds of Amphoreus take us!"

The men cheered but he didn’t miss the skepticism on some of their faces. That was fine. He had squandered their trust with softness and indecision. It was only right for him to win it back.

“If anyone sees fit, I welcome any and all to challenge me in combat for the right to decide the detachment’s fate! Our very own Kremnos Festival!”

That sparked their resolve anew in a rush of cheers roaring like the fires of Strife.

Hypatos was the first to step forward. He was one of the oldest detachment members and one of the most outspoken about Kremnoan values.

Mydei had only just roused from sleep but he spent all nights in his tunic and gauntlets so he was ready for combat at a moments notice. All he needed was some stretches to shake off the last of his lethargy.

Hephaestion nursed his bloody nose while Perdikkas slathered his wounds with salve and bandaged them. Peucesta handed Mydei some grilled meat skewers for a meal, a little charred at the edges due to the distraction, and Ptolemy poured him a chalice of pomegranate juice. Leonnius had disappeared with a message for Phainon: an apology that Mydei wouldn’t be able to make their meeting.

“Are you certain about this, Mydeimos?” Hephaestion asked in a nasally voice.

He rolled his wrists. “Afraid I’ll lose?”

Ptolemy barked a laugh and poured another chalice of pomegranate juice for Perdikkas. “Mydeimos The Undying? Who would worry about you over your opponent?”

“It’s only until first blood,” he grumbled. Not death.

“All the more reason to make that blood count,” Ptolemy said with the same grin he wore while reading the exploits of past battles, and Peucesta nodded his agreement.

The others laughed but Hephaestion's lips were thin. Of course Mydei knew what Hephaestion's unspoken question had actually been. Was he certain about leaving Aedes Elysiae?

Out of all his five friends, Hephaestion was the dearest to him. His closet confidant. The others would have been able to deduce it easily enough that Mydei enjoyed spending time in Aedes Elysiae and was eager to meet with Phainon. But only Hephaestion could take one look at him mussed with dirt, wheat and grass, his face still flushed but not from the exertion of the sprint, and know he was happy.

"I am," he said unbidden and the others stopped laughing at the song Peucesta was reciting about Hypatos' inevitable downfall. "I am certain that this is the right decision for our future."

Hephaestion's eyes, softened with affection for a child that was finally happy, hardened again with the dedication to his prince. He raised his chalice of honey brew.

The other four followed and chanted as one: "May victory ever be yours, Mydeimos."

Hypatos' weapon of choice was a spear. He was adept with a sword but he had been one of the men to teach Mydei how to wield a spear. Now he brandished one against Mydei.

This duel would have to be quick. He didn't know how many other challengers he would have afterwards. A swift victory would conserve his energy and send a clear message to the others. They let him lead while they followed out of birthright and reverence to his immortal body, but he could earn it just the same.

He charged first and darted at the very tip of Hypatos' range. Like any Kremnoan, his weapon was an extension of his body. He knew the length of his spear just as he knew the length of his arm and didn't waste the energy going for a hit he couldn't land.

Instead, he worked on closing that remaining sliver of distance with small but certain steps and only jabbed to keep Mydei from breaching the edge of his range.

The duel wouldn’t be decided by first blood, but whether Mydei could breach Hypatos’ defences. Once Mydei was in, it would be much more difficult for him to defend himself. He could end him in an instant.

But Mydei had another advantage. Hypatos was one of the oldest members from a group of exiles that gathered long before Mydei was plucked out the woods like a feral dog. His age was beginning to set in and his Kremnoan discipline kept his body in fighting condition. But his age showed in his slightly hindered reflexes and less tricky manoeuvres.

Mydei dodged his jab and feinted that he was about to press an attack only to draw back again when Hypatos saw his bluff and blocked against a potential blow. Then he countered into Mydei’s open side.

One he had left exposed. He let the blade barely avoid skimming his torso. Then he snapped his arm shut around the polearm right below the blade and pinned it to his side. A risky, ridiculous tactic no would pull in the heat of battle. Except Mydei who didn’t fear blood nor Death.

He grabbed the staff and yanked with strength far greater this his small body. Hypatos was a better warrior than to let go but his grip faltered just enough. Mydei dropped the weapon and charged in.

There was nothing Hypatos could do. Mydei was too close, too fast, for him to bring the spear back into the new range of combat. Mydei thrust his claw at Hypatos’ face and his eyes closed with acceptance.

Metal scraped skin and red beaded from the surface. Hypatos opened his eyes and his fingers hesitated before they grazed the thin cut on his cheek, smearing blood.

Mydei stepped back and faced the crowd. “Who’s next?”

Kyros. Agathon. Polydorus. The list went on of warriors who stood tall against him only to spill their mortal blood and be knocked low.

The crowd roared, chalices clacking and coins rattling. People offered him food and drink between rounds. The purpose of the duels had been all but forgotten by the thrill of a good fight. Feats of strength that demanded their respect, their subordination, their loyalty. This was a Kremnos Festival and who better to emerge victorious than Mydei.

It was so loud Mydei was almost too overwhelmed to notice the sudden smell of Death. It appeared rapidly, unexpectedly, surging like the tide and clinging onto him, dragging him into the lightless depths.

“Mydeimos!” Leonnius pushed through the onlookers marking the edge of the arena. “It’s Aedes Elysiae. The whole village is being consumed by flames and monsters of the black tide.”

Aedes Elysiae.

Phainon.

“Everyone prepare for battle!”

The detachment scattered to gather their equipment. Mydei was already equipped and limber but he could only stand there, arms crossed and claws digging into flesh.

If Mydei had met Phainon like he intended, then they would have been together when the black tide arrived. They could have fought side by side, guarded each other’s weaknesses, come back alive.

His grip tightened. No. No that wasn’t right. Phainon was alive. He had to be. Mydei knew that he survived this so they could meet again in the future.

But he also knew that the two of them were never supposed to meet so young. A scale, an oracle card, a signet ring. The sun and moon exchanging places ten times to witness their duel.

Mydei wasn’t supposed to know the words Aedes Elysiae but knew them anyway. And what if that was the difference between life and death? What if Phainon died because of him.

“I’m going ahead.”

His feet pointed towards golden wheat fields set ablaze and a sun swallowed by the black tide.

Perdikkas stepped forward to protest but didn’t dare grab him, “Mydeimos —“

“Prioritise your lives and evacuate the villagers!”

The detachment had faced the black tide before. It was an inevitability of wandering the outskirts of Amphoreus, skimming along all the cracks where the black tide seeped through and stained all living things with the touch of not only Death but total annihilation.

They knew the procedure and charged in with caution and control—but not fear.

Not like Mydei. He was always fearful when black tide came. Not for himself but for a comrade too swept up in the fervour of battle, venturing too far into the tide, and getting swept away only to be spat back out an unrecognisable monster. One Mydei would take the responsibility of putting down.

The fields no longer smelled like wheat and sea salt. Every gust of wind mocked him, carrying embers and anguish that bloodied the sky the further he ran.

The hill Phainon liked to hide on and had shared with Mydei was empty. The schoolhouse was ablaze. The marketplace was gouged open. The statue of Oronyx and the Sacramental Courtyard had crumbled as the Titan of Time abandoned the village.

A shrill cry rattled like a death throe and he spun, thrusting his palm out. He caught a creature of the black tide by the jaw. Short and thin. Limbs grotesquely pulled longer than its body and stretched enough for orange to pulse through blackened skin.

It shrieked and charged at him again on clumsy limbs. The same way a child stumbled when they first learned to walk. He grit his teeth and grappled at its body. Its head swayed on its gangly neck and a low voice chittering grated on his ears. He needed to keep it away before it corroded him too.

He swung it round and knocked it to the ground. Feet on its back, he grabbed its head and pulled until a sickening crack echoed in his ears and the head came free and body fell limp. He tossed it aside and kept going.

The house he had shared a meal in with Phainon's family, changed in with old clothes Phainon worried himself over, napped in upon a thin cot he shared with Phainon—it was already a cremated husk of ash and memories. The wind chime rattled out a hollow welcome.

Phainon was still nowhere to be found.

Another scream, a human one, rang through the air. High, female. Followed by a rough bark Mydei knew anywhere.

He raced for the coast. There, cornered on the pier. Audata, Hieronymus and Snowy. Three creatures of the black tide. Audata held Snowy back by the collar while Hieronymus' shaky hands raised a sickle.

Mydei launched himself forward and slammed his feet into one creature's back. It flew off the pier into the water and sank into the sea dyed red.

The other two creatures rounded on him but he was already reaching for one and it had hardly finished turning before his claws were around its throat. He swept its legs out and jerked his arm back, tearing out its jugular in a putrid spray of rot.

One left and it was already swinging at him. No time to dodge. He whipped his hand up and the blade growing from its arms like distended bone and mutilated flesh clashed against his gauntlets.

He winced as it nicked skin further up his forearm. The skin would soon blacken. The injury was small enough he didn't need to worry about corruption.

He reeled his other arm back and punched the creature in the chest. It didn't stumble but it jolted back just enough for him to slip out from under its blade.

He snagged Hieronymus' sickle and dodged the creature's next attack. He closed the distance and looped the sickle around the back of its neck. When he pulled, the head came clean off.

Three creatures dead. Three civilians behind him. Audata and Hieronymus gaped at him. He flicked the evidence of the Black Tide from the metal and flipped the hilt for Hieronymus to grasp. Audata fell to her knees, catching herself on Snowy's big back, with a dry sob.

"Where's Phainon?" Mydei asked and motioned again for Hieronymus to take the sickle. It was hardly a weapon but better than nothing.

Hieronymus' hands still trembled but his eyes widened with alarm rather than the fear of death. "He-he isn't with you?"

"I…" He clacked his gauntlets. "I missed our meeting."

"He could be anywhere!" Audata wailed and her hand grappled at the air, too weak to reach for Hieronymus' leg right beside her. "Our boy. Oh my boy. What if—what if—"

"Phainon's strong," he interrupted, voice too hard for much reassurance but the two parents looked at him for it anyway.

Audata's eyes glistened with more tears to shed, heedless of all that had already fallen. "He is but… but he's just a boy. He's never even left home

and—“ another broken sob.

Mydei wondered if his mother would’ve cried like this for him, if she hadn’t died before he had been thrown away to drown in Death.

“I’ll find him.”

It was a ridiculous thing to promise. Amongst all the blood and smoke and abominations, that he would find a single person. Alive, uncorrupted.

But it was *Phainon.*

And his parents looked at Mydei with hope.

He led them to the edge of the village and told them to run east where they would eventually meet with his army. Then he dove back into the calamity.

There were likely still civilians trapped in corners he couldn’t find but he couldn’t hope to hunt them all down before the black tide did. So he did the next best thing.

At the top of the hill, stood in front of the Sacramental Courtyard, he let loose a war cry. It erupted from his stomach, roaring across the valley, and daring all to come face him and just try to steal a life even the Hand of Shadow could not.

He backed into the Sacramental Courtyard. Before everything could arrive, he tipped the bookshelves to block each of the side entrances. He couldn’t let himself get swarmed. He needed to funnel them in. A small crack between the top of the archways and the bookshelves meant he could slip through if he needed an escape.

The black tide surged to meet him. The creatures flooded in through the main entrance and Mydei tore his way through with hands, feet and teeth when necessary. It was almost nostalgic to taste a monstrous Death in his mouth and feel it rend as it collided with his immortal body.

The successive duels from that morning had diminished his energy but he was still a force to be reckoned with on the battlefield. Even if his senses

were slightly dulled and his reflexes slightly slowed, he was still leagues above the black tide.

He wrenched a creature's arms behind its back and kicked. Its body flew into a group of other creature charging towards him and knocked them aside. He swung the severed arm still in his grasp at another creature before he tossed it aside with a battle cry, preparing to dive back with his hands.

A shadow drifted over the courtyard.

He looked up. Thoughts, visions, memories surged through his mind and his back burned under the weight of it.

The figure was cloaked in black and masked in gold but Mydei could still feel its gaze pricking him. Stabbing him the same as that corroded great sword in its hand.

It tipped its head. Mydei took a single step.

A black blade ripped through his chest. He choked on gold spluttering past his lips. The blade of a black tide creature pulled free and he collapsed to the ground.

Through the cold waters of the Sea of Souls washing over him, he thought he heard someone call his name.

Mydeimos. When he was a child adrift and alone he hadn't known that voice. Now he knew beyond any doubt that it was Gorgo, his mother, who had accompanied him all these years. *Stand up. There are still great things for you to accomplish.*

The Sea of Souls was so cold. But it was also peaceful outside of that abyss he had fallen into after he was born. Not the lull of a warm place, but the cold silence turned his mind sluggish and his soul lethargic. Rest, it told him. Stay here. Forget the Strife that comes with living.

Mydei. And he hadn't known that voice either back then. Still, for the longest time, hadn't known even when the tales of his mother had filled him

with such certainty for the first voice. But the more he heard that name spoken to him everyday—overjoyed, sulky, outraged. In tears, in laughter, in fondness—the more certain he was. *Let's meet again.*

The first thing he saw when he opened his eyes was white. A beacon in the smoke and shadow, gleaming more than even the blade arcing through the air.

Phainon. His face twisted in anguish and crowned in gold. *Gold.* His blade an unending source of destruction against the decimation of his sleepy, sunbathed existence. His back wide and strong where he positioned himself like a bulwark between Mydei's prone body and the black tide coming to devour it.

Mydei coughed wetly and spat gold—the same gold coursing through Phainon's veins—across the floor. He rolled onto his front and his body was still sluggish when he pushed himself onto his feet.

Phainon's sword was locked with a black tide creature. He couldn't break away even as another creature aimed for his exposed side. Mydei whipped a fist across its face.

Phainon's head snapped around like he had been struck. "M-Mydei!"

"Focus!" he snarled back and grabbed the creature still reeling from the punch. He tossed it at the creature Phainon was still caught in battle with.

Phainon's gaze was still filled with too emotions to disentangle. But they were all locked behind a steely resolve and he nodded, raising his weapon ready.

They moved in sync to stand back to back.

The black tide was no match for them. It had struggled when they were alone but together they were unstoppable.

They fought beside each other, opening avenues for a new offensive, covering each other's weak points, and Mydei had never truly understood

the *thrill* Strife could bring until now. It wasn’t just fuel to strike harder, faster, to wrestle for glory and emerge victorious. It was a bulwark. A protector.

Mydei thought the epitome of combat would be the day him and Phainon clashed as incontestable equals, consumed by thoughts of victory. He was wrong.

This—moving in sync like the tide pushed and pulled, like the seasons handed over their reign to the next, like the sun and moon cycled—it was addictive. He wanted more. He wanted it to never end.

A klaxon boomed over the valley and signalled the arrival of the Kremnoan detachment.

Mydei dashed for the side exit and Phainon even didn’t ask before he followed. They hopped over the bookcase, a tighter squeeze for Phainon than Mydei, and ran for the hill where a flag whipped in the wind.

The tight formation parted like a curtain to pull them in and closed around them again. Mydei panted from exhaustion as the detachment pushed the two of them to the back lines but he fumbled behind him with a clumsy hand that could hardly remember to be gentle after such violence.

Phainon took Mydei’s hand and Mydei could face ahead knowing Phainon was right behind him.

Word had travelled faster than the two of them and Perdikkas already had a bottle uncorked. It was one of the most valuable items in the detachment’s possession and only two people had the right to so much as touch it: Mydei and Perdikkas.

“Wounds?” Perdikkas asked immediately.

Mydei stripped his clothes and gauntlets and tossed them aside. He looked at Phainon expectantly and his hands fumbled but he began to do the same. Their clothes were stained with the black tide and someone came to take them away, hands wrapped in ragged cloth, to be burned.

A few small cuts on his arms, his legs, and one across his forehead. There was also the wound through his chest. It had shrunken while he was pulled under the Sea of Souls. But where a normal wound would have already closed with only the thinnest fold of skin left behind that, too, would heal in a blink, the black tide kept the wound open. The blood sluggishly trickled down his torso.

Perdikkas cursed and tipped the contents of the bottle into a shallow dish. He dipped a roll of clean bandages in and soaked them through before winding them around Mydei's chest.

The water was from a Temple of Phagousa. Blessed. It could cleanse the effects of the black tide assuming they weren't so severe they twisted humanity to monstrosity. The detachment had taken them as spoils from an army of Phagousa followers. It would be near impossible get their hands on more.

"I found your parents and got them to safety. Snowy, too," Mydei said as Perdikkas handed him a cloth dabbed in blessed water for Mydei to hold against his cuts.

Phainon still hadn't moved. No reaction even as Perdikkas started wrapping his wounds. His eyes had never looked so dull.

He blinked unseeing at Mydei, then the words hit and his eyes widened. "My…"

He jerked forward and Mydei hardly had time to open his arms before Phainon fell into them and wrapped Mydei in his own.

"Thank you." His voice cracked and his arms trembled where they had been so strong holding his blade. "Thank you."

Mydei let the hold linger for a moment, knowing a single moment made all the difference in a patient's recovery or a battle. Perdikkas was looking at him disapprovingly but Mydei couldn't bring himself to shake Phainon off just yet.

Luckily, Phainon pulled back on his own and Perdikkas immediately went back to purifying his wounds.

They clothed themselves in spare garments. Mydei had his own set, smaller than the ones prepared for the rest of the detachment. Despite being several years younger, Phainon filled out the tunic in all but the slightest slack to the shoulders.

Mydei rifled through a chest beside the medical supplies until he found a small wooden box. He clicked the lid open and pulled out a fresh set of gauntlets. He slid his hands in and buckled until a hand caught his wrist.

“What are you doing?” Phainon demanded.

Mydei had no qualms about shaking him off now, testing his gauntlets with a curl and uncurl of his fingers. “Going back into battle.”

Gauntlets back on, Mydei stood to leave.

Phainon grabbed his shoulder and hissed, “Are you out of your mind?”

“Those are my men fighting on my orders.” Mydei tried to shrug him off but his grip was too tight and only tightened when he realised Mydei was trying to leave. “I can’t expect them to risk their lives while I wait in the back lines.”

Phainon’s grip dug in like *he* had claws to could gouge into Mydei’s flesh and hold him there. “You already died!”

And he finally noticed the tremor through that hand.

“I saw it.”

The look in Phainon’s eyes was *haunted.* The very same as warriors who swore they saw the ghosts of their comrades lingering on the battlefield. In their dreams.

“You-“ Phainon choked and his hand drifted down, large and calloused when it rested against Mydei’s chest. Above the still bleeding wound.

“Right here. You collapsed. Your eyes glassy. You weren’t breathing. Your heart stopped. Mydei…”

No one had ever looked at Mydei with such grief etched into their face. So overwhelming it surged from where it weighed heavy in Phainon’s chest right into Mydei’s squeezing lungs and clenching heart.

“You were dead,” Phainon whispered and he hadn’t realised the sheen of his dazed eyes had been tears until they spilled.

They cut through the ashen grime clinging to Phainon’s skin. Like a Blessing of Phagousa, it cleansed him of the mire and rot of battle. They glided over the curve of his cheeks, dipped under his jaw, down his neck to skin hidden under fabric or fell away to water the earth.

And Mydei was struck by how pretty Phainon looked in tears shed for *him.*

Then Phainon pulled his hands away and swiped at his eyes, his cheeks, wiping away his tears. It seemed for a moment that he was done but the tears renewed with a harsh sniff and he dropped his head into his hands.

Mydei’s tongue was heavy but he found the will to move it. “Find your parents. They’ll want to know you’re alive.”

“While you go into battle?” Phainon snapped but his anger was weakened by the teary waver of his voice. “I’m going with you.”

“No.”

He scowled. “So it’s all right for you to go but not me?”

“I don’t have time to explain,” he snarled back. “Just trust me.”

Phainon’s eyes stayed narrowed, skeptical, his lips bared in the beginnings of fangs. Then his face softened. The anger gave way and he looked Mydei up and down with renewed calmness.

He breathed a sound too rough to be a sigh, too tired to be anything else, as his whole body slumped. “Then go.”

Mydei turned to leave but something stopped him. He glanced back. Phainon was already watching him.

“Phainon…” Mydei clenched his hands at his side. “I’m sorry I missed our meeting.”

His eyes widened, blinking. His lips curled into the smallest smile and Mydei knew they would be okay. “Then make it up to me later.”

“I will,” he promised. “Let’s meet again.”

Then he took off and dove back into Strife to protect everything waiting behind him.

Chapter End Notes

> If you saw the chapter count go up… no you didn’t. My first draft is a near flawless piece of writing with perfectly cut chapters and no added or seriously extended scenes.

▶ Details

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

Mydei deals with the aftermath of the black tide.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There were immutable laws of combat within the detachment: avoid unnecessary cruelty, abide by Kremnoan military discipline, never leave comrades unguarded. To break such laws would incur punishment. Simple camaraderie wasn't always enough to hold everyone together, from the crafty to the fools all with their own hidden desires that could arise at the most inconvenient moments, through every hardship.

But there was another unofficial one: Mydei was the first to change into battle and the last to return. Some loathed that he reversed such glory for himself but who among them could compete with his immortal body as the spear tip of the offensive that breached enemy lines.

The black tide wasn't so simple. It couldn't be purged or coerced into retreat by any death defying show that scattered regular armies. But the detachment fought to slow its incursion so the backline could retreat with the injured and civilians.

The numbing exertion of battle wasn't anywhere near as exciting without Phainon at his back but the tear of corrupted flesh beneath his claws was an adequate outlet for the… fear and panic Mydei let consume him earlier. The moment he heard about the black tide ravaging Aedes Elysiae, he lost control of himself—his rationality, his military strategy, his leadership and responsibilities—when he should have known better. The detachment was his to *lead*, not simply command and vanish. Phainon was a worthy warrior who would have emerged scathed but alive.

Mydei channelled all his frustrations into his fist and ripped the head off a black tide creature. He picked up the body and threw it at an oncoming hoard, opening the way for his men nearby to descend with their shields up and spears out.

While his men fought in formations to watch over each other as they held the black tide, Mydei fought alone. He lashed out with the ferocity of a spear poised to end battles only to withdraw and find himself beside his comrades who needed him most, melding into their attack before he charged off again.

Ptolemy's spear soared past Mydei's head and impaled a black tide creature through the chest. Mydei grabbed the polearm and let the dead body slide itself off the spear tip. The dust hadn't yet settled before Mydei tossed the weapon back to its rightful owner.

The black tide grounded the detachment's cavalry. The horses' bulky stature, speed and strength made them even more dangerous than humans once twisted by the black tide.

"Start moving the frontline back. Do not take risks to hold it," Mydei commanded before he darted away to where he was needed and relay the same orders elsewhere.

When the klaxon sounded from beyond the horizon, the dying wails of the final black tide creatures almost drowned out the signal of the backline's safety. But the second sound bellowed long and loud over the valley and a final third confirmation. The black tide had been suppressed for now but there was no telling when the next surge would bring more creatures to the surface. Mydei ordered a swift retreat.

The wheat fields were still ablaze but the travel worn path was wide enough to let them through with sweat and warmed skin instead of burns. Mydei brought up the rear as they blitzed down the trail faster than the flames or the black tide could follow. They didn't stop until they passed the detachment's backline cutting a firebreak through the long grass.

The evening sky was empty of clouds and relatively warm and dry. No rain to douse the fire. If the detachment were the only concern, they would have packed up and left at the sight of wildfires feasting on dry lands but it wasn't an option with so many exhausted civilians and wounded warriors. A firebreak was the next best option.

The encampment had never been so full yet there was only one person Mydei ached to see. He wasn't so reckless he would skip a medical examination and purification from Perdikkas—not when his thigh still throbbed where a black tide creature had burst from the debris of a fallen house and cut him deep—but his head swivelled as he searched the many familiar and unknown faces.

There. Running errands. Brow set and eyes shadowed with fatigue. Hands steady as he carried a basket of dirtied gauze to be properly disposed of, but stopped long enough to offer a reassuring hand to an injured civilian bandaged around one eye.

As though feeling Mydei's gaze, Phainon glanced over. He took him all in, searching for blood and life on Mydei's battered body. Then he smiled, nodded and they both parted ways.

Neither had time for a proper reunion. Mydei needed treatment and a strategy meeting. Phainon was doing everything he could to ease the burdens of the detachment and refugees. What had become of his friends, neighbours, *home.* The one he had taken Mydei's hand and walked him through.

The medical tent was surrounded by those in need of treatment but Mydei was taken right inside. Leonnius had heard of their arrival and met Mydei there to take his message to Krateros, who arrived not long after Perdikkas had wrapped Mydei's thigh in gauze dampened with Phagousa's blessing. They were running low. Another problem he needed to deal with.

"Your Highness," Krateros's voice croaked from overuse and lack of water. Perdikkas poured him a glass and he threw it back in one swig as though it were honey brew.

“These are only minor injuries,” Mydei reassured him and Perdikkas raised a brow but didn’t argue over how the blade had gone clean through his thigh. “Tell me your report.”

“No Kremnoan casualties; seven major injuries. I’ve told the elders of Aedes Elysiae to draw up a census so they can track the alive, injured and dead.”

There was no category for missing when it came to the black tide. Only dead. A monster without its humanity was as good as a corpse.

The census was necessary to manage their resources. Even without exact numbers, they could continue to rely on the same water supply. The river would suffice for all of them. Once they were on the move, water skins would be more of an issue.

So would food. The detachment balanced rations with hunting and gathering. Either way, it would be a struggle to feed so many extra mouths. The civilians would only be with them for a few days, at most a week, but it was an issue of quantity.

“In the morning send Ptolemy’s cavalry to the nearest settlements,” Mydei ordered as he pulled a fresh tunic over his head.

Krateros stroked his beard. “I’ll order them to purchase supplies first, then warn them about the black tide’s closeness and the refugees about to move through the area.”

All garments touched by the black tide had to be burned; armour and weaponry cleansed in flames. Although Kremnoans possessed a certain laxity towards clothing, another reason to spit *barbaric* when they passed, Mydei could assume they had enough spare clothing to distribute since he failed to see any of the detachment running about the encampment naked.

“Injured and children take the tents. Our men will have to sort out exact arrangements between themselves. Everyone else sleeps rough.”

It was nightfall that finally lulled the chaos to rest. The civilians answered to the census in exchange for dinner rations before settling down to sleep. The detachment kept their distance from the campfires the villagers chose to cluster around but it was impossible to miss the quiet sobs that arose like the crack and snap of firewood under heat.

While Kremnoans honoured their dead with feasts and toasts to their valour, it was not the detachment plagued by loss. Of their bonds, their home and peaceful way of life. So the warriors allowed the villagers to mourn in silence and prepare themselves for the early morning departure.

Despite the protests from the detachment, Mydei gave his tent to a family of six. Instead, he lounged by one of the campfires along the edge of the encampment where Hephaestion joined him.

“Perdikkas told us the news.”

Mydei swirled the chalice of his preferred drink. An offering from Hephaestion, so Mydei had some idea that this conversation would go somewhere he didn’t appreciate. “Be more specific.”

“About that little friend of yours. The one who happens to bleed gold.”

Gold had contrasted against his eyes and his hair so beautifully.

Mydei took a sip. “Right.”

“Leonnius nearly fell flat on his face when he heard. Ptolemy and Peucesta are already composing verse about such a fated encounter. And I’m here asking you: did you know?”

“Not until the black tide spilled it from him.”

“And you asked him to join the detachment even so?”

Mydei grunted. “Never got around to it.”

“Mydeimos…” He sighed and shook his head, giving them both a chance to breathe as they drank from their cups; Hephaestion’s undiluted pomegranate

juice instead of the usual honey brew. It wasn't a night for merry drinks. "He won't be the one to ask."

"I intend to," Mydei argued around the rim of his chalice.

In his defence, he had. The timing had simply been poor. Mydei had been too swept up in the peace Phainon handed him freely, hiding away from his inevitable departure from Aedes Elysiae, before the consequences of his indecision brought duel after duel to keep the detachment together. Then the black tide.

"Will you act on those intentions?"

"Yes."

Hephaestion stayed silent but *waiting.* Until it became clear Mydei had nothing more to say and he arched a brow. "And yet?"

Mydei huffed. "*And yet* what?"

"Mydeimos, I have never seen the prospect of words frighten you so since you first learned to differentiate speech from noise."

Mydei's pride twinged but he hid it behind another long sip. It almost made it sound like Mydei was overwhelmed with cowardice.

"And yet," Mydei relented sharply but he sighed and the edge to his voice softened, "he experienced his first loss today. He needs time."

When members of the detachment were exiled by law, it took them time wandering alone to adjust to the loss of their home. When members of the detachment were exiled by choice, they had long prepared themselves for the same loss. Both groups still mourned that point of no return.

And who if not a warrior could appreciate the pain of witnessing life bleed out into nothingness for the very first time.

"His future is uncertain," Hephaestion agreed with a considering tilt of his head, blond hair burning red in the firelight. "But is that not precisely the

perfect time to offer him something he can grasp hold of and take heart in."

Mydei ran his thumb across the chalice's smooth surface, then the lines of the emblem of Strife carved into the face.

Was it cowardice? If Phainon rejected his offer then he would accept it—of course he would. There was nothing else to do—but it would still ache every time he reminisced on their short time together. They only fought as allies instead of sparring partners once but Mydei knew there would never be anything like it again.

To ask while he was still reeling from such a devastating loss, wouldn't that be the same as coercion? It was natural to seek out sympathetic comrades and stability during troubled times. But it wasn't as though he had no other options. He still had the parents and his dog he adored, and his community he could follow if all he wanted was safety, stability and people who understood.

If Mydei truly trusted Phainon, he would trust him to follow the choice most true to himself. Even if that meant parting ways.

His mouth curled into a self-deprecating smile. "As always, you make excellent points Hephaestion. If you dressed more modestly and masked that accent, you might even pass as an Okheman with that tongue of yours."

Hephaestion guffawed. "To be so insulted by you after offering my sincere advice. Would it be unwise to extend an offer of my company too?"

Mydei shook his head and his smile grew at his dearest friend. "Go rest. I assume you and the others managed to barter, strong arm and cheat your way into a tent for the night."

Hephaestion read the dismissal—Mydei would rather be alone—and left with a wish for a pleasant rest. He must have relayed the news to their friends because none of them came with an offer to join him. It was only him as he swirled his chalice in hand and gazed at the night sky. The day's smoke had blotted out all the stars.

The grass rustled under foot of something bigger than an animal and from the wrong direction to be the night watch. Only one person would be audacious enough to bother him.

Phainon stopped at the edge of the tarp, leaning into Mydei peripheral vision. “Mind if I join?”

He grunted his approval and Phainon lowered himself onto the edge of Mydei’s waxed tarp. Out the corner of his eye, Phainon winced at the pull of his exhausted muscles but he slowly laid down and breathed with relief when he was finally flat after being on his feet all day.

Mydei finished his pomegranate juice and set the chalice aside. He swiped the back of his hand across his mouth. “You should be resting. We have an early morning.”

They needed to get further away from the black tide as quickly as possible. If someone had ever been foolish yet intelligent, courageous yet reckless, enough to measure the exact speed of the black tide’s spread, they weren’t a member of the detachment. They could only assume it was swift and act accordingly.

Phainon tucked his hands behind his head. “Couldn’t sleep. What about you?”

He shrugged. “Couldn’t sleep.”

They both gazed at the same empty sky. Like every star meant to guide them had been snuffed out by the black tide as easily as blowing out a candle. Even the moon was dim and hazy.

“I’ve never seen so few stars in Aedes Elysiae,” Phainon mused, voice lower than Mydei had ever heard it. Too weighted to attempt his usual levity. “Although, it’s not really Aedes Elysiae anymore, is it?”

It was the nature of a wanderer that Mydei had never been attached to one place. The closest he’d ever come was Aedes Elysiae but that was put to an abrupt end. But there were other things Mydei knew how to hold onto. A

home constantly on the move. Nowhere and yet with him every step of the way.

“So long as you remember how the night sky looked from the wheat fields, *that* will be Aedes Elysiae.”

Phainon stared at the sky, and Mydei hoped he was seeing stars, before he rolled onto his side. “You’re such a brute when you fight yet you say the most profound things.” There was almost humour there, if it weren’t so fragile. “Is that the mark of a good prince?”

Mydei took in the view one final time before he rolled, one arm braced under his head, so they were face to face. “Where did you hear that?”

The distance wasn’t much different than when they had laid flat side-by-side. If anything it was larger without the widths of their shoulders stretched across the tarp. But the space narrowed as they curled towards each other.

They had been closer before. Napped beside each other on a cot at Phainon’s house because Mydei was clearly exhausted after a night plagued by the past, or in the wheat fields after a good spar.

But it felt different when Phainon nuzzled his cheek against his tucked arm and watched Mydei, blue eyes almost alight beneath his lashes. There was a scabbed cut just above his brow, a patch of gauze on his cheek, and his skin was clean but his dirtied hair was still ashy.

Mydei wanted to reach out and learn whether his hands could be gentle enough to run along the cut without drawing fresh blood. But he gripped his forearm and waited for what came next.

Phainon shrugged, giving nothing away. “Around. Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos Mydeimos. I guess that oracle card was more literal than I thought.”

Mydei’s grip tightened but he didn’t look away. He owed it to Phainon to meet his eye when confronted with the fact he had been less than forthcoming about his identity. “So…”

“So?”

“What now?”

Phainon blinked. “What now?”

“That’s what…” Mydei exhaled. He couldn’t begrudge Phainon for being difficult. “That’s what I said.”

Phainon nuzzled his head against his arm again. His languid blink was heavy with sleep but he forced his eyes to stay open, if only half-lidded. “What do you want to happen?”

“Don’t do that.”

“Do what?”

Mydei’s face scrunched. “Defer to me. I thought we were…”

Friends. But he was friends with Hephaestion, Perdikkas, Leonnius, Ptolemy, Peucesta. They deferred to his judgement all the time. It was an inevitability when there were more titles to their relationship than *friends;* too many threads tangled together of what they were and did for each other. Friends, confidants, comrades. Teachers and student. Ruler and citizen.

With Phainon…

“Aren’t we friends,” he muttered in his arm, so childish it burned his ears. It wasn’t the same as his other dearest companions but he said friends and it sounded like *more.*

Either Phainon didn’t notice or he didn’t care because he smiled and stretched out a hand. Mydei squeezed his arm a final time and reached out. His gauntlets were sharp, deadly, but he was mindful of all the cutting edges when he twined their fingers together.

Phainon’s smiled, soft at the corners and the crease of his eyes. “We are.”

The burn in his ears spread lower and Mydei concentrated on keeping it out of his cheeks. “Good.”

Phainon was already half asleep and Mydei expected him to drift the rest of the way. He had a long day, and another come morning.

But his fingers twitched under Mydei’s hand and his lashes fluttered, eyes darting down when they had so steadfastly held Mydei’s own.

“What?” Mydei’s voice was low, word slurring together. Maybe he was closer to sleep than he thought too.

He shook his head, biting his lip. “Forget it.”

He shed the exhaustion with a few hard blinks. “Why? It’s bothering you.”

“You have enough troubles to deal with.”

“Without adding you to my burdens?” He let a little meanness, some mockery, seep through. “Stop assuming my limits. If I couldn’t handle it, I wouldn’t ask.”

Another flutter of his lashes as he briefly met Mydei’s eye only to glance away again but Mydei knew he had him.

“Cyrene…”

Mydei hadn’t hovered during the village census. He had delegated Krateros to interact with the village elders and ensure everything was organised for refugees while Mydei managed the detachment. But it was impossible not to notice a head of pink hair missing from the encampment.

He hadn’t known her very well beyond her devotion to Oronyx and her mischievous nature hidden behind an innocent smile. It was Phainon that connected them. But he thought they could have been friends, too, one day and it was all the possibilities of a future she wouldn’t have, one he failed to protect along side the others, that he mourned.

Mydei squeezed once and Phainon gripped tight in turn.

“We were together just that morning. How did she…” His teeth dug in harder than before, enough Mydei expected to see gold. He shook his head and scrunched his eyes shut. “I just can’t believe she’s…”

Another squeeze and Mydei felt his fingers relax again. He ran his thumb along the meat of Phainon’s thumb. “I’m sorry.”

If he made their meeting that morning, been there when the black tide struck, then maybe, just maybe, Phainon would still have best friend.

And he knew it never would have happened. He never would have abandoned the detachment in such a precarious state.

But if Mydei had been better? Done better as their leader? More attentive, more skilful, more mature and less selfish. Maybe he could have alleviated the unease before it erupted and still arrived to their meeting on time and walked away with everything still intact.

Weak and wet, Phainon laughed. “Why are you apologising? I talked to my mum and dad. They told me how you saved them. Snowy, too.”

“I was looking for you.”

But Phainon had been the one to find him in the Sacramental Courtyard. Golden blood pooling around a dead body.

Mydei tucked his legs tighter, almost to his chest. The wound had long since closed but he could still feel the trickle of blood down his chest as though it hadn’t. “I never wanted you to see that.”

“You dead?” He breathed a gutted, hollowed out laugh. “Yeah I never wanted to see that either.”

“You don’t have to pretend to be so glib.”

“I already cried in front of you today. Let me try to preserve some of my dignity.”

Mydei frowned and shuffled closer, just a little, like that minuscule distance would help him rip that mask right from Phainon's face. It would be easier to speak in Kremnoan, the language could be more crude than common tongue but he found it easiest to express himself in, yet it would defeat the purpose if Phainon couldn't understand. So Mydei worked his tired mind to translate the things he needed to say.

"You don't need dignity. You need to mourn your loses and move forward."

Phainon closed his eyes and inhaled deep, releasing a soft sigh. "Mourn, huh." His lips thinned and his jaw tightened around a short, shaky inhale. "That black-robed swordsman, *he* brought the black tide to Aedes Elysiae. Everything I wanted to protect is gone. How am I supposed to move forward when he still lives?"

The two of them had become similar in ways Mydei would never wish upon anyone. Least of all Phainon. No matter how Phainon had let him pretend at playing house in Aedes Elysiae, as much as any sword or spear, his body of steel was forged for battle. Mydei's jagged edges didn't slot into a life of peace.

But peace fitted Phainon in the way peace fitted all lives untouched by Strife. Even more, it embraced him in endless wheat and the sea breeze. A carefree smile, an idealism, a sense of heroism.

Now every shadow upon Phainon's face was burdened by all he had lost and sought retribution for. Like one final death would lift that darkness and make the sun rise warm and tranquil over the wheat fields again.

"Revenge is nothing more than an obligation of the living to the dead," Mydei spoke low but firm.

That wasn't the lesson Krateros had taught him, nor the expectations of the detachment—all of whom eagerly awaited for the day he claimed his father's head. To them, revenge was a matter of honour and succession.

Yet Mydei struggled to see what honour or satisfaction could be found in the act. It was his duty as his mother's son to avenge her and send the man

who murdered her down the Sea of Souls so she could confront him for herself. But he wouldn't celebrate when his father was dead at his feet—hadn't as far as the vague mural of memories told him—just mourned that it had been necessary at all.

He exhaled and could see his reflection held in Phainon's eyes as he came so close their foreheads almost touched, words brushing skin as though he could force Phainon to take them all in. "But you bear responsibilities to those who still live, and to yourself."

A shuddered breath and Phainon rolled onto his back, keeping their hands firmly intertwined but throwing the other arm over his eyes. "What does forward even mean? All I wanted was to protect my home. Protect and help everyone. Now I don't know where to go from here."

Mydei pinched his hand but Phainon's arm didn't move. He frowned and demanded sharply, "What are you talking about now?"

That got Phainon to uncover his eyes and roll his neck to meet Mydei's glare. "Huh?"

He huffed and averted his eyes for a beat before he steeled himself to speak his next words to Phainon's face. "You so arrogantly declared you would make my wishes come true. Wouldn't the Deliverer have to stay by my side to make that happen?"

It took Phainon a few beats to understand but when he did his eyes blew wide. "Mydei…"

He swallowed the rest of the words down.

Mydei squinted. Would he really have to say it plainly before Phainon stopped doubting himself? "You have a place in the Kremnoan detachment. If that is what you want."

None of the Kremnoans would refuse. They all knew that Phainon was the one the Sea of Souls, or wherever that knowledge had come from, had sent Mydei to find. Their patience had worn at the idea of Mydei choosing to

settle in a small wheat farming village for some boy rather than live up to the glory expected of the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos and their hope to return to a place they could proudly proclaim as home.

It was different if Phainon joined their life of wandering. And he had the skill to cut down any objections through a duel.

Phainon hadn't stopped staring.

Mydei clenched the hand tucked behind his head but kept his expression carefully neutral. "Or you can seek out Okhema." That was where they were recommending all the refugees flee to. "The holy city won't turn a Chrysos Heir away. And you won't have to fear another incursion of the black—"

Phainon jerked upright and Mydei hissed as his shoulder tugged in its socket but he didn't have time to complain when Phainon's hands landed on either side of his head.

There were no stars and no moon. Phainon's face was cast entirely in darkness as he loomed over Mydei. But his eyes shone with all the stars plucked from the night sky above his home.

His smile stretched across his entire face. Happier than Mydei had ever seen. "I'll come with you!"

The burn spread down to his cheeks, maybe even his neck, as he hoped the darkness was enough to hide it. "Oh."

"Well, actually I will have to discuss it with my parents. They're far from old but they aren't young either. So it depends on their plans and the rest of the villagers but I would be a terrible son to abandon them if they have no one else to rely on—"

"Breathe."

Phainon took a deep breath and it was too dark to confirm but Mydei thought he saw a slight tinge to his cheeks. So Phainon could absolutely see

his and that knowledge made his skin warm even further.

“But they want me to happy,” Phainon concluded quietly, an absolute fondness overwhelming his face. They was so close if Phainon leaned down any further his bangs would brush against Mydei’s forehead. “So will you tell me what your wish is?”

“No.”

“Then how am I supposed to make it come true?”

“Figure it out yourself, *Deliverer*.”

The name rolled off his tongue so naturally, even more so than the name Phainon.

He pouted and flopped to his side, thinking for a moment before a sly smirk returned. “Scared? Just because I fulfil your wish doesn’t mean I’ll leave.” His grin evened out into something sincere. “I’m staying, Mydei.”

Mydei laughed through his nose and felt his smile grow to match. “I know.”

A few moments passed. Then…

“So what’s a Chrysos Heir?”

Mydei waited for Phainon to laugh at his own joke but he only blinked expectantly at him as the silence dragged on.

After a brief explanation of Amphoreus’ history, probably butchered but Krateros and Ptolemy didn’t need to know, Phainon finally understood that there was a deeper meaning to his golden blood and it was time to rest.

In the morning, after two weeks that had passed like a blissful daydream only to end in a nightmare, the detachment packed up the encampment and prepared to set out.

While Phainon woke up and immediately disappeared to find his parents, Mydei checked through his belongings as he packed his tent. Nothing had

gone missing at the hands of the family he let use his tent that night. Luckily the parents had enough common sense and control of their children to realise it would do more harm than good.

The tent flap rustled and a head of white peeked in. “Mydei.”

Mydei’s heart quickened but he kept his expression in that neutral set most people interpreted as anger and sign to stay away, yet Phainon was so undeterred by. He had news but it was impossible for Mydei to read which kind. How did Phainon balance but boldness and sheepishness at once.

He motioned and Phainon stepped inside, both hands tucked behind his back, while Mydei asked, “What?”

“Here.”

Phainon revealed his hands. A chalice of pink tinged liquid and a bowl of porridge mixed with honey, pomegranate seeds and some herbs. Mydei recognised the touch of Hephaestion and Perdikkas. They knew he would scold them for adding unnecessary things when their rations were in such short supply as is.

But when Phainon presented them to him with a little smile, Mydei could only take both with a muttered thanks.

Then Phainon smiled abashedly. “I know how busy you must be but do you have any time to spare?”

Mydei swallowed a mouthful. “All right. For what?”

“I spoke with my parents.” Phainon fidgeted with his hands. Mydei had never seen Phainon fidget before but he only ate in silence to let him continue at his pace. “They decided to head to Okhema with a lot of the others, so they don’t need me to join them.”

Oh. *Oh*.

Phainon grinned and it was almost like the past day really was nothing but a nightmare and Phainon had awoken unchanged. “So I’ll be true to my word

and deliver your wish, Mydei.”

It was difficult to be dignified with a bowl of porridge in his hands so he exchanged it for the chalice.

He raised it high. “The Kremnoan detachment welcomes you.”

“I don’t have a cup.”

“I’m aware.” Mydei took a sip and then offered it to Phainon. “We share this one. To mark the beginnings of an alliance.”

Phainon took the chalice, stared at the pink contents with an almost amused twitch to his lips, then raised it high before taking a sip.

It was an old tradition. So old it used to be blood in that cup shared between two in an allusion to their new alliance honoured the same as blood ties.

“Oh.” Phainon blinked at the chalice. “This is good.”

Mydei’s smile grew. Finally, someone who could appreciate his good taste. “It’s pomegranate juice and goats milk. Have it if you like it so much.”

Phainon only took another sip, savouring the taste before he swallowed, and then passed it back to Mydei. “My parents want to thank you.”

His hand stopped midair, gruel slipping off his spoon back into the bowl. “Why?”

Phainon’s brows furrowed in confusion. “Because you saved their lives.”

Mydei stirred the porridge. “Huh.”

No ordinary person had ever thanked the Kremnoan detachment for something. Let alone Mydei personally.

He shrugged. “If they feel the need.”

Phainon brightened again. “Great. I’ll bring them to you.”

“Now?”

“Yeah!”

And then he was gone before Mydei could tell him that he wasn’t ready for Phainon’s parents to see him as anything other than the stray Phainon had picked up in the wheat fields.

Mydei cursed and quickly shovelled down the rest of his food and cleaned off his face. When Phainon still hadn’t returned, he occupied his hands by packing.

He had rolled up the mattress, locked up his spare set of gauntlets and was about to begin taking the tent down by the time Phainon pushed the flap aside again. He held the tent open for his parents and his dog.

Snowy bounded right up to Mydei and he quickly dropped to his knees before Snowy felt the need to lunge at his face. He happily rolled over and Mydei carefully ran his gauntlets across his belly.

Both Audata and Hieronymus looked better than the last time Mydei had seen them. But that would likely stay the lowest point of their lives for a long time. Hopefully until the end.

Their skin was pale with bruises under their eyes from a poor night’s rest and an early morning. The clothes intended for warriors were ill fitting on the bodies of two farmers.

Satisfied their condition was as good as could be expected, Mydei lowered his eyes back to Snowy. He moved his hands rhythmically, watching Snowy’s tail sweep side-to-side and ears twitch. It was soothing.

A pair of bent knees entered the top of his peripheral vision. It was Hieronymus’ hands—thick, darkened by long days in fields that no longer existed, wrinkled with the first signs of age—that joined his on Snowy’s belly and rubbed.

“Thank you,” Hieronymus said but his hands kept the same rhythm against Snowy’s ribs. “Thank you for saving us. For risking your life for us and our son.”

Another set of knees. Now Audata’s hands—thick from labour but fingers still more slender, suited for needlework as much as a sickle—joined to scratch at Snowy’s exposed side. “We want to be able to thank you properly, one day, with a meal. We hope you’ll join us.”

Mydei held his breath and waited for them to retract the offer, as though a Prince of Strife could ever be crammed into the rickety seat of a small wooden table to eat a simple harvest. But a warm thigh pressed against his as Phainon, dressed in the red and black of the Kremnoan detachment, ruffled Snowy’s neck and Mydei lifted his eyes. Audata and Hieronymus were already looking at him with the same warm smile they had given their son.

He immediately ducked his head again and promised, “I will.”

Snowy panted happily under the attention of four sets of hands joined together.

Chapter End Notes

> Finally got to the “Phainon joins the Kremnoan detachment” part of this story. One of the two original premises of this story and it only took… 6 chapters…
>
> If you see the chapter count suddenly jump again… I’m sorry. Next chapter was supposed to be 5 short-ish scenes in one chapter but uhhh they’re not very short-ish anymore. So now I’m debating splitting them into five chapters or keeping them in one chapter that’s just really really chunky. Like 15k to 20k chunky… I open a google doc and the words magically appear from the void.

▶ Details

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Mydei is poisoned and Phainon takes care of him.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In Mydei's fourth year of exile, the Kremnoan detachment encountered a waylaid army from Ladon. In the midst of battle, Mydei took a poisoned arrow to the chest meant for Perdikkas.

His body healed all wounds but poison was always a tricky task. He needed to either break it down or expel it. Much like the black tide, it sank into his flesh and blood where it slowed the recovery of his other wounds.

His body burned but he shivered under the fabric draped across his chest and his sweat ran cold. A wet cloth dabbed across his forehead and he tried to reach out a hand but barely managed to twitch his fingers into the cot.

The world was a blur. He couldn't see beyond vague white blots and two specks of blue. He couldn't hear over his blood rushing in his ears and leaving him lightheaded.

His mouth was dry, his throat parched, and he opened his mouth. *Water,* he wanted to ask, but it scratched the inside of his throat and caught there and if he tried to spit it out it would come with blood.

The person understood anyway. A hand slipped behind his back, sitting him upright enough for him to swallow when something cold pressed against his lips and tipped liquid into his mouth.

It was bitter. He gagged and tried to jerk away but the hand slid across his back, looping an arm around his waist that kept him firmly in place.

“I know,” a voice murmured and his heart quieted in his ears. “It tastes pretty awful. But it’ll help speed up the process. Can you swallow for me?”

The hand came back to rub gentle circles into Mydei’s back. When he finished drinking the decoction, it tugged him into something warm and solid. Someone’s side. The hand ran through his hair, pushing back his sweaty bangs.

“I have to change your bandages too,” the voice continued in a smooth, gentle cadence like mothers putting their child to sleep. “The arrow wounds haven’t healed up yet. But the bleeding’s staunched enough that even I can be trusted to watch over you.”

He felt himself being shifted around but he couldn’t bring his body to move. He was being a burden and not a prince—not a would-be king who would find the find a better path for his people—but his nose was full of the scent of wheat. He closed his eyes and breathed deeper until hints of sea salt came through.

Cold air hit his chest before something colder smeared across his skin. Then he was jostled again, almost rocking from side to side, as the bandages were wound back around his torso. After that, he was laid back down to rest. With the fingers scraping through his hair and that voice murmuring in his ear, he was asleep before the pain had a chance to fade.

When he woke up, it was Ptolemy with a book at his bedside and Krateros stood guard by the entrance and Mydei didn’t know if his chest ached from the remaining poison or the absence of two particular people.

“Mydeimos,” Ptolemy noticed the lucidity in Mydei’s eyes first and hurried to help him sit up. “How are you?”

There was still the dull ache where the arrows struck and his heart underneath. He was thirsty and lightheaded. His fingers took twice as much effort to curl and three times as much to lift the blanket.

“Fine,” he said. “Report what happened.”

Ptolemy glanced at Krateros and then retreated from the bedside. “I will fetch Perdikkas, and a hearty meal for you to replenish your strength.”

The burden on Mydei’s shoulders eased somewhat at the mention of Perdikkas: alive and healthy enough to treat Mydei as a patient for the same poison that would have sent anyone else down the Sea of Souls. But the sheer relief only made it more difficult to convince his body to cooperate as the sheer *need* to get up in search of a sick bed, patient pale and feverish and pained into incoherence, dissipated.

Krateros took up the empty position by the bedside. Shoulders back and armour polished of blood, always so rough yet dignified, as though the battle and Mydei’s injury never occurred and this meeting wasn’t in the medical tent.

“*That boy,*” Krateros said with barely concealed distaste, “noticed you were struck down and carried you to the backline with Perdikkas close behind. We sustained a few major injuries but most were minor and we defeated the enemy army.”

While Mydei’s face maintained a stony disposition, his hand unclenched around the mattress. No one died because of his mistake. When Ladon’s flag came over the horizon his rationality frayed and when he saw that archer take at Perdikkas it snapped completely. There must have been another way but Mydei’s emptied of anything except Perdikkas’ final farewell. Pure instinct screamed to throw his own immortal body forward.

Now Krateros’ face twisted with open disgust. “We recovered the antidote to their poison. To think Ladon would fall so far as to use such dishonourable tactics to claim an unearned victory.”

Mydei wanted to pinch the bridge of his nose and massage his forehead where he felt a headache building but his hand was too heavy to move. He needed to conserve his strength. “Who saw?”

“That boy—“

“He has a name,” Mydei interrupted and Krateros words fell silent between gaping lips.

This was the first time Mydei had ever interrupted him. He respected his experience and teachings too much. But the world was slowly beginning to spin and he initially refused to interfere in such a blatant show of favouritism—nothing Phainon ever achieved would earn him the detachment’s respect if he did—but he wouldn’t tolerate such disrespect now that Phainon had earned more.

“He risked his own life for a body he knew was immortal. Isn’t that the type of character and camaraderie Strife seeks to honour.”

“That is correct, Your Highness,” Krateros said but his expression spoke of more before his lips did, “But that boy is not Kremnoan by birthright.”

“And yet the Kremnoan detachment has chosen to honour him as such. As have I,” he pointedly reminded him. “So speak his name next time or I may have issue recalling who *that boy* is.”

Krateros cleared his throat. “Yes, Your Highness. Phainon of Aedes Elysiae —“ he had to switch to common tongue just for Phainon’s name before sinking back into the familiar harsh Kremnoan, “—laid his outermost garments over you and carried you on his back. If the enemy realised you had been struck down in a less temporary way than usual, they didn’t act on it.”

“And our men?”

“Some may have noticed your absence in the heat of battle but Hephaestion and Phainon of Aedes Elysiae rallied their morale.”

Mydei huffed a laugh. Peace suited Phainon like a well-worn cloak but he took to battle just the same as any Kremnoan. Perhaps better with that golden blood in his veins. “And now?”

“The detachment are eager to celebrate this victory with their prince.”

Careful not to betray the movement beneath the blanket, he slowly tested the clench of his hand. Still a little numb but nothing he couldn't handle. Once he stood and his blood started pumping faster, his movement would come back quicker. It wouldn't be seamless but the others would be too drunk to notice.

"I'll offer them a toast once I'm out of a sick man's clothes."

Krateros turned to exit at the dismissal and give Mydei privacy to change. But the flap lifted before his hand could reach it and a head of white rushed passed him to the bedside.

"Mydei, you're awake!" Phainon's voice was too loud but Mydei withheld a flinch. "How do you feel? Do you need anything? Here let me get you some water."

He reached for the jug of water by the bedside and a chalice.

"I have no need of it," Mydei cut him off, heart quickening when he realised Krateros wasn't leaving.

He watched the exchange but Mydei wasn't certain if that was genuine curiosity or curiosity waiting for Phainon to finally reveal his true colours and stab Mydei through the back.

"Yes you do," Phainon countered immediately, chalice already half full. "The only drinks you've had since you went down were those nasty decoctions prescribed by Perdikkas. You were feverish and sweating out the poison. You need water before anything else."

With his declaration, he held the chalice out to Mydei. Eyes bright despite the shadows underneath from the hours of sleepless care he had given. Mydei was doomed.

He swallowed, as dry as Phainon had assumed, and unfurled his hand from the mattress. He suppressed every tremble when he reached for the chalice and Phainon didn't notice anything amiss when he let go for Mydei to take it in hand. The cool weight spread through his palm and fingers.

The muscles spasmed. The chalice clattered to the floor. In the damning silence, Mydei shoved his hand back under the blanket.

Phainon stared at the water splashed up his calf and pooling under his sandals like it had betrayed him and not Mydei.

“Phainon—“

“Mydei, show me your hand?” He smiled when he asked but it lacked his usual carefree and easy warmth. A smile that bordered on a threat.

“My body is fine.”

“Then you should have no problem showing me how fine you are.”

Phainon wasn’t one to give up and Mydei could only lie so blatantly for so long as though the evidence weren’t right beneath their noses. Krateros could be just as stubborn. The two of them would get on well if Krateros could just let go of his prejudices.

He withdrew his hand from beneath the blanket. He didn’t have the strength left to stop the tremors when he dropped his wrist into Phainon’s awaiting palm.

His brows furrowed but it wasn’t with anger, more frustration like the twist of his mouth. “Mydei, you’re shaking.”

“Genius. I wouldn’t have noticed if you hadn’t said anything,” Mydei bit out.

Phainon didn’t flinch at the insult. He inspected Mydei’s hand with that same stricken expression, witnessing every pathetic tremble where his hands were steady enough to tear warrior’s hearts from their chests and monster’s heads from their shoulders.

“Ptolemy told me you woke up. Perdikkas insisted you would be fully recovered once you did,” Phainon mused lowly. He aligned their fingertips and stretched Mydei’s hand out. “So why are you clearly not yet recovered.”

“It’s nothing to be so concerned over,” Mydei said through clenched teeth and tried to wrench his hand back.

But Phainon’s fingers encircled his weak wrist and held as firm as his eyes pinning Mydei in place. “Mydei, you need more rest.”

He barked a laugh. “Don’t declare things you know nothing about. Who knows my body’s condition more than I?”

Phainon’s lips thinned and the frustration hardened under a layer of grim resolve, like this was another battlefield and Phainon would be the victor. The only warning was the squeeze around Mydei’s wrist before Phainon yanked him straight from the mattress.

Mydei wasn’t prepared. His legs buckled and the only thing that stopped him hitting the floor was Phainon. A hand in his. A hand around his waist. The world spun to the rhythm of his heart finally pumping hard and fast all the way up to his ears.

“My legs are asleep after being in a sick bed so long,” Mydei grumbled, eyes down at the floor where the water puddled and his feet would have gotten wet if he weren’t standing atop Phainon’s own.

Phainon sighed and his hands moved. From Mydei’s hand to around his shoulder. From his waist down to the back of his knees. Mydei’s eyes widened and he opened his mouth to protest but the dry air caught his throat and he coughed.

Phainon swept Mydei into his arms and lowered him back onto the mattress. No more agitation just… “Rest more, Mydei.”

Sorrow.

Mydei rolled his head away and glared at the tent wall. It had only been a few months since the last time Phainon was so close to being crushed by despair. Since then he had been nothing but smiles and cheery laughter, even when the rest of the detachment hazed him with teasings, the worst

chore rotation, and duels as a chance to elevate his status so long as he was good enough. He was.

Something as simple as the state of Mydei's body shouldn't have brought even a hint of that melancholy back.

A hand pressed into his, pushing it open with a thumb against his palm and massaging deep circles. It felt good.

Phainon lifted Mydei's hand, still rubbing firm circles as Mydei's limp fingers just brushed Phainon's forehead. When he spoke, every soft sound caressed the skin of his palm. "Your body may be immortal but that doesn't mean you don't feel the pain of death."

Ptolemy returned with Perdikkas and they both faltered at the entrance. Mydei scowled and jerked his head, telling them to come inside. Ptolemy placed the food down by the bedside before he retreated but, rather than leave, he stood guard by the entrance alongside Krateros.

No matter how Mydei emphasised to Perdikkas that his body had recovered, Phainon contradicted him with a wave of the empty chalice to the watery floor as evidence.

Worse still, Phainon insisted he wasn't capable of holding anything—and Mydei hadn't been able to prove him wrong when Phainon passed him a wooden spoon too small for his clumsy hands—so Mydei needed help.

Help eating and drinking.

Perdikkas noted Mydei's symptoms down and scratched his head. "I admit, I fail to see why this poison has plagued you with so many more after-effects than usual."

Mydei glowered at the spoon raised to his lips and the hand holding it but the person it was attached to didn't retreat. How humiliating.

Mydei opened his mouth and Phainon pushed the spoon in before he could change his mind and close it again. Porridge flavoured with some figs, as

though the acidic sweetness could mask the bitter medicinal herbs mixed in.

He considered snapping the spoon in two with his teeth but then Phainon would start fretting about splinters in his mouth. What then? Would he feed him like a mother bird did her children. He shuddered at the thought.

“Shaking? Has your fever returned?” Perdikkas’ eyes widened with alarm and laid a hand against his forehead.

Mydei swallowed the mouthful. “No. My mind went somewhere unpleasant.”

He sighed with relief. “No fever or sweats. Fully lucid. Just some remaining weakness. I’ll study Ladon’s poison more in depth.”

Phainon set the bowl down in favour of the chalice, refilled to the brim with water and held it to Mydei’s mouth. Mydei opened his mouth and tipped his head back. The sooner this ended the better.

“There’s no need for that,” Phainon told Perdikkas with fake brightness.

Mydei almost spat the water at him.

Perdikkas’ brows creased. “What do you mean?”

Phainon took the chalice away and picked up the bowl again, mixing it together for another small spoonful while he ignored Mydei’s glare, one which inspired terror in anyone unfortunate enough to oppose him on the battlefield.

He smiled innocently at Perdikkas. “Mydei lied.”

“*Haikas!* Watch your mouth.”

The realisation hung so heavy he feared the tent would cave on top of them. Ptolemy quickly excused himself, probably off to inform the others of this recent revelation that Mydei’s body of steel wasn’t as reliable as they all thought. Every time he was struck down with poison, his flawless recovery was simply an act.

Perdikkas' eyes darted across Mydei's face and his body, even hidden beneath the blanket. Reassessing.

Krateros paled and took half a step forward before he stilled again. "Your Highness, to take such poor care of your own body…"

"Leave," Mydei said coldly. When no one moved he thumped a hand against the bedding. "All of you! Dismissed!"

Only two people walked out the tent, Perdikkas promising he would return with another decoction and Krateros that he would keep the detachment from inquiring into his condition.

Mydei glared at the loose fist he couldn't bring himself to move again. "That meant you, too."

Phainon shrugged and lifted another spoonful. Mydei eyed it out the corner of his eye but didn't move to take it. "I know. But I won't walk away just because you tell me to."

Insubordination was a terrible thing in an army. If everyone thought they could do anything they wanted then their formations would simply unravel at the seams.

But it was Phainon, a member of the detachment but so much more, so Mydei only tentatively opened his mouth and accepted another spoonful.

He chewed thoughtfully and swallowed. "I'm not so weak I need someone to take care of me."

Phainon smiled, small and a brittle, eyes downturned at the bowl. "I'm aware. It's not your weakness that I…" He continued stirring, seemingly forgetting that he was supposed to be feeding Mydei like he had so insisted, until he admitted in a shaky breath, "It's mine. I'm weak, Mydei. That's why I have to—to take care of you."

I didn't realise you were capable of being selfish. The words were right there on the tip of Mydei's tongue. Sharp as always but meant to prod and

tease and then be brushed aside like usual. He didn't say anything because he wasn't certain if he could temper his prickliness enough for such acrid words, and he knew Phainon might never be so "selfish" again if he did.

"I'm still hungry," Mydei said instead.

Phainon's head perked up, all hopeful wide eyes and parted lips, then he nodded vigorously. "Here."

Only once the bowl and chalice were empty did Phainon let him stand. It wasn't a lie to say Mydei was fully recovered by that point but he didn't object when Phainon helped him change into fresh garments.

Mydei's hair was a mess from him tossing and turning in his sick bed but his unruly hair wasn't an unusual sight, an untamed mane feeding into his epithet of the solitary lion. However, he couldn't stand the braid loosened over his shoulder into a formless cluster of hair.

He unclasped the metal end and ran his fingers through, untangling and smoothing out the waves that came from how long it had spent braided tight. Phainon stared with such narrowed focus, it almost numbed Mydei's fingers again.

"Can I help?" Phainon asked with a polite smile, as though he didn't care either way but offered out of his sense of moral duty. Mydei arched a brow and Phainon swiftly defended himself, "I braid…ed hair before."

Phainon's brows pinched, baffled by himself. There were two people Mydei could imagine Phainon seated behind, running his fingers through their hair and laying the strands over each other: Audata and Cyrene.

Mydei suspected he would regret this but he turned to face him and tilted his head for easier access. "Only if you can make it passable."

"Of course!"

The braid was not passable. It was not even a braid.

“Phainon…” Mydei interrupted partway through the fifth attempt. He didn’t need to check for himself; Phainon’s face told him all he needed to know.

He flushed darker. “I… don’t recall this being so difficult.”

“Is it possible—“

“No.”

That Phainon’s mother and best friend took pity on him. That was the only explanation for how the results could be so poor.

“Let me do it.”

“I just need some practice. Every good warrior needs a warmup.” His fingers slowed and he glanced away, his smile falling at the edges. “It’s been a long time.”

A kicked puppy.

Mydei sighed, “Another three attempts and no more.”

Resolve set Phainon’s features. That persistence, which served him so well on the battlefield, did nothing to prevent Mydei from undoing his hard work after his final attempt. He braided it himself while Phainon sulked and memorised the movement of his fingers, hands following along in his lap. Mydei let Phainon gather the ends and fix them in place with the metal clasp.

Only then did they rejoin the rest of the detachment. All of whom were none the wiser about Mydei’s moment of weakness when he raised a drink to victory with unshaken limbs and a clear mind.

When he gathered with his friends around the campfire, Krateros overseeing from a distance while pretending he wasn’t, there was no avoiding that they knew when they looked at Mydei differently, as well as Phainon at his side.

But it wasn’t a bad thing when Peucesta plucked at his strings with a song about a man apologising to his scorned lover and Hephaestion sent one of his dogs over with a low whistle. Ptolemy passed a drink mixed just to his liking, Perdikkas tossed herbs that burned sweet into the fire, and Leonnius lifted his chalice in their own private toast in common tongue so Phainon could follow along. Mydei downed his drink and it tasted sweeter than usual.

Chapter End Notes

Phainon used “puppy dog eyes”. It was super effective!

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

> Mydei and Phainon get stuck out in the cold. Only one of them is good at handling it.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In Mydei's fifth year of exile, a snowstorm ravaged through Aidonia for three full months. While skirmishes with a number of mercenaries had pushed them closer to Aidonia in the months prior, Mydei kept the detachment away from the main city and its surrounding territory. When the blizzard hit, they were settled outside a small village in Aidonia's periphery.

The earth was frozen solid by the harsh winter and the villagers complained how they would ever be able to till it come the Months of Cultivation. There were no bottomless swamps for Leonnius to sink in.

The greatest threat was the cold. While they weathered the worst of the snow in the proper buildings of towns and villages, the majority of their time was in the wild as usual.

"And that is why we should hold a competition," Leonnius announced, vigorously rubbing his hands against his thighs. "Whoever gathers the most pelts is the victor."

Mydei sipped his spiced wine. He preferred to avoid wines and spirits but he made exceptions for the cold. And only for a specific blend of wine, spices and honey Ptolemy found in a book stolen from the Library of Garbaniphoro. "What brought on this proposal?"

"This blizzard has raged without pause for almost two months. There's no telling when we'll finally be free of it," Leonnius bemoaned. "None of us have frozen to death but we're hardly limber."

“How selfless of you,” Perdikkas teased with an arched brow. “And this has nothing to do with Peucesta thieving your blanket in the night.”

Leonnius gaped at Peucesta. “That was you?”

Ptolemy was equally offended. “And you tried to frame me?”

Peucesta looked from one to the other, shrugged, and continued to wiggle his gloved fingers over a nonexistent lyre.

Phainon’s head bounced between the two of them as he tried to follow the conversation. He had made an admirable effort to learn Kremnoan since he joined the detachment but it was a difficult language to grasp. The sounds were harsher and throatier than common tongue. While grammatically similar, the two dialects shared few words.

But his head perked up and he pointed at his chin. “No,” he said in Kremnoan and then switched to common, “that was me?”

“What?” They both rounded on him at the same time.

Phainon’s hands jumped in surrender. “I woke up with the extra blanket. I rose early for my swordsmanship practice so I gave it to Ptolemy since he seemed cold. I didn’t realise it was yours.”

Leonnius huffed and slurred his next words together as quick as possible into near incoherence, “First Mydeimos and now Peucesta. Who else will be favouring him next?”

“You forgot to add your own name there,” Hephaestion remarked dryly.

It was easy to see why Peucesta had caved. Even with Phainon huddled as close to the fire as he could get without it jumping to his furs and wools, he still shivered so pitifully. Nearly four months in Aidonia and two during its worst freeze in recent memory had not been enough time for Phainon to acclimate to the harsh winter. If anything he had gotten worse.

“If you want limber then I can have you run a message to Aidonia where you beg for safe refuge in the city,” Mydei drawled and Leonnius swaddled

himself further in his himation like it would hide him and Mydei would miraculously forget his existence. “But the idea isn’t half-bad.”

It would be good for morale to have something to pass the time. They likely wouldn’t hunt enough for the entire detachment but anything was better than nothing. The fires of competition would keep them warm for a little while.

The detachment were enthusiastic and separated themselves into groups. Ptolemy was the most sought after for his traps but he sided with his cavalrymen and the men swiftly turned to those most proficient with a bow.

Phainon nudged Mydei, crouched on the ground to string his bow, with his boot. “No one interested in partnering with Your Highness?”

Mydei rolled his eyes. “Only if you remove yourself from the list.”

“Us on the same team? Where’s your healthy spirit of competition?” Phainon teased but his smile was all mirth and no surprise.

“I prefer my competition alive. I fear you will freeze to death if I take my eye off you too long.”

Team decided, they set off with a brief remark for Leonnius to not run off into trouble alone. Leonnius mockingly saluted and Mydei lingered on his intact legs before Phainon dragged him along.

Hunting was a different challenge in the snowy landscape. Many animals entered hibernation or migrated to warmer climates. The constant snowfall covered most tracks and the dead foliage left little cover to hide from the more skittish prey.

Mydei crouched behind a rocky outcrop and drew the bowstring back. The deer had yet to notice them. He hadn’t wielded a bow in some time but he breathed and let his body remember as he adjusted his aim. He loosed the arrow and it pierced through the deer’s head. It let out a death throe and then collapsed to the snow.

Phainon watched him tie a strip of red fabric to the deer's leg with Mydei's name on it. "I wasn't aware you could wield a bow."

Mydei glanced at the nearest red fabric tied to a tree in the distance, then tied another one on a branch overhead as he memorised the location. "Any weapon a member of the detachment can wield is just as capable in my hands."

A steel body forged for war. It showed in how quickly he became proficient with every weapon every member of the detachment had eagerly tutored him in. They claimed it was a gift from Nikador.

Mydei arched a brow at the coil of rope Phainon on Phainon's hands. "But I wasn't aware you knew how to tie snares."

A few had already been hidden along their route. Although there was no telling if they would catch anything, Mydei had admired the skill of the knots and camouflage.

Phainon chuckled. "My dad taught me. And Ptolemy has been helping me expand my repertoire."

Mydei had noticed them in conversation at times—and, upon reflection, seen the rope—but he failed to realise the connection. Hunting competitions were frequent and often came with coins in the betting pool, so it was unusual for Ptolemy to teach his tricks. That made the current list of favour: Mydeimos, Peucesta, Ptolemy.

Although, Hephaestion always spared his time if Phainon requested a spar, when he usually evaded persistent requests unless they came from Mydei or flared into a challenge for a real duel. He had grown soft the first time Phainon soothed a frenzied stray and then regaled him with tales of Snowy. Perhaps he could be added too.

Even Perdikkas had taken days to explain, to the best of the detachment's knowledge, how Mydei's immortality worked. Alongside the best kinds of treatments for which injuries. Not that Mydei required treatment for anything other than the black tide or potent poisons. But Perdikkas, and

apparently Phainon, had certain salves and concoctions at the ready to speed the repairs and numb pain.

That meant Leonnius was the last man standing.

“What’s so funny?” Phainon asked.

Phainon’s face was completely flushed from the cold. The tip of his nose, the highs of his cheeks, the curve of his ears. If Mydei plucked off his thick hide gloves and fur lined boots, he was certain his fingers and toes would be just as icy. He even sniffled as his nose ran.

Mydei’s lip curled even further at the sight. “Nothing for you to concern yourself over. I was just thinking about how you’re bound to lose.”

“And here I thought you wanted to be on the same team so we could be victorious together,” Phainon said with a mocking sigh, a large puff of white, and shake of his head.

Mydei smirked. “Competition is much livelier when you can watch your opponents confident facade crumble.”

“Then shall we keep going so I can witness it first hand.”

There wasn’t much further for them to go before the ground took a steep incline to form a mountainside. It would be unwise to venture into the mountains but he recalled Perdikkas had been eager to locate a local flower that sprouted from cracks in the stone and clambered up rocks.

The majority grew too high but they followed alongside the mountain and plucked any flowers that bloomed within arms reach. They even located a cave with a number growing inside but their bounty was still scarce.

“Shame,” Phainon said through trembling lips. “He mentioned how they were good for stemming bleeding and…” Phainon’s head swivelled. “Did you hear that?”

Mydei assumed he meant the strange thump. But he wasn’t sure what it was or where it came from. It didn’t sound like an animal. Too large.

Somewhere overhead.

The sound rumbled nearer and nearer and a sudden shadow stretched stark across the snowy forest floor. Phainon's arm looped around Mydei's chest and yanked him backwards. His back slammed into Phainon's front and the cave plunged into darkness.

"Avalanche," Phainon explained, breath hot against his nape, and he freed Mydei from his hold. "Sounded like when the wind blows and the snow tumbles off the roofs."

The cave entrance had been completely buried. Mydei kicked the snow and some of it flaked off to scatter across the cave floor but it hardly made a dent. There was too much of it. Too heavy, so that it compacted itself into a solid wall.

Mydei rolled his wrists and flexed his fingers. They were still warm, flexible. "I'll dig us out."

It was too dark to see more than vague silhouettes but Phainon managed to grab his wrist in one attempt. "Your fingers will freeze off."

"They'll heal before that," Mydei corrected him. "At most they'll go completely numb."

Even if his blood froze in his veins and he collapsed of hypothermia, his body would warm again after a brief dip in the Sea of Souls.

No chill in the living world could compare to the waters where the dead gathered. That place seeped beyond skin, sapping the warmth from the marrow of bones. His body had acclimated to that kind of frigid existence. Even after years roaming far from the Sea of Souls and clawing his way free as swiftly as he was submerged, his body temperature remained exceptionally high.

"Let's just w-wait for the others," Phainon insisted, as though his teeth hadn't already begun to chatter.

Everyone would gather back at the camp. When they realised Mydei and Phainon were missing, they would send out search parties in the general direction they had been seen venturing in. Mydei had already tied scraps of red fabric to the trees along their route and Hephaestion's dogs may have been strays but they were prodigious trackers with the right training. Then they would just have to dig the two of them out.

Mydei shook off Phainon's hand. "All right."

It would be too much hassle to combat the cold, the uncooperative snow, and Phainon's objections. If worst came to worst then Phainon would be too weak by that point to oppose him when he started digging.

His eyes adjusted somewhat to the darkness, enough for him to notice Phainon's gaping lips at such an easy acquiescence. Neither of them had an actual light source. The closest was…

Mydei slid down the wall to the ground, "Never mention this to anyone."

"That we almost froze to death in a cave because we were picking flowers?"

Phainon couldn't see it but Mydei rolled his eyes anyway and didn't dignify his snark with any other response.

Instead he evened out his breathing and closed his eyes as he pushed up his sleeves and exposed parts of his neck and collarbone. He felt his heart pumping in his chest, blood flowing through his veins, the heat of his immortal life.

"Mydei, you're—"

"Shut up," he growled and opened his eyes.

A red light washed over the dull grey stone and the white snow. His tattoos were glowing.

It took a lot of concentration to make them light up let alone keep them that way. It usually just happened. When he fought hard enough to require all of

his strength and focus. When he woke in the night from a nightmare that plunged him back into a lightless abyss or a lonely future.

Phainon sat opposite him. There wasn't much space. If they both stretched their legs out then they would overlap.

"So th-those markings of yours…"

Mydei clicked his tongue. "If you must know, they are remnants of my time in the Sea of Souls."

His body healed all wounds without even a mark as a reminder. The closest thing he had to a scar were these red markings where the Sea of Souls—Death and Strife and the struggle to survive—had embedded itself beneath his skin. Every time he encountered them again in force, his tattoos would shift and grow to match the life he led.

He clenched his fist and red dust trickled between his fingers like sand in an hourglass as the time passed in silence.

"H-how much… much longer until they-they come for us," Phainon stammered between chattering teeth. It was a miracle he had any teeth left with how long they had been clattering away.

Mydei tapped his head back against the wall, one leg bent upright so his arm could rest over it. "It's not been that long."

But long enough it was obvious how much Phainon suffered from the cold. While they had crept through the snowy undergrowth, his features had flushed but nothing too concerning. Now his face was bloodless, even as he swaddled his himation over his head and curled into himself to preserve as much warmth as possible. Mydei wouldn't bet a scrap of bronze on his survival let alone gold.

He sighed and unclasped his woollen himation. "Come here."

For once, Phainon's first instinct wasn't to jump at Mydei's command. Not because of Mydei's status but because that's just how Phainon was: a big,

white dog like the one that left for Okhema with his parents. Except he didn’t have any fur to keep him warm.

He stared through Mydei with distant eyes and shivers wracking his body. “Why?”

“Just *come here*.”

Phainon scooted across the rough stone floor and leaned against the wall, their shoulders brushing together but nothing more. Mydei rolled his eyes as he shrugged off his himation and closed the distance so minuscule there was no reason for Phainon to leave it at all. Mydei had already made his approval of physical contact with Phainon clear but his mind worked in the strangest ways.

He begged for scraps of attention but found excuses to avoid Mydei and spar with Hephaestion if Mydei indulged him too much. He plastered himself to Mydei’s side but had arbitrary list of touches and lines he refused to cross no matter how Mydei welcomed him at times he would shrug off others. He did all sorts of things for Mydei from his laundry to cleaning and polishing his gauntlets—a pain and Mydei knew it. The little plates and grooves were not as open to rag as a smooth blade—but he never expected anything in return.

Mydei shed his gloves with his teeth. Then he curled an arm around Phainon’s waist and felt another shiver run through him. Except he hadn’t relaxed his tensed muscles by the time Mydei shuffled under his arm, bringing it around his own waist, and tossed one end of his himation over Phainon’s shoulder. They didn’t have any firewood so their only option was body heat.

It was difficult to tell if Phainon was breathing despite how Mydei squinted at the fabric over his chest. His face had gone completely blank which, paired with the utter paleness, made him look almost like the unflattering portrait Leonnius had etched into the snow the other day.

“Yours, too.”

“Huh?” Phainon muttered unintelligibly which meant he hadn’t frozen solid. Maybe the cold had gotten his brain first.

“Use it as a blanket. Give it to me.”

He reached beneath his himation for Phainon’s, searching blind for the clasp. Phainon shrieked and whatever ice in his veins keeping him so sluggish suddenly turned to steam as his hands flew to his chest and colour surged into his cheeks.

“I can get it!”

With the fabric in the way, Mydei couldn’t confirm for himself but he knew without a doubt that Phainon’s trembling hands were fumbling for the clasp and missing.

“You’ll be a block of ice before that.”

“Keep your hands to yourself! I can do it.”

Mydei’s fingers curled. The biting cold had forced him to remove his gauntlets. Even with his gloves, the heated skin of his palms hotter than any red hot steel was too exposed.

Phainon finally unclasped his himation and pulled it free, handing it to Mydei so he could drape it over their tucked legs. The himation over their shoulders, and partially over Phainon’s head, had a gaping opening at the bottom even when he pinned it together in the middle. But when he used Phainon’s clasp to pin the two sheets of fabric together it created one big blanket. It was easier to trap the heat in when they could tuck the edges against the floor.

“There.” Mydei nodded, satisfied, and leaned against Phainon’s side.

Phainon’s head dropped against the top of his. As though making up for lost time after so many years, Mydei’s body had gotten significantly taller in the past year. Except Phainon hadn’t stoped growing either so their height difference hadn’t shrunken enough for Mydei’s liking.

“You’re warm,” Phainon mumbled, dreamy but still more lucid than he had been. “I can feel your hand through my clothes.”

“Give me your other hand.”

Again, no different than a dog, Phainon placed his paw in Mydei’s open palm. His fingertips were so cold Mydei half expected there to be steam where their skin met.

“Oh, that’s nice…”

“How did you ever manage the winters?” Mydei asked, rubbing their palms together. He knew it must have snowed in Aedes Elysiae considering the name of his dog.

“The winters weren’t as harsh.” He managed a shake of his head and a small smile. “I’ll have you know I actually enjoyed going out in the snow. It was always fun to play in with my friends.”

“Did those friends include fairies?”

His chuckle was still shaky. “You’ll never believe me about that, will you?”

Mydei did believe him but it was more fun to disagree. He snorted, “I’ve roamed every corner of Amphoreus and never seen a so-called fairy.”

Again, not quite true. In the sunlight and the wheat fields, Phainon looked much like a fairy. One who helped farmers and brought good harvests and languished in the grain stalks, sunlight turning his hair near golden, blue eyes like a perfect sunny day.

But in the winter, Phainon looked like he emerged from the snow. Not as a harbinger of famine and blizzards or the cold long nights, but the fun to be had in the snow and the warmth shared between people huddled close around a fire.

“I wanted to show them to you. They would’ve liked you.”

Phainon’s voice had grown quieter and Mydei imagined his eyes had closed. It would have been concerning but he could feel Phainon’s body temperature rising, so he didn’t bother trying to force him awake.

“What about you? You’re so warm. You could… could run around naked in the snow and watch it melt.”

Mydei rolled his eyes and squeezed Phainon’s hand until he winced. “Use your brain.” Mydei relaxed his hand, drawing circles into the meat of Phainon’s thumb. “It’s another… consequence of my time in the Sea of Souls.”

That made Phainon perk up a little. “Another boon? Like that steel body of yours.”

Mydei huffed a laugh. “Something like that. But…”

Phainon’s cheek fell back against Mydei’s head. “But?”

Mydei kissed his teeth and felt the burn of his hands where they met Phainon’s icy ones. “If you weren’t half frozen to death, you would hardly enjoy holding my hand.”

“Mydei,” Phainon whined and nuzzled his cheek against Mydei’s hair, “what about me makes you think that?”

His mouth opened, and then closed again. What made him think that Phainon wouldn’t want to hold his hand? That was a surprisingly good point for someone half-lucid and muttering into the top of his head.

“It’s—my hands are really hot.” Which sounded quite pathetic when he put it that way.

Hotter than the forges of Castrum Kremnos. Peucesta had said in much more complex verse that Mydei barely understood—not long after he emerged from the Sea of Souls and was folded into the detachment. The gauntlets were the only reason he could touch anyone without it scalding.

“Feels nice.”

“Because your fingers are icier than the river we crossed to get here.”

“No no. It’s because they’re Mydei’s hands,” Phainon insisted in that same sleepy voice and he squeezed like Mydei didn’t know where his hands were.

Their body temperature had warmed the air under the blanket. That was why Mydei felt his face beginning to warm too.

“Stop mumbling. I can’t understand you.”

No response. Mydei squeezed Phainon’s hand but his fingers were slackening in Mydei’s hold. He was asleep. Mydei shuffled, getting comfortable against Phainon’s shoulder. The others would come for them soon.

“Phainon,” Mydei whispered and waited. Still no answer. He breathed a shaky exhale. “Do you think fate can be defied? Or am I just as mad as my father for thinking that I…”

After all, his father had murdered his wife and attempted the murder of his son all in an attempt to defy a prophesied fate. A future he didn’t want to come to pass.

When would it be Mydei’s turn to make a sacrifice? What would he be willing to give? And what if it was all for nothing?

“Don’t say that about yourself.”

Mydei stiffened and tried to jerk away but Phainon’s hand tightened around his waist, keeping them stuck together.

“You—“

Did he really *pretend* to be asleep?

“Wasn’t pretending,” Phainon defended himself from an accusation Mydei hadn’t even loosed yet. “Just dozed off. Then I heard some upsetting slander and woke up again.”

Mydei clicked his tongue but didn't push Phainon away when he nuzzled his head against Mydei's temple.

His voice was low in Mydei's ear, as gentle as the warm breath dissipating in a puff of white. "Don't insult yourself by comparing yourself to that…" He finished with quite the Kremnoan insult. One that would have any man, woman or child lunging at his throat with a blade.

Mydei blinked once, twice, just in case he had fallen asleep. "Since when?"

He pulled back just a bit as he chuckled. "Leonnius taught me. But my point stands. You would never lose yourself."

"How can you be so certain?" Mydei asked, unable to mask the bitterness now that he had opened the gates of his honesty. "You've seen me on the battlefield. The solitary lion? Or just a mad mutt?"

"That's different. You let yourself loose but you never lose control."

"Maybe I will one day."

"You won't. If something needs protecting, the only thing you would ever willingly sacrifice is yourself. Your golden blood, your immortal body, your lives." It was only his breath against Mydei's nose, fanning across his cheeks. He wasn't sure the tremors in it were from the cold. "Even when it hurts."

He was so distressed in his crinkled eyes and downturned lips that Mydei wasn't certain if he was talking about Mydei's pain or his own. He knew that face. The one Phainon always made when Mydei was reckless on the battlefield. Like every drop of spilled blood and length of rended flesh was just as painful for Phainon as he imagined it was for Mydei, who had long since grown immune to such trivial pains.

He let himself slump near boneless against Phainon's side, breathing in a crisp scent of winter air. "And if I ever forget myself—"

You will be the one to kill me.

“Then I’ll be by your side to remind you.”

The light of his tattoos pulsed quicker with his heart. It was obvious, too obvious, but he kept his nose buried in Phainon’s shoulder like neither of them would notice.

“All right, *Deliverer*,” he scraped as much rigour into his voice as he could. “Go back to sleep if you want. By the time you wake up, you’ll be warm by a real fire.”

He hummed low in his throat. “Don’t wanna leave you alone.” But the effect was compromised by the tired slur to his words.

Mydei laughed. “I’m not alone. Or are you planning on going somewhere?”

Eventually Phainon’s breathing levelled out again. Mydei didn’t have any more to say but he pinched the back of Phainon’s hand just to catch him in the act if he was pretending again. Phainon’s brows furrowed and his lashes fluttered but he didn’t stir.

He let the light of his tattoos burn out, plunging them back into darkness, and focused on the rise and fall of Phainon’s chest, breath running through Mydei’s hair. He was still alive, nowhere near succumbing to the cold. Just as Perdikkas was still alive. And Leonnius and Ptolemy would be once they emerged from the land entombed in snow.

Mydei’s head perked up as muffled noises came through the snow. Voices. Harsh contact striking something firm.

The light broke through next as a few sheafs of snow flaked off and broke against the ground. As more and more tumbled down and the chunks grew larger, the voices came louder and the light brighter.

Mydei unclasped his himation first and cinched it shut again around Phainon’s chest. Then he took Phainon’s himation from around their legs and wrapped it back around Phainon’s shoulders.

By the time the first dog broke through the snow—a new one. Suited to the climate since they found it wandering the snowstorm with a ravaged ear, muzzle and tail—Mydei was on his feet with Phainon over his back.

Hephaestion climbed over the snow to reach him but Mydei only kicked his discarded bow and quiver towards him. “Mydeimos. Everyone else is accounted for. Water has been heated to warm you both up,” he reported quick and efficient, stooping to pick the two items up.

Mydei boosted Phainon on his back and readjusted his grip on his thighs. He clambered over the heap of loose snow, feeling it give and slide under his feet. Hephaestion caught him with a hand around his arm and let go once he found his footing again.

Once they reached flat ground, Leonnius whistled. “Did he die? Is this his funeral shroud.”

Mydei walked right past him. “He’s asleep.”

“Want me to be carry him?” Leonnius asked but immediately laughed before Mydei could even respond. “Stop running my mouth and start running my feet.”

Mydei closed his mouth again, retort stolen, as Leonnius ran off back to the encampment with the good news.

They followed the red scraps of fabric back to the encampment. The deer and the snares had already been cleared away but Mydei had little care left for the competition. The detachment welcomed them back with some compliments to their hunt—the deer was a clean kill and the snares had moderate success—although Ptolemy emerged victorious with a bear hide.

Mydei didn’t spare them much more than quick acknowledgement as he carried Phainon straight to the tent reserved for the portable water basin and let the flap close behind him. Even without the structure of a building to keep the heat in, it was warm as the steam rose from the water.

“You can stop pretending to be asleep now.”

Phainon didn’t twitch. But when Mydei loosed his hands to drop him to the floor, his limbs sprung to life and clung to him, arms around his neck and legs around his waist.

“How did you know?” Phainon pouted.

“When you stopped drooling on me. Now get off before I dump you in clothes and all. And tell me when how long Leonnius has been giving you lessons on the Kremnoan language.”

If Mydei wanted to throw this information in Leonnius’ face and watch him rush to defend himself, he needed the exact details of when exactly Leonnius added himself to this supposed list. Although, there was little purpose to a list of those among them who favoured Phainon if all their names could be found on it. And Mydei would never deny who was at the very top of that list.

Chapter End Notes

> Phainon’s parents adopted Mydei and Mydei’s friends adopted Phainon. Perfectly balanced.
>
> Mydei to Phainon: Paw
> Phainon: [immediately gives his paw]

▶ Details

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

> Mydei inevitably encounters the black tide and Phainon's thirst for revenge again.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Only twenty dusks later into Mydei's fifth year of exile, the detachment stayed far from the main city where Aidonian loyalists could crush Ptolemy beneath fallen columns. A break in the snowstorm let the encampment push towards the boundaries of Aidonia's territory, hoping to leave before the next big freeze came in.

They stopped in a half-thawed town to sell off their extra pelts and wools that would be rendered unnecessary bulk in the warmer weather outside Amphoreus' coldest region.

Mydei lurked nearby with his hood up and arms crossed. The townsfolk tried not to stare at the scary stranger loitering in the shadows of the street and hurried past to go about their business.

With everyone including him bundled under thick winter clothing, the only thing that distinguished him from the others was the red mark below his eye visible from beneath his hood. Yet everyone just *knew* he was suspicious.

It's because you don't smile. You brood. Phainon told him once after effortlessly convincing a merchant to purchase an ornate dagger he had taken as spoils but saw no need to keep.

The same dagger he had struggled to pawn off to a different merchant just earlier that day. The only difference was that Mydei noticed the first merchant's frantic glances in his own direction, and excused himself for Phainon's second attempt.

If Mydei forced a smile, the situation would spiral so fast the town guards would get involved before he even had the chance to *stop* smiling. He would know. Ptolemy had tried that strategy with him already.

So Mydei kept his head down and waited for Phainon to finish. Then they could move on and reunite with the rest of the detachment…

Except Phainon was gone.

Mydei sighed and a woman startled nearby, glancing over and then scurrying away when he pushed off the wall. He needed to go wrangle his companion because, for all Phainon's skill at selling items with his chivalrous but amiable charms, he also had a bad habit of being scammed.

He could only assume people didn't run scams in a community as small as Aedes Elysiae because Phainon's idea of *value* for anything that couldn't be found in a rural wheat farming village was… frighteningly flexible. He was not allowed in a marketplace unsupervised.

Technically the coin was his to spend so long as he contributed enough to the detachment's coffers to feed himself and maintain his weapon and armour. But there were limits to what foolery Mydei was willing to witness. Especially when someone, usually Ptolemy, would inform him that his latest antique was nothing more than a forgery and Phainon would shrug it off saying other people probably needed the money more than him anyway.

The familiar white hair was tucked beneath a hood but he recognised the himation and boots stood at a stall. Mydei didn't soften his glare at the stall owner as he stationed himself at Phainon's side.

The stall owner flinched but chiselled on a shaky smile and returned to whatever discussion he was having with Phainon, "It's strange. We usually have one or two merchants from the town about half a day by horseback. But they haven't shown up at all this week."

While Phainon responded placatingly, Mydei kept his face flat, unimpressed, and scanned the wares. A fabric stall.

“Do you need new clothes?” Mydei asked, brows furrowed.

As far as he was aware, Phainon’s clothes were still in acceptable condition. He had grown in height and muscle since he first joined but he was still within the range of a standard Kremnoan warrior. And he took care to repair his clothes where he could in the manner taught to him by his mother. For someone once so pathetic at braiding hair, his fingers were surprisingly dexterous when it came to needlework.

“Need? Not at all.” Phainon admired the dyed bolts of fabric and his gaze lingered on a muted yellow. “But I feel a splash of colour might add some charm to the camp.”

The Kremnoan detachment hardly needed *charm.* While it was true the encampment heavily skewed towards blacks, browns and reds, those were simply the most practical. Did Phainon really want to be cleaning blood and gore out of whatever other colours he preferred? The stains would never come out from…

Mydei looked from the yellow in his hands to the purple tucked under his arm. His nose scrunched. “Why those colours?”

Phainon paused like the question surprised him, or maybe just the sharpness of Mydei’s tone. “They’re my favourite.” Another moment too long passed as he dragged his finger along the yellow weave. “They remind me of home. Why? Do you not like them?”

The yellow was far from the gold of the wheat fields but that could never be captured in the simple dyes affordable to the masses. This was likely the closest to be found.

But there was something more important than that.

Mydei glanced again between the yellow and purple. “Do you intend to wear them together?”

“Of course!”

Mydei took the purple bolt from under his arm and set it back on the table. “No.”

Phainon whole face crumpled in sheer heartbreak. “Why not?”

“No.” When Phainon’s expression didn’t move, Mydei pinched the bridge of his nose and sighed. “If you must, wear one at a time. But never both at once.”

That was an acceptable compromise and he immediately perked up again, purchasing both sets of fabric with his usual smile.

“A quick question,” Mydei had to ask as they walked away and Phainon hummed to go ahead. “Has your perception of colour ever been different from those around you?”

Phainon squinted at him, brows furrowed. “No. What brought this up?”

“Curiosity,” Mydei brushed him off but his eyes caught on the fabric again, one laid over top the other in Phainon’s arms. “For any potential weaknesses to exploit in our next competition.”

Phainon chuckled. “Is that so? Sorry to disappoint.”

They met up with Ptolemy and Perdikkas carrying new arrows and medical bandages. Then Hephaestion and Peucesta with some smoked ribs and cheese bread between them. Ptolemy suggested they visit the local alehouse for drinks if they had all concluded their business and none of them refused.

It was an ordinary day. Nothing unusual from any other supply run through any other town thriving in the peaceful periphery of larger city states vying for power.

That was why none of them expected the black tide to surge.

The only warning was black blotting out the sky and devouring the sun. It was mere seconds before creatures appeared as numerous as rain in a storm.

Mydei crouched in a small alleyway away from the main streets suddenly flush with people, crushing each other beneath feet and against walls as they fled. He shoved his hands into his gauntlets and Hephaestion buckled them for him.

Peucesta had no weapon on hand except a short dagger. Perdikkas possessed a sword, and Hephaestion both a sword and a shield at his back. Phainon's sword was strapped to his waist, heavier than the others as he trained his body to throw the weight of a great blade. Mydei had his gauntlets but only Ptolemy had a spear.

Mydei flexed his fingers, testing the joints of the gauntlets in the cold. "Ptolemy, your spear."

It was difficult to see without the daylight but it was undoubtedly panic that flitted across his features, evident in his two steps forward and an aborted third. "Mydeimos…"

But all Mydei could see was Ptolemy's body crushed beyond recognition beneath a pillar. The only proof it was him was the blood-soaked ends of his hair, the bracer around his wrist and his spear flung away by the collapse.

He silently opened both hands flat and any further objections died. Ptolemy presented his weapon and laid it across Mydei's open palms.

"You four return to camp and inform the others," Mydei ordered. "Phainon with me."

Hephaestion paused as he re-buckled his sword from his back to his waist. Mydei knew what he wanted to offer—he could wield his sword beside them. Three was better than two against any foe, let alone the black tide—but, in Mydei's absence, he always entrusted the detachment to Hephaestion and Krateros. He held his tongue and tied his hair back.

No objections, Mydei raised a hand and the rest of them followed. "May we all walk the path of victory and meet again."

Wherever the black tide was spreading from, it had yet to reach them. There was no time to waste and the four of them merged into the crowd pushing towards the town's main gate.

Mydei twirled Ptolemy's spear, getting a feel for the length and weighting, slightly longer and heavier than he was used to. This was the right decision. For those without golden blood in their veins, and potentially marked for death, it was safer to return with reinforcements.

Metal shone as it slid slow and smooth to rest below the spear, overlapping and crossed together. Just like that, Phainon held up the weight for him.

Phainon's lips curled into a crooked smile. "Ready?"

Mydei smirked back. "For victory? Always."

In a twisted way, it was almost nostalgic. The two of them had fought side-by-side on many occasions, from friendly games amongst the detachment to life-or-death on the battlefield.

But this was the first time they stared down such an overwhelming force since that first joint encounter with the black tide. A force that didn't settle or scatter—it only rose inevitability. A river under endless rain about to burst its banks and flood the plain. A raging sea crashing against the coast, wearing it away and gouging its way inland.

Under that black sky that would never see the sun again, the only thing they could rely on was themselves and each other. That Phainon would watch dispatch the blade before it met Mydei's back as he rummaged through the rubble to pull out a sobbing child who had tried to rescue her cat. That Mydei would catch any arrows assailing Phainon as he carried an elderly man on his back until his son could take over.

Mydei thrust his spear and pierced through a creature's chest. The hit knocked it to the ground in a plume of snow and shattered ice. It thrashed, tearing more of its flesh and bleeding orange and black on the blade, yet unable to pull free. It gurgled a dying wail and stilled.

He pulled the spear out and the body skidded across the ice when he kicked it away to open more space in the main street. “That puts me at seventeen.”

Behind him, Phainon sliced through another creature. They had both shed their himations to rid themselves of the extra fabric—too dangerous in battle where a corner snagging could mean their demise—exposing his build hidden underneath. Training with the detachment had squared out his shoulders, shaped his biceps and thighs, and strengthened his core to wield the weighty blade with relative ease.

“Eighteen for me,” Phainon answered tersely, bereft of the usual competitiveness and mirth curving his lip.

That was fine. Expected even.

Mydei dodged a black tide creature’s blades arm and retaliated with a sharp lift of his spear. The limb fell clean off and the next strike was to its neck. He picked up the severed arm and launched it at a creature coming out of an alleyway for Phainon’s back.

This was Phainon’s first encounter with the black tide since it engulfed his homeland. Worse still, the black tide looked the same no matter where it went. The darkened empty sky, the monsters that emerged from it, the smell of blood and rot in the air.

Mydei jumped and spun. He kicked a black tide creature in the chest, feeling the give under his heel even before the crack echoed in his ears as its body caved to the pressure. Once from his kick and again when it flew through a house under construction.

His feet slipped on the landing but he caught himself on his spear. Curse these icy roads. And the narrow streets while he was at it. Once reinforcements came it would be difficult for them to manoeuvre in the Kremnoan formations capable of weathering the black tide.

But when no one laughed at his blunder, he knew something was amiss. Phainon would never fumble such an obvious opportunity to jab at him unless—

He was distracted. His weapon hung limp at his side as he stared into the distance. In the harsh shadows and orange lights of the black tide, a new emotion cleaved apart Phainon's lovingly crafted mask of composure and revealed itself in every harsh line of his face and body: hatred.

Mydei barely glimpsed the set of his jaw and his eyes darkened as though the black tide had already swallowed them too. The harsh reds and oranges set the golden tattoo on his neck alight.

So we can match, Mydei.

Our markings aren't even remotely similar. Just say you want one.

Now they were similar. The golden sun was no longer a reminder of the gentle light over his hometown. It burned hot amidst the devastation, almost pulsing, like the red flames that flickered across Mydei's body.

Phainon darted out into the side streets.

"Phai—"

A bowstring twanged and Mydei threw himself behind an overturned cart. If he had stayed in place, the arrow embedded in the wall would have gone through his brain. The black tide touch such a fundamental part of his body. He wasn't sure what would happen to him if it ever did.

He stood just long enough to hurl his spear up and through the house window the arrow had come from. The black tide creature collapsed and Mydei didn't have anymore time to spare. He gave chase.

By the time Mydei rounded the corner of the alleyway, Phainon had disappeared. He needed a better vantage point.

He took off running, jumped as high as he could, and pushed off the wall for the slight boost in height. He grabbed an open window and hauled himself up before clambering onto the roof.

Rot tainted the air. Beyond a mere smell, Mydei could taste it on his tongue and feel it crawling along his skin. It searched for a way to pry him open

and burrow its way inside. To feast on whatever humanity could be found in a body like his and fester, corrupting him from the inside out. It didn't stop at the body. The mind had to be completely corroded too.

He needed to find that pinprick of white in the darkness. He couldn't see from here. Phainon had gotten too far away too fast. He vaulted across to another rooftop and kept his stride going when he landed so he could jump to the next.

This was too far. He was straying too far from the main street and the town gates. Where was he?

There.

A swarm of black tide creatures. At the centre, a flash of white and steel locked in battle.

Mydei leapt from the rooftops and channeled his raging blood into a fist. The ground cracked beneath him and red crystals burst forth.

He didn't check how many were impaled by those sharp edges. He simply charged at the ones that were left.

All of those negative emotions pressing against his throat, his heart, his mind and squeezing them to impotence—he took them all and launched them at his opponents.

He lost the spear so all he had was his gauntlets and his blood as he tore through death and decay with his hands and dared it to do the same to him. Every cut, every bruise, every drop of golden blood was paid back a thousand fold.

Soon there was only one left. Sword drawn, back to him, panting with the exertion that slicked white hair to his nape.

He turned at the sound of Mydei's steps and Phainon's body went sprawling to the floor at Mydei's fist whipping across his jaw.

He hissed, hand at his bleeding lip and bruising jaw. His eyes were thin rings of blue around a greedy, feral black. “Have you lost your mind?”

Mydei stalked towards him and Phainon had just enough time to get half way to his feet before Mydei grabbed him by his tunic and yanked. Mydei was still the shorter of the two but he hauled Phainon forwards right off his feet, putting an uncomfortable arch in his spine. When Phainon struggled to even his stance, Mydei kicked his legs to keep him there.

He deserved more than a split lip and bruised jaw but Mydei only shook him like the insanity would rattle out through his ear from brain. “I could ask you the same thing.”

They were supposed to fight beside each other. To watch each other’s backs and ensure they both made it back to the detachment alive.

But Phainon had run off without a second thought.

Phainon grabbed at Mydei’s wrist and any sense Mydei knocked into him was gone again. “He’s here. That black-robed swordsman. I saw him.”

Mydei’s teeth ground together. If they shattered they would just grow back. There were things he wanted to say, practically fighting to be the first to spew at him with fire and acid, but when he parted his lips there was no sound.

This was still an area about to be drowned under the black tide. Maybe Phainon saw the black-robed swordsman among the ruins that looked like his past. But they would drown in monstrous insanity before they found him.

Mydei scowled and shoved him away. He stumbled one step and recovered with a warrior’s grace.

Still, the space between them was enough to draw words like blood as he spat, “I didn’t realise you took yourself for a Kremnoan. *Valorous death before glorious return*.”

And he couldn’t keep the mockery from his voice. One that he had kept safely within the confines of his mind and his heart that knew better than that war cry. Strife and the endless gluttony for glory was nothing but a dead end.

He tore off a pointed end of crystal and hurled it. Phainon tipped his head but it was pointless. Either way, it skimmed past him and impaled a black tide creature through the head. More of them poured from the alley.

Mydei kissed his teeth. “Follow me or stay behind. Your hatred will weigh you down and ensure you drown in the coming tide. The choice is yours, *Deliverer*.”

He didn’t wait for an answer before he ran back the way he came. He needed to make it back to the main street so he could scatter the black tide and let his warriors push into the town with a sense of cohesion that could hold against the onslaught.

Over the chittering of black tide creatures and collapsing rubble hitting the ground, he may have heard footsteps echoing his but he didn’t turn to check. It could have just been the black tide finally finding a weakness to claw its way inside his mind.

Left. A shadow. He threw himself to the floor, tucking his shoulder and rolling back to his feet. His legs tensed as he prepared to throw himself at the black tide creature that had tried to take him by surprise.

A steel blade pierced its chest. It howled as the blade yanked free and the next swing came for its head, silencing the painful sound.

Phainon flicked the blood from his sword. Mydei glanced over him from the neck down for any major injuries. None. He kept running.

The black tide had advanced towards the open gates. It would be difficult to push them back but the line had to hold if he didn’t want the detachment swarmed the moment they funnelled into town.

Mydei's tattoos pulsed and a number of small crystals formed in his palm. He tossed them towards the smaller streets that connected to the main one. They exploded on impact and blockaded the extra entrances off. The black tide would have to come straight for them.

White and gold in his periphery. He flexed his fingers and lunged for the nearest horde.

He had just finished ripping it to shreds when the klaxon sounded overhead. Not a signal of retreat but a declaration of war.

The detachment pressed in behind him and there was no day or night under the blackened sky, only the ache of his body and a growing pile of inhuman corpses at his feet as the battle raged on. If there was someone at his back, he didn't know.

Eventually, the incursion began to slow and the detachment advanced. The same way a cut bled quick, then sluggish, and then stopped completely, the black tide lulled. It was just for now. A temporary respite before it inevitably erupted again.

But it was enough for the detachment to claim victory.

They organised search parties and dispersed throughout the town to sweep it for survivors as quickly as possible. Once there were no humans left to find amongst the corpses of monsters, they returned to the encampment.

Krateros reported no casualties—Ptolemy was alive. Mydei still had the chance to apologise for his lost spear and replace it with a new one—as Perdikkas purified Mydei's wounds with the waters blessed by Phagousa. They found the vials in one of the Titan's abandoned temple. While Krateros rattled on with the battle report and even once silence fell, Perdikkas kept quiet. He was too busy glancing furtively between Mydei and Phainon on opposite ends of the medical tent.

As soon as Mydei's bandages were wrapped and he was dressed in a fresh set of garments, he strode out the tent and neither of them stopped him.

His face always rested in anger. Usually various members of the detachment would tease about his bad mood after a stellar victory and offer him a drink. But whatever expression he wore chased even the boldest of the detachment away.

His ears throbbed. His head ached. He hadn't told Perdikkas. If he had, there was nothing the physician could do. It wasn't the type of physical ailment that could be healed or his body would have done so already. It was all in his own head.

But he had over exerted himself. His arms and legs itched. Not the skin but the veins beneath it, all along the extremities where he had drawn blood to create those crystals. The blood replenished quicker than the sensation faded.

He paced his tent.

He wanted more. More battle, more bloodshed to lose himself in. It was the only time he could take the restraints of everything—duty, responsibility, fate—wrapped around him like chains and *pull* with all his might. Every unpleasant thought and memory could be sharpened into a weapon.

Then maybe his head wouldn't be so full.

Phainon charged into battle with hatred his only guide. A death wish. Phainon broke one of the detachment's laws and left his comrades vulnerable. A valorous death still left nothing more than a corpse. Phainon abandoned him. Phainon could have died within arms reach.

"Mydeimos," someone called from behind the tent flap.

He inhaled, tensed his whole body and held it, then exhaled and relaxed. "Enter."

Leonnius walked in first but the flap closed behind Peucesta. Leonnius' neck was wrapped, likely around the same cut that just peeked over his jaw. Peucesta upper arm was bandaged but his forearms and fingers were hale enough for him carry and place a full chalice of honey brew without it

spilling, and to pluck at his lyre. Just twice to test the tension of the strings and he nodded before setting it aside.

No music from Peucesta. They were serious.

At Mydei's open surprise, Leonnius ran a hand through his hair and it still fell perfectly arranged afterwards anyway. "Hephaestion and I swapped."

"I'm his overseer," Peucesta added.

Mydei sat on the kline. "What do you want?"

Leonnius dropped himself cross-legged to the floor cushion without spilling either chalice in his hands. He offered one to Mydei. "To hear the latest gossip of course. How are you looking to settle your grudge?"

Kremnoans returned favours tenfold and grudged a hundredfold. But once the matter was settled it was *settled.* If any ill feeling arose then they were put to rest as soon as possible through whatever means necessary. Every warrior needed to be able to trust the one beside them, in front of them, behind them. Petty grudges had no place among comrades on the battlefield. Especially as their life of exile, fraught with turmoil, could claim any one of them at a moment's notice. To have a close relationship abruptly ended while wrought with resentment would mean a lifetime of regret.

"It's not a grudge," Mydei grumbled as he swirled his chalice, more red than he preferred. Leonnius always skimped on the goat milk; claimed Mydei's taste buds would never mature otherwise.

Leonnius whistled. "Something you won't settle with a duel. Who was at fault? You or him?"

"Him."

He threw his head back and cackled. "Maybe I shouldn't have agreed with Hephaestion's plan. The look on that poor puppy's face must be something."

Mydei rolled his eyes but didn't argue. He sipped his drink, leaning his chin against the hand braced at the elbow on the kline.

Once Leonnius finished laughing, Mydei set the chalice down, thumbing the smooth face slowly. "He abandoned my side to satiate his need for revenge."

The smile slid from Leonnius' lips. He set his honey brew aside. "That's serious."

Mydei let his silence agree.

It wasn't Leonnius who spoke next. But Peucesta.

"Then will you no longer entrust your back to him?"

Mydei's head jerked up to Peucesta's dark eyes, always seeing and observing for the inspiration and verse that would outlive them all. "What?"

Leonnius shrugged, finger running the rim of his chalice. "Brothers in arms need complete trust in each other if they all want to make it home alive. He betrayed your trust. Are you going to do anything about it?"

It was no secret that out of everyone within the detachment—who had spent five years raising, training, teaching Mydei while also battling, eating and drinking, sleeping alongside him—Phainon had supplanted them all. He was the one Mydei trusted the most. The one Mydei wanted at his side not only in battle but when they marched by day and gathered around the campfires by night.

And the others suspected that might change.

Mydei poked his chalice. It swayed, tilted, and the liquid sloshed. But it didn't spill and the chalice fell back into place like nothing happened. "No."

"It's your life," Leonnius said, no judgement as he sipped his honey brew.

Mydei waited for him to drain the chalice before he glanced between the two and asked, "Did you ever expect another answer?"

They shared a look. Amused. Mydei knew their reply.

Leonnius grinned and raised his empty chalice high like a toast. “No.”

Peucesta played a song while Mydei finished his drink. It was a ballad of two brothers who went on to claim glory together. Only once the song ended did they leave him.

He needed to wash off, adorn his spare set of gauntlets, celebrate with his men already so rowdy outside. Yet he couldn’t bring himself to move from the kline.

Over the sounds of drunken cheer, footsteps shuffled on the grass back and forth in front of his tent. Yet no one asked permission to enter.

“Phainon.” The steps stopped. “Just come inside.”

The flaps parted and closed again behind Phainon as he skulked in, head and shoulders bowed. Under different circumstances, Mydei might have joked that the others must have given him quite the chiding. But it would fall flat. Besides, Phainon would have looked the same, even without the intervention of their friends, the moment hatred stopped fogging the forefront of his mind and his rationality returned alongside remorse.

Mydei motioned for him to sit and he did without hesitation. On his knees, still curled inwards at the neck and shoulder even when he tried to keep some dignity in his stiff back. It was as though he had received some terrible news or knew he was about to.

They both sat in silence. Phainon loved to speak, using his whole body to convey every word, so it was surprising that he remained absolutely still. The others must have warned him that Mydei didn’t take kindly to those who didn’t accept their deserved punishment outright.

Mydei blinked slowly as he realised that he had never been… *angry* with Phainon before. The closest he had ever come was annoyance but the difference between that and raw fury was as vast as the entirety of Amphoreus.

Mydei calmed the last embers of his anger with a deep breath. They smouldered, prepared to blaze again at the slightest provocation, but it didn't feel like smoke to suffocate the both of them when he exhaled and spoke, "Your actions spoke enough, so heed my words. Seek revenge for the dead but don't be so eager join them."

"I won't," Phainon swore but his head remained bowed. "I… lost myself. In the heat of battle and my hatred. You have my deepest, most sincere apologies, Mydei. I don't have the words to tell you how much I regret betraying your trust and leaving you in battle."

"I'm not your keeper," Mydei jabbed.

Phainon's shoulders shrunk into himself and Mydei silently cursed. He meant what he said but perhaps the circumstances and his tone were too harsh for Phainon to brush it off.

But he then lifted his head and met Mydei's eye and there was still shame but it merged with his resolve to no longer evade in cowardice. "No. But I abandoned your side once. I refuse to let there be a second time."

Mydei tilted his head, considering as he gazed down at Phainon sat upon his knees while Mydei lounged on the kline. This sort of position didn't suit them.

He sighed and crooked his finger, telling Phainon to rise and then join him with a pat of the cushioned seat. Phainon hesitated but Mydei arched a brow like a dare and Phainon quickly sat beside him. Back straight, legs together and hands tucked in his lap.

Unlike Phainon, Mydei had never hated anyone. But he had also never lost so much at someone else's hands like Phainon. Perhaps animosity towards his father should have gone hand-in-hand with his pursuit of revenge for his crimes against Mydei and his mother. But all he felt was the resolve to carry through his responsibility, and an exhaustion he felt down to his soul. If anything, the only thing Mydei truly despised was…

Mydei rolled his eyes at Phainon's scolded posture and nudged his thigh with his foot. "Hatred is a valuable weapon in the right hands. Use it as a whetstone to hone yourself until you can reach your goal. But exercise caution before you shatter yourself against it."

… *Fate*. Everything true black-robed swordsman had attempted and in-part succeeded to take from Phainon was the same as what fate endeavoured to take from Mydei. His home, his friends, his family. So he knew how to take fear and contempt and use it as just another weapon. The same as his spear, his gauntlets, his immortal body.

Phainon nodded vigorously. "I will take your words to heart, Mydei."

"I think your brain would be better."

"Both would be best," Phainon chirped and when he glanced sidelong at Mydei they shared a smile.

Mydei nudged him again with his foot. "Phainon, know that, if you do one day join the ranks of the dead, the one seeking revenge on your behalf will be me."

Phainon's eyes widened but Mydei didn't know what he found so shocking. If Phainon died—a thought Mydei had hardly even entertained before today, and still scarcely believed—then who else would tear the entirety of Amphoreus asunder in search of retribution except Mydei.

But that was its own kind of curse. This thirst for revenge and the hatred that came with it. One that, if permitted, carved its way through bone and left something hollow behind—a mere spectre of living. If Phainon didn't want Mydei to live by that same curse, then he would simply have to live a long life.

Mydei tipped his head into his knuckles and smirked. "And next time the opportunity for your revenge arises, speak to me and I will gladly be another weapon for you to achieve your goals."

“Mydei…” Phainon breathed, the slightest tremble to his voice under so many layers of emotions. He shook his head. “Just having you at my side is enough.”

The chalice was empty but Phainon didn’t need to know that when Mydei lifted it to his lips the same moment he kicked at him. A playful thing that still aimed for Phainon’s neck but he easily dodged and grabbed him by the ankle, laughing the whole time. And Mydei gave himself away when his laughter echoed in the empty chalice.

That made the two of them, once again, the same. No matter what, Phainon would be the one entrusted with Mydei’s back.

Chapter End Notes

PhaiDei may have their fights but they (and the Kremnoan 5) will make sure they talk it out before the end of the chapter.

Perdikkas the moment he finished treating PhaiDei and finds the others: THE KIDS ARE FIGHTING
The other four: [blue screened]

▶ Details

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

> Mydei spends the night hunting mercenaries and stargazing with Phainon.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In Mydei's seventh year of exile, several city states began to fear the growing numbers and strength of the Kremnoan detachment. Through contracted mercenaries and rogue armies, they hoped to dispatch the eyesore that marched across Amphoreus once and for all.

Rather than try to flee or evade their enemies, Mydei blew their campfires out at sunset and hunted the mercenaries through the mountains surroundings Aenionus. Terrain they had spent the last several days memorising under pretence of marching through. There was no city for Peucesta to lure them into before they set it ablaze.

Nothing but the moon and stars to illuminate the way, it was almost nostalgic as Mydei sprinted through the forest after a fleeing figure.

His body had grown. No longer short and scrawny but tall and broad with muscles he kept amassing to match his brutal style of combat. Every day Phainon struggled to decide between telling him to stop or continue building more. A bit hypocritical considering the Phainon's deliberate exercise regime, designed with accumulated knowledge from the entire detachment, to noticeably strengthen segments of his body.

It had only worsened since Mydei finally adopted more Kremnoan styles of clothing; body finally suited to the loose garments hanging off one shoulder and exposing his torso. There were all sorts of benefits: freer movement, fewer layers in the heat, less fabric to repair or replace. The biggest boon

arose on the battlefield as the sight of his bare body marked in red tattoos, his unruly mane and his golden claws inspired terror in his enemies.

But to be quick and evasive rather than bulky and unyielding was still familiar from a childhood where he *sensed* more than he *thought.* He knew how to lighten his steps, weave in and out of the trees, use the foliage to his advantage so they would never quite know how close he truly was.

Then he struck.

He dove down from the trees and kicked the mercenary to the ground with a boot to their ribs. They hit the floor hard but still tried to roll with the momentum. Mydei was already on top of them before they could recover, his spear driven through their chest. Then he was gone again before they could wheeze their last breath to curse him.

After days of scouting he had chosen this area. Except for the one mountain pass that led to and from Aenionus, there was nowhere else to flee when the mountains penned them in on all sides. It was the perfect hunting ground.

The Kremnoan detachment dressed in their darkest garments, distinguished only with a single strip of red fabric tied around their right arm. They prowled through the darkness in search of their prey with all the animalistic barbarism others accused them of, and would continue until the sun broke over the mountains.

It was far from an honourable battle. But the mercenaries had no interest in honour when they lurked in the shadows for days on end as the detachment roamed the mountains. A scavenger stalking a lion, not for the carcass of the prey but for the moment the lion was vulnerable enough to butcher. Observing. Waiting for the weakest moment before they would strike.

This was the chosen battlefield of their enemies. It was only right for the detachment to meet them upon it.

He leapt over a creek and his feet grazed the grass when a flash caught his eye. He threw himself to the ground just as a blade flew over his head.

Close. Maybe it would finally be an opponent with skill and not just surprise.

He rolled away and to his feet as the great sword plunged into the earth where he had first dropped flat. The moon gleamed off the hilt and edge. He squinted. He knew that great sword—had sparred against it and been saved by it. He would recognise it anywhere even as the tip pierced through his back.

“Phainon.”

His assailant yanked his sword from the ground and paused. He stepped out the shadow between two trees and lowered his hood, revealing white hair and bright blue eyes. “Mydei! I didn’t realise it was you.”

Mydei took Phainon’s offered hand, letting himself to pulled to his feet. “Is that so? Just when I thought you had finally seized your opportunity to dispose of me for good.”

At eighteen, Phainon had stopped growing taller sometime in the early half of the year, and, as though his body couldn’t remember how to be static, put on even more muscle in his shoulders, biceps and thighs. Mydei was still growing fast but two years difference and nine years of neglect means difficult to dispel. A fact Phainon always took advantage of by draping himself over Mydei’s shoulder at every opportunity.

Even now, his arm slung over Mydei’s shoulder while the other hovered over his own heart in mock offence. “The end of our relationship requires something more fitting. Something remarkable that the poets of Amphoreus would write epics about for eras to come.”

“And how would you accomplish that small feat?”

His smile grew, ever more mischievous, and he leaned closer with a secret shared just between them. “A duel declared in front of the entire Kremnoan detachment. It would continue day and night until I finally found the answer to that immortal body of yours.”

Mydei's tenth thoracic vertebra ached like it had already shattered once before. But that wasn't enough to deter him from the idea of that duel between them nor the thrill that Phainon had envisaged it, hardly different from his own fantasies, too.

Mydei grabbed at the wrist dangled over his shoulder and squeezed like he meant to shatter the bone. "Good luck with that. I'll wear you down before you get anywhere close."

Phainon kept his hand in place and chuckled. "That's very confident of you."

The rustle of the undergrowth alerted them to a presence and they both fell silent. Too strong and too low to be the wind when the branches overhead hadn't even swayed. Mydei flicked the dagger from his belt into the bushes with one quick movement. A quiet squeal. Not human but, when they parted the bushes, a rabbit.

"Huh." Phainon plucked the dagger out and cleaned it with a flick before spinning the hilt to face Mydei. "Good throw."

Mydei sheathed the blade with a mild hum. "I have always been better at game hunting than you."

"Hey now. I give you an honest compliment and you give me lies in return."

"That's why you stole one of my rabbits during our hunting competition."

"You will never let that one go, will you?" Phainon said with a forlorn little sigh and shake of his head. "How long has it been? A year? That was an honest mistake, I swear it upon my honour as a warrior."

Mydei had actually forgotten all about the incident until now. It was nothing of note, simply routine hunting competition during an easy spring, but Mydei would swear Phainon stole one of his rabbits to supplement his own kill count and edge out Mydei for the victory. Phainon had always denied it.

The results had hardly mattered considering they were technically on the same team the entire time.

Still, he rolled his eyes and shrugged Phainon's arm off just as it was returning to its chosen perch on his shoulder. "If Nikador strikes you down before morning, we shall know why."

"Ah ha!" Phainon cheered, entirely too loud considering the night hunt. He was triumphant even as Mydei walked away and he trailed behind. "So if I live then I must be telling the truth and you can no longer bring the matter up."

"It means Nikador happened to be asleep."

Phainon took the sharp reply in stride and laughed, leaning forward into Mydei's peripheral vision, eyes crinkling when their gazes met. "Then I will declare it before every battle. Surely Nikador must watch at least one in our lifetime."

Mydei paused. First under the guise of listening for any close movements. Then in consideration as he gazed at the full moonlight and pinpricks of starlight through the canopy. Simply watching as the always did, seeking to capture stories to scatter across the night sky.

"It would have to be a grand battle," Mydei murmured. "One that could shake the earth and the skies."

When he glanced over again, Phainon had a hand on his great sword and the other his hip. He was already smiling at Mydei, too gentle for a conversation about their weapons levelled at one another, but it was a language shared between them. "Then I'll save my declaration for the day we finally duel with our all."

Mydei's lip curled and he twirled his spear, balancing it across his shoulders as he picked any direction to start in. Just to get moving. They had stood around long enough his sweat was cooling dewy on his skin.

“Acceptable. And I will continue to bring the matter up until then, lest you forget.”

Phainon sped up to walk at Mydei’s side, mindful of the spear but bypassing it to brush their shoulders together. “Oh Mydei, like I’d ever forget anything about you.”

There was no reason for them to stay together—two people made more noise than one, they were both capable fighters on their own, they covered more ground apart. But every time he glanced around, he caught sight of a red armband and white bangs peeking from beneath the hood moving in tandem with him through the darkness.

The mercenaries had realised the hunt was on after the first dying cries echoed through the night. Few had the courage to stand against the detachment without a well-timed ambush. The ones that did were the first to perish in the opening wave of the bloodbath.

The rest of them hid amongst the undergrowth, burrowing into caves and clambering up trees where they could lash out with an advantage and boost their meagre chances of survival. Others hoped the detachment would simply miss them and move on, leaving them to flee. Only to be caught by the groups stationed on either end of the mountain pass.

Although the two of them had a habit of competing with numbers, that was reserved for the black tide or hunting competitions rather than human lives. There was no celebration or witty remark when Phainon’s great sword pierced someone’s chest or Mydei’s spear cut through their neck. No regret either. Only a quiet resolve and acceptance that Death had come to the mountains of Aenionus. If not for the mercenaries then it would be the detachment.

Their encounters began to dwindle until several hours passed without a hint of an enemy. They searched through tree hollows, empty fox dens, small caves but all turned up empty. There were only other detachment members, still roaming, but the smoke occasionally rising from the trees meant they were settling down for now.

They wandered along the river. Mydei even challenged Phainon to delve into the water and check a small cove nestled into the wall. A child would have been lucky to fit inside but Mydei stood at the bank, hanging over the sunken river, while Phainon stood calf deep and peered into the opening because they had raced over who could climb a tree fastest and Phainon lost.

“Feel free to borrow my spear,” Mydei said with just a tinge of mocking and a thump of his spear against the ground.

Phainon’s great sword would just about fit but the spear would be more flexible if anyone were hiding inside—they definitely were not—yet he waved over his shoulder. “Keep that for yourself.”

The grass rustled behind him, quiet beneath the gurgle of the river but not low enough to escape his senses. One person. Kremnoan military training.

“Your Highness. Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

Phainon jerked his head into the cove roof and he reeled back, hissing Kremnoan curses near silent under his breath but Mydei could read his lips well enough. A snicker escaped Mydei’s pressed lips and he arched a brow when Phainon shot a glare at him as he rubbed his sore head.

Then it settled into an amiable smile when he glanced over Mydei’s shoulder. His knees and waist bent, about to kneel or at least bow, but the splash of water up his thighs stopped him.

His expression turned a bit more sheepish at that and he waved instead. “Good evening, Krateros.”

It was far from evening but to say *goodnight* would be an even greater blunder. Phainon generally sought approval so long as the other person was worth his respect and it wasn’t being maliciously withheld. Krateros was one of the few people Phainon *wanted* approval from. He certainly knew how to select a challenge for himself.

“What brings you here, Krateros? Where are your men?” Mydei asked as he offered Phainon a hand and hauled him onto the bank.

“We found someone cowering inside a fallen tree trunk.” Krateros kissed his teeth. “These mercenaries are nothing but cowards. To disgrace themselves by fearing death at the hands of their enemy.“

Mydei hummed and Phainon paused as he squeezed the water from his clothes. Not to catch Mydei’s attention but mere curiosity at the sound, neither agreeing nor disagreeing with Krateros’ sentiment.

Mydei nudged him with his foot and pointed at his drenched lower half again, telling him to focus on the task at hand, before he spoke to Krateros, “I assume the smoke curling belongs to our own men.”

Krateros checking Mydei up and down for injuries or anything else he needed to address, and then lingered on Phainon. “Yes, while they are taking a reprieve from the battle they also remain vigilant for any mercenaries the campfires may draw out.”

“So long as they keep their weapons at hand and honey brew from their tongue, they can do as they please.”

Krateros looked between the two of them again, confusion pinching his brow. That was fair considering, while the rest of the department gathered into small parties, Phainon and Mydei had split off alone at the beginning of the hunt. In the vast mountain range, they had somehow ended up back together in hardly any time at all.

“You two…” He shook his head and masked the confusion behind an authoritative cross of his arms that only grew more intimidating with every grey hair he collected with time. “Have either of you taken a rest since the hunt began?”

“Not yet,” Phainon said, slow and brows furrowed.

Although they weren’t at rest, they were hardly at work either. More so at play.

“See that you do,” Krateros advised, too gruff for his words and stiff shoulders. “To… dry off. The water will weigh you down. And the night is cold.”

Mydei’s lip quirked as Krateros walked back the way he came. Perhaps Krateros would never be fond of Phainon but Mydei didn’t think Krateros was fond of anyone except for Mydei himself. Even then, was any of that fondness addressed to him or to the crown Krateros envisioned he would one day wear, and the woman he had failed in the past.

If Krateros knew Mydei’s own treacherous thoughts directed at their dynasty and homeland—that the so-called false prophecy and voices of traitors in Eurypon’s ears were nothing but truth—perhaps he would have agreed with Mydei’s father and tossed him into the Sea of Souls himself.

They wandered without even the facade of searching for more mercenaries until they found a rocky outcrop in the open, cushioning it with their chlamys to rest.

Mydei unwrapped his jerky rations and offered some to Phainon, the same way Phainon offered his waxed leather flask of pomegranate juice, despite both having their own full rations. Phainon took the jerky from Mydei’s fingers with his teeth. Mydei let Phainon tip the juice into his mouth before taking it back for himself.

Phainon chewed slowly when he usually gobbled his food so quick Perdikkas had to dislodge his food before he choked and Mydei challenged him to name a single thing he tasted except for the obvious *salt.*

Then he uttered, more a question than a proud declaration of intent, “Valorous death before glorious return.”

Mydei stilled. He slowly swirled his own flask like it was a chalice. “Going into battle against your dinner?”

Phainon didn’t rise to the bait he simply rested his arm over his propped knee, fiddling with a length of smoked jerky and gazing unseeing at the

trees. “While the rest of the detachment adopt it as their motto before they charge into battle, I’ve yet to see *you* use it.”

“What of it?” Mydei drawled as his heart quickened and he tore into a length of boar meat just to feel something that wasn’t his tongue between his teeth. “To constantly use the same speech would lessen its effect.”

Now it was his turn to hum noncommittally. He chewed thoughtfully at the jerky and didn’t grab another, only dusting his hands off. Mydei finished his food in silence despite his appetite disappearing as quick as the cold night descended once the sun vanished into the horizon.

Phainon raised his flask to the moon and stars. “May victory always be yours.” He tilted his head into a smile in Mydei’s direction. “You use that one all the time, no?”

“All the time is an exaggeration.”

“Then, you use that one and subtle variations the majority of the time.” Phainon tapped his finger at the stone beneath him to a deliberate rhythm, following the steady beat of his thoughts. “But that, too, is a traditional Kremnoan sentiment.”

“And what of it?”

“It just feels as though… you’ve never been fond of that idea. Valorous death before glorious return.” And then, as though Phainon hadn’t cracked Mydei’s head open on the rocks and read his hidden thoughts, second in secrecy only to one deception, illuminated in moonbeams and starlight, Phainon smiled like the sun. “Is that right, Mydei?”

His mouth opened and even moved but no sound escaped. But words should never be used where actions sufficed.

His hand shot out and Phainon’s eyes widened, reflecting black and gold, but didn’t move even when Mydei’s glove pressed against his lips and his claws dug into his jaw. No blood. Just the threat of Mydei’s gauntlets drawing gold to smear across his round cheeks and sharp jaw balanced

between adolescence and adulthood. Maybe some light bruising beneath the tips, thumb on one side and four fingers on the other.

“Speak of this to *no one*,” he growled with all the ferocity of a cornered animal.

Phainon’s brows creased and he would have tilted his head if he were able. But Mydei’s hand kept his head firmly in place and his mouth shut. He couldn’t answer.

Mydei let go but Phainon still didn’t speak, just stared at Mydei with eyes as deep as the pit of the sea Mydei had once crawled through. Brighter, lighter, even in the darkness of the night. Rather than weigh him down and drag him into a watery grave, it sought to lift him like wind beneath feathered wings during a warm, clear day as Phainon searched his every feature with something working behind his eyes.

“So,” Phainon began cautiously, hand loosely cupping his jaw where Mydei had grabbed. “You… don’t entirely agree?”

Of course. Phainon had never let anything go in his life. The same as following his every step, sticking to him, completing chores and favours—just another thing he was so dogged about.

Mydei crossed his arms and squeezed. The same as prying teeth, the word was dragged slow and bloody from his mouth. “No.”

Phainon only hummed blithely, massaging the redness that would likely darken to bruises. “You never mentioned that before.”

A harsh laugh tasting like iron came next. “I never mentioned that I—“ he clenched his jaw. Never before had he voiced it out loud. But it wanted out so badly he could feel it knocking the back of his teeth, “—*oppose* the most central creed of Kremnos.” He pushed his bangs back, clawing at his scalp. “Oddly enough, I never saw fit to *mention* it in conversation.”

There was no offence in Phainon’s expression. He only offered his flask. Mydei had his own. He took it anyway and threw a mouthful back. Tartness

washed down the back of his throat and left a bitter aftertaste with no milk to dilute it. He dragged his arm across his mouth as he passed the flask back and Phainon took a sip too. No words. Only their breaths falling into rhythm as they watched the stars.

When he was ready to spit something other than vitriol and panic, Mydei spoke. “Strife is nothing but a dead end.” He chuckled as hollow as the sentiments that united his detachment. “Valour? Glory? I’ve clawed my way out the Sea of Souls and listened to the longing cries of the dead countless times. There is no valour. No glory. No eternal battlefield. Nothing worth discarding your life for.”

On instinct, Phainon’s head swivelled but he stopped himself and forced himself to look at the tree tops curling with smoke where the detachment rested, the mountains in the distance that sealed them off from the rest of the world, the sky above them that connected Amphoreus’ lands—its past, present and future.

“Then what is it like?” Phainon asked, casual yet soft where he was usually loud in his cheer. “Tell me, Mydei, what it was like for you.”

No one had ever asked before. Not like that. Not in a way that wasn’t probing for imagery of an endless battlefield of past heroes. Their only interest, drunk on battle or honey brew, was an exhilarating tale. One he gave them in the form of creatures slaughtered at the hands of a child.

Mydei’s exhale trembled like his soul had never quite thawed, even after seven years. “Light, sound and warmth were all unknown. The only constant were the monsters. Not as monstrous as creatures of the black tide. But they knew I was… not the same as them—smaller, weaker. When they hunted me down and my body stitched itself back together, it would begin all over again.”

He knew Phainon had given up the facade of not looking, reliant on the barest tip of his head and his eye peering out the corner. But Mydei didn’t want to know what kind of expression he was making. To some extent, he already knew. The pure anguish at Mydei’s anguish, like he would take any beating, any impairment, any pain if it would spare Mydei the same pain.

But there had to be more. Sympathy. Worse: pity. Maybe realisation that violence was as much a part of him as his own blood. That he was nothing more than another monster from the Sea of Souls constrained to a human body. What else would explain his resistance to the Hand of Shadow and his undying body?

He didn’t want to see something that could change the easy rhythm between them he always took for granted. Miss a beat, a step, and they may never align again.

Yet he wanted to be seen. For someone to understand even a sliver, as slim as a newly waxing moon in the night, and there was no one who understood him better than Phainon.

He squeezed his arms tighter, carefully not to tear fabric and flesh with his claws as he held himself the way people usually held others or were held by them. “No pain in this world could ever compare to what I already endured. And in the places where the dead gather and wait for passage along the West Wind, they speak to me. It’s nothing but frigid ruins brimming with sorrow.”

Only two voices had ever given him reassurance. The rest clamoured for him to join him. Give up on living, just as they were forced to do, and sink to the bottom of the Sea of Souls where he would never again wake to a warm sun.

All those souls dressed in Kremnoan garbs or armour who took one look at his own clothing and the mark of Strife over his chest. They gathered around him, a legion of the dead who elevated him to the fore of an endless battle that would never come, no matter how they hoped. Warriors who still hungered for glory in a place it would never be found. As though, stripped to their barest selves, that voracity was as much a part of them as anything else—more than the desire for life.

Pinpricks stung his arm and he let go before blood could bead through the tiny holes in his sleeve. He dropped his chin against his tucked knee, eyes lowered to the drab stone. “What could be more courageous and venerable than fighting for a future to live by?”

One where his friends yet lived. Even if they turned their backs on him once they inevitably realised the truth of his disdain for Castrum Kremnos and its crown, so long as they had the chance to *live*, he could accept the most bitter loss.

The shuffle of fabric, and the air warmed with Phainon's presence. His feet slid into view beside Mydei's own without touching. "But once you become king would it not be possible for you to create change."

He shook his head. "If their minds were so easily swayed, fear would have done so already. This ideal has been ingrained throughout Kremnos' entire thousand year long existence. The cycle of Strife and the Kremnoan dynasty keep each other aflame."

A wildfire blazing out of control. A destructive force of nature whose strength was never to be doubted. But it would one day consume everything and then itself when there was nothing left to burn. Not a soul left to throw itself onto the pyre in the name of honour.

But a corpse was still nothing more than a corpse. When the soul departed for the Sea of Souls and the body became carrion, a glorious death made no difference.

"To claim the throne and lead the detachment home," Mydei recited the purpose handed to him. The voices of his friends who still lived but should have died and bestowed their final words onto him echoed in his mind. His hands clenched, scraping through fabric to the stone. "Would be a death sentence issued by my own hand. Perhaps not immediately but their future and the future of their children will end in blood."

Because they would rather expend their lives fighting for their homeland, a valorous death for a glorious irrational outcome, until the black tide swallowed them all than even attempt to adopt a peaceful way of life. Even if an eternal day burned just over the horizon, the final haven of Amphoreus, the Kremnoans would refuse safe refuge and fight until their final breath.

Honour, Courage, Tenacity, Sacrifice were not inherently detrimental values. Mydei strived to uphold them with every draw of his weapon, knowing he could never expect his warriors to follow them if he did not. But even Nikador knew they were most formidable when balanced by Reason.

Phainon waited for him to say more. Mydei kept his lips thinned but he closed that final distance so their feet bumped at the ankle bone; their thighs and shoulders pressed together.

“This view of the stars…” Phainon said with a smile clear in his voice. Not the big showy one, or the overly polite one. Not teasing or goading. An honest one. “It’s nostalgic.”

To Mydei, the night sky was simply the night sky. So long as it wasn’t the Evernight or the lightness abyss, the moon was the moon and the stars were the stars. To Phainon, being beneath a starry sky reminded him of a time when he was young and gazed up at the same sky. *Home.* And he could pretend everything was unchanged.

Phainon pointed. “That’s my favourite constellation.”

His finger drew through air like he could touch the sky itself and leave proof of his existence there. Maybe he could. Stars were named after heroes. Perhaps, one day, a constellation of a hero wielding a great sword would be named after Phainon of Aedes Elysiae. It would be fitting. Phainon would not only engrave his name into history but the very sky itself.

Mydei’s body was stiff, prepared for the nonexistent threat that had set every part of him on edge, alight, and faded away like nothing because it was Phainon beside him.

He leaned back on his hands and squinted at a cluster of tiny, distance lights. “What is it?”

“Leon. The lion.”

Mydei squinted harder. “I fear your eyes are different to mine.”

“Here.” Phainon threw an arm over Mydei’s shoulder and tugged him close, the lines of their torsos squeezed together so Mydei could follow the line of his finger. “See. It starts over there and then—“ he dragged his finger through the stars, “—goes like that and ends—“ he flicked his finger, “—at the tail.”

He repeated the motion. Just as he must have done—or had someone do for him. A mother, a father, a best friend—in the wheat fields untouched by Strife and bloodshed. Now Phainon was an adult dusting off the memories of a young boy as he tried to follow the stars and take the two of them to a safe and peaceful home. Somewhere simple.

“I still don’t see anything.”

“Come on, Mydei, use some *imagination*. Or must I check with Ptolemy if that word exists in the Kremnoan dictionary?”

That excuse had become unusable only two years into Phainon’s time with the detachment, unless Mydei felt particularly audacious. Phainon’s brain was built for knowledge and so much exposure to the language meant he absorbed it quickly.

He huffed but did nothing to elbow Phainon from his shoulder. “The only star I need to be aware of is Cynosura.”

“The star to help navigate the poles? How pragmatic of you,” Phainon chuckled with a small shake of his head. “But I refuse to believe that you don’t possess a favourite. There has to be one you’re drawn to. What about the heroes of old scattered across the night sky? Surely one of their tales must call out to you.”

Of all the ballads Peucesta sang, epics and poems of old heroes, none of them had ever particularly resonated with him. The rest of his friends had at least one or two they would request Peucesta recite for them, but Mydei only listened and appreciated the skilled voice and coordination of his

friend, holding a weapon more powerful than any spear. One that thrived in war and peace.

Mydei stared at Phainon’s bright eager eyes and the stars glittering across them. “Is there a dog?”

He perked up and held up two fingers. “There are actually two.”

Phainon flopped onto his back, one arm behind his head while the other remained free to gesture at the sky again like some strange, forgotten ritual to summon Aquila. Mydei laid down next to him to stand a chance of seeing the thing that had Phainon so enamoured.

“Canis Major,” he stated as he traced it with his finger. “And Canis Minor. Big dog and small dog.”

Mydei hummed, considering, but the angle wasn’t good enough. He shuffled closer, head laying on Phainon’s sternum while he gazed up. “Show me again.”

He could hear and feel Phainon’s heart beating fast but he obliged in drawing both constellations out again. Mydei could almost see them if he squinted and tilted his head just so against Phainon’s chest.

“Canis Major is my favourite,” Mydei concluded anyway. “But it could provide useful knowledge to hear about the others.

They stayed like that—Mydei’s head pillowed on Phainon’s chest and Phainon’s arm draped across his shoulder. He pointed out the stars and recited stories he had read in books, learned from home, or heard from Peucesta and Ptolemy—until the sun reached through the mountains. Mydei saw nothing but Phainon’s pale skin against the dark sky, outstretched hand just within reach if he dared to grasp it, and heart steady beneath his ear.

Chapter End Notes

> PhaiDei chose their favourite constellations based on each other. Neither of them noticed. They’re losers.

This chapter (and next chapter I’m ngl) slightly delayed because of irl stuff. Not bad. Just things that consume more time than I thought they would unfortunately.

▶ Details

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

> Mydei has one last night to resolve himself to fulfil one prophecy in an effort to subvert another.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In Mydei’s tenth year of exile, the awe disappeared from the voices of those who uttered the name Castrum Kremnos and only the fear remained. The renowned mobile fortress that heralded Strife and defeat at the hands of the fearless warriors it housed had become the home of something else: a Mad King and Mad Titan—there was no match more perfect.

The Kremnoan detachment’s ranks swelled with their infamy. Exiled Kremnoans flocked from across Amphoreus to join and many chose to exile themselves from Castrum Kremnos, fleeing the Mad King, to pledge their loyalty to the Crown Prince and pin their hopes of restoring Castrum Kremnos to its full glory onto him.

As time passed, the dreams and memories, the feeling that he had done something before or the relief in feeling as though he hadn’t, began to get more distant. Hazier. As though the desperation that had forced him to peer beyond the veil of the world had, after ten long years of sleepless nights, grown weary.

Or perhaps unnecessary. Perdikkas ground herbs by the fire. Leonnius ran around the encampment to snatch food from every cooking pit. Ptolemy polished his sword. Peucesta strummed a song about a hero finally returning home. All of them alive and thriving at Mydei’s side.

None of them would live forever, but in the years since Mydei had rewritten their deaths with his one hand, Fate had never come for them again. As

though Fate were not a predator on a relentless chase for its prey, but a mere snare in the road that Mydei guided them past.

Only one snare remained.

“Mydeimos.”

He blinked slow, eyes burning from how long he had simply stared at the scene in front of him. One from a dream if only his dreams weren’t so terrible.

Hephaestion offered him a new chalice and Mydei placed his down on the grass—empty. Not that he realised until now—and took it. The lowlight, more shadow than fire so far from the campfire, made it near impossible to see the colour of the liquid but Mydei knew it would be the same as always: mixed to perfection.

Hephaestion sat at his side. “Why so distant? Has the mark of a decade finally disillusioned you to the greatness of your companions?”

Mydei spun the chalice stem between his fingers. “Not at all. I was merely thinking about something.”

“The strategy to take Castrum Kremnos is sound. We all agree,” Hephaestion immediately reassured him of the conclusion they had come to in the war tent just the day prior.

But it wasn’t the battle that would come with the dawn that had captured Mydei’s thoughts.

“Hephaestion.”

“Mydeimos.”

Mydei raised his chalice to the full moon, pink liquid dyed milky. “You are my dearest companion. In my absence I would entrust my detachment, my warriors, my people to you.”

Hephaestion stayed silent. Not because he was waiting for Mydei to continue, potentially a cost to his grand compliments, but due to his gaping lips and wide eyes. The chalice almost slipped from his hand.

“I… I’m aware,” Hephaestion finally scrounged together some composure after Mydei’s highly effective opening strike. “And honoured by how you honour me.”

Mydei hummed. He could leave the conversation there. Hephaestion might think him a bit strange but the events of the night and the next day would leave little space for him to linger over it. If it ever came up again, it could be blamed on the nerves.

But Mydei was never one to back down after deciding on a course.

“Have you ever considered what may have been if we had never found Aedes Elysiae?”

If Mydei had never found Phainon. If Phainon had never joined the detachment.

Hephaestion was still his dearest companion but it was no secret that Phainon was *more*. It wasn’t the detachment Mydei entrusted to him—but his own back.

Never in six years had Mydei caught even a speck of bitterness or gloom. Not when Mydei discussed the detachment’s next location or aim with him, nor when Hephaestion and Phainon nursed strays back to health together. Not during encampment training regimens and sparring sessions nor when they all shared honey brew together.

Hephaestion was the same as all Mydei’s memories of a future that would never come to pass. It was Mydei who was different: less dependant on him militarily and emotionally. After all to the them that should have been, their closest companions began to leave one by one until only the other remained.

Not only were the six of them still united, a seventh member had melded into seamlessly.

Phainon, who was more to Mydei than even his dearest companion. Who Mydei relied upon to keep him sharp physically and soften his rough edges emotionally. A distinctly non-Kremnoan touch, without all the expectations that Mydei wholeheartedly wished he could make true. But refused to just the same.

Mydei asked if Hephaestion had ever considered it, yet Mydei had no need to imagine—he already knew.

Hephaestion only shrugged. “Perhaps once or twice. But never in much depth. Only as a passing thought that…” He chuckled and tucked his hair behind his ear. “Of relief. That the Sea of Souls had gifted you such a name as Aedes Elysiae.”

Mydei blinked at him. “Relief?”

Now Hephaestion smiled, just as sheepish as that little laugh, so far from the wild grin of the battlefield Mydei had learned from him, and the colour to his cheeks wasn’t only the distant firelight. “Yes. Not that you were unhappy for those first four years. But your happiness always had a weight to it. As though you could never fully enjoy the moment.”

Mydei pressed the chalice to his lips, if only to stop himself from doing the same with his fingers and tracing the edges of his smile. Hephaestion had no reason to lie but it was something Mydei had never noticed about himself. How obvious was his dissatisfaction?

“In that unknown wheat farming village with the unknown boy you met, it was as though you finally discovered how simple happiness could be.”

Simple happiness. Perhaps that was what it looked like to a Kremnoan. Joy that didn’t need honour nor glory.

It was simply allowed to be, and not earned. That was why Mydei had never thought about it that way but Hephaestion was far from wrong. With

Phainon, he could be whatever he wished to be—shrewd or childish, wise or foolish, courageous or fearful. Without the burden of his titles and responsibilities of the Crown Prince or even Mydeimos. He only had to be Mydei.

Even now, he watched Phainon pluck at the strings on a lyre as he glanced between his fingers and Peucesta nodding his approval between words. And what was Mydei to do except smile.

He swallowed the rest of his drink in one and stood. “Come. Let’s join them.”

Hephaestion laughed loud and not abashed, accepting the hand pulling him to his feet. It was always Phainon who noticed him first, body attuned to Mydei’s presence, able to locate him no matter the crowd of a marketplace or the chaos of battle. He didn’t stop strumming even as Mydei tugged off his gauntlets and presented his open hands.

Leonnius whistled. “Mydeimos has finally returned to his musical career.”

Phainon missed the next note and Ptolemy winced. Yet Phainon was busy searching Leonnius’ face to Mydei’s hands, then Mydei’s face, and dropped to Mydei’s bare hands again. “I wasn’t aware you could play.”

“I have many talents.” Mydei shrugged and motioned with his hands again.

“It was Peucesta’s idea,” Perdikkas said, pestle and mortar set aside for some fig juice.

When Phainon looked questioningly at Peucesta, he lowered his warmed goats milk mixed with honey, good for his throat, and explained, “To teach him to gentle his hands.”

“Huh.” Phainon handed the lyre over and scooted over so Mydei could sit beside him on the felled log. “Did it work?”

Leonnius raised his chalice of pure pomegranate juice. “Snapped so many strings Peucesta dug a grave for them.”

So close to the fire pit, it was only natural Mydei felt his face warm. He shifted the lyre in his hands, his arms, and stretched his fingers across the strings.

“But yes,” Hephaestion showed some mercy with a smile at the corner of his lips, inclining his head. “Have a listen for yourself.”

As though Phainon’s body weren’t already tilted towards him, ears open and waiting, eyes fixed on the slope of Mydei’s face. At such an angle, the reddened tips of Mydei’s ears must have been visible through his hair, and they were too close for Mydei to hope the light and shadow of the fire could hide it.

Mydei played one song, one of three he knew. The rust fell away like an old weapon, picked up from a forgotten battlefield so that the craftsmanship below could be revealed and appreciated after so long.

At some point, he had simply stopped picking up the lyre. There was no incident to deter him when his friends had only encouraged him despite the sheer number of broken strings and shrill notes that defiled their ears.

He just knew that one day, and once upon a time, it had hurt to hold a lyre with no one to play it for.

Now, Peucesta sang along, never faltering even when Mydei strummed the wrong string with the wrong timing. The others sang along at the rhythm’s crest. Phainon swayed at his side, shoulders bumping but too gentle to dislodge his hands over the strings.

When he finished, cheers erupted from their small group of seven and everyone raised their chalices. A new one found its ways into Mydei’s hand and he raised it too, all downing their drinks as one.

No alcohol. They knew better than to drink excessively before a battle.

The lyre returned to its rightful owner, playing idle notes to accompany their conversation passing around the circle, rising and falling as the fire

simmered and jumped. Sounds that broke away in flickering embers only to merge once again at the right moment.

“How are the remedies?” Mydei asked Perdikkas.

He chuckled and shook his head. “You worry too much, Mydeimos. The remedies have improved with the herbs you recommended. But they’re still unnecessary. Hephaestion’s condition has been stable for years now.”

Across the fire pit, Hephaestion threw his head back and laughed at something Leonnius had said. An embarrassing story based on Ptolemy’s arms thrown around Leonnius’ neck.

If Mydei wanted to preserve moments like it, he must maximise Hephaestion’s odds of surviving the relapse of his illness in the coming months. Supplementing his diet and stocking every ingredient Perdikkas could possibly need, to the confusion of both, was far from enough.

Even if Perdikkas were here, he couldn’t stop destiny from taking me.

Hephaestion had said so himself, whether as a final comfort or a fatalistic acceptance Mydei didn’t know. But he knew better than to risk it.

They parted ways for the night. Mydei’s private tent had recently become a shared tent after the others complained that Phainon had gotten too large to continue sharing with any them. Mydei had told them to rearrange themselves to make room, yet it was nothing but a cursory argument and they all knew how it would end.

So it was Phainon who settled in the cot opposite Mydei’s with wishes for a good rest before blowing out the candle. Phainon’s breaths that played in Mydei’s ears as they lengthened and evened out under the influence of sleep, just loud enough that Mydei wasn’t quite alone as he closed his eyes, greeted by darkness and his thoughts.

Illnesses like Hephaestion’s, which plagued him throughout his entire life, weren’t as simple as an enemy to evade or cut down. While Perdikkas’ life hadn’t ended during that ill-fated battle against Ladon in Mydei’s fourth

year of exile, he still had yet to find any cure and Mydei began to accept there were none for Hephaestion's condition. Instead, he needed Hephaestion to survive in spite of his relapse.

Mydei needed the Kremnoan detachment inside Okhema.

"Mydei…" a bleary voice whined, still half-asleep, and Mydei paused partway to the tent entrance. "Where are you going?"

He huffed a laugh. His footsteps had been near silent but somehow Phainon had woken up anyway. "A walk."

He yawned, a shadow moving in the dark as he pushed himself up. "Wait a moment. I'll join you."

Mydei rolled his eyes. "Lie back down and rest."

"What have we said about stones and glass houses," Phainon retorted, too slurred to be sharp, and tossed his blanket back onto his cot.

Mydei's frowned. "Don't be sloppy. At least fold that."

Even if Mydei didn't intend to be gone long, he had smoothed the creases from his blanket so it appeared untouched. Diligent cleanliness was simply good practice when infections and infestations spread like wildfire in such close quarters, which he failed to instil in Phainon after six years.

Phainon stretched his arms overhead, yawning again. "We'll be back soon anyway. Watch, the bedding will still be warm."

The encampment was dark. Quiet. The only noise was the wind buffeting the occasional bird in the trees, and the woodland creatures or the night guard shifting through the undergrowth. Everyone wanted to be well rested come morning and the world held its breath so it could bear witness.

Only the two of them were awake to leisurely stroll the encampment until they found a spot far enough from the tents and patrol route for peace.

Mydei was so accustomed to Phainon at his side that he felt the privacy of being alone; two sets of footsteps and breaths falling as one. But it was better when he could turn his eyes from the full moon and find Phainon already looking his way, never shying away even once caught. His lip only twitched into a small smile, just wide enough to be a little smug and cheeky.

To onlookers, it appeared that Mydei was always spoiling Phainon, indulging his affections and whims. But in truth Mydei was the one that had been spoiled by him so thoroughly he knew no one else could ever compare.

“What was it about this time?” Phainon asked in a voice that had fully shed the remnants of sleep. Eyes just as clear; shining as pale as his hair under the full moon.

Do not shed tears for me. It’s not befitting of your status.

Mydei grunted. “The same as usual.”

Farewell, my dear friend… you must… lead us home.

Ten years of spitting in Fate’s face, yet he always knew it would come to this. Perdikkas, Leonnius, Ptolemy, Peucesta were all alive and by his side. He would do anything to guarantee Hephaestion would be no exception.

So tomorrow he would once again join hands with prophecy when he took his father’s head. A long sought revenge, but also a means to an end: so that the Goldweaver would open Okhema’s gates to them, and that the detachment would follow him through.

“The Son of Gorgo will be crowned in the blood of eternal Strife and it’s dynasty.”

Those were the words Krateros had told him when Mydei asked why his father would toss him, a new born infant, into a place for the dead. The prophecy his father had received all those years ago. A prophecy that

Mydei, in keeping with Kremnoan tradition, would slay his father. Then he would turn his blade on Nikador and end the Kremnoan Dynasty.

Mydei laughed but it rang hollow like a wind blown through empty bones. “A mere handful of words. But it was enough for my father to end my mother’s life and abandon me to the Sea of Souls. For what purpose? So the world would never be without Castrum Kremnos and Strife at its helm.”

He laughed again and did nothing to mask the bitterness with only Phainon as witness to his true feelings. To the Kremnoan detachment, who had despised Eurypon’s rule and not Kremnos’ legacy, who still claimed its name and traditions for themselves, it would be unimaginable to ever slight Nikador as the embodiment of Strife itself.

Elsewhere in Amphoreus, people spoke of Death as a peaceful West Wind that carried people to a Sea of Flowers. In Castrum Kremnos, Death was an eternal battlefield where warriors gathered across the centuries to earn ever greater glory. Strife was the creed which Kremnoans lived and died by.

Only Phainon knew of the great betrayal Mydei would enact come the end of tomorrow. Mydei would not take the Kremnoan detachment home. Even if it earned him pure disdain and vitriol where he had once known affection.

The chill pulled his skin and he shivered. The fire pits smouldered low or had gone out entirely, leaving the night wind to sweep through the encampment unperturbed.

He crossed his arms, and took in the full moon and final time before he exhaled softly. “Come. Let us return.”

He had walked off that uncomfortable tightness in his chest and spoken his thoughts aloud. It was time for him to go back to sleep and greet tomorrow. No more fleeing, no more evasion, no more wilful ignorance.

No footsteps followed.

“Mydei.”

He paused but his heart didn’t tremble when he faced Phainon even with his carefully crafted mask, aloof and confident and a leader above leaders, laid pathetically at his feet. Backlit by the moon and almost luminescent in the night, Phainon made a hazy figure that Mydei would always find no matter the darkness he would have to wade through.

No smiles. Just grave sincerity as he laid a hand over his heart and swore, “Even if victory absconds itself from your path, I will walk it with you.”

Victory that could only be achieved alongside glory and Strife. For him to part ways with one would mean parting ways with them all.

Mydei dipped his chin into his smile that went beyond the usual slight curl of his lips. A futile attempt to hide the extent of his fond grin. “Of course you will. After all, my wish has yet to be fulfilled, Deliverer.”

This time, Phainon was in step at his side as they returned together, both of their minds spoken and heard—just as Mydei knew he would be.

Some levity lifted Phainon’s solemnity when he smiled into his next complaint, “Do you ever intend to tell me this wish of yours? Or am I supposed to guess?”

At first, Mydei never told Phainon his wish because he simply didn’t possess the words. Past, present, future jumbled together. Inexplicable knowledge. An undesirable outcome. He wished to bloody his fists on Fate and emerge victorious but there was no way to explain that to anyone who wasn’t him.

But there was something else he wanted, too. Even before that wish to see the people he cared for alive and happy. One that came to him as a sunlit voice in an abyss that had seemed so endless. But that voice told him of a whole world outside of it and have Mydei a hope to cling on to. To meet again. To battle side-by-side. To see the smile ever present in that voice for himself.

Now those two wishes had become one. Mydei had become too selfish, too spoiled, in Phainon’s presence. He wanted it all. He never wanted to let

anything go.

He would tell him. He would. Once everything came to pass and the dust settled; no matter the outcome, Phainon would know everything. Mydei owed him that much when it was meeting Phainon that had given him the opportunity to experience this simple happiness for himself. Once Mydei joined in alliance with prophecy only so he could spit in its face once again, bringing ten years of exile to an end, Phainon would have already fulfilled his wish.

“Are you telling me you can’t figure out something so simple? How embarrassing for you, Deliverer.”

“Mydei, it’s been six years and you’ve never had the decency to give me so much as a hint.” He suddenly perked up and his smile turned challenging. “Give me one chance. One question.”

Mydei scoffed. “If you only mean to inquire into the details of my wish then my answer will remain the same.”

He tutted. “Give me some credit. If you fear that the question may give you away, feel free to back down and withhold your answer.”

Mydei scowled at the obvious taunt but Phainon only lifted his brows in retaliation. “Ask away.”

Phainon pulled ahead on quick feet and spun on his toes to face Mydei, who had gained the new responsibility of making Phainon didn’t fall and smash his skull open on a rock. He raised his hands to set the scene for, regrettably but not unpredictably, more than one simple question.

He cleared his throat. “Imagine, if you would, a clear spring day accompanied by a warm breeze and the gentle waves. On that day, instead of a ring, a young boy from Castrum Kremnos washed up on the shores of Aedes Elysiae from the Sea of Souls.” Phainon flourished his hand towards Mydei. “What would you have done?”

If there was no Kremnoan detachment to find him and take him in and raise him, wandering across Amphoreus between battlefields and sieges, with the expectation that he become king. Only golden wheat fields and the open seas, radiant beneath a gentle sun that would warm him in place of the flames of Strife.

A sweet fantasy. The same he had given himself over to those years ago. It wouldn't last. When Phainon asked such a question, it was without any knowledge of the feral beast Mydei had been when he emerged from the Sea of Souls. It had taken skilled warriors, not the steady hands of farmers and fishermen, to tame him into something human.

If the Sea of Souls had gifted him not the name Aedes Elysiae but the place itself, Mydei would have fled from the beings who looked like him and hunted in numbers larger than him. If they tried to speak to him in sounds his brain hadn't yet learned to decipher, or gone so far as to force him to stay, he may have lashed out, even killed someone if that was what it took to escape. If he made it to the forests and the wheat fields, none of them would ever find him again. If so, it was likely he would have eventually been found by the Kremnoan detachment and never returned to Aedes Elysiae.

"It depends," Mydei said, slow and deliberate from deep in his chest, braid swaying with the tilt his head. "Would you have kept me?"

The ground dipped. Phainon's heel met empty air and his face slackened with surprise as he fell backwards. It was only a small hole, something easy for him to recover from when he had been forced to compose himself after much worse on the battlefield, but Mydei caught his outstretched hand.

He didn't pull him up and Phainon didn't slip away from under Mydei, leaned over him, with his usual grace. From the arch of Phainon's back, all of his weight was balanced in their intertwined fingers and he let the two of them stay there.

"Kept you?" Phainon's eyes slid down to Mydei's throat, bobbing when he swallowed and Phainon followed the movement. His lips quirked. "Sure.

People take in strays all the time. Just have to give them a collar: return to Phainon.”

Heat flushed across Mydei’s face but he didn’t dare look away—knowing it would be his loss if he did. A loss in some undeclared, unnamed competition where the first to flinch accepted defeat—he only kissed his teeth. “Bold words for the one who’s been collared.”

A small black thing. Phainon managed to pick it up in the few moments Mydei had lost sight of him in the marketplace. It had been tasteless and bland, even Phainon debated how to wear it when it would cover the sun tattoo he liked so much. The detachment felt the need to intervene and customise it with a slit across the tattoo and a golden buckle hammered into the same symbol of Strife adorning Mydei’s belt. Now Phainon hardly ever took the thing off.

The hand Phainon let hang limply by his side finally moved, grazing his collar with a mocking tilt of his head and lips. “I put this on myself, so surely the only person I belong to is me.”

The symbol of Strife gleamed in the moonlight, as bright as the sun peeking beneath and between black leather.

He yanked Phainon onto his feet and smirked as he stumbled, suppressing that heat in his face. “Whatever you say.”

An arm reached across his shoulder. A habit even when they had both reached their final heights and Phainon flaunted a mere finger’s width over Mydei.

“I would have,” Phainon murmured in Mydei’s ear, breath ghosting down his jaw and warming his neck like…

They were just behind the rows of tents. Mydei kept his voice low, “What?”

“Kept you.”

Phainon’s fingers toyed with the end of Mydei’s braid, golden tip between his index and middle finger while his thumb brushed over the bumps and dips.

“You would come to the fields with me and Snowy to hide and play instead of work. Join me in school so we could learn to speak and read and write. Swing a wooden sword and speak with the fairies and pretend to be heroes. Then at the end of the day we’d go home together to eat at the same table, sleep in the same cot, and do it all over again.”

The sweetest of fantasies, too naive for even a daydream: idyllic, peaceful.

“Warmer,” Mydei relented as though it pained him.

Phainon perked up, fist clenching the braid in his surprise and Mydei hissed at the tug of his scalp. He hurriedly let go, threw his chin over Mydei’s shoulder and beamed. “Really?”

Mydei grunted. Not affirmative nor denial, so it was essentially a yes. “Turn your mind from the past that cannot be changed. Focus on what you can grasp with your own hands.”

Phainon hummed thoughtfully. “How like you.” His hand flexed against Mydei’s collarbone, lifting so his hands could curl as though he were grabbing hold of something just ahead. “Will another six years pass before I get a second clue?”

“If you need another six years then perhaps you haven’t been looking close enough.”

Phainon hurried two steps ahead to lift the flap of the tent, letting Mydei duck inside before he followed. The tent closed with a final breeze at their back, secluding them in a low lit privacy most used to sleep. They stood at the entrance and faced each other.

Phainon’s grin grew. “I think you may be right, Mydei.”

He didn’t let Phainon’s concession shake him, only arched a brow. “Is that so.”

“Definitely. And when is a person as honest as they are in sleep? Especially with those dreams of yours.”

And when Phainon sat down it wasn’t upon his cot with its mussed blanket in a heap. Phainon dropped himself onto the cot on the opposite side of the tent— *Mydei’s cot* . He even had the audacity to pat the surface like he had a right to invite its owner.

Heat plunged like his stomach, spreading from the just-cooled tips of Mydei’s ears and crossing his cheeks until he could feel it down his throat. “And just what kind of truths are you hoping to extract while I’m fast asleep?”

The leaps in logic it had taken Phainon to reach this conclusion were completely irrational. But Mydei was already kicking off his sandals and sitting down. He breathed, letting the sound fill the tent where it was just the two of them tucked away in the night. When Phainon stared at him with his tail practically wagging, Mydei laid down facing the wall.

The bedding shifted and a warmth staved off the cold air they had let inside with their exit and entrance. Phainon laid against Mydei’s back, squeezing himself closer as he draped the blanket over them both.

“Who knows?” Phainon whispered. Mydei felt the rise and fall of his chest as he breathed, as he spoke, each puff of it hot against the shell of his ear. “But I’m looking forward to finding out.”

The solid weight of Phainon’s arm rested against Mydei’s waist. Mydei felt another deep inhale and then the rumble spreading through Phainon’s chest before the sound reverberated through the air.

Phainon was singing. In low tones and murmurs for Mydei’s ears alone. A sadness tinged every note. Like memories, like longing, and Mydei could smell wheat and sea salt warmed by the sun.

For nineteen years, Mydei had been in love with a man who had etched himself so deep into his soul that the Sea of Souls couldn’t wash it away; transcending all reason as it revealed every carefully penned engraving.

In his thirteenth year, he gained a name for that man—that boy—who had been by his side ever since.

Over six years, Mydei’s love that had been fact softened and bloomed. It was no longer an old mark on his soul that he carried from one life to the next. It was tending to each other’s wounds. It was knowing each other’s every move on the battlefield. It was lying beneath a great sky in a vast world and thinking of home when sharing one heartbeat.

It was Mydei’s eyes half closed with sleep as he murmured the one vulnerability to his undying body. It was the total press of their bodies together, so nothing could dare to slip between them and into the one spot that could separate them for good, which was Phainon’s answer.

The love of my life. It had been years since the words came to Mydei unbidden. But it wasn’t accompanied by the hazy impression of memories, feelings, recollections of any life except this one—anyone except him. Now, it was just this Mydei who was in love with this Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.

Chapter End Notes

> The song Phainon sings for Mydei is coronal radiance. Enjoy that fun fact.

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

Mydei sieges Castrum Kremnos and fulfils a prophecy.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The gates of Castrum Kremnos opened for the exiled Crown Prince and his followers. A homecoming. A welcome on behalf of the citizens dissatisfied by the current reign who witnessed the detachment enter the city disguised as entrants into the Kremnos Festival.

The city guards, old comrades before their exile, turned a blind eye to their familiar faces. If any of them held suspicions at Mydei and Phainon's distinctive eyes beneath their hoods then they kept those silent and waved them through the gates together.

At no point in Castrum Kremons' long history had it undergone anything that could be considered a siege. It was impossible. While other cities had high walls to repel potential invaders, Castrum Kremnos was defended by foundation and walls that, at the ruler's whims, *moved.* Wars had been won through the city's strategic movements to deploy troops from two separate locations, rain projectiles on the enemy, or reshape the terrain.

Any good siege was a two pronged attack the culminated in a single aim: crumble the walls and cripple morale so the city could be broken open and claimed anew. To attempt the same against Castrum Kremnos was a pointless endeavour when the city could simply escape elsewhere.

Invaders risked greater losses when Castrum Kremnos' quarry and forges enabled a near endless supply of projectiles to launch from their high walls. While Kremnoan territories could be skirmished for, Amphoreus had long accepted that it wasn't only its patron Titan that made its central stronghold impossible to assail.

The mobile fortress rarely settled in one location, and never lingered for long. The only time it settled was the Kremnos Festival; always stationary just long enough to gather strong warriors, then relinquish those that survived while the dead gathered into that blade hung over the city.

Although it was a tradition long sullied by the Mad King.

Mydei propped his spear over his bent knee and polished the blade until the reflection of even his *earring* sparkled back at him. Once he was satisfied, there was just enough space for him to set the spear behind him on the narrow bed, frame half rotted and mattress threadbare, where it silently settled. Then he reached across to the bed opposite and picked up the great sword without a sound while its owner was preoccupied.

Leant against the wall, Phainon peered out the window to the streets below their shabby inn. “So those are Nikador’s Titankin.”

Giant creatures of stone lumbered the streets. First carved by the hands of Nikador, they consolidated human and animal strengths in dark stone mined from the city’s quarries. The softer white stone adorned their bodies like garments and armour; unnecessary when they were blessed with the Titan’s golden blood that didn’t spill even when struck.

Mydei inspected Phainon’s blade for any faults. Nothing. The same result as his inspection that morning before they left the encampment. But being cautious in the final moments before battle could differentiate the victor from the departed.

He set it back down where he found it. Then rose to squeeze past the table and chair in the corner and join Phainon at the window. He kept a hand on his hood, hiding his hair and eyes, casting the tattoo in shadow.

Everything in Kremoan life was done with vigour, whether military training, mourning, celebration. So long as it never veered into a lack of discipline, to live life loudly was a sign of strength and tenacity.

Yet the streets were near silent. Rather than the feast and cheer expected of the city’s most sacred festival—one where the right to rule was dangled

before the people if only someone was courageous and skilled enough to earn it for themselves. A time where warriors proved their worth by bathing in the blood of those defeated at their own hands, honouring themselves and their lineage—the streets were near empty.

The number of Titankin surpassed the Kremnoans. The few people they could spot moved about with efficiency. Not joy nor anticipation. Heads down and feet swift; the open streets a means to an end rather than a place of merry making the entire city could partake in equally.

After all, the Kremnos Festival was nothing but a formality now. A place where Kremnoans clashed against more Titankin than fellow warriors, sentenced to death so their fallen souls may invigorate the Blade of Fury.

Few warriors flocked to Castrum Kremnos to participate when the chance for glory earned in blood was replaced by stone servants of Strife under the king and Titan's deteriorating sensibilities. The festival had long lost its purpose of honour or crown. It was only a massacre: every spark of steel and spill of hot blood meant to temper the Blade of Fury.

A bloodbath that Kremnoans offered themselves to with grim determination to overcome unflinching stone, glorifying themselves in its dust and golden blood, upholding a tradition that had abandoned them.

Phainon bumped their shoulders together. "When will I be receiving the tour?"

"This is the outer city. I—" *Grew up.* He brushed the strange thought away, "—would have been raised in the inner city."Phainon stared, expectant, but Mydei only arched a brow back. "What more do you want? If you're so curious, ask Ptolemy."

Ptolemy had been younger than Phainon when Mydei first met him in Aedes Elysiae. Yet he found a way to sneak in and out of the Library of Garbaniphoro with stolen books in his satchels. Ones that recorded Castrum Kremnos' history down to its hidden corners and secret passageways.

When Ptolemy tried to return the books that should have been Mydei's, looted from a library that was his by birthright, he had only laughed, telling him to do as he wished with them. Throughout the years, they were all carefully stored in waxed leather and kept in conditions as well as could be expected in exile.

"Come now, Mydei," Phainon trilled his name like a challenge. "You must know at least one fun fact about the place."

Mydei flicked his forehead and he flinched away, rubbing at the reddening spot with a pout. "The only things *you* must know is the location of the Path of Conquest and the straight march to the arena."

There were still preparations that needed to be completed before the detachment could launch the offensive. Until then Mydei—and by extension Phainon, who was just an infamous for his own skills as he was for battling at Mydei's side. His exploited birthed stories that his body must be equally as undying as Mydei's, for him to hold the position at the Mydei's side without ever losing his life—was to stay hidden. Lest the Royal Wing Elites, Titankin, and other loyalists could discover and hunt him down.

Mydei backed away from the window and dropped into a chair. The legs were thin and unbalanced, rocking and creaking under his weight. But he let his hood fall, pushing a hand through his hair and exhaled harshly through his teeth.

The detachment had splintered apart throughout the city. Until he received the signal, there was no way for him to know if they made it into the city unscathed, remained undetected, and completed their tasks safely.

Mydei crossed his arms, holding tight to his arms, and controlled his next breath. It was a strategy he learned in the Sea of Souls, just another mark of his time there that persisted even after ten years. The closest thing he had to comfort was his own warmth and the memory of someone else holding him —his mother's arms. Phainon's arms—and he recreated it the best he could.

Their rations were open yet untouched on the table. Their weapons and armour had been inspected and polished. For now, it was just him and Phainon.

Phainon with his lighthearted goading as distraction. But Mydei watched Phainon's eyes flicker between the mundane empty streets and buildings all the way to the white and gold towers spiralling in the distance. His questions weren't solely for Mydei's benefit.

"Why are you so fascinated with Castrum Kremnos?" Mydei reopened the conversation.

Phainon's head jerked up and he reeled away, guilty as he tried to mask that interest. A strange reaction. While Mydei had no love for the city that his companions and warriors still considered home despite their long years in exile, he would never begrudge any of Phainon's fascination in its finer qualities. There had to be something to Castrum Kremnos other than the classic Strife and barbarism. Although, there was nothing Mydei could say from experience.

When Mydei stared, unimpressed, Phainon accepted he had been caught and relented with a smile through the slightest wince. "Well, this place may have held my future… once."

Back when Phainon's eagerness to journey to Castrum Kremnos alone and train as a warrior was Mydei's only indication that he may have been willing to leave his peaceful home for the detachment's harsh life of exile. But the choice was snatched from Phainon before Mydei had a chance to offer.

Mydei's brows furrowed. "How did you even learn of Castrum Kremnos?"

In that small village untouched by Strife. There were still small worries: personal quarrels that escalated into scuffles, particularly rabid predators that ventured too far into the village, the occasional bandit or troublemaker. Small concerns that required nothing more than a few loosely trained but strong, healthy men to pick up their weapons. If not for the black tide, the flames of war may have been forever unknown to Aedes Elysiae.

Phainon chuckled, relaxing against the wall again so he could fulfil his role and watch the sky. Not that he took his eye away from Mydei. “I was fishing one day but, oddly enough, nothing was biting. I almost fell asleep before something finally caught the line! When I yanked it out,” he said with a swing of his arms, pulling in a fishing line, “it was a gold ring with a funny little symbol on it. The village elders told me it was the symbol of Strife and must have come from Castrum Kremnos. Through the Sea of Souls for it to end up in Aedes Elysiae. Later, Cyrene told me lots of stories about how it was full of only the strongest and most honourable of warriors.”

It was far from an incorrect assessment but, while a nice change from the slander rambled by the rest of Amphoreus against the city and its Titan, Castrum Kremnos was hardly a city worth romanticising. It was a city of war and conquest. Needless battle and bloodshed that created many Aedes Elysiae’s, villages razed to the ground, for the sake of glory.

Mydei arched a brow. “I fear you were misled.”

“Perhaps a little.” Phainon glanced out the window and shrugged, too small and too casual to be genuine when everything Phainon did was so big. “Not that it mattered in the end.”

Castrum Kremnos was far from Aedes Elysiae. Geograhically, across space long since subsumed by the ever advancing black tide. And by the oppressive air of the grand architecture in the distance, gold glowing molten as it speared the sky, distant from the slums they resided in for now. Perhaps Phainon saw old houses and golden fields ablaze anyway.

“This city could never even hope to deserve you,” Mydei said.

The corners of Phainon’s lips curled and his eyes practically sparkled when he hummed. “That must be why I fled the monotony of my training regimes to join the detachment of that infamous solitary lion.”

He smirked with a small shake of his head. “Now they’re too good for you.”

Phainon cocked his head but it wasn't the look of an overeager puppy when his hair swayed, daylight flashing off the askew symbol of Strife buckled to his collar, and he smirked. "Then I'll just have to prove myself."

Mydei stood and Phainon didn't back down when Mydei reached for his throat. His claw hooked into the black leather and tugged. Just enough to let air slip underneath like the easy hitch of Phainon's breath. Enough for Mydei's other hand to fiddle with the buckle and straighten it again.

The entire detachment had stories about Castrum Kremnos. For every subject Phainon could endeavour to learn about, there would be at least five pure blooded Kremnoans born and raised in the city who were eager to lecture him about it. Mydei knew from experience that it was easier to get them to start talking than to stop. But Phainon had wanted to hear it from Mydei.

He let the collar snap back into place. "I wasn't raised here," Mydei reminded him, quietly into the space between them as he gazed at the rounded symbol. "This city is as new to me as it is to you. But, supposedly, the outer portions of the city were constructed by convicts. So the workmanship is… questionable at times."

He peeled away to slouch against the wall, the width of the window between them. Phainon examined the room with new appreciation despite it being just as damp, gloomy and cramped as before. Then peered out the window to do the same with the surrounding buildings. Everything appeared the same to Mydei but he watched Phainon out the corner of his eye, knowing Mydei would have to watch the sky because Phainon had forgotten, and smiled.

Against the evening sky, red smoke curled up from the buildings. Another trail of smoke rose, and another, and another, and even more where Mydei couldn't see them from this inn's mediocre, at best, vantage point. The smoke vanished not long after it appeared. Extinguished. The detachment was ready. The red smoke amongst the grey confirmed Mydei's suspicions.

Although the detachment entered the city quietly, Kremnoans would never accept a homecoming without their heads held high and their intentions

declared from the depths of their stomach. At the sight of red smoke, the scattered groups merged back together at the wide open boulevard paved right to the arena entrance.

Their empty flag and the blare of their klaxons whipped in the winds blown down the Path of Conquest.

An army of warriors led by Royal Wing Elites and Titankin emerged to meeet them. Both armies were raised on Kremnoan tactics, arranged in similar formations and armed with similar shields and weapons—the first to crack would shatter.

Mydei flexed his fingers, a greatsword flashing out the corner of his eye, and his hand clenched into a fist as he smirked. This battle was no different from the rest. The outcome depended on cohesion of his army and disruption of the other. To be the spear that scattered enemy lines and the shield that defended his own was a simple task with his undying body and such a persistent white shadow at his back. He roared a battle cry and charged.

His tattoos pulsed as he shattered a Titankin with one punch to the torso and another to its jaw, red crystals floating among the grey stone. Before its torso could turn to dust, he grabbed it and lifted it as he spun. An arrowhead pierced through and stopped just short of Mydei’s eye. It clattered to the floor as the stone crumbled.

He scanned for the archer as he bent low to scoop the fallen arrow. There. A Titankin tall enough to shoot from behind two rows of enemies. He launched the arrow at its head but it knocked it out the air with a twist of its bow. He scowled but it wasn’t unexpected when the thing had been staring straight at him.

A Royal Wing Elite thrust their spear and Mydei easily side stepped. He caught the polearm, half a mind towards snapping it and the other towards stealing it, but his body was already moving. His knee coming up and hand swinging down. A bowstring twanged and he knew it was aimed at him. No time to move. He would take the hit.

Metal gleamed and a great sword cleaved the arrow from the air. Mydei snapped the polearm. One hand on the shaft attached to the blade, the other hand shot out and grabbed the warrior by the tunic. He spun and kicked the Royal Wing Elite towards the detachment and kept spinning as he pulled his arm back. He flung the spear tip at the Titankin archer and pierced it through the head.

At his side, Phainon looked him over once while Mydei did the same to him. Nothing to find, their eyes met and they nodded—two whole breaths spared—before resuming the battle.

At least three ordinary people were required to subdue one Titankin, so Mydei and Phainon took responsibility for the bulk of the stone beasts while the detachment clashed with their fellow warriors.

The madness of the Titankin was exposed when the creatures broke away from formation to overwhelm the two of them even at the cost of leaving their human comrades exposed. It made them easy prey for the detachment and they pushed through the first legion into the Hall of Strife where the next legion defended the entrance to the Kremnos Arena.

Mydei caught a Titankin’s great sword and his feet slid against the floor as it pushed all its cumbersome weight upon him. A burst of red crystals shattered the stone blade and engulfed Mydei’s fist as he punched through its arm at the shoulder. He lunged for its throat and crushed the stone in one hand, head falling and fracturing in a white plume.

The doorway was near. The quantity of warriors had been exchanged for a glut of Titankin and better quality Royal Wing Elites to better fit the limited room. But they scattered and perished just the same under the assault and the detachment seized the opportunity.

Krateros kicked a warrior off his spear, hair stuck to his sweat slick skin and blood that wasn’t his own, eyes dark with the thrilling frenzy of battle when he found Mydei. “Go! Everyone, gather in a defensive formation. Protect His Highness!”

Krateros' battalion gathered around him and blockaded the doorway to the arena from the remaining warriors and Titankin. Behind their row of shields and helmets, it was only Mydei and Phainon sent to press onwards.

At the heart of the city, Kremnos Arena stood poised between the pit of roiling lava below and the Blade of Fury above. A forge for warriors, heated and struck and tempered for the sake of Strife.

Stood at the centre, his father awaited his arrival, accompanied by a final handful of Titankin. Undoubtedly the best.

Phainon swiped at his forehead with his arm, sweat dripping from the ends of his hair, but his smile was free of exhuastion. "Four against one. How much would you bet on me?"

Mydei drew his spear from his back and discarded the cloth bound around the blade. "Nothing. Unless it's you and I competing, *everyone* bets on you. I wouldn't make any money."

Phainon chuckled. "To think I'm worth so little to you."

All four Titankin aimed at Phainon. This time not from madness but careful control, so that it was Mydei and Eurypon left to face one another. There were no words to exchange as they each levelled their spears. One of them would be conquered and one of them would be crowned in blood.

While Eurypon's mind as a leader had deteriorated to madness, his body was still fastidious as they clashed. Even years onwards, long enough for Mydei to reach adulthood, it was obvious how he emerged victorious from a Kremnos Festival of the past and held steadfast to the crown ever since.

Both body and mind were honed for combat. Quick and precise strikes. Keen eyes that noticed any and all vulnerabilities. The courage to risk his life for the advantage.

To think this man had dishonourably poisoned his wife and thrown his child into the Sea of Souls.

But for all Eurypon’s skill, Mydei had spent every waking moment of his childhood battling with his life as forfeit. Every day in the Sea of Souls and the wilds of Amphoreus forged his body of steel from merely armour into a weapon. At first a feral child who could only lash out at everything before it could destroy him first, and into a disciplined warrior who commanded armies.

He had waged battles on every terrain, under every disadvantage and advantage, and emerged victorious to stand before the King of Castrum Kremnos. Not for his crown but for the vengeance owed to his mother and to himself, and for the future he wished to see.

For others, risking their lives took courage and restraint to overcome fear. An opportunity to earn a valorous death enough to suppress the inherent desire of all things to keep living. For Mydei, Death was something he had experienced as much as he had forced onto others. His oldest companion, second only to pain.

An aging body of a bygone king couldn’t compete. To the end, Eurypon epitomised Castrum Kremnos—past strength that waned in the present and would inevitably crumble against the onslaught of the future.

Mydei disarmed him with a flick of his wrist and kicked him to the ground.

It was all so familiar. The same spear tip poised at the same face laughing as the end drew ever closer. The same burning sky as the fortress blessed by Nikador fell to a siege for the first time in its thousand year history. The same end to the same prophecy.

“A fierce fighter…” Eurypon praised in a voice hoarse from battle. “I did not expect such heroism from a feeble Okheman. Fulfil your duty as the victory, warrior, and tell me your name. I seek an honourable death from you.”

A father brought low at the feet of a son he couldn’t recognise. The rest of the city knew of the Kremnoan detachment, many hoping for their return home to herald the return of Kremnos’ former glory. Yet Eurypon lacked

the wits or the attentiveness to his citizens to realise that the detachment and its leader were not Okheman—but Kremnoans finally seeking justice.

“As if you have any honour!” Mydei spat. “Listen closely. I am the leader of the Kremnoan detachment—Mydeimos. I’m here to finish you, *father*.”

The same speech and the same dreaded realisation as Eurypon The Mad King realised that his true madness was believing someone so undeserving could ever transcend prophecy.

For the first time, his voice trembled as he gasped, “It is you. The beast spurned by all. So, you did defy death. The prophecy was true—you will bring an end to my Kremnoan dynasty.” His fists clenched into the ground and he jerked forward, spear tip drawing blood. “Then swing your blade! Take my crown, coronate yourself with an old king’s blood, and inherit it all. Become the new rightful king of Kremnos.”

Mydei scowled and stamped his foot onto Eurypon’s stomach, wheezing out a pained breath, to keep him in his place. “No, I don’t want the crown. Listen—if there’s only one end for the kings of Kremnos, then the crown means nothing to me.”

More Strife. Another dead end drawn long like the dying breath of a wounded animal. But it would be Mydei’s blood splattered across the wall.

“All I want is your life. To avenge mother and my comrades!”

Eurypon cackled low and breathless beneath Mydei’s foot yet still so arrogant. “But the walls of Kremnos will not fall with me. Do you truly think you can escape Fate’s grasp, my son? The son of Gorgo is destined to be crowned in blood!”

Mydei glared down the length of his spear, capturing blood and insanity in its polished edge. “Father, in some ways you and I… are more similar than I would ever wish to admit.”

Eurypon scowled and opened his mouth to retaliate but Mydei patience for this farce had worn thin. He brought his boot down upon his chest and drew

a long line of blood across his throat.

An old king. A coward. Finally in the dirt where he belonged.

“But you and I will never be the same. To subvert Fate you sacrificed your wife, threw your newborn child into the Sea of Souls, and tried in vain to enslave a Titan by desecrating the body of a god—when you should have resisted Fate’s inescapable grasp with the strength of your *own* mighty will. And now Fate’s reckoning is upon you.”

The same ending to the same story. A prophecy.

So it should have been the same too when those sneering words faded away in a gurgle of blood and the Blade of Fury pulsed in acknowledgement of all the souls that had joined it. When Mydei crouched down and pulled the signet ring from the old king’s finger and clenched it tight, hoping it would crumble to dust and take Castrum Kremnos with it. Mere relics of the past.

But the ring, bloodstained and unscathed, mocked him.

The Kremnoan detachment, the entirety of Castrum Kremnos, behind Mydei. But no one at his back. At his side. His dearest companions another bloodstain on the steps of history and Fate.

Yet when he turned, a lone figure stood tall by the exit to the arena. White hair streaked in gold and red. Blue eyes that never looked away. The scent of wheat and salt which made Mydei think of home that needed neither the golden fields nor the sea. Just the memory of them etched into his soul by his hand entwined with another’s.

The spear fell from his hands and Mydei ran. Impulsive, undignified. But if Phainon—who had seen him at the highs of his victories and the lows of his despair. Had clashed against his vicious brutality and held him gently afterwards. Had found the edges of his mask shaped like a crown and watched him bleed when it pulled free, only to stymie it with steady hands—never strayed from his side, then what need did he have for dignity. Not a king, a prince nor The Undying. He was just Mydei.

There was no surprise on Phainon’s face. No boisterous, victorious grin. Just the softest of affection as he opened his arms wide and welcomed Mydei in. Mydei’s rough voice and stony demeanour. Mydei’s temperament honed for battle and not for peace. Mydei’s burning body too hot to hold. Mydei’s nightmares of a world that had happened but only to him. Mydei’s lips that clashed against his.

It was Mydei gathered in Phainon’s arms, hands held over his tenth thoracic vertebra, and Phainon kissed him back like he had been the one waiting since before they had ever met.

Lips dry and dusty from battle, tasting of sweat and blood, where they moved with adrenaline and six years of longing from each other’s side.

Mydei pulled away and Phainon tried to chase, eyes still closed and arms holding him tight, but Mydei set his hands on Phainon’s shoulders and his eyes fluttered open. He didn’t let go, holding Mydei aloft over that finger’s width of height different he so loved to gloat about.

One of Mydei’s hands traced the long line of his throat and over his jaw with the very edge of his claws. Shivers and raised skin followed as Phainon’s eyes flitted between Mydei’s hand and his gaze, too wide and hungry to settle in one place.

He cupped a cheek flushed from more than exertion and leaned in again. He stopped just short their lips meeting, heavy breaths mingling together. When chuckled lowly into the small space between them, Phainon licked his lips like that was a kiss.

Mydei smiled, entirely too fond for his next words, “I want that duel.”

Phainon’s eyes dipped from Mydei’s eyes to his lips and he was already leaning in again. “Okay. Right now?”

“We need to be—“ Phainon managed to push past Mydei’s arm and land a peck. Mydei bit his lip in retaliation, “—further from the city. I didn’t kill *Nikador*.”

“Wanna try?” Phainon tilted his head, gazing through his lashes with nothing but amorous confidence. Mydei swatted the back of his head and he tossed his head back and laughed. “Another time then. If it’s the two of us not even a Titan can hope to emerge victorious.”

Mydei scoffed but felt his ears burn and Phainon’s grin knew it too. “Ridiculous,” Mydei chastised and kissed him on the forehead, watching his brows rise and his eyes widen, tail practically wagging. “Now put me down.”

“But what if I want to carry you out the city in my arms?”

“Then I will gouge out your eyes and leave you here,” Mydei threatened as he placed a kiss on one eye, thumbing a small cut bleeding gold at the edge, and then the other.

Although Mydei’s feet touched ground, Phainon’s hands slid up his back, around his shoulders, and searched for Mydei’s hands. He let him grasp one but shook the other free, once again unfurling his fingers to find that ring.

Phainon hummed, taking Mydei’s wrist in hand like a consolation prize. “What is that?”

“The signet ring.” He jostled the ring to show the emblem, the etched lines pooling blood. “Every ruler of Kremnos adorns it upon their ascension, either through combat or marriage.”

Branded in Strife’s name until it came time to brand another. A vicious cycle.

Phainon stared at it, wide eyes tracking the gold moving between Mydei’s fingers. There was nothing particularly eye catching about it. A bland chunk of gold that had seen more bloodshed than anything else. Since Mydei refused to take the crown, he had no need for such a symbol and refused to place it upon his thumb.

He stretched out his arm, held over the arena’s edge where the rising heat of the lava below grasped hold. A final warning.

He opened his hand and the ring glowed molten as it fell. There was no splash. But he knew the moment it sank into the lava because his next breath came easier as the weight of a thousand year old dynasty melted away.

There was nothing more for them here. When Mydei raised an empty flag and loosed the same battle cry he had unleashed at the battle's beginning, now from the arena's exit, all of Castrum Kremnos knew who had emerged victorious. The prince had been crowned in the blood of the Mad King.

It was something worth celebrating as the final loyalists were rounded up and given their honourable deaths. As though madness had beget madness, the Titankin had grown sluggish with Eurypon's death. Less quick, less strong, less brutal. They were easy to subdue.

Then the detachment mourned their losses in song, feast and honey brew as the citizens joined them to celebrate the end of one reign. None of them yet knew that a new dawn for Kremnos under a new king wouldn't rise with the next sun.

While cheer filled the streets finally befitting a festival, Mydei returned to the arena and gazed up at the Blade of Fury. Mydei had avenged his mother and opened the way for the detachment's future in Okhema while Eurypon's body had been strung from the arena's walls for all to witness.

Yet the only true winner was Strife. It had feasted on their battle, ever stronger for all the warriors who had given up their souls. An executioners blade over Kremnos.

Around his waist, Phainon's arm squeezed reassuringly. Wordless but saying all he needed to. Mydei laid his hand over Phainon's and squeezed back.

"Mydeimos."

He glanced back as though he wouldn't know that voice in his dreams, in death and then the next life. Hephaestion, alive after battle, still healthy in the colour of his cheeks and steady feet, smiled.

Mydei's heart quickened as he turned to face his five friends. Phainon's hand stayed, steady and grounding. A gesture that didn't go unnoticed by their five companions.

Hephaestion tilted his head in the arch of his brow. "Are congratulations in order?"

The two of them exchanged a glance. Phainon shrugged. Mydei inclined his head towards the others. It was such a familiar exchange it almost distracted him from what he needed to say next.

Phainon smiled and practically purred, "Perhaps."

They cheered and a flurry of words came next. A betting pool. Coin. Some brief congratulations may have been scattered amongst the talk of profits and losses.

"You can skip them. We have more pressing matters." Mydei crossed his arms but he knew any attempts at stern leadership were lessened by Phainon practically draped over him. Mydei didn't shrug him off. "The red smoke from earlier."

While the detachment had signalled the completion of their own small tasks with smoke, the role he had entrusted to these five alone had been hidden amongst them, only distinguished by the mineral that dyed smoke red.

Instructions to gather a handful of their most trusted men and search the forgotten corners of the city for evidence of the black tide. Red for confirmation that the incursion had already begun.

Ptolemy, who guided them with his unique knowledge of the city's history and layout, stepped forward. "The black tide's invasion had begun. In the city's catacombs and corners where regular citizens would fail to notice. Not with its usual destructive surge but—"

"Filtered through the strength of a Titan," Mydei concluded and the Blade of Fury pulsed again. Like the beating heart of a Titan in its death throes. "Come morning, I will…"

The words lodged themselves in his throat. The serrated edges of blades he had swallowed for ten years, accumulating and knowing it would be all the more painful the day he could no longer chew them down, grit his teeth and grin through it.

Phainon's hand moved from his waist to his lower back. Mydei shuddered at the heated press of his palm spread against that one spot and his words came easier.

He held his head high. "I will enter into self-imposed exile and take all those willing to follow as I join hands with Okhema. I'm certain you all have your grievances that I left the old king's blood to nourish the earth rather than crown myself. Speak them now."

The five exchanged glances. There was… nothing Mydei could read. Mydei leaned more of his weight back into Phainon's hand. Those silent conversations between them all were a natural consequence of the time and hardship they endured together. Now he was an outsider to their conversation.

They silently nominated Hephaestion and he smiled weakly. Some grime stained the skin in front of his ear that he missed cleaning up after the battle, yet this was the most off balance he appeared all day. Not when faced with enemies or the black tide in his homeland—but meeting Mydei's eye.

"Mydeimos," he said and inhaled deeply, until his chest expanded and his shoulders rose. "We already knew."

Mydei blinked. He might have even swayed but Phainon was so close, against his side, at his back, it was impossible to falter. "What?"

He tucked his hair back. It fell loose again and he dragged his fingers to fiddle with the ends. "There was no need for you to say as much. Your actions spoke your intentions well enough. It was easy to see how happy you were without the burden of prince, let alone king."

Hephaestion glanced meaningfully between Mydei and Phainon. At the minuscule distance between them and Phainon's hand at Mydei's back.

Mydei let his mind slowly run over the words again. "You never spoke of this."

At that, Hephaestion's smile softened. "We waited for you to resolve to tell us yourself. There are many burdens on your shoulders, Mydeimos. Some of which were placed by our own hands. It was only after seeing you with someone closer to your own age, acting more like a carefree child than you would have ever felt free to show us, that we realised our mistake."

His eyes burned and his throat bobbed, as though the sting was just another thing he could swallow down and sequester away. "You weren't…"

Outraged. Disgusted. Betrayed.

Hephaestion took a step forward, hesitated on the second, but he took in Mydei's face and closed the distance. His face was too blurred for Mydei to discern his expression but his hand was gentle when he lifted Mydei's in his palm.

He bowed his head and Mydei's fingers grazed his forehead. "You are our prince, Mydeimos. But first and foremost you are our most cherished friend." He lifted his head, so close it was impossible to deny the smile curving his lips. "Why wouldn't we want our friend to be happy?"

Ptolemy thumped his spear against the ground, drawing everyone's eye as he lifted an empty hand to the sky in a toast. "You faithfully served the detachment all these years."

Perdikkas raised a hand. "Spilled your blood in place of our own."

Peucesta raised a hand. "Carved yourself into the image of a king when you were only a child."

Leonnius raised a hand. "Never faltered with your feet against the earth and the rust-scented wind at your back."

Hephaestion raised a hand. “A simple happiness isn’t a bad thing. And neither is a selfish one.”

In his entire life, Mydei had never shed tears. As a child, the Sea of Souls took them away before they could fall. By the time he emerged into the living world, his mind and body had been numbed by pain and hardened by Death beyond the ability to shed tears.

Hephaestion laid a hand against his chest. His heart. “We will follow you wherever you wish to lead us. Not because of your regal blood or your undying body, but because our love and loyalty belongs to a friend.”

But his eyes watered and tears fell hot down his cheeks.

“I wanted to fulfil your wishes. To bring you all home,” Mydei’s voice stayed steady, heedless of the tears, but it had lost any semblance of authority as it shrank into itself. “But to do so would be a death sentence for you all. More than that desire to fulfil your wishes, I wish for you all to live.

He tried to scrub at his face but the metal gauntlets would only draw blood in place of tears. A hand on his chin angled his face and those same hands wiped at his cheeks, his jaw, beneath his eyes and was followed by the press of lips, quick and light everywhere tears had fallen. Phainon pulled him into an embrace.

Then another at his back, at his sides, surrounding him in warmth as his tears escaped him. First in silence and then as quiet sobs that had waited nineteen years to be heard. And they all held him through it until his cries quieted to hiccups, quiet sniffles and then finally to nothing.

From the ground that had spent a thousand years stained in nothing but blood, his tears bloomed seven lilies stained red in the name of his friends still by his side.

Chapter End Notes

> I have been informed by my friends that this fic should be tagged slow burn. Whoops.

Learned that little detail the chapter PhaiDei FINALLY KISSED. THE SUFFERING IS OVER

▶ Details

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

Mydei and Phainon finally have their long-awaited duel.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Discontent thrummed through the detachment and the citizens of Castrum Kremnos. But Mydei kept his head high as he marched all those willing to follow him out of the city gates.

The moment Mydei announced his departure from Castrum Kremnos in self-imposed exile that morning, their ranks that had endured for ten long years finally fractured.

The black tide lurked about the city like weeds, too persistent to ever be completely gouged from stone. Confronted with the proof of Nikador's madness, the inability to safeguard Castrum Kremnos and its citizens, some accepted Mydei's decision to leave the city as sound.

Others resolved themselves to remain. To be chased from their homeland was too disgraceful; they would rather combat the black tide until it eventually, inevitably, consumed them. Mydei accepted those losses and the disdain that scored itself into his back as they scorned his retreat.

But there was one spot their eyes were never permitted to touch. Phainon's hand remained firm over Mydei's tenth thoracic vertebra.

By the time they returned to the encampment, Castrum Kremnos was nothing but a blur on the horizon. Unmoored without its ruler, the stronghold drifted away; nothing but a burial ground for those who refused to leave the husk of a dynasty, now the home of a Mad Titan to sow Strife from.

In the days prior to the siege of Castrum Kremnos, the encampment had been suffused with an undeniable anticipation. But it was stifled beneath their ingrained military discipline. Every warrior knew the importance of preparing for battle, so their excitement hung in the air like the moment before lightning struck.

Now that the storm of conquest had passed, any exhilaration waned under the deluge of responsibilities and uncertainties. Manage the wounded, notate the sudden influx of exiles, distribute resources.

It was far from the glorious return home imagined by the detachment, or the grand liberation envisioned by the citizens. But Kremnoans weren't only steadfast during combat. This was another part of war—its aftermath. Another chaotic battle ground everyone tackled with resolute focus.

Only a half a day was needed before Mydei was presented with the final numbers of the Kremnoan detachment. It had more than doubled in size. A list lacking many familiar names, and filled with unknown ones.

People who raised Mydei: taught him language, battle strategies, how to wield many weapons. Who had clothed and fed him and bled for him as much as he bled for them. Now they had parted ways. While they chose to return to their homeland, the detachment had become a new home for many people and Mydei would lead them towards the dawn.

"Your Highness," Krateros called out in *that tone*; donning the role of a disapproving teacher once more.

Mydei faltered and Phainon stumbled at the abrupt stop, caught by the hand around Mydei's waist. By the cross of his brows and pinch to his face, it was obvious that Krateros was displeased about something.

There were many reasons to be disgruntled when the encampment was so cramped with people who had yet to fully settle after two days. The detachment shared roots with the former citizens of Castrum Kremnos but ten years was long enough for the detachment to create its own systems and rhythms better suited to a life of wandering.

Mydei waved Phainon to go ahead. Hephaestion needed help calming the dogs down, stressed over the sudden influx of unfamiliar scents and movement about the encampment.

They had adapted well for those first couple of days. Until Leonnius delivered the message to Mydei that one of the newer detachment members had seen them as nothing but mangy strays and gone to kick one. Members of the original detachment had intervened and prevented any significant damage but the dogs were shaken. While they often played with or obeyed Mydei's commands, it was Phainon who was the more reassuring presence for them.

He glanced from Mydei to Krateros and back again before tilting his head in silent question. Mydei shrugged and flicked his fingers again for him to go. Phainon's smile didn't waver under the blunt dismissal; he only pointed at his cheek. Although Mydei rolled his eyes, he kissed the spot right above his finger.

Too greedy, Phainon tried to turn his other cheek for another and Mydei finally shoved his face away. He watched Phainon glance out the corner of his eye, blue crinkled with as much mischief as joy, and Mydei narrowed his eyes in warning.

Phainon turned his face into Mydei's palm. One kiss through Mydei's gauntlets wasn't enough for him and he left a quick, sharp bite. Mydei gaped, speechless at the lingering feel of blunt teeth through the leather, and Phainon pulled away with a little smirk.

Then he ran off with laughter in his footfalls.

Mydei tried to rest his face into its usual unimpressed stare, one that bordered on anger no matter his true feelings, but knew it was a futile effort with the heat in his cheeks. A small bit of colour, but unmissable when Krateros observed him so closely with keen eyes.

"Is there an issue?" Mydei asked, already running through the list of things he needed to oversee, delegate or do himself; ready to slot in whatever problem had risen to Krateros' attention.

“I believe this conversation should be had in private,” Krateros insisted cryptically.

They retreated to Mydei’s tent. For the first time since Phainon began to use it as his own, both cots were tidy on their respective sides. After all this time, all it had taken was Phainon insisting the two of them share a bed, leaving his untouched while Mydei’s was perfectly made, as always, by morning.

If Krateros noticed he didn’t dare comment as Mydei lowered himself onto the kline. Rather than lift his legs to lounge against the end, he invited Krateros to sit.

Mydei reached for the table and poured them both a drink. Just water for now. They didn’t have the luxury of indulging in honey brew with so much work to be done.

When Krateros kept his thoughts between him and the chalice at his lips, Mydei prompted him to speak, “Is this private enough?”

Krateros nodded but took another breath as he set his chalice down. “Your Highness, I taught you many things as you came to understand this world.”

Mydei kept his back straight and shoulders square, a diligent pupil if not for the languid swirl of his drink. “And I remain grateful for your teachings.”

“There was one thing I always told you to bear in mind.” Whatever hesitance he previously possessed vanished as his expression hardened into a challenge. “What was it?”

Many teachings had passed from Krateros to Mydei over the years. There were only two things Krateros was so austere about: Kremnos’ five tenants, and…

“A lion should never dwell amidst its prey.”

There was no relief or approval when Krateros nodded. “Never reveal your vulnerabilities to anyone.” He crossed his arms and his forehead creased

with something between a troubled frown and a glower. “So what is it you intend to do with Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

Mydei’s brows rose. “Is that any concern of yours?”

“It is,” Krateros answered without hesitation. “It shall remain as such so long as I continued to serve you and that boy remains at your side.”

“If Phainon is considered a boy then so must I.”

“I see that in many ways you are. And are still in need of guidance.”

The chalice landed on the table with a harsher thud than Mydei intended, water almost sloshing over the rim. “Our relationship is a private matter.”

“You are the Crown Prince,” Krateros refuted, voice rising. “You have already rejected the crown and led your people from the high walls of their homeland. Do you intend to shirk more of your responsibilities? I once vowed to your mother that I would give my life to protect your reign only for the crown to stay on the old kings fallen head.”

At the mention of his mother, any outrage Mydei felt swelling in his chest cooled, flames doused in ice water. He rested his weight against the kline, temple against his knuckles. “Did my mother really have such expectations of me? Did she wish for me to commit patricide, to steal the throne, and continue this endless conquest?”

With Phainon at his back, it had been so long since he was last submerged in the Sea of Souls and he intended to keep it that way. He could still perfectly recall the utter devastation on Phainon’s face the first time he witnessed Mydei crumple to the ground as a corpse. Years and numerous injuries had passed since then but any time the heat of battle urged him to be more reckless than usual, a flash of white in his peripheral restored his rationality.

But if Mydei were to die tomorrow and found himself adrift in the Sea of Souls, a voice or sometimes a golden figment reaching out to him and guiding him back to the world of the living, what would she say?

There was no way for him to know without taking a dagger to this throat then and there. All his mother had ever spoken of were the virtues of strength and endurance, and the great things Mydei still had left to accomplish. Did she mean patricide and the crown? Or a new path away from that vicious cycle consuming itself with every turn?

Even Krateros did not answer.

Mydei sighed, “Do not mention this matter again. We will not dishonour the fallen by placing words in the mouths of the dead.”

If the day ever came, then Mydei would ask for himself. Not because it would shape the outcome he sought and the sacrifices he would make to take his people there. But because he owed it to his mother, who had stayed his weary soul every time he had need of her since childhood, to know her true self. Even more than the revenge he already delivered to her.

“Even so,” Krateros continued, slow where he had just been so quick to anger, “the Kremnoans followed you, their prince, out from their homeland and are soon to arrive at the mercy of their worst enemy. They look to you for reassurance of their future. For evidence that their decision was not the wrong one.”

There had been no command. Quite the opposite when Mydei renounced the throne, his ultimate authority over the Kremnoans, for a self-imposed exile. Those willing to join were welcome.

He had plainly spurned the crown and its title, yet the detachment still referred to him as the Crown Prince. As though he hadn’t tarnished that crown with his own hands and wished for it to rust to nothing. While his companions accepted him first and foremost as their friend, the same couldn’t be said for the rest of the Kremnoans.

When people spoke to him it was with deference, often going as far as reverence, belonging to his title. He would prefer if they used his name alone, but the older, more traditional Kremnoans were scandalised enough when Mydei refused kingship. It would take time to completely wear away tradition.

However, even if his title faded from their lips and history itself, he would never abandon those who looked to him for leadership. With or without a crown, it was his responsibility to safeguard the future of his people.

“If anyone has any objections, they can voice them with a duel. Either of us will be more than willing to meet them with our weapons raised.”

That should have been the end. If two parties came to opposition in ideals, it was only natural for that to be resolved through the clash of steel.

The twist of Krateros’ expression said otherwise. Strange for a man so committed to Kremnoan tradition. “There are many objections. Or has your newfound *vulnerability* made you deaf to them.”

A newfound vulnerability. Whether Krateros was referring to Phainon’s person or the love between them, he was wrong in every aspect. None of it was new, but something tenderly nurtured over the years that had only now blossomed in full. None of it made Mydei weaker, vulnerable, but stronger with something behind him to be protected, and to guard his own back. Not as an exchange, but from their own free will.

“It’s not like a Kremnoan to grumble over such matters,” Mydei grumbled himself. “If they seek an answer then they will have to present the challenge themselves rather than shy away in unbecoming gossip.”

It was the exact behaviour Kremnoans mocked other city-states for, particularly Okhemans with their silver tongues and endless need to wag them. For Kremnoans, if one word was sufficient then why use ten?

“Fraternising so intimately with outsiders only intensifies their unease, and concerns that you prize the opinions of outsiders more than your own people.”

Even better, words should ever be used where action would suffice. Yet Mydei had been forced to listen to Leonnius report such drivel passed between the former citizens of Castrum Kremnos.

When Phainon introduced himself as *Phainon of Aedes Elysiae* to every new face it was impossible to pretend the dearest companion of the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos, and one of the leading figures of the Kremnoan detachment, was very much not Kremnoan.

Phainon had only laughed at Leonnius' report. Then tried to conspire what other bland, uninspired insults they could spark themselves and watch spread like wildfire in a dry prairie. The six of them had been less impressed but Phainon read the silent look they shared and immediately refuted the idea they hunt down the bad actors responsible for such slander.

Mydei scoffed with as much disdain as when he first heard the first of many insults. "Phainon? An outsider? What a terrible joke. Six years of blood and steel given better than any Kremnoan, only to be denounced as an *outsider*."

"Only those within the detachment have witnessed his feats for themselves. To those who lived in Castrum Kremnos until a mere few days ago, all they have are rumours of his prowess. But does his disposition really speak of a battle-hardened warrior?"

He could converse in Kremnoan fluently yet never lost his country accent or fully adapted to utilising the back of his throat for the language's harsher sounds. He kept his more modest sense of dress that covered him from head to toe. He lacked a military cleanliness instilled from young.

The biggest transgression of all: he clung to Mydei constantly, as though he would die if they shared the same space but not the same air. *Like a consort clung to the powerful arm of a king.* Mydei's blood had boiled so quick his tattoos flashed a dangerous red when Leonnius repeated that one.

To the obstinate people who valued the traditions of Castrum Kremnos above all else and descended from their lofty fortress from necessity rather than choice, this was a problem. Which meant it became Mydei's problem.

Mydei clacked his gauntlets, feeling on his palm the remnants of a playful bite that hadn't even pierced his gloves. "He should not be made to bear the burdens of the detachment."

Krateros scoffed. “You claim he is Kremnoan in all but blood. Now your actions and words speak otherwise.”

“It has nothing to do with his lineage.”

“Yet you would have Hephaestion or I bear the detachment in your stead.”

“Neither of you would be forced to demean yourself to prove your worth to people salivating over your every move, hungering for a vulnerability to exploit,” Mydei hissed with a flash of teeth and his tattoos, blood rising to the surface, crystals threatening to pierce his skin.

Krateros didn’t flinch, as though Mydei were an unruly kitten and not the solitary lion with blood and gore between his maws. “He need not bear responsibility. He only need remove the ones forced upon you by your shared follies. Is he incapable of even this? Is he not your equal? If the idea offends you so, it’s shameful to do things by half measures. Your intentions must be clear beyond doubt if you seek to provide stability.”

Of course they were equals. They could never be anything else.

But, as Mydei considered Krateros’ words and noticed the slight purse of his lips paired with the tinge to his cheeks that were far from anger alone, Mydei realised the, embarrassing, solution he was so insistent upon. Mydei had been too prepared for insults, the same friction between them over the rarely spoken matter, and missed Krateros’ true intentions.

He huffed a laugh through his nose and his face eased into a small smile. “I understand.”

Krateros eyed him skeptically. “You do?”

Mydei picked up his chalice and downed the rest of it in one, dragging a hand across his mouth. “I have heard the complaints of you and legion, and shall work to rectify them immediately.

Words should never be used where actions sufficed.

In the field that had hosted Castrum Kremnos just a few days prior, Mydei and Phainon stood opposite one other, armour and weapons aflame under the rising sun. At the edges where grass plains met the forest, the entire Kremnoan detachment gathered as witnesses.

Phainon flowed through his routine stretches, loosening his muscles to swing that hefty great sword. “So when I win do I become king?”

Even without any intervention, Mydei had every intention to fulfil their shared wish: a duel at the peak of their abilities, acknowledging and saluting each other in their full glory, as they both strived for total victory before the entire detachment. A duel to shake the earth and the heavens and earn Strife’s gaze.

Just not now. The same as the direct acknowledgement of the love that had flourished between them over the years, Mydei had first intended to wait until circumstances calmed before he brought the matter up for discussion. Unfortunately, his emotions trumped his reason towards the end of the battle and he let everything spill free—from a soul rending love to heart wrenching tears, and had never felt so light for his confession.

Once again, circumstances altered his plans. This duel doubled as proof of Phainon’s status as Mydei’s one and only equal, and Mydei’s declaration of intent. If anyone harboured doubts or questions, they only need to witness and remember this duel to have their answer.

“There’s no longer a King of Castrum Kremnos for you to win the title from,” Mydei reminded him as he felt the pull of his shoulder blades from his own stretches.

“So what do I get out of this exactly?” Phainon asked with an arched brow, as though he would walk away if Mydei told him *nothing*. As though he hadn’t already revealed his hand years ago at the mention of a full fledged duel between them.

Mydei smirked. “If you can defeat me, I guarantee the spoils will be worth the effort.”

“Funny,” Phainon said. No laughter but grin so carefree across his face. “I thought the spoils had to be agreed upon before the duel.”

Mydei laughed under his breath and showed some small mercy, “In Kremnos there are two duels where the spoils go unsaid. If, after six years, you’re still completely unaware of that then you must be beyond all hope, Deliverer.”

“Oh, is that a hint? You only ever use that little nickname when you’re thinking about wishes. If I win, will you finally tell me what your wish is?”

That elicited a full laugh. “*Deliverer*,” the nickname rolled off his tongue in a lazy drawl, “think harder and you’ll have your answer.”

His brows twitched in consideration but there was no sign he found the answer. He simply set a hand upon his great sword and Mydei kicked up his spear in answer. They circled each other as the duel commenced.

“Mydei,” Phainon said before the first clash could mark the end of all conversation that didn’t come as the sing of metal.

He didn’t allow Phainon’s words to distract him, searching for an opening he knew from experience didn’t exist. “What? Chickening out?”

Phainon’s lips, distractingly, quirked. Mischievous, sly, almost triumphant and Mydei reassessed his stance for any vulnerabilities—there were none—but Phainon only said, “I never stole your rabbit.”

It took a moment, but when Mydei realised he tossed his head back and laughed. “Looks like you may have just sealed your fate.”

Then the battle truly commenced.

The weight of Phainon’s great sword should have put him at a disadvantage against Mydei’s quicker, longer spear. But Phainon swung a sword with one hand that some men struggled to lift with two. It was effortless, never letting the unwieldy momentum take him anywhere he didn’t want to go

when he swung and recovered quick enough to parry Mydei's dodge and jab.

Six years wasn't a long time to spend mastering a weapon. Even for Kremnoans, it took a lifetime for someone to claim mastery and most never made it to that pinnacle. If there was no one better at wielding an immortal body as Mydei, then no one could compare to Phainon's prowess with a great sword. A skill forged and tempered with two goals: revenge on that black-robed swordsman from Aedes Elysiae, and to stand as Mydei's equal.

Every strike was proof of his efforts. Beyond any doubt, Phainon was Mydei's one and only equal in this world. That's the way it always had been, and always would be.

Mydei blocked the next blow and felt the metal protest under the force. His arm tingled at the collision, from the sheer might and intention behind Phainon's every move. He shifted his weight and met Phainon's strength with his own, pushing him back just enough to slip free. Then closer while his arms were off balance. He drew his arms back for a swing aimed right for Phainon's chest. Blue eyes eclipsed by black widened and Mydei's grin sharped. A dare.

Phainon dropped low and lunged. The spear nicked his forehead and dripped gold down his nose, down his cheek, but it was nothing compared to the damage if Phainon's shoulder hadn't caught the spear shaft. The twist of his body. His raised arms where Mydei had thrown him off. He was already prepared for another—

He swung. Mydei tried to dart back but something hooked his ankle and he stumbled. He wouldn't rebalance in time so he dropped limp the ground and the great sword sailed overhead. Before the blade could fall upon him, he rolled to his feet.

Panting, sweating, covered in the most minuscule of cuts bleeding gold already beginning to staunch. They took the time to breathe.

Mydei's fingers ached more when he unclenched them than when they tightened again around his spear. "You *tripped* me."

Phainon smiled, which meant yes. Not that Mydei had any doubts. “Would that be a problem?”

“I simply didn’t expect you to rely on such underhanded tactics.”

He barked a laugh, rough with adrenaline and exertion. “What is it you always say about that conspicuous body of yours? It’s your greatest weapon. Surely you of all people should understand someone using their own to the fullest.”

“By *tripping* me like two children in the marketplace,” Mydei jabbed, sharp as the twirl of his spear, raising it ready.

Phainon yanked the tip of his great sword from where it rested in the earth. “If only all the men sent down the Sea of Souls by Mydeimos The Undying had realised that they only needed a child to bring him low.”

He arched a brow. “Admitting to being a child now?”

His grin grew. “I prefer to think of myself as an exception.”

The reprieve was over and they charged at each other again. No matter what Mydei brought to the fore of his flurry of attacks—speed, strength, strategy, dexterity, deception—Phainon matched him blow for blow. Like a dance, one would lead and the other would follow only to snatch the initiative back for themselves. A constant give and take. Push and pull. A challenge in every spark of steel and heavy breath to *keep up don’t fall behind stay as an equal*.

That was why duels were the final stage of Kremnoan courtship. Mydei flaunted the pinnacle of his every attribute with his life, honour and legacy at stake, and Phainon responded with a demonstration of his own. There was no better way to learn everything about a person than when they were on the other end of a blade.

But for the two of them it was nothing more than a formality. What was there for Mydei to still learn about Phainon? He already knew the shape of his arms and legs, his body, from eating, bathing, sleeping beside him. He

knew Phainon's sharp mind and tenacity from their many sieges and defences at each other's side. He knew his courage to step outside the safety of the easy path to join a nameless army of exiles and face down Death. He knew he burned with as much hatred as love. He knew he wanted Phainon and nobody else.

When Mydei's spear finally snapped and Phainon's great sword shattered under the force of their blows, they spared a single breath to toss them aside, shards glowing under the crescent moon.

Mydei bared his teeth and Phainon flashed his back as they reverted to their basest instincts. Conquer or be conquered. It was the very root of Strife and Mydei had never been so starved and so glutted by it.

He raised his hands ready and Phainon lunged empty handed to grapple at him with nothing but themselves. Phainon swung a punch and Mydei snatched his wrist with reflexes honed through experience of such close combat. Phainon jerked his arm back and hauled Mydei with him right into a head butt. White burst behind his eyes and warmth trickled over his lip. Nose bleed. He kicked Phainon in the chest but he was so disorientated behind his watering eyes it was only enough to make Phainon stumble.

Mydei licked away the blood, smearing gold over his upper lip and teeth.

This was it. The weapons had been so, so close. That had been the duel he thought he wanted: both warring at the zenith of their prowess. A show of sparks closer to lightning, erupting into a wildfire through their veins.

But here, now, finally, it was everything and *more*. Nothing between them. No weapons, no masks, no responsibility or duties or titles. They were stripped raw and still couldn't bear to look anywhere else as they collided in a blazing heat that would consume anyone other than them.

The duel lasted for fourteen days and fourteen nights. Something taken straight from a dream, a hope, a wish. *Better*. Because their years at each other's sides made them so.

It ended with Phainon’s every pant of breath and drop of sweat and blood falling against Mydei’s face. Phainon’s arm across Mydei’s bare chest, his legs pinned on either side of Mydei’s waist, his hand around Mydei’s throat.

Phainon’s eyes were black, his fangs bared, every inch of him the same flushed mess as Mydei but only one of them emerged victorious. It wasn’t Mydei, and the defeat stung in the places that never outgrew the desire to hoard glory, finally relearning what it meant to lick his wounds. But he had never been so thrilled to be thrown into the dirt and thoroughly defeated.

“Yield,” Phainon hissed, as rough as his raw, bloody knuckles trickling across Mydei’s exposed throat.

The tension that Mydei carried with him in every waking and sleeping moment dissipated as he relinquished everything to the man above him. “I yield.”

Phainon’s dropped like the dead right over Mydei’s body: skin slick with blood and sweat, muscles still twitching having forgotten how to rest, hearts beating in a lingering rhythm of their battle.

The sun was rising, a warm hand stretching over the trees and grass towards them. Their discarded weapons gleamed in the distance but there was no telling where Phainon’s ended and Mydei’s began.

It was the same sunlit gleam off Phainon’s near translucent hair, off his skin slick with sweat and blood over the grass and mud stains. A shine Mydei longed to see off an earring, a red gemstone inlaid in gold, and a gold tipped braid.

He grunted at the weight. His body was undying, not beyond fatigue. “Get off, you’re sweaty.”

“Can’t move,” Phainon bemoaned in a slur. Then immediately jerked his head up, chin propped over Mydei’s collarbone. “I won.”

“Is there a hole in your head?“

He grinned lazily, pure satisfaction in the crease of his lips and eyes, blue slowly returning to his eye. “It’s nice to hear, don’t you think?”

Mydei forced his arms to move, trembling with muscle fatigue, and he pushed Phainon’s messy bangs back. Neatly hidden by his hair was a thin line across his forehead where Mydei’s gauntlets scratched him. Mydei wished for it to heal, for every wound and scar and trace of a troubled life to disappear from Phainon’s body. He silently hoped this one would stay even knowing it wouldn’t.

“Congratulations, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, you have bested me.” He laid a kiss on his forehead, lips coming away tinged a thin layer of gold. He licked it clean. “Half of my honour, my life, my soul is now yours.”

As though his honour had any meaning with no one to share it with. As though the life he had now wasn’t owned to encountering Phainon amongst the wheat fields that day. As though Phainon’s name hadn’t been etched into Mydei’s soul the day he was born.

Phainon tipped his head, begging for another kiss that Mydei gladly laid upon his nose. He chuckled weakly. “That almost sounds like a marriage proposal.”

“It is.”

Phainon stopped laughing, stopped breathing. His body tensed before it remembered it was too exhausted for that and went limp again. “Oh I passed out from exhaustion. This is a dream.”

His chest rumbled under Phainon’s cheek with the beginnings of a laugh, too tired to form as more than a purr. “It’s flattering to know you’ve dreamt of such a thing.”

“All the time.”

“You never mentioned anything.”

“Mydei, you kissed me for the first time three days ago. Or however many days ago now. I lost track of time.”

Seventeen. But the fortnight had blended together into one long event; somewhere beyond the passage of time as a dream was finally realised.

Mydei scratched at Phainon’s scalp, his head nuzzling into the sensation of the same claws that had viciously tried to tear victory from his chest was reduced to soemthing so gentle and doting. “To me this was always… an inevitability. Phainon, you are my wish. Not just a duel but everything you would be happy to share with me, and for me to share with you.”

A home that was constantly on the move but would eventually settle beneath the light of an eternal dawn. Warmed through with more love, from Phainon, from his dearest friends, than he thought he would ever be permitted to have.

“Oh,” Phainon murmured, more a puff of air against Mydei’s neck.

While Mydei ran his gauntlets through Phainon’s hair and slowly down his back—massaging at that spot Phainon complained ached whenever he overexerted himself under the weight of his great sword—Mydei dredged up past memories from the Sea of Souls. But they didn’t come with the taste of Death like stagnant water pouring down his throat. It was warm, comforting, in the shape of a voice he had come to hear every day and would for every day to come.

He spoke of two words that kept him company for four years through the terror of knowing beyond doubt that the people who meant the most to him in the world would perish while he was helpless to save them.

And a boy he stumbled across in a wheat field at a quiet edge of the world and how everything had fallen into place.

“Mydei,” Phainon said, so anguished for all the pain Mydei had managed to keep hidden throughout the years, “all this time… you never revealed this to anyone…”

Phainon’s head was still laid over Mydei’s chest, his heart, not from exhaustion but simply because he had no wish to move. Even the hand that had idly drawn patterns over Mydei’s stomach—including Phainon’s own name at one point, not that Mydei stopped him—had stilled while Mydei revealed the secret buried in the deepest part of him.

“Who would believe such a thing?” Mydei said with a quiet laugh, tinged with a hint of that self-deprecation, that loneliness, he should have outgrown.

Phainon’s head lifted, no need to search for Mydei’s eye when there was nowhere else he would be looking. The pinch of his brow was too distressed to be truly aggrieved at the long held deception, and rest of his expression was hardened with resolve. “I would have.”

“You would,” Mydei agreed easily, yet he rapped a knuckle against his temple. “But everything was so complex. These feelings and memories I couldn’t discern.”

Sometimes, back then, treading the worn path of some Mydei before him along the course of Fate, it was difficult for him to know where he ended and someone like him began. Meeting Phainon, sparing his friends—the more he diverged from that set route the more he shed that eerie sensation of someone else living through him, him living through someone else.

But he was never certain until the moment he realised that his love for Phainon was his and his alone. From the memories and experiences they shared between them.

The sun had risen but no one from the Detachment dared to fetch them, letting them languish in the warm grass marred by their duel.

Mydei kissed the crown of Phainon’s head warmed by the day. “Harbour no doubts. That love was a thought and a feeling. But over those six years what grew were my *own* feelings. Not for some distant memory of a past or future Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, but the you who was by my side through it all.”

Phainon's breath hitched and he lifted himself up, hands on either side of Mydei's torso. He blocked out the sun overhead but Mydeu could still see it, reach and grasp it, in the radiant smile Phainon reserved for him.

"Me too," Phainon breathed. "To me, it was always going to be you, even if I didn't know it before we ever met or even the first time I saw you. Not the Crown Prince, or Mydeimos The Undying. Him, too," he chuckled and Mydei's lip curled. "But even if you were just Mydei who appeared in the wheat fields of Aedes Elysiae like a stray kitten and stayed."

It wasn't some grand revelation. Mydei's heart quicken anyway. He knew Phainon felt it when he lowered himself back down to snuggle against him.

Mydei's hands wrapped around his shoulders. "You were far from subtle."

"And you never acted on my lack of subtlety."

Mydei shrugged, fiddling with the short hairs at his nape. "Why rush? I enjoyed what we had. I never longed for more when you were always at my side."

"But now you're in a rush to… get married?" Phainon asked, more curious than uncertain.

He snorted. "There are many people in the detachment who would protest at the mere idea we *rushed* anything."

Phainon's hand returned to Mydei's torso, draw swirls, flowers and hearts. "So those six years were courtship? Is there some sign unique to Kremnoans? None of you ever mentioned that to me."

"Courtship is just a process for two parties to learn enough about each other and decide if they would equally benefit from pursuing marriage."

Phainon pinched his side. "Just when I was beginning to think you had a knack for romance after all…"

"We don't have to be wed straight away. It would be more difficult that way considering the current circumstances," Mydei admitted.

The detachment was being held together by sheer vigour. It would take time to march to Okhema, and then even more time to get his people to acclimate and settle.

When they were to be wed, it was the only thing Mydei wanted on his mind for days, weeks, months or however long it took to organise. It would come second to nothing and no one. A grand affair, combining whatever traditions from Kremnos Mydei was willing to keep and whichever Phainon longed for from Aedes Elysiae.

“Consider the duel a statement of intent.” Mydei took Phainon’s hand in his —a hand that had held him and held a weapon for him—and kissed his ring finger. “Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, I intend to marry you. If not today then someday.”

Phainon’s fingers twitched. Then he turned their hands so he could lean down, dry lips lingering on Mydei’s ring finger, a second kiss in the words, “Another inevitability.”

Mydei chuckled. Is there anything more fitting for us?”

Because Mydei knew they were destined to meet each other. Somewhere, somehow. Never so early that their roughened edges had a chance to grow around each other like they had never been apart—rather than clashing, sanding, until they fit together. Even if their love never came to fruition, Mydei wasn’t privy to a time when love hadn’t been nurtured somewhere between the two of them.

Phainon lifted his head, eyes still heavy with the weight of a duel that said everything that could ever need to be said between them, but smiled like he had never felt exhaustion and declared anyway, “I love you.” His arms wrapped around Mydei, back arching so they could slide between him and the soil, hands folding over his tenth thoracic vertebra. “Honour, life, soul—we’ll share in it and protect it.”

A shaky breath of disbelief, relief, escaped through Mydei’s lips. He bumped their foreheads together and closed his eyes. “You succeeded after

all, Deliverer.” But that title that once fit better than anything not longer felt so fitting off his tongue. “Phainon.”

Every impossible wish fulfilled by Phainon’s hands.

Chapter End Notes

> Went from six years of something to actually getting together to a marriage proposal less than three weeks later. PhaiDei are truly iconic.

Chapter 14

Chapter Summary

> Mydei and Phainon arrive in Okhema to greet a new future and some old faces.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Word of the Kremnoan detachment's movements journeyed quicker than their feet. Between the detachment's route and the holy city, the only major city, although reduced to the remains of one, was Janusopolis. The fallen walls and temple neutrally became the neutral ground chosen by Okhema's Goldweaver.

On the other end of the crumbling bridge out of the ruins awaited a legion of warriors. Unmistakably Okheman by their armour, and the woman at their head. Dressed in a white chiton adorned with gold laurels creeping across her body and head like her blessed blood and fine hair had bloomed jewellery. Mydei halted the detachment at the sight of the infamous Romance demigod.

Despite the Kremnoan detachment outnumbering the Okheman legion, the Goldweaver remained steadfast as she assessed first Mydei and then Phainon with dull eyes. Her golden threads strung so thin they were near imperceptible between half-fallen pillars.

Although his recollections of her were vague and hazy, he knew there was no chance she would turn them away. The Flame Chase Journey she had dedicated hundreds of years to only lacked two demigods. All of Amphoreus knew that two amongst the Kremnoan detachment's ranks bled gold—who better to bear the Coreflame of Strife than the heir to its dynasty.

A tent had been set up prior to their arrival, offering some privacy for their discussions. Inside, a young child with red hair garlanded with flowers smiled in greeting, at once childlike yet restrained. Burdened. Phainon grinned back with a little wave and the child's smile grew at the reciprocation.

While the Goldweaver took her seat beside her young companion, Mydei crossed his arms and loomed over the table. "Lady Goldweaver, if these negotiations will drag on then I will need to order my men to set up camp."

The Goldweaver didn't flinch at the tone and face that scattered enemies; if anything, her lip curled into the slightest bemused smile. "That depends entirely on whether we can reach a satisfactory arrangement."

With the fall of their city and the long days of marching, the Kremnoan detachment's endurance was beginning to wear thin. It was different now. Both when they moved or rested, the detachment was no longer so carefree, billowing like clouds drifting through the sky wherever the wind sought to take them.

Their numbers had swelled with those unfit for a life of wandering—children, wounded, elderlies, or simply those unaccustomed to the life and less adaptable than the others. Their resources were thinner, stretching to meet their physical needs. Compounded by the anxious uncertainty of their future, morale was exceedingly low. The detachment needed somewhere to settle.

However, if the two forces came to arms, the sheer numbers and discipline of the Kremnoan detachment led by Phainon and Mydei would force the Okhemans into a retreat. If they launched an attack against the holy city, the Goldweaver's threads would prevent them from storming the city walls. From there, it was questionable whether the detachment's current ranks could endure a protracted siege.

Peace was their best option.

The child stared up at Mydei with such hopeful eyes. "We don't want to see Chrysos Heirs fight."

“We…” He sighed and pulled out the chair opposite the Goldweaver. “Would also like to avoid unnecessary Strife.”

Phainon took the seat beside him and the girl’s smile was relieved. Grateful, when she glanced between the two of them.

The Goldweaver hummed, light and airy, but as elegant as the cross of her arms over the table and the slight smile of a casual conversation, not the negotiation between two armies eager to kill. “Then allow us to keep this brief. The refugees of Aedes Elysiae hold you and your warriors in high regard. They speak of how you fearlessly plunged into the black tide and rescued as many civilians as possible.”

“Kremnoans do not fear death nor the black tide,” Mydei confirmed, already aware of the only thing the detachment had to offer. “Make no mistake, we believe in the value of an equal trade. In exchange for safe refuge, the Kremnoan detachment will act as the holy city’s spear and shield against the incursion of the black tide.”

The black tide was a horrifying perversion of nature. If Mydei were able, he would keep his people far away from it. But he meant what he said: the detachment would never accept pity and charity, their pride as warriors wouldn’t allow it, not from anyone, let alone their age old enemy.

The main virtue of the Kremnoans was their military might. If not for the presence of the Goldweaver and her defences wound around the city, the Okhema would have fallen to Kremnos’ siege long ago. That same undeniable strength, which earned them scorn for their savagery from the rest of Amphoreus, was the one thing of value they could hold steadfast to after the fall of their city. And offer with pride.

While the detachment’s days of conquest were over, the familiar lifestyle of military training and excursions would hold them together in such turbulent times.

“Prince Mydeimos, I do not take the solitary lion nor the blazing sun at his back for fools,” the Goldweaver rebuked, her small smile falling into something too disinterested to be anger, despite her scathing tone.

So do not take me for a fool.

Phainon nudged Mydei with his knee beneath the table and he tapped him back; a signal for him to go ahead.

Phainon's lips curved into a warmer smile, amiable yet sincere, as expected from a face that often looked stranger without a smile and even rested in one. "Lady Goldweaver and…" He met the young girl's eye again. "Forgive me for not asking sooner, but what would your name be?"

The girl laughed. "We are Tribbie. And there's no need to call Agy that."

"So long as we remain on amicable terms, Aglaea will do fine," Aglaea agreed but her expression unsoftened. She hadn't yet received what she truly came for.

Unperturbed by the strange phrasing, Phainon bowed his head. "It's a pleasure to officially meet you, Lady Tribbie and Lady Aglaea. I am Phainon of Aedes Elysiae. As you can probably guess for yourselves, you have my most sincere gratitude for sheltering the refugees of my hometown."

Aglaea tilted her head, blond locks swaying like the golden threads about the tent, only visible when the candle light glinted off them just so. "As long as the holy city is able and the refugees have no intention of disturbing the peace, it will offer sanctuary to as many people as it can hold."

But the Kremnoan detachment was not the same as other refugees. They weren't half a displaced village of farmers or fishermen. They were a fully armed and armoured legion of Okhema's worst enemies asking for access to the city. Far from a headless viper in its death throes from the fall of Castrum Kremnos, their Crown Prince marched at their head for them to follow. Once they were inside the city walls, the only obstacle left to a full siege was the Goldweaver.

Even without a siege, there were other risks. Friction between Kremnoans and Okhemans was already guaranteed and would hinder attempts to assimilate Kremnoans into the city. It could spark civil discontent, protests

or even riots, that challenged Aglaea's questionable decisions. To provide the detachment refuge was an enormous risk.

Mydei nudged Phainon—Mydei's turn again—but it was a pointless gesture when dull eyes flicked to him before he could even inhale to speak; the Goldweaver's threads read their every move. Their persistent presence at the edge of his peripheral, perhaps moving or perhaps not, since his arrival was a power play.

There was no need for such theatrics. He had Leonnius collate rumours on the Goldweaver and had Peucesta recount every poem that venerated, or even slandered, her as soon as he resolved to relocate the detachment to her city.

Whether all the tales were true—he highly doubted it. In the same manner rumours about him were highly exaggerated—was irrelevant. Rumours told him what people believed to be true and the kind of power they attributed to the cold, ruthless woman, the very antithesis of the passions of romance, did not arise from nowhere.

"Lady Aglaea, with your vast information network, you must know the traditions behind Castrum Kremnos' lineage of kings," Mydei said.

"I know all about Kremnos' archaic traditions."

He huffed a small laugh. "Then you and I are in agreement. I took my father, the old king's, life with my own hands. Yet I refused to crown myself in his blood—to continue Kremnos' history of conquest while we fought against the maddened Titan of Strife and the black tide in the city that was now mine. Because needless Strife will only bring an end to Kremnos, my life and the lives of my people."

To shed lives like trees shed leaves, all in the name of conquest, honour and glory. Eventually the tree would be left barren to wither.

Mydei squared his shoulders and tipped his head back. Not in arrogant condescension, but confidence from one ruler to another. "I have no intention of entering your city through deception only to raise arms against

the only place my people will be safe from the black tide for the foreseeable future.”

Aglaea levelled that same stare back at him. Unwavering poise. While Mydei laid his intentions bare, she searched for any signs of deception. When she straightened back into her chair and raised the back of her long, delicate but deadly fingers to her chin, he knew she hadn’t found any.

Tribbie turned from Aglaea to Mydei. “But you know there’s something else we are also waiting for.”

“Of course. Mydei and I…” Phainon glanced at Mydei for one last confirmation, the final chance to escape.

But Mydei was never one to submit to fear and he only quirked a brow at Phainon, as though questioning whether he had forgotten that.

Phainon laughed under his breath, short and breathy but fond. “We have already decided that we will be willing to join your efforts in the Flame Chase Journey.”

Aglaea wasn’t yet satisfied when she tilted her head. “The decision to dedicate yourself, mind and body, must be entirely your own. It is no game. Once made, your life and your loyalties will belong to the Flame Chase.”

Mydei smirked. “So long as it doesn’t jeopardise the future of the Kremnoan legion, you can have this undying body as your own.”

Finally, her expression gave. Just the slightest bit, as imperceptible as her threads, but Mydei was adept at reading people he engaged on the battlefield and the table wasn’t a large enough distance to disguise the softening at the very corners of her heartless mask.

“Then we are in agreement,” Aglaea concluded. “Okhema welcomes the Crown Prince and the Kremnoan detachment in exchange for your assistance against the black tide and services to forward the Flame Chase.”

The holy city was still a few days march from Janusopolis. Despite the proximity, both armies refrained from mingling during marching or resting hours, with very few exceptions. Mydei and Phainon frequently conversed with Aglaea and Tribbie about the state of their men, immediate plans for the day or night, and the expectations held of the Chrysos Heirs.

Leonnius ran messages at Mydei's behest and refrained from stumbling on his swift feet when an Okheman expressed mocking surprise he could understand the common tongue enough to pass word.

Ptolemy attempted to organise a small hunting competition. It ended with accusations that the detachment used deception to be victorious and a full conflict nearly erupted over wounded pride.

Perdikkas volunteered his concoctions when a number of Okhemans were injured while seeking shelter in a dilapidated temple that then collapsed over them, only to be spurned as though he offered poisons and not cures.

Peucesta discussed a famous Okheman epic with some of their musicians; a fruitful conversation marred by other Okheman's overhearing and scorning him for believing a Kremnoan could hope to understand the higher literature of the holy city.

Hephaestion's polite conversation openers were frequently repudiated with insults aimed at his more delicate face and physique for battle. Yet the same warriors were too cowardly to accept his suggestion of a friendly spar.

By the time they reached Okhema's gates, it was abundantly clear how great the challenge of assimilating into the holy city would be when neither people were willing to meet halfway. While some Okhemans and Kremnoans had overcome their initial hesitance to engage in productive conversation or exchanges, the vast majority remained steadfast in their segregation. Old blood stained; it would take effort to scrub it clean.

Still, his friends didn't question his decision when they gathered around the fire pits with honey brew. Like a lost spar, they took the defeat in stride and concocted a new angle of attack with a thrill for the challenge.

Provisions had been made by Aglaea for the detachment to reside in the city barracks. While space, resources and the citizens' morale had been prepared for the sudden influx of their worst enemy—a group of barbarians who drank the blood of their victims—the barracks were stationed on the outskirts of the city. Out of sight unless someone came searching for them.

Unease permeated the cramped quarters, still within Okhema's high walls where it was difficult to flee and easy to be cornered. But it was the first time they had a real roof over their heads and walls at their sides to keep the wind out since they departed from Castrum Kremnos.

Healers from the famed Twilight Courtyard arrived to treat the injured and check for any infections or diseases that could trigger an epidemic in the city. Mydei silenced the Kremnoan cries of outrage at the implication they would ever allow themselves to wallow in *filth.*

Even once their initial indignation quieted, it was far from calmed. They hovered over the healers in crowds practically brimming with bloodlust ready to overspill if a single mistake was made. Never mind that the piercing stares caused the healers' hands to tremble.

The Chrysos Heir with pink curls and a strange floating creature smiled at Mydei appreciatively when he ordered the Kremnoans give them space to work. Only Perdikkas and his physicians were permitted to observe, help if the healers needed the extra hands and, more importantly, act as a familiar presence to reassure the patients. Perdikkas was fascinated with the glow at Lady Hyacinthia's hands and she was more than happy to explain as she made swift work of any lingering aches and pains from their long journey.

Despite the strange bugs Lady Aglaea insisted were perfect for communication, Leonnius ran laps from the barracks to Marmoreal Palace as Mydei's messenger with a golden tassel from Aglaea in case anyone dared be too persistent with their questioning of the Kremnoan moving through the emptier streets. While he passed word to Mydei, it also gave him the unique authority to tell stories to the children; things about the city to ease the nerves they grit their teeth and buried but never went away.

While Mydei walked back and forth around the barracks, putting out fires of discontent and anxiety everywhere he went, Ptolemy recited the basics of Okheman courtesy and had him repeat the most crucial points back. Over the chatter, Peucesta plucked at his lyre with the beginnings of a new song intertwined with the familiar rise and falls of the old ones, evoking memories of honey brew, the campfire and a distant home nestled inside their new one.

A short distance from the barracks, Hephaestion conversed with the Okheman warriors that lingered nearby. Some were, tentative, acquaintances he had made over the past few days who came with a genuine interest in how the detachment was settling. Others were not officially stationed nearby but lacked the confidence to leave the Kremnoans unchecked.

Beside Mydei at every step was Phainon. Never too close but never far enough Mydei couldn't find him with a quick glance around the room.

Even now, Phainon awaited him at the entrance to the barrack. His smile grew as Mydei approached and he offered a hand. "Ready to go?"

So that Mydei could uphold his image of independence from Aglaea, she retreated to manage her own affairs upon their arrival through the city walls. She only requested his and Phainon's presence at Marmoreal Palace once the situation and sufficiently stabilised. It was a chance to meet the other Chrysos Heirs, discuss the Flame Chase Journey and the needs of the Kremnoan detachment.

But Leonnius was a traitor who failed to informed Mydei that Marmoreal Palace was a bathhouse.

Mydei had no qualms with stripping off his dirtied travel garments and slipping into the thin bathing tunic. The issue was…

"Stop pouting," he told Phainon without halting from folding his clothes.

He squeezed tighter around Mydei's middle, head over Mydei's shoulder so he couldn't ignore the push of his lips even further as he whined, "*Mydei*,

all these people are gonna see you in this."

"It's hardly any different than my usual clothes and you have no qualms about those."

"It is," he sulked with another squeeze. "The whole detachment dresses like that."

"It's a bathhouse. Everyone will be dressed like *this*. "

"But…"

"Phainon, what would you have me do? Bathe fully clothed?"

"Is that an option?"

"Use your brain and tell me."

Everyone turned out to be an exaggeration. Tribbie had mentioned that Chrysos Heirs were famous in Okhema and attracted more public attention than they often sought, so a changing room was reserved exclusively for their use alongside a private bathing area.

The Hero's Baths were the most decadent scene Mydei had yet to witness in his life as a prince; although it was a title more in name than riches. Not only did it hang in the air over the rest of the bathhouse, it had a sweeping view of the skyline cast in eternal daylight by Kephale's protection.

Golden water flowed down from a cracked pearl overhead and into the baths. Waters that shimmered with the blessed of Phagousa.

The other Chrysos Heirs were already in the baths, drinks and food at hand. Tribbie waved from her seat on the edge, drawing the attention of the two other red haired girls she had told them about during their travels: Tinnon and Trianne. Lady Hyacinthia, accompanied by the strange creature she had introduced as Ica, also raised her hand in greeting with a soft smile, as steadfast as the one worn by the man at Mydei's side.

The man clinging very adamantly to Mydei's side, arm slung around Mydei's waist so Mydei's unclothed side was pressed against the bathing garments over Phainon's torso, so thin it was practically bare skin to skin.

They had yet to meet the last Chrysos Heir, seated at the edge furthest from the others where she watched them with wide eyes. Ptolemy had warned that Okhemans could be more… averse to skinship between comrades.

At that, they had both turned to look at Phainon across the barracks, a child on his lap and another hanging off his arm as they listened to Peucesta's song. With those senses of his attuned to Mydei's every move, Phainon's head immediately perked up and swivelled.

He cocked his head in silent question, whether Mydei needed him at that moment, and Mydei waved his concerns away. Phainon nodded and blew Mydei a kiss. Peucesta's next word warbled with suppressed laughter. Ptolemy and Mydei's shared look right betrayed the truth: it was hopeless.

Departed their fearsome reputations, none of the Chrysos Heirs hesitated in their presence. The two of them sat so close, thighs and shoulders together, despite the luxurious size of the baths probably helped soften the image of two incarnations of Nikador who ravaged the battlefield.

The others laughed, suggested ideas, and shared their troubles freely. Even when Mydei's words sounded perfunctory as usual, none of them were offended by it.

The water also did wonders to relax the atmosphere. Waters blessed by Phagousa were a necessary precaution to hoard away in case of encounters with the black tide, but he never encountered it in this quality nor quantity. All the fatigue seeped out of his heated blood into the waters and steam.

"How are the detachment's arrangements?" Aglaea asked.

"They remain anxious," he admitted with slight shrug. No one expected them to feel at ease immediately. "The barracks are too small for everyone to stay comfortably."

Aglaea plucked a grape from a floating platter and toying with it between her fingers. “I’ve already gathered the paperwork for the construction of more barracks to accommodate your numbers. Your soldiers will also receive a stipend for their services.”

Efficient. The mind to anticipate issues and resolve them swiftly was a trait he valued within the detachment, and he made an effort to promote those who demonstrated the ability to ease his burdens rather than add to them.

Even without the Coreflame of Romance at her fingertips, it was obvious how Aglaea maintained power for centuries despite the tumultuous opinions of the Flame Chase over the years. She was rather terrifying, and that only heightened Mydei’s opinion of her.

“We can move some of the injured to the Courtyard for now,” Hyacinthia suggested. “It won’t be much. But it would alleviate some numbers.”

Mydei shook his head. “Being separated would only make everyone more anxious. Thank you for taking the effort to come to the barracks, Lady Hyacinthia. Perdikkas had much to say about your capable hands.”

If it weren’t for the heat of the bath already flushing her cheeks, he was certain she would have blushed to accompany her bashful smile. “Just Hyacine is fine. And I’m happy to be of service to all who need it.”

“In that case,” Mydei began, more tentative than he would have liked, and Phainon squeezed his hand under the water, “one of my men has been plagued by illness since young. I fear the change in conditions may result in a severe relapse in the coming months.”

The shy preening at the compliments disappeared as quickly as it came, replaced by a look he recognised from Perdikkas’ face whenever Mydei entered the physician’s tent dripping gold behind him. Solemn when confronted with an issue that could take lives and they held the power to solve, but never cold and distant.

Only earnest as she nodded. “A stress induced flareup of a chronic illness. Would you mind me asking for their name?”

If he sighed with relief, it was silenced by the lapping water. “Hephaestion.”

“Hephaestion,” she repeated slowly, committing it to memory. “I didn’t treat anyone by that name today. I can come to the barracks again tomorrow for a check-up. If I want his medical history, Perdikkas would be the one to ask, right?”

Mydei smiled. From their limited interactions, he quite liked Hyacine; her positive attitude doing nothing to detract from her wisdom and dedication. “That’s correct. If tomorrow doesn’t fit your schedule then there’s no need to rush to trouble yourself.”

Hyacine laughed. “I wouldn’t call it trouble when there’s a patient in need.“

“I will be happy to lend my aid wherever possible,” Castorice offered but she frowned. “Although, I lack the same abilities as Lady Hyacine, Lady Tribbie, Lady Trianne, Lady Trinnon, or Lady Aglaea.”

One of the first things they had discussed was a brief warning about Castorice’s *unique constitution* due to her connection with Death. It explained the physical distance between her and the others, and the self-doubt evident in her words.

“Thank you, Lady Castorice. Everyone has unique skills and abilities; they only require the correct circumstances to apply them. Mydei turned back to Aglaea and the original conversation. “It would also be beneficial to organise joint training exercises once tensions cool. The more controlled exposure the legions and guards have to one another the better.”

Aglaea considered it for a moment before suggesting, “Perhaps a week’s time. If the situation remains unstable then we can reconsider the exact date.”

Across several quints that bled into hours, they discussed the future. One where the Kremnoans assimilated into Okhema. Where they pursued the Coreflame of Strife that was Mydei’s by birthright and tradition before he left it behind in his homeland.

While Phainon refrained from speaking much on matters of the detachment, leaving them to Mydei unless prompted with a nudge, there were a number of discussions that revolved around him. An education in the Grove, where another Chrysos Heir resided and, Aglaea explained with scorn, was too self-absorbed to deign to greet them. The kind of education Mydei was unable to receive without accusations of falling to Okhema's persuasions, which would damage his relationship with the detachment.

There were ideas for public relations campaign with Phainon's boyish charms and heritage rooted in Aedes Elysiae, whose refugees had successfully assimilated into the city, at the fore. A good middle ground to show Okhemans that not all Kremnoans were lower than even the most savage of animals.

The conversation ended as Aglaea, rather ominously, revealing she had their measurements and would prepare garments befitting her two new Chrysos Heirs. He wouldn't deny the Goldweaver, as renowned for the quality of her garments as her ruthlessness.

For now, the changing room had clean chitons for them to redress in. They were white with a few accessories, simple yet pure gold, to hold the fabric in place but were otherwise plain and unassuming. When Mydei finished pinning his in place, Phainon was still fumbling with the drape, head and eyes down. So he couldn't anticipate Mydei's hand threading through his hair as he leaned in to press a kiss to his temple.

His fingers froze around the clasp, eyes widened and lips parted. Mydei chuckled and began to pull away but that brought Phainon back to life. He grabbed Mydei's hand in his own while the other cupped the back of Mydei's neck, keeping them in place.

"What was that for?" Phainon asked, entirely too fond, eyes roaming across Mydei's face like the answer would be written there. It was, because Mydei was just as disgustingly lovestruck.

So he didn't shy away even when the intensity of Phainon's gaze on Mydei, always on Mydei, made heat rise to the tips of his ears. "It was a thank you. For everything."

A tenderness that made Mydei appear as more than a fearsome warrior prince, something gentled, for the better, by Phainon at his side. A silence so Mydei could do his job as prince, as king in all but name and crown and a ring he destroyed, despite his time in the detachment and his status as Mydei's equal and parter earning him the right to speak.

For so much more than could ever be put into words but Mydei would spend a lifetime trying.

"Not that I don't appreciate it. *But*," he dragged the word out and his smile didn't reach the peak of its usual coyness. Too soft, even as he teased, "I think you missed."

"Have you ever known me to miss?"

Mydei could launch a spear across two battlefields and still perfectly impale an enemy's head.

Phainon hummed thoughtfully. "Nope." He lowered Mydei's hand from his hair, dragging down the side of his neck, over his exposed collarbone, straight to his chest. Phainon's heart beat earnestly under Mydei's palm. "You got me right here in one clean shot. I won't ever recover."

"Sap."

"Your fault," Phainon murmured, eyes flicking down to Mydei's lips and they were dilated black when they came back up. "So take responsibility."

"I already offered to be wed," Mydei reminded him.

His ears burned down to his cheeks but he leaned in and Phainon met him halfway for a short kiss turned long when Phainon stepped closer and Mydei hauled him further in. Although they shared a tent and a cot, they were too exhausted from managing the detachment's present and future while still marching by day to do more than succumb to sleep at night.

The bath had cleansed away that exhaustion, and left them alone for the first time in weeks.

As always, Mydei had to be the first to pull away while Phainon chased. Mydei stopped him with a press of their foreheads together.

“Goldweaver…” Mydei managed between pants. “The surprise…”

Phainon licked his lips, seeking the lingering taste of Mydei on them. That expression beneath his half-lidded eyes was completely at odds with the way he so pathetically begged, “One more?”

“Greedy,” Mydei chastised and gave a final kiss. “Now stop fiddling with the chiton. Let me do it.”

Long flowing fabrics didn’t suit life in a farming village or on the move, especially not with such expensive decorations and soft material. It was easier for Mydei to control the drape and pin it in place for Phainon, smoothing it out to fall beautifully over his broad shoulders, muscled chest, trim waist and down his legs.

“How do I look?” Phainon asked with wide, overly innocent eyes.

Mydei knew what he was really asking and leaned in for another kiss, breaking away quickly before Phainon could turn it from something chaste into something more. He kept their hands intertwined.

“Adequate. Let’s go.”

“Wait a moment. My pocket.”

Phainon retrieved his pouch from his travel garments and began to tie it around his waist like always, before he paused. Then he peered up demurely and Mydei sighed, holding out a palm for Phainon to drop the pouch so Mydei could tie it for him.

A Garmentmaker waited for them outside and led them through the halls of Marmoreal Palace. People didn’t spare the effort to be discrete when they stared, mind spinning rumours about the solitary lion and blazing sun that had come to reside in their holy city.

But Mydei was never one to waver under the gaze of others and neither was Phainon. In fact, he donned his second most charming smiled—the most charming one was reserved for Mydei alone—and waved at them like this were a casual stroll through the marketplace of some unimportant town that knew neither of their names.

They arrived at a closed door, a private room, and the Garmentmaker left as soon as it was clear it had delivered them successfully to the location. They glanced at each other in silent question and both shrugged.

Phainon reached for the door and Mydei didn't stop him, stepping aside to give him space. The door swung open and Phainon froze.

Thoughts of betrayal flashed through Mydei's mind. But that didn't make sense. Aglaea needed two more Chrysos Heirs. Even if the detachment's arrival swung public sentiment away from her, her grasp on power was far from fickle enough—

Phainon stumbled into the room and their joined hands, squeezed bloodless, bones creaking, dragged Mydei in behind him and he knew his face was just as stunned.

Age lined their skin and hair but the sight of the two who had welcomed Mydei into their home was unmistakable.

Phainon released a shaky breath, "Mum. Dad."

Audata's hands cupped over her mouth fell away as she took a step weighed by hesitance and disbelief. "Phainon… my *boy*."

In Hieronymus' arms, Snowy panted away, tongue lolling and tail wagging, and he yipped and squirmed at the sight of his long lost owner.

Phainon's hands slackened around his and then let go as he ran to the mother and father he hadn't seen in six years. They welcomed him with open arms and, together, fell to their knees.

“You’ve gotten so big and strong.” Hieronymus chuckled wetly. “I can hardly believe it.”

Phainon lived life loudly. His joy, his love, and even his tears. He wailed and sobbed like, in the arms of his parents, he had returned to the child Mydei had once stumbled across in the wheat fields.

Mydei leaned against the wall. Perhaps he should have left them to their private moment but any movement would draw extra attention to him when the family huddled on the floor were so consumed by sheer happiness to the point of tears. Reunited with his parents, Phainon didn’t need Mydei for support the same way Mydei needed him.

Mydei wanted to be there for him anyway.

Once Phainon’s cries tapered off into sniffles, he turned back. He really was an ugly crier—swollen eyes, snot, flushed face—but Mydei couldn’t help but smile.

“Mydei…” Phainon whined, more pathetic than his usual theatrics but asking for the same thing.

That brought everyone’s attention to him and his first instinct was to push down his smile, square his shoulders, and bear the weight of the gazes that fell to him with expectations. But the moment passed and Mydei relaxed again when those eyes on him didn’t feel uncomfortable.

Phainon smiled through the tears. “Come here.”

“Mydei…” Audata had the same smile as her son. Had given it to him during long days in a home they thought would last forever but would have to start anew here. “To think you’re the same Mydei. You look even bigger than Phainon.”

Phainon sniffed, teary yet somehow so indignant. “Actually, I’m still taller.”

Mydei pushed off the wall and rolled his eyes. “Not when you’re down there.”

A finger hooked into his chiton and tugged. “Then get down here.”

Mydei let Phainon pull him to the ground, his arm catching Mydei’s waist before his knees could strike the floor too hard, and their small huddle opened to let Mydei inside. It was warm. In the same way Aedes Elysiae had been warm. Small and cosy. Peaceful. He never wanted to leave.

Audata reached across, too many emotions to name in the squeeze of her hand over his leg. “You’ve been taking care of each other.”

“Of course!” Phainon tugged Mydei closer into his side, every bit of space eliminated in a well-practice instant, like a needless apology for pulling his hand away when he ran to his parents. “And for the rest of our lives too.”

A blink of confusion, then their eyes widened.

“I…” Mydei cleared his throat but didn’t dare shrink away from their questioning gazes. “I hope it’s all right that I didn’t… ask for your blessing.”

Audata sniffled. Her tears came renewed and Hieronymus hugged her against his side in the same way his son always reached for Mydei.

He placed a kiss to her cheek and rubbed her shoulder soothingly. “Our boy is getting married. Our Little Snowy.”

“Not yet,” Phainon interjected and his hands grappled uselessly at the air, not quite sure where to go. “I’m still… still your Little Snowy—“

“What are you waiting for!” Audata suddenly yelled and she swatted at his hands. Mydei’s equal, tied with him for the most fearsome warrior of the Kremnoan detachment, in all of Amphoreus, yelped. “If you find a good man who wants to marry you then you *marry him*! You think good men grow like wheat!”

“N-no but-“

“Snowy’s already so old! Don’t you want him to see you get married?”

Snowy barked, as though on command. Mydei scratched behind his ears and he rolled over. After the bath, Mydei's hands were still bare of his gauntlets and he scratched all along Snowy's belly without fear.

"Well-"

"You always used to talk about how cute Mydei was! And now—"

"Okay!" Phainon finally burst with embarrassment, flush disappearing down his neck and underneath his chiton; the red a lovely contrast against the white. He burned hotter when Mydei arched an amused brow. "We get the idea. We'll… discuss a date."

Hieronymus ruffled Phainon's hair with a chuckle. "Your mum is just happy for you, Phainon. As am I. For both of you, Mydei."

Mydei scratched at the inside of Snowy's thigh and his leg thumped. He projected his voice past the mumble it instinctively pulled into at the blatant approval, "Thank you."

"You must be awfully busy," Audata said, acknowledging without naming the duties that awaited outside this room. Phainon nodded, eyes still low to the ground. "But come for dinner whenever you're free and we'll be happy to see you. You must have a lot to say about your time away from home."

Phainon perked up and his grin returned brighter than ever. "We will."

"Mydei, feel free to bring people with you," Audata offered.

In truth, proper courtship was something of a gap in Mydei's education. It had been wholly unnecessary compared to the much more crucial skills and knowledge he had needed to learn as a child. By the time he came of age where the proper process of courtship would be applicable, none of the detachment felt the need to teach him. They were much too preoccupied betting on his relationship with Phainon and, supposedly, any attempts to educate him was ruled out as cheating.

The only thing he had known was the story of his parents, who underwent ten duels and tied as equals in every instance before deciding to wed.

Still, Mydei was fairly certain that the two families meeting was standard.

It was instinct to clack his claws together, fingers forming a loose fist. But he was stripped of his gauntlets. Instead, he gripped Phainon's hand when he asked, "Would five be too many? Perhaps six?"

"You spent six years feeding Phainon's appetite, six people for one night doesn't compare," Hieronymus jested and Phainon made no attempt to defend himself. But Hieronymus' smile softened after his playful chuckle. "You and any of your friends and family are always welcome."

With their address scrawled on a strip of parchment and carefully tucked away in Phainon's pouch, they parted ways outside Marmoreal Palace. By the time they returned to the barracks, the Kremnoan detachment had settled down to rest after their long journey. The few Kremnoan guards stationed at the entrance saluted as the two of them passed by.

The sun never set in Okhema. It was the blessing of Kephale stood tall over the holy city with the Dawn Device over their shoulders.

His body knew it was time to slumber but the sky was no different between when they first arrived in the city and now. As though no time at all had passed. No matter how different Mydei felt with every step forward lighter than before.

The only thing that betrayed the hour was the empty training grounds. A sky full of daylight and yet it felt as though the only people awake were the two of them.

"Your parents are doing well."

"Yeah."

Mydei arched a brow at the lacklustre response. The entire walk back, Phainon had been oddly distracted as he stared ahead in a daze; only

Mydei's arm around his waist prevented him from walking into walls.

He first assumed the emotional exhaustion had intensified the physical kind, accumulated after so long and too deep in his body for even Phagousa's blessing to wash away. But Phainon had been the one to forgo sleep at the barracks for the training grounds.

"Phainon."

"Yeah?" Phainon still stared ahead when they had long since stopped walking.

There was nothing but a blank wall and a rack of training weapons. What was so interesting there, or in the confines of Phainon's mind, that could whisk Phainon's attention elsewhere?

Mydei pinched Phainon's chin, turning his head so there was nowhere else for him to look. His eyes, his ears, his mind on Mydei alone. "A warrior who allows themselves to be pressured into the rhythm of others will inevitably face defeat."

Don't rush. Everyone from Krateros to their five companions to the old detachment and now Phainon's parents wanted them to be wed as soon as possible. All for their own reasons but the outcome was the same.

If the day they were married wasn't the happiest day of both their lives then it was pointless.

Phainon sucked in a deep breath. "It's not that. It's-it's something else. Just don't be upset with me."

He pulled his chin from Mydei's fingertips and Mydei's brows creased, deepening still when Phainon avoided his questioning gaze. He waited as Phainon rifled through the pouch he insisted he bring with him. It was the kind of pocket everyone possessed and kept close: coins, a dose of emergency anaesthetic, whatever other valuables they could need at a moment's notice.

“Found it,” he muttered to himself.

When he straightened, he breathed through the lingering nerves and steadied himself with newfound resolve. There was something held tight in his fist. Too tight for Mydei to get a glimpse.

“Close your eyes.”

Mydei closed them, waiting in darkness but every sense as attuned to Phainon as Phainon’s were to him. The rustle of fabric as Phainon moved, the skim of something across Mydei’s cheek rose up towards his forehead, and then a cool weight dropped around his neck.

“Open them.”

Phainon’s smile was even, pretty and tame, which meant the nerves had returned and he simply chewed them up and swallowed them down. “I found it a while ago I just… I wasn’t certain how to go about returning it to you.”

Finally, Mydei looked down. Hung from his neck was a thin chain, something almost delicate if he not for the markings of Kremnoan forgery, ensuring it was as resilient as his regular jewellery. At the end of the chain was more gold. A ring.

When Mydei cupped it in his palm, stamped on the surface was the emblem of Strife. But it was more than that.

“I really did fish it up one day. As a child. And then the priests and Cyrene told me about Castrum Kremnos. It felt… like a sign? Like something important. So I kept it close all these years. At first as a reminder of what I wanted to do with my life and I thought I might be able to reunite it with its owner when I eventually got to the city. Then… then you arrived and I joined the detachment and I kept it because… I’m not certain honestly. Because it felt right and—“

“Breathe,” Mydei told him even when his own breath was caught in his lungs.

Phainon paused to take a deep breath, searching Mydei's expression the entire time. When Mydei gestured with a lazy hand, he continued, "I thought it was just interesting jewellery people liked to wear. I didn't realise it was more than that until…"

"Until you saw me take a similar one from my dead father's finger," Mydei finished as Phainon's strange reaction that day, an observation buried under all the emotional highs and lows, finally made sense.

He nodded meekly, fingers twined in front of him and the same colour to his cheeks as his bitten lip. "Then a lot was happening and I didn't know when or how to return it to you after all these years. So I promised myself it would be safely in your hands once we were inside Okhema."

Then he didn't say any more. He simply peered up at Mydei through his lashes. A scolded puppy when Mydei hadn't even said anything yet because…

What was there to say? What words could possibly be enough?

Words should never be used where actions sufficed.

Cold metal pressed against Mydei's lips as he kissed his mother's ring returned to him from the Sea of Souls by Phainon. Phainon who had been connected to him in so many ways before they ever met.

Then he grabbed Phainon by his chiton and kissed him too.

There was so much he wanted to tell Phainon through the press of their lips, their shared breath, his hands clenched until they trembled. When Phainon's mouth and hands moved against him just as desperately, he knew Phainon understood and hungered to say the same things back.

But there were things that had to be said in words, too. Ones hidden so deep even Mydei hadn't unearthed them until that moment. Once, he would have left them half-uncovered and half-buried, only there for him to acknowledge in passing but never aloud.

Now, they spilled freely, easily, like rain softened the earth and made life bloom. Not because he owed anything to Phainon but simply because Mydei wanted him to know.

When he pulled away it was to murmur against his reddened lips, “Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, I lied.”

Phainon’s eyes widened with a thousand questions and the faith that Mydei would answer. Too enraptured to look away.

“Half my honour, half my life, half my soul. It’s more than half.” Mydei laughed at his own past foolishness. To think it would only ever be half. “All of it—all of *me* is in your hands. Always.”

The past, the present, the future. Beyond something Mydei could ever hope to comprehend but knowing all he needed to ensure Phainon grant his selfish wish.

From the Sea of Souls, to the wheat fields, to the wilds of Amphoreus, to the Dawn of tomorrow. The memories had been engraved into Mydei’s soul and he could only hope to press every word, every touch, every memory even deeper. So deep it could never be removed and Mydei would always remember Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.

Chapter End Notes

> And they all lived happily ever after forever. The end.
>
> Thank you everyone who read to the end my self-indulgent fic about Mydei saving his friends and falling in love and getting a chance to fully experience love and happiness.
>
> This was my first multi chapter fic and it go wildly out of hand but I enjoyed every moment of carving this little world out. I’m exceedingly happy with how it turned out.
>
> ▶ If you’re curious about how out of hand it got this is the comparison with the first draft because I still look at this and laugh and know I

always will

I’m honestly sad it’s over. But alas all things must come to an end and this fic was never about the flame chase etc. I do have a couple ideas for extra stories in the same setting but I’m not gonna promise anything because I am both sad but also a bit burnt out from this fic.

Anyway, I was overwhelmed by the support for this fic. Especially from all my lovely regular commenters (you know who you guys are). It made such a difference to my motivation to get this fic out as quickly as possible.

So everyone, thank you so much! I hope you all enjoyed reading as much as I enjoyed writing it!!

Chapter 15: Extra Story One - Family Dinner

Chapter Summary

> Mydei and Phainon's two families come together for the very first time over dinner.

Chapter Notes

> Jumpscare POV switch to Phainon!
>
> The very first time I've written Phainon's POV without making him suffer immensely. Hurray!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was strange to once again have a place to call home. As a child, Phainon never thought he would be without one. Life was contained to Aedes Elysiae: the golden wheat fields he would sow and harvest alongside his parents, the sea he would fish from with the other villagers and his friends, the small wooden house warmed by one hearth the four of them would gather around forever.

Even once Phainon grew a little older and the world expanded beyond the reaches of the wheat fields through Cyrene's stories and the weathered treasures washed upon the shore, he always believed Aedes Elysiae would be home.

He could outgrow his childhood house, get married, have children of his own. He could venture into the world of heroes immortalised in song, the starry sky and people's hearts. He could leave his small village for Castrum Kremnos and train to be the warrior that could protect those he cared for and fulfil their wishes.

But his heart would always belong in Aedes Elysiae. The place he could always return to.

Until it was consumed by the black tide and black-robed swordsman. Those peaceful days were destroyed, twisted into monstrous affronts to nature and burned to bloodstained ashes.

Yet his unmoored heart was given new direction. Perhaps, if Phainon had followed what remained of his friends and family six years ago, Okhema would have become as close to a new home as he would have found in his lifetime.

Instead a boy arrived in the wheat fields and heralded the arrival of the wider world. Six years of wandering, never settled, never stagnant, always on the move towards something just beyond the horizon, and Phainon found home. One with shields for walls, impenetrable when stood together. Fire pits for hearths, dug in the evening and covered in the early mornings. Foundations embedded in the people, moving and shaking but never crumbling.

At one point, Phainon may have considered that first meeting fate but now he knew better. Mydei had entrusted the truth to him. The truth of this future he had guided them towards: small back grown broad to shoulder his burdens, wreathed in the dawn only he could see until the moment it rose to envelop them all.

So Phainon had long outgrown the need to have a house to feel at home. If Mydei decided the weight of kingship in all but name was too great for him, then Phainon would be the one to pack their belongings and carry them through Okhema’s gates as they returned to a life of self-imposed exile together.

But he wouldn’t deny there was a comfort to that old idea of home. A nostalgia when he opened the front door, footsteps ringing with a wind chime echoing the sound of his childhood alongside the words from his lips:

Mum, dad, I’m home.

Their house in Okhema was larger than his childhood home in Aedes Elysiae. It had a small but proper courtyard to spend time in the open-air

with privacy. A bathroom connected to the city's aqueducts. An andron with more than one kline so his parents could entertain guests, and a large kitchen to match their hospitality.

As a student enrolled in the Grove of Epiphany, his lodgings and meals were provided. It was the house he spent the most time residing in due to the demands of his studies, yet it was a mere empty shell he was forced to occupy. It was always the streets of Okhema he ran back to at the slightest free time in his schedule.

Here, the aroma of his mum's cooking had been changed by time and the ingredients available. But it still waved away the fog of his memories, returning him to those simple days, enveloping him in the warmth of a life that didn't truly know peace because it didn't yet know strife.

Except now he entered the kitchen without any chastisement from his mum to remember to at least wash his hands before attempting to thieve food ahead of mealtime. It was routine when he cleansed his hands, glanced at the ingredients waiting to be prepared, and took up a suitable knife.

Today was an important day. A wariness flitted across his mum's face but she didn't object when Phainon began to carve into the raw catfish. This would be the first time they cooked together in the two months since Phainon first arrived in Okhema alongside the Kremnoan detachment. All she knew was the child who refused to touch raw meat and crafted barely edible salads.

Phainon laughed away her anxieties. "You worry too much. I may not have had easy access to a kitchen per se but you learn to make do with what you have."

A crease of skepticism at the corner of her eyes but it eased as he nimbly sliced through the fins and cut cleanly around the head in preparation to remove it later. For now, he kept it for a better grip as he worked to remove the skin. Familiarity in every pass of the blade, feeling the memory of scorching hot palms cupping the back of his hands. A chest pressed against his back rumbling with the evidence of the voice low in his ear.

His cheeks warmed with blood and the ache of his sudden grin. He cleared his throat and blinked twice, shaking off the ghost of sensation before he lost a finger to distraction and his mum never trusted him with a knife again. “I also happened to have a good teacher.”

“Ah.” He didn’t look up, sliding the knife just under the skin to take as little flesh as possible with it, but she did nothing to mask the smile in the high lilt of her voice. “Would that be one of the friends we’re meeting today, or your betrothed?”

The knife slipped. No longer a clean strip of tough skin as he sheared a deep chunk of meat with it and he could hear Mydei’s disapproval at the lifted scraps. He squeaked wordlessly as any composure he previously regained vanished, a rock throwing ripples across still waters.

She tittered behind her fingertips. “Is there a need to be embarrassed? Is that not what you are? Betro-“

“Stop,” he wailed and withdrew the knife before he could butcher the fish entirely. Mydei would know it was him with one experienced eye.

If he had been chopping anything other than raw fish he would have dropped his head into his hands. All he could do was tuck his chin against his collarbone as he slumped to rest on his hands splayed across the countertop.

Betrothal. The intent to be wed, one day. An inevitability.

The idea that Mydei wanted that future—something utterly definitive, fixed in ink and blood, when everything between them had been nurtured in their transient lifestyle gallivanting the wilds of Amphoreus—with *Phainon* was almost unbelievable. It was something Phainon had never even contemplated when every day, every moment, was spent basking in Mydei’s presence coloured like the warmest dawn leading him into pleasant dreams.

This dream Mydei had fought so hard to ensure was their future. Alone, even when Phainon thought he was at Mydei’s side, his back, with every step.

A cool touch grazed his cheek. Although he was accustomed to a warm palm others and the cold itself flinched from, he leaned into the gentle hold on instinct, tilting his head to meet his mum's eye.

She brushed her thumb along his cheekbone. "Oh dear, I recognise that look on my Little Snowy. You're all grown up but you still make the same face when you get lost in your thoughts."

He huffed a weak laugh and nuzzled into the soothing touch. "Am I that obvious?"

"You've always opened your heart to the world. It's not a bad thing."

Content, Phainon hummed. Every reminder that six years away from his parents hadn't changed him beyond recognition was a relief. "Mydei says the same thing."

Not exactly. He was every bit the stray cat Phainon first thought him as upon their initial meeting. Every affectionate lick or cuddle was accompanied by the flash of claws and fangs.

Earnest to a foolish fault, Mydei had called him. Too soft and sweet to be a genuine insult, not when Mydei finished, *so someone will have to stay by your side to stymie that bleeding heart of yours.*

She took her hand back, Phainon letting it go with only the slightest noise of protest, and shook her head as she grabbed a new knife to finely slice the cabbage. "That's because Mydei has a sharp eye and sharper mind. I couldn't have picked a better husband for you."

Phainon poked the hilt of his knife, more fearful of any potential missteps with the short blade than he felt when loosed upon the battlefield with a greatsword in hand. "Back to that again?"

"Happiness begins in the home."

He successfully withheld a flinch in all but the upward jolt of his head, eyes wide. "I *am* happy. Elated. The sight of Mydei—no, just the thought of him

—makes my heart sing praises to Mnestia for blessing humanity with concepts of love and beauty.”

Did he give off the impression otherwise? If there was even the slightest hint that he was displeased with the current state of his life then Mydei would know. He would have picked it up with the speedy precision of hunting hounds scenting blood. These were the types of things he knew about Phainon before he even realised it himself.

“The only thing I have to despair over is that our responsibilities keep us more separate than we’ve been since we first became companions.”

Which was no secret. Phainon whined about their long periods of separation, head propped on Mydei’s chest and Mydei’s bare hands running through his hair, whenever their busy schedules permitted them a moment of true privacy. A tricky task considering Phainon’s commitment to lectures and classes at the Grove while Mydei was confined to Okhema, particularly the barracks along the outskirts housing the rest of the detachment.

He dragged his finger back and forth along the countertop and quietly admitted, “I simply hadn’t prepared for us to… be betrothed so soon.”

Six years. Not of skirting around the love burning steady between them like a well-tended hearth and not the flames of Strife that surrounded them. They simply enjoyed each other’s presence, revelling in the ways in which they already came together with their soft curves and harsh edges while the rest grew around each other with age and shared experience.

Marriage wasn’t something he ever seriously considered. It had only crossed his mind as a child who hadn’t yet considered paths other than the one treaded by those around him: marriage, children, a long and peaceful and happy life.

He had never truly yearned for anything more than they already were for those six years before Mydei poured more love than Phainon ever thought he deserved past lips and into his heart. As much as Phainon already harboured there for Mydei.

And he still hadn’t thought of marriage. Mydei was the crown prince with the future of his people on his shoulders. Phainon was a village boy who had been lucky enough to have the opportunity to stand at his side, and fought with every breath to prove that offer wasn’t a mistake.

As soon as Mydei confirmed that his words at the end their duel were truly *a proposal to be wed,* it was all Phainon could think about. He wanted that. He wanted that more than anything. Even if it didn’t come with a house, children, nor a long and peaceful life—it would be a happy one.

He just hadn’t been prepared for how much he wanted it.

He hung his head with a sigh, “Every time I think of us together in that sense, permanent and irrefutable, it reminds me of all the distance forced between us now.”

His eyes squeezed tight. Phainon missed him. He missed Mydei so fiercely his heart ached and every pulse of it carried that yearning down to the tips of his fingers. The simple acts of living—sleeping, breathing, cooking—were plagued by Mydei.

He constantly searched for gold and red in the corner of his eye only to be disappointed when it was someone else, sometimes just a figment of his imagination. They were drawn to each other like rivers to the sea and Phainon had always been more than willing to drown. After so long, every separation felt like a part of himself was missing.

A muffled sound opened his eyes again. A giggle, slipping through his mum’s lip pinned between her teeth even as she continued slicing the cabbage.

Phainon frowned. “This isn’t really a laughing matter.”

She patted his cheek and went back to chopping. “I can see that you two will be very happy together.”

He picked up the knife to resume skinning the catfish. The skin was too tough to eat and Mydei wrinkled his nose if any of the muddy flavour

remained. Phainon was certain Mydei wasn't aware that his nose wrinkled whenever he smelled or tasted something unpleasant. It always filled Phainon with the urge to kiss the tip of his nose.

He smiled to himself as he imagined that peck and the way Mydei's nose would only crease more but he would never pull away. "There is no one else."

His feet had carried him to every corner of Amphoreus but even if he had stayed forever in Aedes Elysiae, taken Mydei home like a stray from the wheat fields, kept as a house cat without the need to grow into a lion, the truth would be unchanged: there was no one else anywhere in Amphoreus. It could *only* be Mydei.

The gentle smile Phainon had first learned from his mum, one she wore for him and his dad and Snowy, was reflected back at him now. "Then let me thank the man who makes my son happier than I've ever seen him. And even taught him how to feed himself for a change."

Not just himself, but everyone he cared about. After all, this was the day his parents would be officially introduced to those Mydei considered family.

With all the skills and care handed to him over the years, he helped prepare every dish alongside his mum, his dad who returned to the marketplace, and Snowy who snuck scraps, as the day passed through the ends of Entry Hour to the beginning of Descent Hour.

His parents had made it clear that their home was Phainon and Mydei's home, so there was no need for either of them to knock before they entered. Mydei was always sure to knock anyway. While his parents finished setting up the andron, Snowy followed on Phainon's heels to welcome their guests.

At the front was Mydei. Dressed in a white chiton loose around his chest and thighs but cinched tight around his waist with the belt taken from his usual outfit. The black and gold emphasised the trim cut of his waist while a swathe of red embroidered in gold draped over his shoulder.

It was a gift from Agalea after too many complaints through the golden threads of Phainon occupying his hands throughout his sparse time in Okhema by clinging to Mydei's side and laying them over his half-exposed chest. It was an attempt to hide Mydei from the gawking civilians, lacking the detachment's cultural laxity towards clothing and desensitisation to bare skin.

The material was expensive. Tailored to fall loose enough to expose that red tattoo of Strife where Gorgo's ring rested on its chain, teasing the top of his chest with an invitation for Phainon to slip his hand right under, but tight enough to prevent any flowing fabric from hindering his movements. Yet Phainon could have sworn he saw the vibrant red of his markings—heated blood. The colour of passions: both war and love—showing through the white. Another tease.

The cross of Mydei's arms, fabric pulled tauter across the expanse of his chest, didn't help. He cleared his throat and Phainon swallowed, eyes drifting up past ring, then the gold and blue of his necklace, to meet that amused gaze beneath an arched brow. His hair was brushed and his usual braid interlaced with golden chains and blue jewels.

"Hi," Phainon croaked.

Mydei's lip curled into a smirk as he assessed Phainon from his usual unkempt hair to his simple, short tunic. "Hi."

Then he looped a hand around the back of Phainon's neck and tugged him into a kiss. At the first press of their lips—soft, tacky with something vaguely sweet—Phainon forgot where he was and why.

He slid his arm around Mydei's waist, not to pull him close but just to hold him, and returned all the affection Mydei bestowed him so freely. The most precious gift. Invaluable, irreplaceable. Yet Phainon always found himself so hungry for more. And he knew Mydei would indulged him because, in this, they were still equals. Equally greedy.

It made the world beyond the soft fabric and hard muscle beneath his hands, the fragrance of pomegranate hazing his mind, and hot breath against his

lips—everything simply disappeared.

And come back with the sharp clear of someone’s throat.

Mydei pulled away just enough to tip his head back over his own shoulder, still clutching to Phainon’s neck with one hand while the other wound under Phainon’s arm. Phainon peered over his other shoulder.

Their five friends stared back at them. Well, Ptolemy had turned away with a bashful smile tilting the one edge of his lip Phainon was privy to. Perdikkas had a hand sealed over Leonnius’ mouth but Phainon could imagine the incoming whistle or crass comment based on the crease of his eyes alone. There was a glaze to Peucesta’s eyes, a look that only arose when his thoughts drifted to poetry and lyricism.

The slight curl to Hephaestion’s lips was amused even as he raised the ceramic amphora in his hands. “Is now the time for you to invite the rest of us inside?”

Phainon counted heads and his brows furrowed. “No Krateros?”

Mydei released him, lips glossy with whatever Phainon had tasted on them, and patted his chest on his way past. “We settled on one mouth for them to feed for every year we fed you.”

A few chuckles arose from the others as Phainon finally shuffled out the doorway to let them inside.

Although Mydei played it off with humour, the true meaning behind the absence of Mydei’s sour-faced, strict teacher was obvious: no need to overwhelm Audata and Hieronymus to that extent. Although his parents had hidden their nerves well, Phainon’s perception was honed on the battlefield where even the slightest of movements in his enemies differentiated life from death.

His mum had been more frantic as she obsessed over the exact flavour every dish, which hadn’t paired well with his dad fumbling like he had never watched water boil over the fire before. They were so nervous it

almost infected Phainon, but the only reason his hands had to tremble was sheer eagerness to see Mydei again after ten long days without him.

While Mydei had marched ahead at the entryway, he waited patiently beside the doorway to the andron. Out of sight so Phainon could take his hand—bare. Adorned with rings both thick and thin. A decorative vambrace down each wrist—and lead the way into the room.

His mum jumped from one of the kline's arranged in a half circle, table laden with food between them, and hurried over to wrap Mydei in her arms. "Mydei, how are you?"

From the side, Phainon blinked as Mydei only rumbled a laugh and returned the embrace as though it were natural, replying with a light jest, "Lured in by the aroma of your cooking." He stepped back, Phainon taking his mum's place by slinging his arm around Mydei, and motioned behind him. "These are my companions."

Hieronymus rose to join them. "Hello, Phainon tells us you watched over him during your travels."

"I'm certain there are many stories he's yet to tell you," Hephaestion said with a bright smile and Phainon felt a shudder pass through him. He offered the amphora. "We prepared honey brew for the occasion. Thank you for welcoming us into your home despite all the troubling rumours."

Hieronymus took the amphora with a light laugh. "You must be Hephaestion. As for those baseless rumours, everyone from Aedes Elysiae who stands here now thanks to the Kremnoan detachment knows not to heed any of them."

"Cast them from your mind," Audata reassured them, "as we do. And finish introducing yourselves."

Alongside their introductions, there were other gifts they presented as gifts for his parents' hospitality. A basket of figs and plums, a jar of honey, a bolt of silk, and meat carved from spit-roasted pig prepared and cooked by Mydei's own hand.

“This is very generous of you,” Audata said with a furtive glance between the gifts in her arms and across the table. “We’re grateful but there was no need to trouble yourself.”

“Nonsense. This much is nothing,” Ptolemy insisted with a dismissive flap of his hand. “After all, Phainon would never have come into our lives if not for you.”

“Then where would our dear Mydeimos be,” Leonnius said, so exaggeratedly mournful Phainon was surprised he didn’t have tears to accompany it.

“Besides, we never gave you our proper thanks for welcoming Mydei into your home all those years ago,” Hephaestion delivered what should have been a killing blow with that suave smile and tuck of his hair behind his ear.

Audata only shook her head, exasperated as she struggled to string the words together, “When we welcomed Mydei into our home… and all of you now, we—we never intended to treat you as guests.”

The lax air around them shifted into something sharper. An old instinct that prickled at any violation of hospitality, a warrior’s hand always ready to draw their weapon at the slightest sense of danger. Experience had prepared them for the worst when the safety promised between a guest and host collapsed.

It was usually around the time soldiers surrounded them with blades poised to maim for ransom or simply kill and be rid of the Kremnoan scourge blighting Amphoreus.

Not that his parents could sense their sudden discomfort, the five of them searching for reassurance in Mydei. Who appeared unthreatened but equally confused, glancing from Audata to Phainon. He subtly shook his head, just as clueless.

But Peucesta’s voice rose above the unease, “There’s no need to mark debts amongst family.”

Everyone held their breath for a different reason as Peucesta's word fell, weighty, upon them.

A smile brightened Audata's face. "Yes! Exactly! Thank you, Peucesta. Phainon was right when he told us you have a way with words."

Peucesta returned her smile with a small one of his own. "I see where Phainon learned his own earnest words from."

"And his lovely smile," Hieronymus added with an enamoured grin of his own towards his wife.

Audata swatted at him. "And you gave him your shamelessness."

"Lucky him," Leonnius chirped, once again relaxed as he teased Phainon with a particularly pointed grin. "He may not have caught Mydei's eyes without it. Did he ever regale you with the tale of how we first met?"

Perdikkas snickered and Phainon flushed as both his parents looked at him, curious for the bait Leonnius dangled before them. Phainon's wide eyes silently pleaded with Mydei but he snorted, squeezed Phainon's wrist draped over his shoulder and remained otherwise silent.

"Not that one, no." Hieronymus motioned to the klines. "How about we discuss it over our meal? The food's getting cold."

"Phainon, get changed into something more pleasant," his mum ordered with a dismissive wave of her hand out the room.

He frowned down at his clothes. It was a tunic: simple but hardly something to till the fields in. There was nothing wrong with his clothes. If anything, a simple glance around the tool confirmed Phainon fit right in. The only person who stood out was Mydei. Not that he would complain about getting to see Mydei overdressed.

Mydei huffed a laugh. "I'll lend a hand before you offend our eyes."

Across the room getting comfortable on a kline, Leonnius' mouth opened but Phainon interrupted him with an accusatory jab of his finger, "Not in

front of my parents!”

Leonnius’ mouth slowly closed. Then opened again with an overly pleasant smile and tone, “The first time we met, your son drew his blade on me and accused me of being deviant.”

Phainon dropped his head against Mydei’s shoulder and whined, “Mydei, I’m being persecuted by our friends.”

“As the only other witness to this event, I can attest that this is exactly what you did.” Mydei mercilessly left him for dead even as he petted his hair.

Phainon lifted his head with a prominent pout, the kind that tempted Mydei to kiss it from his lips if only they were somewhere more private. “Well, I refuse to stand here and be subjected to it.”

His hand casually slung over Mydei’s shoulder crept across to rest over his collarbone. Phainon was almost entirely draped over him and something preened in the back of his mind at the possessive hold Mydei only leaned into. His grip tightened so he could haul Mydei backwards out the room with him and he wished they could walk through Okhema the same way.

“I told you I would come with you. Cease your tugging,” Mydei demanded but didn’t struggle as they exited into the courtyard.

Phainon hummed, feeling it pass from his chest through Mydei’s body and into Phainon’s hand on the other side. “More delicate treatment requires a fee.”

Mydei scoffed. “What an inattentive lover.”

“Bold words after you so mercilessly abandoned me to the mercy of our companions.”

“I never claimed to be any better.”

Any insult to Mydei, even in the soothing cadence of Mydei’s own voice, blazed through him like sparks in summer fields parched by drought. Almost lightheaded as he seethed on instinct, exhaling smoke and not air.

Everyone in the Grove knew better than to speak ill of Mydei or anything Kremnoan in front of him: he returned their ignorance with hours of lectures, and accompanying notes delivered to their hands the following day. Anaxa always rolled his eyes at Phainon's essays for class and scolded him for not using even a fraction of the efforts he spent on his extracurricular debates.

He bit his tongue before he could habitually jump to defend Mydei against his own words. Instead he angled his head upwards and watched Mydei's gaze, kept steadfastly ahead, flit down to his beseeching eyes. Lower, to his lips.

"Again?" Mydei asked, exasperated but only in that usual push and pull for a question he already knew the answer to.

"We were interrupted earlier."

"Yet you had more than enough," Mydei dismissed even as he leaned almost imperceptibly closer.

Phainon licked his lips. "Quite the opposite, I haven't had my fill yet."

"There's plenty of real food if you would stop with the delays." Mydei was so close, breath hot against Phainon's upper lip.

Close enough he gazed up through lowered lashes. "That won't be enough to sate me. I only want you, Mydei."

The very corner of Mydei's lip curled, not quite a smile nor a smirk. Something in between and wholly satisfied. A taunt that itched Phainon's mind and he responded by kissing it from his lips. That hand draped over his chest reached up to grip Mydei's chin, angling Mydei's neck into a more comfortable position where Phainon rose from his slouch to meet him.

Just a taste. A quick flick of his tongue along Mydei's bottom lip.

Phainon pulled away before Mydei could shove him off and scold him for something too indecent in his parents' home. He slid his arm down to

Mydei’s waist and sidled up next to him so they could walk to his room.

The taste lingered in his mouth and he licked the roof of his mouth. “What’s on your lips?”

“Nothing now that you licked it all off like a slobbering dog.”

Phainon smiled. “Then I’ll put more on for you, so what was it?”

He huffed but answered, “A concoction of beeswax, honey and olive oil.”

He squinted at Mydei’s lips. With the balm removed and Phainon’s saliva cooling, they had lost their lustre, but that wasn’t the only difference. “Did that concoction also contain a pigment?”

Mydei’s expression remained unchanged but the very tips of his ears coloured, stark against both light and dark tones of his hair. “A slight one.”

So slight Phainon had failed to notice, too enthralled by the rest of Mydei’s decadent appearance belonging to a crown prince rather than a warrior if not for those indisputable muscles. But now he could see where the colour had rubbed off with the balm, except for the smear at the corner of Mydei’s lip.

When Phainon’s bedroom door closed and Mydei scanned the room from the kline on one side to the shuttered window on the other, Phainon took the opportunity to lean in and lick the remainder of the pink clean.

“You—“ Mydei spluttered and shoved his face away. “Insatiable mutt.”

Phainon licked his lips again, knowing Mydei felt the edge of Phainon’s tongue graze against his palm when he shoved his face even further away before letting go.

“Have you considered a bolder colour? Bright red would suit you.”

As vivid as his markings. So that it would stain Phainon’s own lips with the same smear of colour. Matching, as Mydei left kisses across his cheeks, down his neck and arms. Against every bit of exposed skin he could find.

The outfit Aglaea had prepared for *The Deliverer* was modest even by Okheman standards but he could always forgo the long white coat if it meant wearing the shape of Mydei's mouth like a brand instead.

Or maybe Phainon could paint his lips and add his own markings to Mydei's body.

Mydei scowled, as though he had pried Phainon's brain open and witnessed the thoughts fly through unfettered. "You speak as though you don't have a brain. And here I thought you were averse to sharing."

Phainon's brows furrowed. "What does sharing have to do with this? Isn't it quite the opposite?"

The long-suffering look on Mydei's face was so judgemental Phainon joined him to question his own intelligence in the brief moment before Mydei alleviated him of his misery.

"How can your mind be so innocent and still so…" His nose scrunched. Phainon imagined a peck that tinted it red. "Perverted. Next time you walk past one of this city's brothels, take a note of the colour they wear on their lips."

Phainon tilted his head, forehead ceasing as he tried to recall something he paid such little attention to it was barely even a passing memory. Nothing. But he had enough mental acuity to deduce from Mydei's unimpressed look.

"Ah."

"Now cease with the delays and change into something more presentable."

"What's wrong with this outfit?" Phainon despaired with another glance down and over his shoulder down his back.

"Nothing," Mydei reassured him despite reaching for the belt. "It's presentable. The colours don't hurt my eyes."

"It was one time."

One time Phainon had ignored Mydei's dissuasions and attempted to wear both yellow and purple in tandem. Ptolemy had sprayed the honey brew from his mouth while Leonnius cackled. The next morning, Peucesta had silently handed Phainon a full set of clothes with both pain and pity in his eyes.

Mydei plucked the fastening from shoulder; nothing to stop the fabric from sloughing off Phainon's body and leave him bare. "But consider that this dinner is… as much about us as the meetings between our families. Perhaps more."

All along, Phainon had considered this dinner to revolve around everyone *except* for him and Mydei. They were the only two people in the room who knew everyone by more than name and second-hand experiences retold with nostalgia.

So he had forgotten why Mydei's five companions, more family than friends, and Phainon's parents were meeting at all.

Phainon frowned at his own foolishness. "You're right."

"Fine words to remember," Mydei agreed as he opened the wooden chest beside the full-length silver mirror.

From it, he retrieved one of the white chitons embroidered with golden vines and laurel leaves, alongside a blue swathe of fabric, both gifted by Aglaea. While Phainon may have struggled when he first arrived in Okhema, he had quickly grown comfortable with the long finery far removed from life in a farming village or self-exile. There was no reason he couldn't dress himself.

But he didn't object when Mydei raised the fabric over his head, only stooping low so Mydei could ensure the layers fell correctly when he let go. Mydei fixed the chiton and blue decorative chlamys into place with a golden pin shaped like the sun, and cinched Phainon's waist with a gold belt adorned with a blue jewel.

Then he swept Phainon's discarded tunic across the thin layer of dust atop the rarely used jewellery box. He cast an assessing eye over Phainon, stood exactly where Mydei had left him, before retrieving the pieces he thought best.

An armlet that, like Mydei's own, emphasised the size of Phainon's bicep trained to lift his greatsword, but paired it with daintier bangles than Mydei's vambraces. No rings and no necklaces. But he clipped a single earring into place: gold and a red jewel.

Mydei stepped back to admire his work and Phainon twirled to help him.

Although he still complained, "This feels slightly excessive."

Mydei arched a brow and gestured a hand down his own conspicuously decorated body. "Is it now? Before you answer, recall those fine words from earlier."

"You're right."

He hummed approvingly. "I am."

"But you are aware my parents have no particular investments in seeing me the lover of a wealthy prince?"

Mydei crossed his arms but stared Phainon right in the eye, unblinking and unflinching as he answered, "Of course."

Which meant he was lying.

But Phainon's heart only swelled. How could it not when Mydei made himself look so gorgeous every person of age would beg for the chance to kiss his feet let alone be betrothed. And he did it because he still felt the need to make a good impression on his parents. Two people whose affections had begun when Mydei was just a scrawny, unkempt child Phainon had brought home by the hand.

It was so endearing, Phainon couldn't contain his grin. "Mydei, my parents were content for me to join you in *exile* if it made me happy."

Mydei blinked slowly, working hard to keep an indifferent, implacable mask in place. Flawless if not for the smallest crease of his nose.

Phainon tangled their fingers together and left a small kiss on the tip of his nose, watching it scrunch more and compel him to leave another. Then he took one of their joined hands and pressed it against his chest.

“I mean it, Mydei,” Phainon murmured. “The only thing you ever have to bring home is *you.*”

Mydei rested their foreheads together, eyes like the dawn burning through Phainon to brand him from the inside out. “I’ll take you at your word.”

A short kiss. Chaste and sweet even when there was no more honey on Mydei’s lips. Phainon’s eyes fluttered half open and he parted his lips to ask for another one.

He choked on the request when Mydei hooked a finger in his collar, turned and pulled.

“Enough stalling. You would need to hide here for *months* before the others run out of your embarrassing stories.”

Phainon chuckled bashfully as he stumbled after Mydei, leading him around by the leather collar buckled by the symbol of Strife. “You noticed?”

“You’re far from subtle.”

“Speaking of. When were you going to tell me that you visit my parents’ house when I’m not around?”

That was the only explanation for the ease with which his mum and Mydei had hugged in greeting earlier. Casual, as though they had done it any number of times.

“I came for dinner a few times in the past,” Mydei said nonchalantly.

Phainon pouted. “You see my parents more than you see me. I used to see you every hour of every day and now I’m lucky to see you for a few hours a

week. I’m deprived, Mydei!”

He rolled his eyes at this old bout of whining. But Phainon meant it as much as the first, second and thirtieth time!

“If you’re so desperate to see me daily then graduate sooner and return to Okhema.”

Apart from removing himself from the student roll, it was the easiest solution when Mydei was prevented from enrolling due to the political optics. It would only splinter his relationship with certain sections of the detachment who would see an Okheman education as indoctrination and a betrayal.

Unfortunately, as brilliant as Phainon was, it wasn’t so easy to accomplish. He sighed, “Anaxa knows my intentions and has chosen to prolong my torture.”

Mydei snorted. “Torture? Have you attempted becoming a better student?”

Just as Mydei crossed the threshold of Phainon’s bedroom and into the light of the courtyard, Phainon snagged his wrist and they paused. Gaze lowered to the floor, his grip tightened and Mydei silently waited, head tilted back over his shoulder where sunlight glinted off his earring.

Phainon worked his jaw before he admitted weakly, “I miss you.” And the rest of the words broke free. “I miss you so much, Mydei. All of the time. Just the thought of you makes my heart ache.”

It was unbearable. Phainon would rather fight a thousand of Strife’s Titankin than be separated another week. He laid in his empty dormitory and sought comfort in the memory of steady breathing on the opposite end of a military tent. Then the warmth of a body snuggled close to him, which he had only gotten to enjoy in full so briefly before they arrived in Okhema.

In the safety of the Grove of Epiphany, now another student who learned about the world rather than experience it under their nails and cutting skin,

he longed for the days where he charged into battle and the black tide. It was danger but never *dangerous* when the two of them were side-by-side because Phainon never once doubted they would overcome everything in their path.

He pushed a hand through his bangs, eyes clenched shut. “I caught your scent on the clothes I met you in two weeks ago and couldn’t bring myself to move for hours, consumed by the last time we were together. I couldn’t sleep that night without them close by, as though they were a substitute for you in my arms.”

A laugh hollowed out by self-deprecation escaped him. Mydei remained silent. No doubt lost for words after such a pathetic admittance.

“Me too.”

Phainon’s eyes opened wide. He didn’t blink, taking in the sight of Mydei glowing radiantly in the eternal daylight, illuminating the flush of his cheeks.

His eyes softened, creasing at the corners like the slightest upturn of his lips. “I miss you too, Phainon. More than words can describe.”

“Oh.” And Phainon laughed again but it was quietly bemused, ghosting down the muscles of Mydei’s back as he slumped his forehead against Mydei’s shoulder. “The two of us are… two halves of the same mess.”

“This should be the easiest of trials we’ve gone through.” Mydei sucked in a harsh inhale. “Yet it feels like the most difficult.”

Phainon laid his agreement in a kiss upon Mydei’s bare skin. “I know we aren’t parting ways forever. But it feels the same as an eternity. I’ve never felt such a temptation to be selfish as when I dream of taking you in my arms and leaving everything else behind.”

“Since when do we flee from our troubles. Unless you’ve chosen to adopt an Okheman mentality,” he teased.

“No,” Phainon replied in a harsher language that scraped the back of his throat, “Kremnoan is a better match. Sometimes, I just wish…”

A hand reached back to pet his hair and he nuzzled his forehead against Mydei’s shoulder as he replied, “I know. It will be easier once everything settles down. You adapt so expertly in battle. You can adapt to this, too.”

“Just…” Phainon dredged a weighty exhale from the depths of his chest. “Come here.”

“Everyone is waiting,” Mydei reminded him but turned without a struggle.

He stepped into Mydei’s awaiting arms, the lines of their bodies merging into one as Phainon slumped entirely against him. He buried his nose in the crook of Mydei’s neck and cradling his hands over Mydei’s single weak spot entrusted to only Phainon.

Warner than the Dawn Device, forges and the hot baths. Sweeter than any of them, scented with honey and pomegranate.

For the first time in weeks, Phainon *breathed* and Mydei did the same. As though all their anxieties could be so easily expelled within the safety of each other’s arms, where they chose to stay for a little while longer.

By the time they returned to the andron, the conversation had moved on from how hopelessly enamoured Phainon was from the moment he first met Mydei, to the point he drew a sword on Leonnius before fully comprehending the situation. Instead Ptolemy regaled them with the history of a city they had once visited, but which one amongst dozens Phainon wasn’t sure.

Everyone indulged equally in food, honey brew and nostalgia.

From the floor, Hephaestion petted Snowy, half asleep draped over his lap but head popping up when there was a particularly raucous round of laughter. “They made me a very wealthy man when the betting pool finally closed.”

Heaping his dish with a salad mix of cabbage, coriander and rue seasoned with honey vinegar and silphium, Ptolemy clicked his tongue and shook his head. “After six years, you emerged the greatest victor from that fiasco.”

Perdikkas sighed and bemoaned, “What sane man would have guessed they would officially begin courting so shortly after the fall of Castrum Kremnos? And even bet substantial coin on it?”

Hephaestion threw his head back, almost bumping Peucesta’s leg where he lounged on the kline behind him, as he laughed and lifted his chalice. “Mydeimos may act rational and stoic, but he is a man as hot-blooded as any. The rush of long-awaited victory can drive men to do many things. But I must admit, even I was stunned by the speed of your betrothal.”

The others cheered their agreement and raised their chalices.

On the kline reserved for the two of them, Mydei rolled his eyes but lifted his chalice of pomegranate juice and goat’s milk. “If you reveal all your secret insights into my nature, you may find your future winnings shrink.”

He threw his drink back and Phainon leaned forward to pour him another chalice of the his favourite beverage, mixed by Phainon’s own hand to ensure the ratio was just right. While Phainon was there, he scooped more of the olive relish onto both their dishes. When he reclined back, Mydei shuffled into his prior position leaned against Phainon’s side.

“Well someone else here has their own insights,” Ptolemy said and his foot nudged Leonnius’ leg, sharing the same kline.

Leonnius shrugged but the twist of his lips was particularly menacing paired with his scars and narrowed eyes. “Hephaestion said it best. Our dear Mydeimos rarely loses control of himself. Almost every instance is brought about by Phainon. After letting himself loose once, I just knew—ah. Peucesta, how would you say it?”

He thumbed at his lips, cleaning away the grease of the pig meat and smear of soft goat’s cheese, topping the same slice of bread freshly baked by

Audata. “When a man of great restraint indulges once, he continues to indulge as though he lacked restraint all along.”

Leonnius snapped his fingers. “That. So I assumed it would be a brief courtship. Laid to rest by their swift betrothal.”

Phainon blinked at this new information his friend had never told him. “You bet coin on that?”

Leonnius’ grin sharpened. “I *made* coin on that.”

“The more popular option would be a courtship as drawn out as… whatever it was you were doing for those six years,” Perdikkas sighed, a hand to his head like the mere thought gave him a headache. One he sought to cure with a long sip of his drink.

Mydei’s eyes narrowed and his smile was so overly pleasant it was more terrifying than any stoicism or wild smirk in battle. “Considering how much coin you claim to have won, you must have bet on Phainon’s victory.”

Sensing danger, Leonnius chuckled weakly. He looked to Ptolemy but his friend only glanced away; as the other four did, finding themselves preoccupied by their food and drink or Snowy’s fur.

Leonnius threw back the rest of his honey brew and slammed the chalice down with the fearful grit of a man facing their own death. “It could have been anyone’s victory. I decided on a coin toss. Far from Nikador’s battle-honed senses or even Cerces’ reason, perhaps it was Zagreus who favoured me in that moment.”

The long, low hum from Mydei’s chest betrayed nothing. “I hope the gamble was worth its weight in gold.”

Another weak laugh and Leonnius poured himself a full chalice that disappeared just as quick as the first.

“I heard the poems about your duel but I thought they were exaggerated,” Audata said with awe as she stared at the two of them cuddled together like

two chimeras on the kline.

Hieronymus patted his own thigh. “Our Little Snowy—“ a few knowing looks and sniggers at the nickname but Phainon ate his catfish, flavoured by the fig leaves it was wrapped in as it baked. Face serene, “—has always been stubborn.”

Peucesta nodded. “I composed those poems myself.”

“Oh!” Audata clapped her hands, delighted. “We’ve been told how talented you are with any number of instruments and lyrics.”

“An Okheman writer reached out for collaboration. The songs have spread quicker than anticipated.”

“Not to say all of his compositions are… true to life,” Hephaestion warned her.

Phainon laughed and shared a conspiratorial smile with Mydei. “It’s more interesting that way, no?”

It was the reason Mydei and Phainon had given Peucesta permission, along with this anonymous writer, to interject tales as outlandish as they wished to make them. The more preposterous the better.

Perhaps it was wrong of him as a student of the Grove dedicated to the pursuit of truth and knowledge, but it was so entertaining to witness what people were willing to accept as true when Mydei was a figure larger than life. A warrior born from legends, destined to be immortalised in the stars alongside other great heroes.

The conversation flitted between all kinds of stories as wild as the lands they had been realised in. Each spanned the six years of the detachment’s most triumphant highs and Mydei or Phainon’s own most embarrassing lows.

Five warriors, born and raised for the battlefield, previously unknown to the two farmers who had never held a blade sharper than a kitchen knife or

scythe, and Mydei and Phainon the only familiarities to bridge the two—yet it was so effortless.

Phainon hadn't even realised he harboured doubts until the disbelief slipped into relief that not even a hint of awkwardness weighted the air, uplifted by carefree laughter and simple conversation. He hadn't expected anything dramatic to occur, certainly not violent, but oil and water never mixed. Everything from age to past life experiences to the present made the two halves of Phainon and Mydei's lives so dissimilar they were hardly recognisable as paths through human life.

Yet everything had blended together. Less like oil and water, and more like two separate amphoras of wine poured into one as the fruits and spices blended together into a more delicious flavour and aroma than either could hope to accomplish alone. The type to warm him through entirely with a single sip.

While Phainon offered to whisk Mydei away from Okhema and the Kremnoan detachment to live a life only for themselves, and meant every word of it if Mydei had agreed—he knew Mydei would never abandon his responsibilities. It was outside of his nature: one that cared too deeply for the people who turned to him, gazing at his back for inspiration and reassurance of the future, to ever betray the hopes entrusted to him.

Besides, that was simply a quiet, selfish wish. This life was infinitely better. More than a wish, it was dream too wonderful to even dare to wish for. And was now safely within their joined hands that would never let go.

Dinner ended with a dessert of honey pancakes, served alongside a platter of the gifed figs and plums. Action Hour was slowly coming to an end, Snowy fully succumbed to slumber on the rug beneath the central table, but Peucesta asked if Audata and Hieronymus would like to hear a song. At their enthusiastic agreements, the plucked strings and trilling voice of Peucesta resonated through the room.

After one full song to admire Peucesta's craft, Leonnius requested another for the rest of them to join him. Since Phainon's parents knew no

Kremnoan, Peucesta selected one of the recent popular songs in Okhema: a tale of Mydei and Phainon's exploits told in common tongue.

While everyone joined along, eyes distracted away from Phainon and Mydei, he placed a kiss against Mydei's temple and dragged his lips down the shell of his ear. "How are you?"

Although Mydei abstained from alcohol, his cheeks were flushed with the warmth of the room and his eyes dazed with unadulterated joy, he almost appeared intoxicated when he nuzzled further into Phainon's side.

"Disappointed," Mydei said. Phainon blinked, lips parting wordlessly now that his scripted reply was inapplicable. "You made a mistake skinning the catfish."

With the voices of their family singing, Mydei's words almost snuck free from Phainon's mind but he replayed them to the rhythm of the ballad.

He slumped his head and laughed into Mydei's hair. "Apologies. I became distracted."

"What have I told you about distractions?"

Phainon's heart swelled so large he struggled to breathe through his overwhelming affection with no where to go but he swept Mydei into his arms, pulling him onto his lap, so it might pass through Phainon's skin and settle beneath Mydei's own.

"They belong in neither the battlefield nor the kitchen."

Mydei tucked his head under Phainon's chin, words brushing down Phainon's neck to warm the metal mark of Strife. "So what exactly did you let yourself be distracted by."

"What else but the same as always: my beautiful husband-to-be," he practically purred in Mydei's ear, lips and voice brushing the skin.

It was directly in front of his eyes and he watched the blood flow upwards, tinting the very tips. Phainon tucked the hair back to expose the reaction in

full and Mydei swayed to bump against him chastising but didn’t shrug him off. His ear was almost as red as his hair. Phainon wanted to bite it.

Mydei cleared his throat. “It appears you’re still in need of more lessons.”

“Or someone who will feed someone as hopeless as myself,” Phainon countered with a pretty flutter of his lashes.

“Lessons it is,” Mydei said flatly. “Until you are no longer so helpless.”

“What if my stringent teacher never deems me acceptable? My lessons will continue?”

“I expect nothing less.” It was almost scathing but the way Mydei peered at him through his lashes, lips tugged to bare teeth in a wild grin…

And Phainon smiled. “For the rest of our lives, Mydei?”

“For the rest of our lives, Phainon.”

Chapter End Notes

I am back in this verse and they make so so happy!!

I debated having the extras match the main story and be in Mydei’s POV buuuut one of my extra story ideas doesn’t really work unless it’s Phainon POV. And I’m an all or nothing type of person.

So enjoy these opportunities to read how pathetically down bad Phainon is (which will likely have to wait until after PhaiDei week because I need to actually finish prepping for that sorry).

I wasn’t sure whether to post the extras as a separate thing or not. But I figured it would be easier for people who want to read them to find it here than anywhere else.

And yes the “anonymous writer” is Castorice. Her and Peucesta are bonding over their love of PhaiDei fanfiction.

Chapter 16: Extra Story 2 - Honourable Words

Chapter Summary

> Mydei and the Kremnoan detachment are tasked with an excursion against the black tide.
>
> Phainon is the last person to find out.

Chapter Notes

> Remember everyone: Communication is key in all relationships—romantic or otherwise.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Ordinary life revolved around nature's rhythms. There was reassurance in the celestial bodies that told them when to eat, work, sleep; and the changing seasons that dictated what type of work they performed in cycles of sowing and harvesting, peace and strife, work and rest.

Even once Phainon's life expanded beyond fields to be tilled, planted and harvested along the beat of nature's dance, life in the Kremnoan detachment wasn't so different. They marched great distances, confronted armies, and sieged cities from spring to autumn. In winter, the detachment settled down like beasts hibernating through the cold conditions least suitable to their transitory lifestyle, and lurked in wait for the snow to thaw and the hunt to resume.

Although the last bastion of humanity as Amphoreus crumbled, disfigured by the black tide into something indistinguishable from the wild days of Phainon's adolescence, Kephale's blessing made Okhema exempt from much the Titans' natural laws. Warm days and clear skies blended together into one eternal day on the cusp of spring becoming summer.

But life in the Grove of Epiphany was an entirely different existence. Day and night blended together as Phainon was crammed into the libraries,

studies and research laboratories with nothing but oil lamps to illuminate the miserly gloom. The one boundary preventing them from completely merging was his class schedule.

The seasons were even more indistinct. The leaves sheltering the Grove from wind and rain never changed their verdant hues, as evergreen as Cerces' knowledge nurturing humanity.

Four months into Phainon's student life and he was finally given a proper break. Something related to Cerces absconding with Mnestia for two weeks in order to personally understand the Romance espoused by the Titan. But the reason was of little importance. What was of utmost important was that he had two whole weeks with no classes, no field trips, no research studies.

One final, blunt reminder from Anaxa that he would not be available for *any* questions, no matter how dire they were *perceived* to be, and Phainon was free. He sprinted from his seat with a quick farewell to his disgruntled professor and straight to the dromas stable.

None of his fellow students nor professors attempted to stop him. Sightings of a white blur dashing through the Grove had become commonplace in the past months, so the others watched with amusement, encouraging cheers, and some slight concern when he leapt down a few levels rather than follow the tree's inner spiral. It was less than a day's ride to the Holy City. There wasn't a moment to waste. He wanted to make the most of his two weeks.

Two weeks. Such a thing used to mean little to him. Days in the detachment passed much the same, stretching into weeks, months, years. But it was far from a dull monotony.

Morning meant hurrying to meet Mydei in his private tent or by the cooking fire pits, until he eventually claimed one half of Mydei's tent as his own and they greeted the day together. Midday meant sparring, hunting or any other competition to be had with Mydei and the others. If they were on the move then it meant marching to the beat of a rowdy song that carried them forward.

Evenings were the time to settle into camp, bathe in local waters, and prepare dinner at the campfires where they gathered for food and honey brew, song and dance, laughter and good company. The clamour lasted until the moon was high in the sky, bidding them to crawl into their sleeping cots in preparation for a day that would be just the same as the one passed.

Now the thought of two weeks was enough to make his heart race; tight in his chest but so light he feared how easily it would be crushed when those two weeks came to an end and he was forced to return to the Grove.

It was certainly a more luxurious life, less physically demanding, than he was used to: he didn't have to catch and clean his own meals, his bedding was softer than thin cots on hard ground, he was never required to wield a weapon. But those were never things he disliked about life in a farming village and the wandering wilds. They were enjoyable in their own way. He could understand the merits of either lifestyle, and why some were more suited to one than the other.

What vexed him more than anything else was the separation. If he spent two weeks with Mydei—his betrothed. The title alone made him giddy, lightheaded, and was often the cause of others catching him laughing under his breath in the library—and the gold thread, stretched across the plains and forests between them, was wound tight around them, Phainon feared for his resolve to disentangle themselves.

It wasn't the type of fear that kept him away. He may be on the path of a scholar now but he was first and foremost a warrior, a Kremnoan one, an honour that he had rightfully won long before a fourteen day and night duel began the process of setting it in stone. He grappled with fear, charged towards it with heated blood, conquered it so the spoils could be paraded.

Heartache was much more potent than any fear but that too failed to keep him away. It was a pain he was willing to withstand as proof of where his heart truly laid. He trembled with it as he passed through the city gates, dromas thankfully trained to slow upon entering civilisation because Phainon's mind was elsewhere entirely at the first touch of the Dawn Device bathing him in Kephale's light. He yearned to see the same light

warming flawless pale skin, brightening hair the same gold and auburn as his childhood, glinting off golden jewellery, including signet ring.

Unfortunately, he was slowed by the people bustling back and forth across the stables. He was a frequentest visitor by now and he had yet to see the space so lively. But the arms laden with boxes and saddles, carts stacked with crates and sacks, and the garments of those around him—all of it was familiar.

The Kremnoan detachment preparing to depart.

He dismounted with a reassuring pat of the dromas' flank as he scanned for the most familiar faces amid the myriad flitting past in long strides. "Ptolemy!"

Scroll in hand as he barked orders amidst a huddle of his men, Ptolemy's head jerked up. As Phainon slipped through the crowd, Ptolemy's eyes widened and he flinched away. It was far from his usual smile and hearty pat on the back. His feet shuffled as though he were about to commit such a transgression as *fleeing,* despite standing in the open before his men.

Phainon checked over his shoulder but there was nothing that could provoke such a reaction. Certainly no Krateros, Hephaestion nor Mydei coming to scold Ptolemy for somehow fumbling his orders. Next he looked down at himself. There was no offence to be taken from his clothes: Mydei had complimented the soft blue tunic in the past and his trousers were plain enough to avoid clashing.

He raised his hand in a small wave and smiled through the awkwardness. "Ptolemy."

Only to be met with rapid blinks. Perhaps an eyelash had tumbled, or an inopportune wind had stirred the red soil into his eyes. He may have been gone for the past month and a half, too busy with a workload thrice as heavy as other students to visit, but if that was enough time for Ptolemy to forget his face then he was due a visit to the Twilight Courtyard.

“Phainon,” Ptolemy finally said, as though it were squeezed from his lungs in a weak wheeze that happened to take the shape of his name. “You’re in the city.”

He nodded and maintained an amiable smile, even as the warriors around Ptolemy averted their eyes. His skin prickled with various gazes on him from all around the stable. “Something about a festival to Cerces and Mnestia. The Grove’s activities are on hold for the next two weeks.”

“Right,” Ptolemy said, eyes on Phainon but too hazy to do more than peer through Phainon as he gnawed his bottom lip. “Wait here.”

A flick of his hand rallied his men to follow him a short distance. The braying dromases and horses were loud as ever but Phainon glanced out the corner of his eye and many of the men lingered where they had previously hurried like their lives—worse, their honour—was at stake if someone noticed them hesitating. The Kremnoan shouts had dimmed into a muttering din too quiet for Phainon to parse.

Still, the stable’s noises combined was enough to muffle Ptolemy’s exchange with his men. With his back to Phainon, Ptolemy’s face and lips were impossible to read. He could only rely on the faces of the others: stern, stricken, stressed.

It was foolish to jump to conclusions, to make assumptions—not enough evidence, Anaxa would berate him, and toss his research essay plan into the fire—but he could feel the beginnings of his hypothesis snapping into place. He didn’t like the end unfolding.

Under the eyes of so many he had fought and bled with to earn a mutual respect, he resisted the urge to clench his hands or shuffle his feet. All were signs of doubt that reflected poorly on him but, more importantly, Mydei as their prince who had chosen Phainon. Most certainly not a prince, not even Kremnoan, and now wavering somewhere between a warrior and scholar in his lifestyle.

Ptolemy passed on his scroll and his men scurried away as he returned to Phainon. His shoulders had relaxed but his face was carefully blank. Unlike

Leonnius' outrageous tongue befitting a trickster more than a messenger, Ptolemy was never a talented liar, so he had opted against a shaky, false smile. For his face to be so utterly unreadable was impressive, which meant he was serious.

Phainon breathed once. A steadying one usually taken on the cusp of battle. "Or perhaps I misheard and it was a festival to Nikador that unshackled me from the Grove library."

An unasked question. An opening for an explanation regarding what exactly the Kremnoan detachment was doing in the stables when it was already abundantly clear. So it was really an entirely different question that weighed the air between them more than the bellowing klaxon and suffocating smoke of war.

Ptolemy's face was unchanged and his voice flat, "You should speak with Mydeimos."

Worst of all, Phainon's traitorous heart fluttered at the mention of his name, spurring images of sun lighting the horizon gold and red with the dawn he hoped they would greet together. It burned down the back of his throat as his jaw tightened. "Where is he?"

"The barracks."

Tersely, Phainon muttered a brief thanks, one Ptolemy only returned with the bob of his throat before he bowed his head. Neither said farewell as Phainon departed from the stables through the backstreets.

The barracks, stables and armouries were all connected by a number of streets constructed for soldiers to move cargo and themselves in high volume while bringing minimal disruption to civilians. Away from the prying eyes edged too sharp to be wariness alone, it ordinarily made them a more private avenue through the city.

Today was an exception. The backstreets were perfect straight lines, spaced just over two carts' width, with no branches: people either walked towards him or behind him but there was nowhere to duck away and hide. As he

strode towards the barracks he kept his chin and shoulders back, smile unfaltering, as though he were oblivious to the startled second glances. No one attempted to stop him. They parted for him as he stepped into the barracks.

Mydei wasn't inside. Only Hephaestion, issuing commands to the few Kremnoans inside that ensured his attention flicked to the new shadow darkening the doorway. His words locked behind his stiffened smiled.

Then eased into surprised cheer. Another much better liar. Hephaestion had a talent for sniffing out what people wanted to hear and handing it to them with a smile. "Phainon! Back from the Grove so soon?"

Hephaestion's arms opened and Phainon accepted the half-embrace, one hand occupied with a scroll. The strength of the hand clasped over his shoulder as they parted more than made up for its absence.

"A festival for Cerces. I have two weeks off," Phainon gave him the short version. "Have you seen Mydei?"

For one lingering moment everything was almost normal. They embraced, they smiled pleasantly, they spoke without stammering. But the others held their breaths and then absconded with a tilt of Hephaestion's head, scuttling like they couldn't get away fast enough.

Hephaestion furled his scroll, wooden ends clacking together, as he sighed, "In the training grounds around the back. I'll get him. You two should speak in a more private setting."

"I appreciate it." And Phainon meant it.

Whether they liked it or not, they were both public figures. Mydei had much more experience in that regard: he had accepted it with graciousness at the same age Phainon was still crying over a scabbed knee from mistaking a hill for flat ground. A duty, a title, an isolation he should never have been forced to shoulder when youth was about exploring new things, failing with little consequence, and laughing it off among good friends fumbling their way through a big world in much the same way.

That may be Phainon’s opinion but he had always approached Mydei’s status in the detachment with the solemnity it deserved. With the same reverence Mydei upheld his title and all the expectations that came with it, even when he was a short, wide-eyed malnourished child. It was a balancing act of humility, to learn and defer to those older, wiser, than him, and staunch leadership befitting their venerated Crown Prince.

He would never be petty enough to jeopardise his position. Not when they were wanderers, and certainly not when tensions were high in a city where the detachment felt every shaded corner held an enemy poised to strike. Phainon may have entertained the wild thought but he never honestly expected to be stabbed by an unknown assailant with a grudge written in blood dried from an age-old rivalry between city-states.

But he had never even thought to consider the idea that the dagger would be lodged in his back by the person he trusted most.

Only a few moments later and the barrack door opened again. Phainon didn’t dare lift his head from the slip of light stretched across the floor, bending around a broad silhouette, before the door shut the daylight out. Footsteps so adept at falling silent made themselves known across the stone.

When was the last time they had seen each other? Six weeks ago. Anaxa had begun to assign him workloads heavier than all his peers and insisted he had to be able to accomplish at least that much before he could graduate early.

Six weeks yet Phainon lifted his head and it was as though no time had passed. The red garments set him apart from the city’s sun-bleached stone. A flame that flickered with the wind against Mydei’s strides and a beacon that drew Phainon in with the same mindless devotion people reserved for Kephale’s light. Loose, wild, untamed—garments suited to prowling the backstreets like a lion waiting to be released from its urban cage. Eager to meet the wilds and bloody his maw, gold dyed red like the ends of his hair hanging loose around his shoulders.

The braid was still the same. The one Phainon had created with his one hands stir last time they were together. Too distracted by Mydei below him, fiddling at Phainon's hair with an absentminded comment about growing it out, he had made a mistake parting the hair into equal strands and failed to notice until he was clasping the bottom of a lopsided braid.

When he offered to try again, Mydei had only laughed him off and plucked the end from Phainon's hand. With only a few nudges, Mydei had begun to wear more pigmented lip tints in private; not quite a red but more noticeable than the teasing hint of pink, especially when it clung to Phainon's bare skin.

The stain was still there. Curved around the golden clasp. Phainon had watched, wide-eyed, when Mydei brought the braid to his own lips and kissed the metal warmed by Phainon's fingertips, lids low as he held Phainon's gaze with a smug victory over his dumbstruck reaction. Then he yanked Phainon in for a proper kiss and everything was forgotten as Phainon was helpless, never even attempting a half-hearted struggle, when Mydei wanted him close.

As helpless as he was now. The same hair, the same clothes, the same sharp angles and surprisingly soft curves. As though nothing had changed.

The difference was in the finest details. Mydei at his most relaxed was reserved for Phainon and four walls that shut out a world beyond the two of them. Only then was Mydei at ease; as much as he could ever be in a world that had gutted and bled him dry over and over again since his birth.

Now, Mydei stood with the stiff shoulder and facade of the crown prince. The one that stood too far ahead to reach for. His broad back a shield, a flag and a spear point protecting those behind him, held aloft as an ideal to strive towards, guiding the way forward.

He was guarded. His eyes sharp and unflinching as he waited for Phainon to meet his eye and one of them was trapped by the shield wedged between them but Phainon wasn't certain who. There was nothing to be gleaned from his expression nor body language, yet it told Phainon all he needed to know.

Phainon’s heart trembled. It always did at the sight, at the thought, at the lingering scent on stolen fabric, of Mydei. Even whilst Mydei gave him the same look he gave everyone else.

“The detachment is preparing to leave,” Phainon launched the first assault like spears thundering against shields, striking fear into their enemies and scattering their tight formation into something easy to defeat.

Mydei blinked slow, unmoved, because he never flinched whether his body was the spearhead or the shield to be struck. “It is.”

“Where?”

“A black tide expedition.”

Finally, the question with such an obvious answer it had greeted his arrival in the city with the detachment’s movements and the startled reaction of his friends. To hear it in Mydei’s own words would be the final death knell. Perhaps his months in the Grove meant something after all, because his body was unwieldy with the curiosity—the overwhelming need to to ask:

“Without me?”

His voice wavered but it was too late to pluck the words from the stagnant air between them. He swallowed like they were still nestled safe against his trembling vocal cords, but his throat burned with the empty air plunging heavy into his stomach.

Mydei breathed, so deep it was almost a sigh when he exhaled and answered, “Yes.”

The smile on Phainon’s face was weak. Worthless and unconvincing. He longed to tear it from his face and throw it to the floor so it would shatter at Mydei’s feet so his stoic mask would crumble with it.

He forced a breath, shuddering hot through his clenched teeth. “Why?”

A slow blink. The eyes of a predator, calm and composed as they stalked disorientated prey. But Phainon bristled and his lips pulled with the urge to

bear equally sharp teeth. Maybe that would rouse some passion—love, anger, hatred. Anything that Phainon could recognise.

“Focus on your studies. And your family.” Mydei motioned to the window. The world outside was so bright it felt too far from the darkness crushing the room to be real. “Audata and Hieronymus will be happy to see you.”

The disbelieving laugh was so caustic it burned his tongue. “You’re leaving?”

“Preparations still need to be completed.”

“When?”

That made Mydei hesitate. Finally a hint of someone real behind the unflinching military general. But he crossed his arms and his voice was beyond steady. It was flat with the boredom of someone who wanted a conversation to end. “Parting hour.”

“You had no intention of telling me.”

A rhetorical question Mydei didn’t bother to answer. He only tipped his head, lopsided braid swaying, arms tightening around himself, and blinked slow while Phainon—

“You’re going to leave me behind.”

Broke. Just a bit. At the very ends where he wanted to close his lips back over his teeth into a shape he hadn’t yet decided. A thin line. A scowl. A pained smile. The break in his voice fractured his expression. He didn’t know what face he was making, just that it wasn’t indignation. This was weakness. One he hadn’t wanted to show.

But, for the first time since stepping into the barrack, Mydei *saw* him. Not through the veneer of a prince nor a warrior gazing hazily across a ravaged battlefield. Mydei looked with the fleeting emotions that pierced through the surface: there and gone in the brief moment before Mydei regained his composure.

Then he turned and there was nowhere to look except Mydei's back. "Wait for me to return and we can discuss it further."

"I have two weeks," Phainon blurted out. It wouldn't change anything. He said it anyway. "I wanted to spend it with you."

Too pitiful to be a request. Resigned.

"Go home, Phainon. And… look out for Hephaestion while I'm gone."

Phainon's head jerked up, eyes wide. "What do you mean?"

There barracks were empty. Mydei nothing more than an apparition sent to shatter him and dissipate, lingering only in the faint scent of pomegranates. He waited for the sweet fragrance to fade and long after.

Akin to a scolded child, he tucked himself against the wall where the daylight couldn't scald him to action. Head dropped between his knees and arms looped behind his neck, he made a miserable sight. Not because he thought, for even a moment, that Mydei would return and take pity on him if only he appeared pitiful enough.

He just wanted to pathetically wallow where no one would find him.

"You stayed put."

At the remark of equal parts surprise and humour, Phainon slowly raised his head. The daylight burned but he kept his eyes open and let it. "You too."

Hephaestion chuckled and nodded to the open spot beside him. Phainon patted the threadbare mat and he sat with another short laugh, less humorous when it was tinged with something heavier. "My condition has been less stable in the past weeks. Lady Hyacinthia insists on watching me more closely and Mydeimos ordered me to remain."

Four months, almost five, had passed since the detachment arrived in Okhema. Mydei had yet to tell him every fragment of the past—fragmented like a smashed mural he never pieced together in full. The edges didn't quite line up and there were shards missing, but what was thrust into his

hands, his head, was enough for him to know the broad strokes and what he needed to do—but this detail Phainon knew.

“How…” he picked at the mat’s fraying edge and swallowed. “How do you feel?”

Hephaestion glanced over but Phainon avoided his gaze, unravelling thread with the same focus as someone who wove it, and he shrugged. “Fatigued at times. Shaky at others.”

He lifted his sword hand. It was plagued with a slight tremor. If he were in any many other professions, it would be hardly noticeable and even less consequential. For a warrior, it decided life and death.

“But it’s manageable,” Hephaestion assured him and let his hand fall limp with a harsh slap. “And yet Mydeimos is so…”

Of course he is, Phainon didn’t say. Because Mydei had never told Hephaestion or any of the others that this shattered mural existed, let alone what he found amongst the rubble. *You’re supposed to be on your deathbed.*

It explained why Mydei had ordered Hephaestion to stay behind. Ever loyal and reliable, Hephaestion had no issue with obeying Mydei’s commands with ease instead of questions, bitterness, outrage.

It didn’t explain why Phainon received the same order.

“I should be glad.” No false joy in Hephaestion’s voice. The softness was real and drew Phainon’s eye, only to find Hephaestion already gazing sidelong at him with a knowing smile. “It means he cares.”

Phainon’s nails scraped stone through thinned fabric as his fist curled into the mat. “That may be so. For the one he dared to show his care to face-to-face.” His eyes stung. It wasn’t the daylight that forced his eyes shut tight. “I never would have agreed to enrol in the Grove if I knew it would come to this.”

The long periods of separation were manageable. Their reunions—always too short. Never enough to soothe his longing. Never enough time—were like dreams that made the waking world bearable. The division that sundered his flesh and never the distance between them was temporary.

But Phainon had been under the impression that nothing would change in spite of the vast time and space between them. He was wrong. Not only had Mydei decided Phainon was no longer worthy to stand by his side as his equal in battle. But Phainon wasn't even worthy of being told as much to his face.

"Come now. You two have always shared an understanding. Don't tell me, now that you're the target of his stone-faced ways, the two of you have become mere strangers," Hephaestion cajoled. A voice reserved for a campfire, honey brew in hand and the night air refreshingly cold and crisp.

Phainon pushed a hand through his hair and laughed weakly. "Time changes all. Separation makes it more likely for our respective changes to diverge."

Amidst his wallowing, he missed the flit of shadows and fabric until it whipped towards him. A sharp smack whacked him between the shoulder blades and he jolted forwards into his knees. He gagged at the unexpected force.

"If you intend to sulk with deaf ears then I'll leave you to do so in privacy," Hephaestion berated, so stern it bordered on a glare. "But while alone with your thoughts consider: when Mydeimos has ever felt the need to use deception. To shame his enemies?"

He dropped his forehead against his knees and his skin stung beneath his clothes as he breathed, pain sharpening his mind. "No."

"Then when?"

"Never."

That was the answer every Kremnoan would give. Only Phainon knew about the truth nestled deep inside Mydei's heart that had festered in the

open cuts of a child afraid to lose what little he had and the fresh scar tissue of a child that had already grieved that loss—in the past, in a premonition, set to become the future. Were those deceptions? Only in the same way this had been: withholding the truth.

But, ever since they collapsed in a field after a duel no one else could endure much less revel in as they did, Phainon had never once blamed Mydei for the silence throughout the years before he was ready to end it and spoke through a rising sun.

Time changed all. Except Mydei, apparently, because he still chose to protect the people he cared for in the same way he always had.

The one who had changed was Phainon. Nervous when he had always been self-assured of his place at Mydei's side that had become so physically distant he lost sight of it.

"I'm supposed to guard his back," Phainon murmured. "He shouldn't have to shoulder every burden alone."

"Well, no Kremnoan would dare defy the will of the crown prince," Hephaestion said and Phainon raised his head to ask for advice from one of two people even Mydei deferred to. But Hephaestion smiled, sly where it creased his eyes and he tilted his head. "Except you never treated him much like a prince. Do you intend to change that?"

Phainon huffed a laugh and smiling came easier than it had since he arrived in the city. "I wouldn't be fit to be his betrothed if I did."

With a firm slap of his knee, Hephaestion stood. "Then let's find you some armour."

The next laugh came even lighter with his disbelief. "Is that not defying the prince's will?"

"You said so yourself: the two of you are set to be wed. In that sense, am I not doing what I've always done?" When Hephaestion offered a hand,

pulling Phainon to his feet, it was with a roguish smile befitting a winning strike on the battlefield. “I’m only obeying my prince.”

There was no shortage of supples in the armoury to scavenge a set of greaves, a chest piece and a plumed helmet suited to Phainon’s proportions. From there, he slipped in amongst the Kremnoans loitering around the barracks. Their duties were fulfilled and sparring an inadvisable use of energy they would soon need to march, so they merely chatted and leisurely prepared their travel packs as they waited to depart.

Some sent him second glances and likely deciphered who was beneath the helmet when a few strands of white hair and his bright eyes were still visible. They promptly turned away, mouths shut with the slightest upward tilt at the corners to seal their silence.

Since Hephaestion was staying in the city and Ptolemy was too terrible a liar to obfuscate Phainon’s identity for long, Phainon hid himself among Peucesta’s men. Once Mydei confirmed with each of his generals that their warriors and supplies were accounted for, Peucesta winked at him and issued the order to march away from the safety of Okhema’s walls.

Feet pounded against the earth in one swaying mass of dark leather and glinting metal, setting the rhythm beneath the booming tenor of Kremnoan war songs interrupted by jaunty music more crass than valorous. Peucesta’s battalion was especially raucous with the detachment’s best musician at their fore to lead the chorus to near defeating heights where Phainon nestled in the centre.

It thrummed in his ears, his head, his body. He grinned and sang along in a language he learned but never perfected. It made his voice stark amidst the tongues that formed around the rough edges of Kremnoan first and common second. All the men around him knew exactly who he was and chose to sing, sway, and march with him anyway.

In the Grove, there was no shared rhythm. Every scholar flitted through their own research, flicked parchment at their own pace, stewed in their own thoughts after every class and symposium. In the detachment,

loneliness was squeezed from existence. There was simply no space between the press of bodies and voices for it to find and fester within.

Even once night fell to smother the heat and noise in their temporary encampment, he ate and drank with the others around the fires, listening to their stories and jeering laughter or comments while occasionally throwing in his own. There were any number of tents he could have chosen to spend the night in, falling asleep to the wind knocking against the breathing and snores of his tent mates.

But the weather was mild and the earth dry, so he laid beneath the night sky. The breeze stirred the smouldering remains of their fire pits and carried the embers upwards to join the stars. Once a familiar sight, they were impossible to find in Okhema's sky where the Dawn Device eclipsed the small pinpricks of light.

The Grove's planetarium was for study alone and failed to compare. The stars were much too large, too close, only ever as far as the domed ceiling, even if Phainon snuck inside when the room was empty and laid down with the memory of someone beside him. A heartbeat matched to his own while they drew constellations like carefree children out past their curfew.

He reached and his index finger sketched two outlines across the sky: a lion and a dog. His hand fell limp into the space beside him. Empty.

They were still too close to the city. If Phainon exposed himself, Mydei could send him back assured that, unless the earth suddenly cracked open or the Dawn Device crumbled, he would safely pass through Okhema's gates. No sharing a fire nor a tent. They were less than fifty paces away but it may as well have been the distance between the Grove and Okhema when Phainon still couldn't crawl into the same sleeping cot, curl around Mydei's back, and fall asleep together.

The grass rustled with more than the wind and he knew better than to hope but his head swivelled a little too fast. Not that it made a difference when fabric dropped over his head and obscured the silhouette with the rest of the world.

He caught the fluttering edge and flipped it over his head. The blanket settled warm around his shoulders, thoroughly heated by the fire without catching, with the same ease Perdikkas sat beside him with two chalices of honey brew. When Phainon accepted a drink it came with the bitter undertone of pomegranates but neither spoke a word as they watched the stars in silence.

The black tide surge was over a week away from Okhema by foot. It was plenty of time for Leonnius to sneak away after delivering a message from the front to the rear, Perdikkas to check his constitution from sleeping and eating rough after being pampered in the Grove, Peucesta to recount his newest, half-complete poem that was a collaborative project with Okhema's famed anonymous writer.

By the third night, reclined against a tree as he whittled a fallen branch into a sword just the right size for a newborn and too small for anyone else, even Krateros found him. He didn't comment on Phainon's failure to remain at Mydei's side nor drag him there as punishment for disobeying direct orders. He only nodded and strutted off again.

After three days of travel they were beyond the point Mydeimos was likely to send Phainon back alone, and it would be foolish to split his forces just to provide Phainon an escort. But Phainon had yet to think of a way to reveal himself. If this were an elaborate prank or a dramatic theatre performance then he would have no qualms trouncing into his tent and dramatically stripping his chlamys.

What kind of face would Mydei make once he did? Certainly not a smile, and Mydei was more likely to punch than kiss or hug him. A troubled frown? Mounting outrage? Nothing at all when every thought and emotion was wrapped in chains and hauled out of sight?

The overcast third day led into rain through the fourth day. Not the light spring showers that were more refreshing than a hindrance, but the heavy rains of summer slipping into autumn. The storm had started in the night and soaked the earth, footsteps over footsteps dredging it into heavy, muddy tracks that slowed their progress.

The songs lost their cheer, gloomy with the downpour beating the noise down and drowning it in thunder. Compared to the frigid winter months they hibernated in Adonis, these conditions were almost pleasant, even if his skin prickling in the damp cold disagreed.

It was expected when the messengers bolted down from up ahead, as quick as the lightning, outracing the next strike, and one broke away to speak to Peucesta while the other ran past to the battalion behind them. Mydei must have decided to find shelter off the main road and wait out the storm—

“Retreat and into formation! Strife Titankin have ambushed the fore!”

The fore.

The warriors around him began to draw back. It was standard. Not out of advanced military tactics to regroup and recompose themselves, nor any kind of long-standing tradition. Echoing down the legion was an announcement of battle, of bloodshed, against more than any chance encounter: these were the extensions of their own mad Titan of Strife.

Their movements were orderly but their faces were dark. Displeased. Precisely because they were forced into retreat—not by an enemy but by their prince.

Only Phainon had yet to move. The others shifted around him, flowing downstream like a river while he withstood the pull, resisted it, as he pushed forward to snag Peucesta’s arm. The next battalion had already shifted into the space abandoned by their own but the warriors parted around the disruption and Phainon kept them trapped in the centre: the calm amidst rushing rapids.

He was anything but calm as he shouted over the thundering skies, armoured footsteps, and his heart. “Where’s Mydei?”

It was all so loud. Darkness rolled in on all sides and rain dripped down his chlamys to soak through where the wind lifted to expose his ordinary garments. The winds and the water chilled him, hands shaky when they were empty of a sword to hold onto.

Lightning flashed across Peucesta's face, illuminating it in pale lines meeting harsh angles. "Holding the frontline."

The rest went unsaid but Phainon heard it as clearly as the war cry of a solitary lion. Phainon threw his travel pack and chlamys to the ground, ripped his sheathed greatsword free, and ran.

The trodden earth was slick beneath his soles and slid from under him. He staggered against the muddy surface trying to drag him down, finding his balance, and didn't slow again. While the others shuffled into a retreat, Phainon sprinted for the frontline held by an army of one.

Because it was always Mydei alone at the fore. Whether the slim back of a malnourished child or the broad shoulders of a warrior, in actions rather than words, this was how he chose to demonstrate his care.

A lightning flash illuminated the empty stretch of road darkened by long silhouettes and shadows. A stark white creature loomed over a lone figure not even half its size. The lightning faded and the gloom plummeted down upon them in a crash of thunder echoed by a Titankin's roar.

An anguished cry. A death knell. The white figure crumbled around the gauntleted hand plunged through its stomach. The scattered ashes of its head had yet to touch the ground before Mydei spun and lunged for the nearest Titankin in the horde descending upon him.

Phainon needed to move. To do something. Anything. Mydei had already ripped another head free and used it to bludgeon the weapon from a third Titankin's hand before punching it through the neck. He pummelled Titankin to the ground like children knocked wooden towers yet more swarmed. Each more committed to Strife's ideals—valorous death before glorious return—than even Nikador's human followers who threw away life for honour.

The consequences of Phainon's disobedience were irrelevant when inaction meant Mydei fighting, bleeding, *suffering.* And believing he had to do it alone.

But something was wrong. Mydei fought in two ways: controlled precision or unrestrained aggression. Always the former until he let himself loose into a frenzy of the second, born by an intent to kill honed like an executioner’s blade over a lifetime.

When an axe skimmed Mydei’s side, an arrow lodged into his shoulder, a fist caught him in the throat and he coughed gold across the blackened earth, it was careless. Mindless. Instincts dulled and rusted.

Mydei fought with desperation.

It was unlike anything he had seen as Mydei tore through the horde. No savageness, brutality, or self-assurance. When lighting illuminated his features for a fleeting moment, the feral flash of his fangs were nowhere to be seen. He was akin to wounded prey determined to down a predator if it just clawed and bit enough.

Against the darkness and rain and overwhelming numbers slowly, too slowly beginning to dwindle, Mydei slipped. The most juvenile mistake he had ever made in battle. One knee. He was already halfway upright. But it was enough for a shadow to fall over Mydei’s unguarded back.

That distance between them closed like nothing. The Titankin swung and Mydei jerked around in realisation.

Metal clashed. The kind that scraped bone and teeth. The Titankin paused with surprise. It was brief but that was all Phainon needed. He shoved his greatsword against the Titankin’s sword and it staggered but Phainon chased in two long steps and drove his blade through its chest.

He glanced over his shoulder. Mydei was already looking at him. Eyes wide, sparking as bright as the golden blood smeared across his cheek and lip despite the dimness that felt just a little lighter than a moment before, he blinked in disbelief and—

They lunged at the same moment. They brushed past one another and the emotion was snuffed from Mydei’s profile like it never existed. But there were more urgent concerns.

In a single swing, Phainon decapitated the Titankin that had aimed for Mydei's back. Mydei returned the favour with a Titankin knocked down and crushed beneath his heel.

Phainon heaved a breath. This was a warmup, far from enough to wind him. It was something else he braced for as he turned.

Mydei's face was carefully blank. The most terrifying it could ever be. More than fury or tears because at least Phainon could read the crease of his brow and eyes, the tilt of his lips, the flash of his teeth, and know what he was thinking. What he was feeling. This was the face of Mydei shutting Phainon out the same as anyone else.

Still, they knew better than to argue on the battlefield. They naturally stepped into place. A fraught ceasefire. The narrow slip of air between them tingled with the promise of lightning. A stormy onslaught. Yet, back-to-back, they eviscerated the last of the Titankin to the same rhythm in their swing and steps.

The rain and thunder were no longer adversaries disrupting the familiar beat to their dance. Just like a red streak covering his weaknesses when his swing took too long to redirect, or Phainon earning an extra breath for Mydei to recover from overcommitting with his whole body—it all melded together.

As though nothing had changed from their long days in exile that he wished were longer still. Never ending. Years stretching into lifetimes.

But their exile came to an end, and so did the battle. That past reverie splintered in the ragged breaths between them. No enemies left to face, they could only turn on each other.

"Why are you here?" Mydei asked lowly, as level as his facade hiding all those messy thoughts and emotions he wanted everyone to believe he didn't possess.

Phainon's fingers twitched. He wanted them all. To pry them from Mydei's head and inspect them and understand him. Fully, wholly, undeniably. So

Mydei would never feel the need to deceive him again.

He sheathed his greatsword and steadied himself with a breath. “You entrusted your back to me.”

That one weak spot. The only one and he was the only one who knew of it. It was his to protect and he would sooner let a blade through his back than Mydei’s own.

“I told you to stay in Okhema!” Mydei snarled. Roared, like Phainon had simply failed to hear him the first time.

Before Mydei had bared his fangs and fury.

His aching fingers hands tightened around his sword hilt and his next exhale came short from his tight chest. Mydei’s hand was where it had always been, around his lungs, his heart, precisely where Phainon had cut himself open and invited Mydei inside, but this was the first time Phainon had ever felt it squeeze.

“I’m your betrothed. Not one of your generals or foot soldiers,” Phainon reminded him through clenched teeth, in case Mydei had truly forgotten beneath that furious haze dampening the golden clarity in his eyes.

His chest heaved and his voice thundered over the storm. “So you should be the last person to betray my trust!”

“Trust? Betrayal?” Phainon almost laughed but he only sneered. “Look at your own deception in hiding the expedition from me!”

They prowled closer. Neither backed down. They were so close Phainon could see the rain clinging to Mydei’s dampened lashes and almost felt it drip down his own cheeks.

“And you donned petty disguises and hid your presence in the detachment for days.”

“You would have demanded I return to the city otherwise. What lie would you have told me then?”

“I never lied.”

“You simply withheld the truth. The same as you always have.” This time Phainon laughed. Bitter and ugly but Mydei had crushed him to pieces in his fist and scattered the remains like a worthless amphora, made to hold love and breaking under scorn, and he had to know that. “I thought *fear* didn’t exist in the Kremnoan language.”

A mockery of a joke Mydei had told him years ago when the language was still unknown to him. The others had laughed while Phainon confusedly tipped his head before letting the matter rest.

But it did, as Phainon learned. A meaning tricky to grasp over the years. *Fear* existed in many words, so inextricably connected to other concepts—of cowardice, of shame, of betrayal—that fear itself was absent except in unspoken scorn. Fear did not exist because it was not allowed to exist.

And yet Phainon had been confronted by cowardice, shame, betrayal. All of it born from Mydei’s fear.

He grabbed Mydei by his tunic and dragged him inwards. Closer. Nowhere to hide when Phainon demanded in a low growl, “What are you so terrified of, Mydei?”

Bones creaked in both their hands he snatched Phainon’s wrist tight enough to bruise and hauled them even closer. The vein in his neck throbbed with his hastening pulse, as quick as Mydei’s tattoos burning and fading and burning again.

The rain ran down his throat, under his collar, and he swallowed against the premonition of where Mydei’s bared teeth would pierce when he ripped out Phainon’s jugular. It already belonged to Mydei: marked by an emblem of Strife on a collar. Until he dropped the leash and was surprised when Phainon thrashed.

“Do I seem afraid to you?” Mydei ground out through his clenched jaw.

Lips pulled into a snarl. Eyes narrowed in a glare. Face flushed from more than the cold.

“Yes.”

He scoffed and slapped Phainon’s hand away. “Then you lost your eyes somewhere in the library.”

Mydei’s feet shifted, about to turn away. Again.

Phainon snatched his shoulder and yanked him back. Mydei tried to shrug him off and push him away when Phainon reached for his arm. They scrabbled, hands grappling to push and pull, fighting against the slick mud and the storm as much as each other.

A palm thrusted at Phainon’s nose and he side-stepped, blocking with his forearm before that jab could turn into a swing at his jaw. He darted forwards and he missed Mydei’s tunic when he jerked backwards. But the momentum lifted his necklace off his breastbone and Phainon seized the jewel encrusted golden plate at the centre.

A win. Except Phainon choked at the pressure around his throat as Mydei grabbed him by the back of his collar. Flecked with mud and golden blood, neither relinquished their hold. Stalemate.

Phainon panted, throat bobbing against the constrictive leather. “You were relieved to see me until you decided on more deceptions. Or did I misread that too?”

“It isn’t fear,” Mydei insisted again and his hand trembled around Phainon’s wrist. Suppressed rage. The after tremors of battle. The cold. Or—

“It’s only you and I here, *Your Highness,”* he said mockingly. “No one else will hear that their immortal Crown Prince feels fear just like an ordinary mort—“

Mydei slammed their foreheads together. The crack echoed in his ears and his eyes danced with lights as he stumbled, but the hand in his collar cupped

his neck and caught him before he could fall. His brain rattled around his skull, skin and bone throbbing where their foreheads pressed together. He blinked the light away and the rain couldn't soothe the heat of Mydei's body, his gaze, burning through Phainon.

"If you die out here, the one carrying your corpse home to your parents will be *me!"*

The world shrank down to golden eyes. He couldn't look away. There was nowhere else he could possible look beyond Mydei's eyes—the cusp of dawn, the heat of war, the flames of the hearth—and that desperation returned to his slitted pupils. They dragged heavy across Phainon's face, holding his gaze only to flit down over his cheeks, his lips, and back again. Like he was afraid to forget Phainon's face if he ever became a sallow corpse.

He didn't know what he expected, if anything at all, when he dug his fingers into Mydei's cracks so the truth would finally bleed out of him. He never could have guessed that this is what he would find. Mydei was frightened after all. Terrified that Phainon will perish.

It was so simple. Every deception in Mydei's life had been born from the fear that those he cared for would die for his sake. So simple and yet Phainon had failed to see it.

"You're too reckless when it's for someone else's sake—"

"I don't want to hear that from you," Phainon quipped back on instinct when his mind was still reeling from the crack of bone and, more electrifying than a lightning strike, Mydei's admittance.

Hair damp, nose red from the cold, and Phainon's mind still reeling, Mydei's glare fell flat. "My body is immortal. Only one of us comes back from the dead."

"And I'm the one who stands vigil over your dead body while you do!"

So Mydei was fearful that he would, one day, have to find Phainon, blood and life staining the earth gold. Only one of them had guarded a prone body or a deathbed. Even if Phainon knew Mydei would return, there was always the possibility that *this time* would be different.

“I have many lives to give. You have only the one.”

“You don’t know that!”

“Have you lost your mind?”

Through the cold numbing his skin, the back of Mydei’s necklace dug awkwardly into his hand. He let the jewel fall between his fingers but one thing remained cradled in his palm. Phainon’s eyes followed the thin gold chain up where it laid around Mydei’s neck and he had failed to notice. Then back down to the signet ring shining in a the rain pooled shallow in his cupped hand.

“You think Death could keep me from you?” Phainon croaked, voice rough from his shouts. He should be better than this. Than losing control. But Mydei has always tested his self-restraint, just never like this. “I would drag myself from the Sea of Souls and slay Thanatos at its gates if they tried to stop me.”

Finally, Mydei paused enough for the damp air to cool the fury loosen in puffs of fire and smoke meant to choke them both. His voice was breathy, raw like Phainon’s own, “You truly did lose it.”

“Don’t act like I’m selfish for holding you to your word. Honour. Life. Soul —“ Phainon’s hand lifted and, having basked in the heat of Mydei’s body and his own, the ring was warm against his lips, “—you promised all of it to me. I have no intention of letting anyone else have any of it.”

Dumbstruck, Mydei mumbled, “I… did…”

“You did,” Phainon repeated as the fight left them. “And I promised mine back to you.”

For the first time in the long years they had known each other better than anyone else in this world, they both had spoken and been unable to hear one another.

Exhausted from more than battle, now they were nothing more than two people stood drenched in the rain.

Phainon smoothed his thumb over the symbol of Strife, whispering under the rain, “Unless, you had a change of heart.”

Mydei heard him anyway. “No. I just…”

His face twisted and he ran a hands through his hair, gripping darkened strands as he tried to grasp hold of the words escaping him. Hazy with confusion. Lost.

Slowly, Phainon asked, “Was it because of Hephaestion?”

“No. Yes,” Mydei corrected himself, words quick when he usually considered his answers beforehand like a man being taken to an executioner’s platform. “Not entirely.“

Troubled by his own uncertainty, his brows pinched, hand tightening in his hair, and he cupped his mouth, sealing away any more unwarranted answers.

“Take your time,” Phainon reassured him and lowered the signet ring back to his chest. “We should return to the others and set up camp for now.”

Phainon reached—and hesitated. But their relationship wasn’t one of hesitances, so he grasped Mydei’s hand and intwined their fingers. Mydei glanced at their hands and squeezed and Phainon felt it around his heart beating steady for the first time in days.

They were utterly soaked by the storm still raging around them but Phainon breathed and felt it warm him through. They would be all right. They always were and this time would be no exception. There never would be so long as Phainon had a choice.

By the time they returned, the encampment was already partially pitched. While Mydei disliked formality, his tent was one of the first to be constructed. They could have dragged their feet straight inside but Mydei's sharp whistle cut through the din of rain and chatter.

All eyes turned to them and silence lingered over the encampment. Phainon smiled, lifted their joined hands in a wave, and cheers erupted in a crash louder than thunder. Their companions were the loudest as they peeled themselves away from the others.

Leonnius clasped Phainon's shoulder but addressed the situation first. "I saw the two of you back-to-back and knew the Titankin would be handled in no time."

"Any injuries?" Perdikkas asked with an eye towards any golden smears, but they were all too thin to be much threat. "Physical. Since emotional isn't my area of expertise."

Mydei swung their joined hands for them to see again and answered, voice still rougher than usual, "None."

"None," Phainon echoed.

Peucesta smiled. "All passions are ignited one the battlefield."

Ptolemy's head swivelled between each of them, face dazedly slack. "So…"

"We all knew," Leonnius confirmed for him and a firm pat to Phainon's shoulder.

"Not all," Mydei corrected gruffly and Phainon nudged their shoulders together with a small smile Mydei returned at the corner of his eyes.

Ptolemy frowned. "I—how should I feel about this exactly?"

"Motivated," Peucesta said.

"Do you mean demotivated?" Ptolemy retorted skeptically, knowing Peucesta was never one to mix words.

“Motivated,” Perdikkas agreed.

“Motivated to work on keeping a straight face,” Leonnius teased with a sharp smirk.

“Hephaestion knows, doesn’t he?” Ptolemy asked and the silence was answered enough. He sighed. “He’s not even here and he knows.”

Perdikkas offered a consolatory pat of his back. “Sulk when the lot of us are no longer tempting illness with the rain.”

The four of them were still partially protected by their chlamys, waxed leather repelling water, but Mydei and Phainon had discarded theirs for the sake of easier movement in battle. They were akin to a drowned cat and dog, and the others scattered to find them dry linens amongst the supplies while they retreated to Mydei’s tent.

When Mydei parted the flap, Phainon followed him inside so they could shelter from the frigid winds. Leonnius returned with a basin of water and cloths. Without dry tinder to light a fire, the water was still cold but they had suffered worse than cold cloths to wipe themselves down with. It was a worse fate to have nothing at all. The fresh garments Perdikkas returned with were dry, as was the bedding in the chest Ptolemy carried inside.

Swaddled under all three blankets Perdikkas had insisted upon, there was no need for a furnace when Mydei’s body burned hot enough for the both of them. He was better than a blanket. There was weight behind his warmth as he laid atop Phainon’s chest and let Phainon wrap him up in his arms, hand resting over a knob in Mydei’s back.

His breath brushed hot through the tunic and his words sank through fabric into Phainon’s skin. “When Hephaestion died, he was my dear companion. The only one I managed to keep by my side. Unlike the rest, it wasn’t circumstance—noble self-sacrifice, nor battle—that took him from me. But sickness. His own body, and that is something beyond my power to change.”

Phainon combed his hand through Mydei's damp hair. "Hephaestion is in good hands. His health has been entrusted to a stable life in the city, and the healing hands of the Courtyard."

Mydei squirmed against him. Not to force distance between them but, cheek nuzzling against Phainon's chest and leg slotting between Phainon's own, to get closer. "Then I found myself thinking, Hephaestion was my dear companion and now I have a person dearest to me—more beloved than anyone else could ever hope to be. If fate truly wanted to be cruel, perhaps they would take them away as the cost of the others' survival."

Phainon's heart ached at this weight Mydei had suffered in silence. He never wanted to be a burden to anyone but least of all to Mydei. Yet, so long as Mydei cared for him so deeply he could lose blood and bone and that tenderness could still never be gouged out, there was little Phainon could do except swing his sword for the sake of them both, hold Mydei just like this afterwards, and hope it was enough to lighten his many burdens.

He knew because he was the same way. Mydei could shatter him, destroy him, scorn his doubts, his irrationality, his mistakes that were born from an affection so deep it would remain in every broken fragment of his being. Loving someone so much was its own burden to some but Phainon embraced it, yearning to feel its weight every morning and night.

Besides, he wouldn't be Mydei if he chose to destroy Phainon out of anything other than misguided love.

He kissed the crown of Mydei's head, tasting rain as he promised, "I'm not going anywhere."

"You should," Mydei said. "This life… you have the potential for more than this endless slaughter scraping out another day for the holy city."

The conversation had circled back around to this. For him—and him alone of every person he had grown alongside in the detachment, including Mydei—it was a tangible option for him to discard his greatsword, the aches and pains of battle, the threat of death. He could turn away from being a warrior and walk the path of a scholar. Mydei wanted him to but…

“I don’t want to attend the Grove,” Phainon admitted quietly.

In their first month, it hadn’t been much of a discussion. There were good reasons Aglaea had insisted he enrol: connections, credibility, knowledge and skills to challenge the Council of Elders. It meant reputation, which could all be directed towards advocating for the detachment.

Phainon splayed his hand flat across Mydei’s back, his weak spot, and felt the breath shudder through Mydei into him. “The most alive I’ve felt in months is whenever I’m at your side, especially in battle.”

“The separation will pass. The knowledge you accrue will not,” Mydei argued, no matter how reluctantly.

“I was considering… slowing down. There’s no need to graduate at the same pace as everyone else. I can divide my responsibilities and time the way I want.”

The only reason he insisted on graduating ahead of schedule was so he could cut their separation short. He thought he could survive condensing it down and shortening the ordeal. But so long as he could see Mydei for more than one day a week, then he didn’t care if it took twice as long to graduate.

Mydei propped his chin on Phainon’s chest and tilted his head with a slight wrinkle of his nose. “Is that possible?”

“I can discuss it with Anaxa.”

Despite his prickly attitude and habit of shooting alchemical bullets at his students, Anaxa was willing to restructure classes and coursework to help him graduate sooner. This should be fine too. Although he may have to endure a bullet between the eyes and a lecture about commitment before Anaxa revealed he had a plan prepared already because Phainon was never subtle about where his heart and mind laid.

“You told me to go home to my family,” Phainon recalled from their argument in the barracks. “Mydei, you are my family. You know that, don’t

you?”

A small hum and a carefully neutral face. Inconclusive, if not for the lingering wrinkle to his nose.

It was so endearing, a habit Phainon was certain Mydei was clueless he possessed, that Phainon smiled and was helplessly drawn in. He kissed Mydei’s nose and the wrinkle deepened before easing away as Phainon whispered, “I want to get married.”

Mydei searched his features, perhaps finding what he was looking for or perhaps not, before he leaned closer. His breath warmed Phainon’s upper lip as he brushed their noses together. “Don’t rush.”

“I’m not,” Phainon insisted in the space between them so narrow each word was practically a kiss. “I’ve simply had a change in priority. I want to wake up beside you every morning in a home we share. I want our clothes mixed together in one chest. I want—I want everything. I want it all. With you, Mydei. Honour, life, soul. These things don’t last forever so why are we wasting time waiting?”

He kissed him. Slow and languid. The kind of kisses he wanted them to share every morning when they awoke and every night before they slept—for the rest of the time they had left, whether it ended with the evernight or the new dawn. And all those feelings were given right back to him as Mydei kissed him just the same. forehead, lifted their intertwined hands to lay another kiss on his palm and then the back of his hand, down to his ring finger.

When Phainon pulled away, it was only to take the ring swaying against his chest and lift it to his lips, whispering breathlessly, “Marry me, Mydei.”

Mydei leaned down and his lips brushed the ring between them as he held Phainon’s eye and murmured, “I will.”

The ring rattled on its chain as he let it drop and pinched Mydei’s chin, coaxing him the rest of the way into a proper kiss that made Mydei’s tattoos

flash on the other side of Phainon’s closed lids. Fire lancing through Mydei’s body and Phainon’s just the same.

Phainon panted against his lips. “My love, my life, my soul—it’s all yours, Mydei, and nothing will ever take it from you. So don’t shoulder your burdens alone. Tell them to me plainly. No more secrets.”

Mydei licked his reddened lips. “Next time… my first instinct will always be otherwise,” he admitted shamefully and heaved a deep breath. “But I will be honest with you. You deserve nothing less.”

His eyes prickled but tucked Mydei’s bangs behind his ear, the back of his fingers caressed his cheek, as he smiled, shaky but truthful. “That’s all I want. I just want you, Mydei.”

“You have me.”

“I know.”

Tomorrow they would wake up. Maybe the rain would have passed in the night. Maybe the storm would continue to hound them through the day. No matter what, tomorrow they would march towards the world’s decay that all with good sense fled from. They would wage war for their lives and the lives of those behind them.

But, in some distant tomorrow, when they returned to the safety of the holy city where the day brightened eternity, they would fall asleep just like this in a bed, a home, a life they shared, and dream of an even more distant shared tomorrow.

Chapter End Notes

> If you never hear from me again then you’ll know the PhaiDei merch sold out at MCM Comic Con by the time I got there on Sunday and my immediate reaction was to end it all.

▶ This is a joke.

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